Pure Feeling

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/17843750.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam/Glimmer (She-Ra), side relationship - Relationship, Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam, Original Characters, Mara (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Marlena (He-Man), Randor (He-Man), Man-At-Arms (He-Man)

Additional Tags:
the cliche family au we've all been waiting for, and by that I mean I legit haven't found one and I'm APPALLED, family au, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Family, we're bringing in all the cliche tropes here, Fluff, Fluff and Angst, still figuring out some things here and there, so will add more tags and characters as I figure out where they fit into the story, Mara is Adora's daughter in this AU, Alcohol, Catra is Puerto Rican in this AU, In fact it's safe to assume she'll be Puerto Rican in almost any AU I do, unless I say otherwise, Glimmer is Filipino, slowburn

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Stats:
Published: 2019-02-18 Updated: 2020-12-15 Words: 130,667 Chapters: 17/?

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Pure Feeling

by TechnoSkittles

Summary

A lot can happen in eight years. There's even more than can happen in just five.

Getting over your crush from high school would not be one of them apparently. Something that Catra is quick to discover during one incidental shopping trip on a sluggish late summer afternoon. All in one moment, she's spiraling again, memories of heartbreak, betrayal, and unconditional love hitting her with the force of a typhoon.

A typhoon named Mara.

Notes

I'm a little surprised this idea hadn't been done yet so of course I gotta do it.

Updates are probably gonna be kinda slow for this. Just a fair warning.

See the end of the work for more notes

if only for a moment

She should really just tell her. Before it's too late.

But here she sits, silent and waiting, waiting for a moment she isn't sure she's ready to grasp.

Adora sits next to her, drumming her fingers on her lap as she waits for the rest of her family to finish rearranging all of her belongings into their car. Her dad is grumbling to himself, taking out boxes and twisting around others, before sighing and starting over completely. They had been helping him just half an hour ago, but eventually saw that he was so wrapped up in his own way of doing it they decided to just back off and sit on the front porch.

"*When do you leave?" she asks, tugging her fingers through her ponytail.*

Catra shrugs and leans forward, dropping her head on her hands. "Our semester starts two weeks after yours, so I'm not leaving until next week." A twist in her stomach reminds her that it'll be a lonely week with Adora so far away.

She considers and regrets for the millionth time, wishing she had kept up her grades a lot better so that maybe she could chase Adora to Brightmoon University together. But the past was the past. She hadn't. And now they were attending different colleges.

"*I'll call once I get unpacked," Adora offers and Catra smiles, nudging her shoulder with her knuckles.*

"*You better." It wouldn't be the same though. They both know that.*

Tell her how you feel.

Catra grimaces and peers out beyond the shadowed porch, squinting against the sun. It wouldn't change anything. But…

"*Hey Adora?"*

Her friend perks up beside her, giving a little hum.

Catra makes the mistake of looking over. She sees the sparkle in her eyes, her sunkissed cheeks from two many hours at the lifeguard station they both worked at, her sloping jaw and cut collarbone peeking out from her camisole. She eyes those pink lips, recalling all the times she'd dreamed of kissing them senseless, playing with the idea of how they would taste.

She can't. Not like this.

So she shakes her head and mumbles something about hanging out over Thanksgiving break, her attention already past the porch again, watching Adora's dad close the trunk of the car.

And misses the way that Adora deflates entirely.

The next few minutes are a blur of the rest of Adora's family gathering their last belongings and getting settled into the car.

Her and Adora linger at the bottom of the porch steps, encased in each others' arms, holding tight and reluctant to let go.

"*I'll call you," Adora promises again.*

And Catra smiles, biting down the ache her cowardice has cost her. "Don't have too much fun without me."

Then she watches Adora get into the car which pulls out of the driveway only seconds later, leaving her behind.

Catra trudges through the automatic doors of the grocery store, sighing at the immediate relief that the A/C provides against the summer heat. One of the employees greets her to which she gives a half-hearted response, focusing instead on gathering up one of the carry baskets. She shuffles further into the store, mind slowly

running over her mental list of things to get so she can go home and nap.

She decides to grab some snacks in preparation of the late nights she knows she's about to have. Things that will sustain her just enough to get through her oversized workload she'd just been dumped with. A few bags of chips. Some crackers and cookies.

Then, in an attempt to actually acquire *real* food, she heads over to the soup aisle, knowing that soups and instant noodles will be the only things she'll have any energy to prepare with her long hours.

She's browsing through the vast selection of soup, grimacing at some of the choices and idly considering others when a voice brings her out of her hazy, half-dead stupor.

"Catra? Is that you?"

Eight years - well, five technically - and she still could recognize that voice in an instant.

With wide, startled eyes Catra tears her attention away from the store display and immediately locks on a face she had convinced herself she'd never see again.

Adora is standing there behind a cart which is half-full of a multitude of food items. Her hair is out of its signature ponytail that she remembers from high school and their early college years, but is still pulled back on either side with the rest cascading down her shoulders. Catra takes a moment to marvel at how long it's gotten - nearly down to her waist. The opposite of her own hair that was now cut off just at chin-level.

Gone was the skinny girl from their teen years. She'd filled out a bit more, mostly in the hips it would seem, but she still has the same leanness about her that tells Catra she is still keeping herself in shape. Maybe better than before.

Her face is softer though, if looking a little worn down and ragged. There's a slight sunkenness to her eyes that tells of late nights, but honestly Catra is much the same in that department.

Words fail her for a long moment to the point that she begins to feel awkward. Panicking, she offers a shaky smile and hopes that Adora doesn't notice.

"Hey Adora."

Stupid. Five years since she's last talked to her best friend of nearly twenty years (and crush for nearly half that time) and all she can say is "*hey Adora"*?

Catra isn't sure about the interdimensional properties of the grocery market, but she hopes that somehow the floor tiles have the ability to swallow her up and save her from this whole situation.

Instead it's Adora who saves her with a mirthful laugh. Catra's back stiffens and her heart does a thing and wow she's really missed hearing that laugh. Those eyes, which had previously been looking at her with a film of disbelief and shock, are so fond and warm now and Catra can't help but feel like she's seventeen again, basking in her best friend's presence before they both had to leave.

"God it's been…" She pauses, eyes rolling up briefly to try and calculate the years. "Forever!" she finally settles on.

"Yeah, well, adult life really does stretch on, doesn't it?"

"Yeah." Her voice is quiet and the conversation abruptly halts and Catra panics again because what does one *do* in situations like these? She considers leaving, walking off and going about her life just as she had the past four years without Adora. But the thought doesn't settle right and Catra realizes that she's just missed her so much.

It wasn't either of their faults really, even if Catra had pushed most of the blame onto Adora initially. College life was crazy. Classes were demanding. They both had met new people and soon enough they had just...drifted apart. Phones calls were fewer and further between. Breaks came and went and though they'd always tried to make plans to meet up, they always fell through.

By each of their junior years, they'd just stopped trying altogether.

Catra had always been resentful about the break. She'd been angry and upset that her best friend since childhood had just abandoned her without a thought. But with time and age, she had come to terms that these things just...happen. She was just as responsible for their rift as Adora was. When Adora began to drift away, she hardly reached out.

But now, here she stands in front of her best friend, years later. Is this a second chance? An opportunity to fix things and pick up where they had left off?

Catra nervously taps her toe on the floor, realizing she doesn't know where to begin. "Um, so what are you-"

"Mommy! Mommy!"

They both freeze and in the next couple of seconds, a small girl - no older than the age of four - came trotting up between them, clutching a packet of cookies to her chest. A wide grin is plastered on her face and she's bouncing in place as if unable to contain the boundless excitement bursting inside. Which, would make sense honestly, given she was so *tiny*.

She stops in front of Adora and stretches out her arms to show off the package. Catra takes that moment to notice her blonde hair tucked into two neat pigtails. Adora tears her gaze away from Catra to look down at the little girl and frowns when she sees what she's holding.

"Mommy can I *pleeeease*, please, please get this?"

Adora sighs and plucks the packet out of the little girl's hands, her bouncing failing to cease, and turns it over to examine it. "Mara you already got your one sweet thing," she says exasperated.

The little girl - Mara - scrunches up her nose and Catra is *floored* by the familiarity of it. By this whole situation really. One twist after another.

So much for a simple grocery trip.

Mara is pouting now, her big eyes wide and shimmering with rejection. "Bu' I waaaaant it!"

Adora hands back the cookies and smooths a hand over the top of Mara's head. "Next time, okay? Now go put them back."

When Mara looks ready to argue back, a stern look crosses Adora's face. "Put them back or you don't get *anything*."

Her ultimatum springs Mara into action even though she does *not* look happy about it in the slightest. With a final pout she runs off back down the aisle and Adora watches her go with a sigh, not turning back until Mara's rounded the corner out of sight.

When her gaze returns to Catra, she's met with wide eyes and a slack jaw. She straightens up immediately, a pink tint to her cheeks and now *she's* the one looking skittish.

Catra closes her mouth and blinks rapidly, trying to run and catch up to all that had transpired before her. "Um...so you...you, uh….have a kid now?"

A wave of guilt and shame plays across Adora's face before she ducks her head down, pushing aside some of the items in her cart. "Yeah."

Catra nods and clears her throat. "So...you got married?" Her voice feels like gravel in her throat and *fuck* was she really dumb. She really should've known better.

At this Adora's head whips back up, eyes alarmed. "What? No! Oh *god* no!" When she sees Catra's apparent confusion, she sighs again and leans against the cart as if suddenly weighed down. "It's a long story."

Catra bites her lip and before she can think better of it, "I've got time."

Adora stares blankly at her and she scrambles. "I mean, not *right now* but like...later."

"Later?" Adora parrots and there's something in her eyes that Catra's too flustered to interpret at the moment.

Instead she says lamely, "Yeah. Later."

It's silent for a few moments. Enough time for Catra to convince herself that she's royally screwed this up. She's about to back out of the aisle, soup forgotten in favor of surgically extracting her foot from her mouth, when Adora smiles at her - weary but genuine and so full of warmth that Catra wonders where the A/C went.

"That...sounds really nice actually."

A rush of relief courses through Catra's system and she feels herself deflate, worn out from such a simple conversation. "Awesome, yeah. Um…" She digs through her pocket and pulls out her phone, extending it out to Adora. "I'll need your number again. I kind of changed numbers." Kind of? You either did or you didn't. *Hell*, she was really a fumbling idiot.

But Adora doesn't - thankfully - comment on this. Instead she takes the phone, typing away for a few short seconds before handing it back. "There. I texted myself so I could have your number too."

Catra smiles and gears up to say something else - what? She has no idea because she isn't planning *any* of this out - when Mara comes running back up to Adora, hands empty this time around.

She's jabbering away about something as she does and continues on even when Adora picks her up and props her on her hip.

"Mara," Adora cuts in and, obediently, she's silent. "I want you to meet someone." And then she looks at Catra and for some reason, she feels panic set in again. Like stage fright or something. Mara looks over at her too, round cheeks puffed out and eyes curiously looking and Catra feels like *screaming*.

"Mara, this is Catra. One of Mommy's *bestest* friends." Her thumb strokes Mara's upper arm and in a more level voice she addresses her next. "Catra, this is Mara - my daughter."

Awkwardly she waves at Mara and offers out a squeaky "Hi" then internally winces. But the girl doesn't acknowledge, probably isn't even aware, as she squints her eyes at Catra, scrutinizing her. Again, the action is so familiar that it nearly causes Catra pain and if there was any doubt before, it's gone now.

Then Mara's pointing at her. "Your eyes are differen' colors."

"Mara!"

Ignoring Adora's outburst, she smiles, so bright and wide. A look so pure that it actually melts Catra's heart into mush.

"I like 'em!"

She's surprised at first, but then lets loose a good-natured chuckle. "Thanks, kid." She passes a brief glance at Adora who still looks mildly upset at Mara's bluntness. "Your mom said the same thing when we met as kids."

The soft look that Adora gives her takes her already melted heart and obliterates it.

"Well we should probably get going," Adora declares. "It's a school night after all."

Then, with the dramatic flair of a professional thespian, Mara rolls her eyes back and slumps in Adora's grip, letting out a long, drawn out groan. Both of the older women chuckle and exchange short goodbyes before Adora rushes down the aisle, still carrying Mara. Catra turns to watch them leave and is greeted with a giggling and waving Mara.

"Byyyyyye, Mommy's fren'!"

Catra plasters on an exaggerated smile and waves back, but softens when Adora flashes her one last smile before they turn the corner.

Minutes later, she's still standing there, looking at the place they'd both disappeared, groceries forgotten. Eventually, she manages to shake herself and goes back to browsing the soups, dumping a few in her basket before heading towards self-checkout.

Maybe this week wouldn't be so bad after all.

revisit a life we both left behind

Chapter Summary

Tonight is a night for reminiscing, yearning, and....vodka?

After 5 years of zero contact, Adora and Catra decide to play catch up. Some things have changed. Others....not so much.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora's fingers fiddle with the edges of her phone. Her heart thrums in the deep recesses of her chest, almost lost in the percussion of the song blasting on the club speakers. The condensation from her glass drips onto the lacquered counter and she watches it with an intensity of someone trying to avoid any and all eye contact.

Next to her sits Catra drumming her nails in tandem against her own glass. Head propped in her hand and eyes lazily drifting across the sea of bodies littering the dance floor, she seems unaware or unconcerned with the awkwardness permeating the air between them. Or maybe she was even *reveling* in it. Deriving some form of entertainment from watching Adora squirm.

Adora fiddles with her phone again. As nonchalantly as possible, she unlocks her screen and scrolls through her messenger app. Finds Glimmer's name. Contemplates typing out a message.

I need out.

But then Catra looks over at her, eyes piercing and ripping before dropping down to Adora's phone. In a guilty panic, Adora turns off the screen again and gulps down some water.

She knew this would all be a horrible idea.

"Mara! Tita Glim Glim is going to be here *very soon* and you *still* haven't cleaned up the kitchen table like I asked you to!"

A distant groan from further into the small apartment is the only response that Adora receives. She's about to march into Mara's room to drag her out with threats of moving her bedtime up an hour when the doorbell rings. The same time she turns to look at the door she hears the little pitter patter of feet accompanied by a high pitched squeal.

Adora watches her daughter with a exasperated smile and amused chuckle as the tiny toddler strains to unlock the top lock of the door. She balances on her tiptoes and wriggles her fingers, flexing them into fists and stretching as if somehow hoping to achieve the impossible. After a few seconds of watching Mara struggle, Adora finally walks over to assist in unlocking the door and allows Mara to do the honors of opening it herself.

Standing in the hallway is Glimmer who immediately brightens upon seeing Mara - disheveled and stained overalls with no shirt underneath and all. She bends her knees and opens up her arms, catching Mara as she leaps into her arms.

"Lil' Sprite!"

"Tita Glim Glim!"

Adora smiles at the exaggerated reunion as the two cling to each other and Glimmer lifts Mara up to prop her on her hip. "Thanks again for agreeing to watch her."

Glimmer looks to Adora with a smile and bounces Mara on her hip to readjust her as she walks into the apartment. "Of course. Though you know Bow is moping because he picked up that extra shift and is missing out now." She waggles her eyebrows. "Although I'm sure he'll get his chance to babysit if tonight goes well?" Her voice did little to mask the heavy insinuation laced into it.

"Glimmer I *told* you, this isn't….it's not *like that*!"

"I think that'd be a little easier to believe if you weren't so dressed up." Her eyes trail up and down Adora's outfit with a raised eyebrow for emphasis.

Adora groans and looks down at her dress, running her hands down the fabric, picking at invisible stray threads and imaginary specks of lint. "I knew this was too much. I should change." Her teeth worries the bottom of her lip, not being mindful of the lipstick she had just applied minutes before Glimmer's arrival. "Yeah. I'm changing. I look ridiculous."

Glimmer rolls her eyes and lets Mara crawl out of her arms back to the floor, her squirming making her increasingly difficult to hold. Once back on solid ground, Mara tugs on the bottom of Glimmer's shorts, practically vibrating with excitement.

"Tita Glim Glim! Wanna see what I did in arts an' crafts today?"

Changing gears quickly and putting her hands on her knees to be more level with Mara, Glimmer offers up a big smile and ruffles her hair, messing up her already lopsided ponytail. "Abso-freaking-lutely!"

Mara holds up a finger, a silent signal to wait, before she runs off down the hall to her room to fetch her project.

As soon as she's gone, Glimmer straightens up and smiles assuringly at Adora. "Hun, you look *gorgeous*. Don't freak, okay? I'm sure you'll be fine tonight."

When Adora still doesn't look convinced, Glimmer sighs and steps over to Adora, subverting a strewn toy on the kitchen floor and grabbing both of Adora's arms. "Adora? Seriously? You're gonna be okay. I mean, you guys *were* best friends for like, all your lives, right?"

Adora shrugs off her grip and takes a step back, turning and busying herself with collecting haphazard crayon drawings on the kitchen table and stacking them together. "Yeah. Keyword is 'were'. We haven't seen each other in over five years." And it was

all her fault, but she doesn't tack on that detail. "I'm sure she's mad at me or hates my guts."

Glimmer crosses her arms, a look of skepticism crossing her features. "Isn't she the one who invited you out for drinks?"

Pausing, Adora looks up and bites the inside of her cheek. "Yeah but…"

"But…?"

"Shut up."

When Glimmer shoots her a smug look, Adora sticks out her tongue which receives a dry "yeah, *real* mature" before she turns back to straightening up the kitchen table, grabbing loose crayons by the handful and tossing them into the bucket with the rest. "Look, Catra's….complicated. She's never been straightforward with her feelings or intentions. We used to be close enough that I was able to read her most times but now…" Adora lifts the bucket and stares sadly into it, mind drifting away into a sea of memories. Simpler times. Easier times. "We haven't talked in so long. I think I forgot how to do that. So now I'm not sure we can connect like we used to."

There's a moment of saturated silence which allows Adora to soak in her nostalgia and doubt before Glimmer sighs and walks over to lean her elbows on the table, one foot tucked behind the other. "She's probably just as razzled by this as you are. I mean, after all, you have a *kid* now. That's, like, a huge part of your life she knows nothing about."

Adora slumps and groans again, throwing her head back. She begins to run her hands through her hair, only halting mid-way when she remembers that it had taken her nearly fifteen minutes of fighting with it to get it to stay like it was. Withdrawing her fingers she leans against the table so that she's nearly sitting on top of it, setting down the bucket of crayons with a tad more force than necessary. "Yeah and then there's *that* whole thing."

"What? Are you embarrassed of your own daughter?"

Immediately Adora whips her head up, eyes wide with a mixture of shock and disbelief before her features harden and she frowns. "No! Of course not! Just...she's going to want to ask a lot of questions." When Glimmer gives her a look that conveys "well *duh*" she shakes her head and grips the edge of the table. Her bare heel scuffs at the plastic tiled floor. "I don't know….I'm not ready to tell her everything that happened."

"So just tell her that."

Adora throws her hands up and jumps to her feet, nearly screeching in frustration. "Then she'll get upset because even after all this time, all these years of not talking to her, she's going to think….*ugh!* I don't know! If I *don't* tell her then she'll think I'm...it'll make things worse!"

"If you two were as close as you've told Bow and I countless times, I'm sure she'll understand?" There's a hint of exasperation to her tone. The more rational part of Adora's brain peeps up that she's right to feel so frustrated with Adora's anxiety because everything she's saying makes sense. But the much stronger sense of nausea and nervousness latches onto her steadfastly and she continues to spiral down into worse-case scenarios.

"And what if she doesn't? Or what if this whole thing is some drawn-out and convoluted plan to catch me off my guard so she can yell at me for abandoning her?"

Glimmer quirks an eyebrow and props her hip against the kitchen table. "You really think that she's petty enough to do something like that? C'mon, Adora. It's been *years*. I'm sure she just misses you."

The rest of Glimmer's words are lost on Adora, however. "Oh god. That's exactly what she's doing. She's going to tear into me like wet paper and honestly? I think I deserve it."

Glimmer rolls her eyes and ticks off a finger. "Okay, first? Way to have faith in your best friend. And second," she ticks off another finger, "Way to have confidence in yourself. Adora...people grow apart sometimes. I mean, you remember that one time me and Bow drifted apart for awhile sophomore year?"

"You guys stopped talking for a total of five hours because he didn't respond to a text you sent. Which, by the way, you forgot to hit the send button so it was all just a huge misunderstanding," Adora deadpans.

"You get the point!"

When Adora still doesn't look convinced, Glimmer sighs. "Look, Adora, I don't know what else to tell you. If you're really that worried you can always not go, but I don't see how that's going to make things better for either of you."

As Adora turns over Glimmer's words in her head, tossing them about internally and considering the pros and cons of staying home and forgetting the whole thing, Mara comes running back into the kitchen. Clutched in her hands is some paper and string concoction coated in an abundance of glitter. Adora internally winces, knowing that she'll be finding glitter wedged into her carpet and scattered about the laminated kitchen floor for what would be weeks.

"Look! Look!" She skids to a stop in front of Glimmer who bends down to take a closer look. "It's a fairy soldier!"

Glimmer gasps and tenderly plucks the paper figure from Mara's hands, turning it over and eyeing it carefully. "A fairy soldier?" she parrots.

Mara nods enthusiastically. "Yeah! She has a magic staff that she hits people with!"

"I can see that! She looks so tough!" Then Glimmer makes a face, something that Adora thinks makes her look constipated but Mara giggles delighted, hands already reaching for her creation again.

Adora smoothes her hands down the front of her dress again, sighing with a sense of resignation before turning back to her bedroom. "I'm going to change."

This catches Glimmer's attention who straightens up with a disapproving frown that Adora misses. "Adora…"

Adora waves over her shoulder dismissively, shutting down whatever argument her friend is about to make. "I'm still going. I just want to change into something more...practical." And then she disappears into her bedroom, leaving Glimmer to be bombarded with stories about Mara's day at preschool.

The bar that Catra had selected was a sleek-and-chic type of place, something more suited for a young crowd whose concerns laid more in what they thought was trendy. The layout is spacious and open, a large area cut out to the side for a dance floor that looks up to the raised platform where live performers - mostly DJs - could set up. The furniture is modern to the point of near dysfunction. The lighting is dim, allowing for the color-changing lights that are wrapped around the ceiling edges to glow. The same lights line the underneath of the bar on the opposite side of the room, accented with more uncomfortable-looking chairs and adorned with a full wall of liquor bottles that look almost more like decor rather than to actually mix drinks.

It's Friday, but the night is still young enough that the space seems mostly empty, save for a few patrons scattered about the entire establishment. They're clustered together in hordes, dressed in club-style clothing - dresses that clung, pants that hung, shirts halfway unbuttoned, and tops that could be barely considered as such. Adora tugs self-consciously on her blazer, feeling vastly over and underdressed all at once. She suddenly isn't sure if changing had been for the best or not.

A low synthetic beat plays on the overhead speakers installed higher up on all the walls, a placeholder until a live performer that

is scheduled to perform for the night surely. Adora's lips twist at the music choice, unfamiliar with it and overly not impressed.

Within just seconds of standing near the entrance of the bar, Adora decides it's not a place she'd want to return to. Her opinion might have been different back in her early college years. This might've been the *exact* sort of place she would have spent her weekend nights, dancing the night away, downing drinks without abandon, losing herself in a loud and boisterous atmosphere without thought to the future morning that promised a wicked hangover.

Maybe having a kid had changed her more than she had thought.

Putting all those thoughts aside, Adora scans the area more carefully, looking for a distinctive bob of dark curls whilst also trying to not seem too out-of-place in the foreign atmosphere. It may have only been five years since she's been absent from this scene, but all of a sudden it feels like ages. There's a slight twinge of nostalgia in her chest that she bats away quickly, knowing that it really is for the better that she had given all this up.

Not that she had much of a choice but….

Responsibility is kind of a bitch.

Luckily, her eyes land on the person she's looking for. Seated at the bar is her long absent best friend, sipping delicately from a tall glass of water. On the counter is a smaller glass filled with something that is a toxic green color, topped off with a couple of cherries. Her outfit is actually sort of similar to what some of the other people in there are wearing: a deep red turtleneck, sleeveless crop top; distressed maroon jeans; knee-high laced boots; fingerless leather gloves; and a leather jacket draped over the back of her chair. Another pang of nostalgia shoots through Adora, this one more bittersweet.

Chopped hair aside, Catra hardly looks like she's changed. Like no time has passed at all.

Though her brain is still whirling with indecisiveness, considerations of turning and leaving and keeping the past in the past plaguing her thoughts, her feet move forward. Soon enough she's sliding onto one of the empty bar stools next to Catra and places her things on the counter.

Catra looks up from her drink and Adora's heart stops.

"Um, hi," she chokes out.

Mismatched eyes look her up and down, assessing her in just under a second but Adora lingers on the motion, feeling suddenly self-conscious again. As if she expects Catra to turn her away or, worse, realize she'd made some sort of mistake.

But then she smirks, a motion without malice, and Adora can breathe again.

"Hey Adora."

Scratch that.

Catra's smirk widens. "You're late."

With a scoff and roll of her eyes, Adora powers on her phone screen, tilting it so that Catra could see. "Only by fifteen minutes."

Catra raises a single eyebrow and takes a languid sip of her drink. "'*Only'* fifteen minutes? Big words coming from the Punctuality Princess."

Adora scrunches her nose and twists her mouth into a grimace. *That* nickname again. Some things really didn't change. "Yeah, well, you try having an uncooperative toddler and still make it anywhere on time."

As soon as the words were out, Adora realizes it was the wrong thing to say. She had been planning on avoiding the elephant in the room for as long as she possibly could. Bringing it up would only bring on an onslaught of questions, dredging up painful

histories, diving into why's and how's. Sure, it isn't something she could skirt around forever, but she'd been hoping that it was something that wouldn't be out in the open so soon.

But of course. Her and her *stupidly big* mouth…

Catra's lips are pressed into a fine line, eyes only peeking out from the corner as she struggles not to look too interested. Adora can practically sense the restraint that Catra was practicing, the thousands of questions running over her eyes as she swirled her glass, sloshing the drink inside around the ice cubes. Desperate for a distraction, Adora tugs the menu in front of Catra closer to herself, exaggerating her interest in the different cocktail concoctions listed.

"So what's good here?"

From her peripheral vision, she sees Catra shrug before setting her own glass down to stir the contents with her straw. "Not really sure. First time here." She taps her nail on the side of her glass. "This ain't half bad though."

Peeking over her menu, Adora leans closer. "Which is…?"

And then Catra's in her space, manicured nail trailing down the menu before tapping one of the selections. "The 'Rum Pum Punch'," she quotes. "Real fruity though. Heavy on the rum. Dunno if it'd be your thing."

Adora purses her lips. "What's *that* supposed to mean? Are you assuming I can't handle my liquor?"

Catra gives her this look that screams "obviously". "Adora, we went to a party once and you got wrecked on a Mike's Hard. Just a single one."

Crossing her arms, Adora struggles not to look too pouty. "I went to college just the same as you."

A short laugh. Wide eyes and raised eyebrows. The most incredulous look that Adora's ever been on the receiving end of (and she went through her senior year of college pregnant so that was really saying something). "I promise you, our college experiences were nothing alike." Then she downs the rest of her drink and firmly plants it back on the bar counter.

There's a part of Adora that knows that Catra's just teasing. After they'd lost touch with one another, their lives had splintered off in different directions. There was so much that Adora didn't know about Catra anymore just as there was so much that Catra didn't know about her. Even when they had still been talking it was so few and far between, short conversations that could hardly qualify as such because they'd been reduced to questions like "how're classes?" and "how are you holding up?"

So Adora really didn't know what Catra had been up to while at college. They never talked about their weekends out. Hardly talked about the new friends each had made. Besides the occasional question with a clipped answer they'd exchanged in the free moments they'd remembered the other girl, there really was so much that neither knew about the other's life.

Logically, Adora knows all this. And that Catra's merely commenting on that. But somehow, there's something within her tone that sounds accusatory. Like Catra might still blame her. That she might still be upset, after all these years. And Adora can't find a single reason why she shouldn't be.

And then there's the part that sounds mocking. "*I promise you, our college experiences were* nothing *alike.*"

Adora glances around the club, a place so foreign and a scene so nostalgic, distant despite the short passage of time since she'd last been in one. All the night outs she'd had to give up. Parties skipped out to catch up on homework and studying from skipped classes. Miserable mornings spent clutching the porcelain of her toilet. The stares she got walking around campus. Hiding out in her apartment whenever she didn't have class because she

couldn't take the judgment anymore. Teachers, for all their show of being accommodating, relentless and suggesting she drop for the semester, implying that they didn't think she was *capable*.

When Adora checks back in, Catra is giving a new order to the bartender. After she's done the bartender looks at her expectantly. To her side Catra has this grin about her, one that Adora can't decipher in her haze of thoughts, but all she knows in that moment is the need to prove something.

Taking one last parsing glance at the menu, Adora orders the first thing that sounds familiar. "A screwdriver please."

With a nod, the bartender turns her back on them to gather up the ingredients for their drinks. Adora hears a low whistle and looks over to Catra who actually seems somewhat pleasantly surprised. "Vodka? Going hard so early?"

"You'd be surprised what I can handle." There's a slight bite to her tone and she winces. None of it was Catra's fault. She didn't even *know*. But there was still this ever-present need to prove people wrong. To prove that that was more than capable of what people gave her credit for.

Catra's giving her another look. Her eyes on locked onto her, analyzing her inch for inch, and when they reach her gaze, there's something behind them that she can't quite place. It's soft. It's guarded. It's understanding. It's lost.

Adora has never been one to handle being under such scrutiny well so she casts her gaze away just as Catra murmurs out something. The music is too loud, so she misses it entirely and when she asks for Catra to repeat whatever it is she said, she only receives a head shake in response. Just before she can push further, there's a smirk pulling at Catra's lips and she gestures lazily with a wave towards Adora.

"So what's with the adult version of your old high school look? Trying to impress me?"

Adora frowns and looks down at her clothes: brown slacks coupled with red flats, a loose white button down topped off with her red work blazer. She'd chosen something that looked nice enough to wear out that wasn't as over-the-top as the dress she'd been wearing before. "What do you mean?"

"Really, Adora? You look like a fancier you from high school. Remember that red bomber jacket you wore, like, every day? And those poor beaten red converse? I could actually hear their cries of agony with every step you took."

Adora purses her lips, still struggling to make the connection. "Yeah, well, you still look like you're skipping fourth period underneath the bleachers."

Catra laughs lowly. "Okay first, I didn't *skip*. I just got there later than everyone else. And second, these *are* my clothes from high school." She takes a sip of water and tugs on the bottom of her shirt. "Never grew out of 'em."

Adora bites her lip. "Must be nice."

Again, she realizes her slip a second too late. Thankfully, before Catra can press her for further clarification, the bartender arrives with their drinks and Adora uses the opportunity to change the topic.

"So what are you up to nowadays?" It's a simple question, so simple it's almost cringeworthy. But it takes the focus off of her for the time being, something she could really use to collect her thoughts and composure. Besides, she is genuinely curious about Catra's life after having not spoken to each other in five years. It doesn't make up for all the time lost, but maybe it's a start?

Catra nods thoughtfully, as if she'd been expecting this question eventually. "Right. Ended up dropping out mid-way junior year. Became a professional drug dealer. Currently in the process of starting a cock-fighting syndicate. *Not* as easy as TV shows make it out to be."

Adora chokes on her drink and is immediately rewarded with Catra's guffaws. "Oh! Oh *man!* Gullible as ever, huh Adora?"

Narrowing her eyes, Adora grabs a fistful of beverage napkins to wipe her mouth and dab at the bit of dribble that dripped onto her shirt. "*Not* funny, you *ass*."

"I can see the stick is still firmly in place up your ass too."

Catra nimbly dodges the swipe that Adora makes towards her, still giggling incessantly as Adora can feel the vein in her forehead pulsing. It's annoying, but there's still something about this whole dynamic that Adora has missed desperately.

"Okay, okay! Fine. Graduated with a BFA, jumped around some minimum wage jobs for some time while doing random illustrating gigs on the side. Then about two years ago I went full-time into doing some freelance work. Happy?"

Adora perks up. "Freelance? What's that like?"

Catra takes a small sip of her drink, nails drumming against wood as she considers the question. "Eh. Depends on the day. Sometimes the jobs can be ridiculous. Sometimes the clients are even *more* ridiculous." She shrugs and leans back on her chair. "But it pays the bills well enough, so can't complain too much, I guess."

Adora nods and leans her elbows on the bar. "I heard freelance is where the real money is."

Catra shrugs again. "Like I said, it really depends. Sometimes the job's not that big. And then sometimes I still get assholes who insist I do it for the 'exposure'." She scowls at that, taking another swig of her drink. "As if I didn't deal with enough of that BS in college. Plus, it's not nearly as steady as a contracted job would be."

"Well, at least you're doing something you like." She thinks to her own job - a boring desk job for some company that she's still not

entirely sure on what purpose it serves or what exactly it is that they do.

"I mean, I guess. Although, sometimes it's such a pain in the ass I wish I was doing something else. For instance, this job I just finished up? Awful conditions, lackluster pay, and *way* too many particulars….But when the well's dried up, you'll drink anything, ya know?" And to punctuate her statement, she knocks back the rest of her drink, switching immediately to her water.

Again, Adora thinks of her current job. One she took on purely because she needed something to pay the bills and expenses of having a child. One she kept because of her lack of other options. "Yeah. I get what you mean."

A silence falls between them and Adora scrambles, trying to think of a way to keep the conversation going. Preferably with the focus *not* on her if she could help it. She taps the side of her thumb against the bar, teeth gnawing her lip as she tries (and fails and tries) to think of another question to ask. "Um…"

Catra looks over expectantly which only makes the panic build. "So….what's the worst client you've had so far?"

She blinks, possibly stunned from being asked that particular question. Then she turns her eyes upwards in thought, sucking in one cheek and playing with her water glass. After a few seconds her eyes light up and she turns to Adora with an exasperated grin, eyes alight and shining in the dim room. "Okay, now get this…"

The next few minutes are spent with Catra recounting the array of awful clients she's had, comparing them to customers she'd had to deal with while working retail and other odd minimum wage jobs fresh from college. Each story was accented with Catra's trademark snark, a trait that Adora is sure was the reason she even *got* into most of these situations, but still made an entertaining story nonetheless. There are moments where she's doubled over clutching her stomach, laughing at some sassy

remark that past Catra had said or some ridiculous request a client had made.

In the midst of their conversation the bartender comes over, taking another drink order for Adora and refilling Catra's water glass when she declines another drink.

"I drove here," she explains at Adora's questioning look.

Adora nods and sucks down her own drink, finishing it off with a satisfied sigh. "Not me," she sang.

"Someone drop you off here?"

Adora gives a half-shrug. "I mean, technically? I called an Uber." Anticipating the next question she continues, "My car is in the shop for a minor repair. I'll be able to pick it up again in a day or two."

"You don't have any friends who could've dropped you off?"

There's something to her tone that Adora can't quite place, but she finds herself getting strangely defensive. "I mean, yeah. Most of them are just busy tonight and I don't really like putting people out. The only one who was free was Glimmer and she's-" Adora cuts herself off, hesitating as she realizes that she's allowed herself to slip yet again. Unfortunately, it's too late because Catra is looking at her expectantly, waiting for the rest of her explanation. "Um...she's already babysitting for me."

"Oh."

"Yeah."

Another silence falls, broken only by the synthetic beats of another song over the loudspeakers. This one seems much harder to save and Adora fears that the end of their outing has moved up immensely. She watches Catra fidget in her seat to turn and look out to the dance floor which has filled up significantly since

Adora's arrival. Meanwhile, Adora turns and stares at her drink, avoiding any and all potential eye contact.

Why is this so hard? They'd been best friends for the better part of two *decades*. Even after spending so much time apart, one would think that it wouldn't be *this* difficult to pick things back up.

Unless, of course, one of them had, like, a *kid* or something. That might throw a wrench into things.

Adora groans internally. She hates that she's making such a huge deal out of this. She hates that she can't be forward with someone who knows her almost as well as she knows herself. But….seriously. *How* does someone work having a kid amongst a five-year separation into a conversation flawlessly? Really. She'd love to know.

And then there's Catra's side. What did *she* think of all of this? Is it just as awkward for her as it is for Adora? Is there some sort of leftover resentment over how they left things that is being fueled by the fact that she had a kid and never told her? Or does she have some skewed perspective on her now, believing her to be stupid or easy or something to that extent?

Adora chews her lip. If the shoe were on the other foot…

Fuck. She doesn't know! If Catra was the one with some surprise kid, she'd be….well *surprised* obviously. But would she think any differently of her best friend? Would she be judgmental?

Adora sighs. Why does any of it really matter? She doesn't have the same viewpoint or thought process as Catra. So whatever her thoughts would be if the situation were reversed doesn't help her to understand what Catra is thinking *now*.

Spotting her phone, Adora remembers the parting conversation she'd had with Glimmer before leaving the apartment.

"*Look, if things start getting awkward or going wrong, I'll text and let you know. Then you could call me and, I dunno, say something*

happened with Mara."

Glimmer places a hand on one hip. "You mean give you an excuse to leave?"

"*Exactly."*

"*Adora…" She looks exasperated. "Are you sure that'll even be necessary?"*

Adora nods. Glimmer just...doesn't know Catra like she did. She *doesn't even know Catra like she once had anymore. Anything is possible at this point. "Absolutely."*

Adora rests her hand over her phone, chewing her lip as she considers using her last resort to get out of the situation. When she gets back home, Glimmer would definitely say that she's overreacting. Honestly, there's a part of Adora that knows that to be true. But it doesn't quell her rapidly beating heart or her shaking hands. And like an animal cornered, Adora's main thought at the moment is to escape before it's too late to.

She brings the phone closer to unlock it, scrolling through her apps to send Glimmer a text when she notices that Catra's eyes are on her again. She hesitates, freezing in place to avoid any sort of awkward confrontation, hoping that Catra will just *stop looking at her like that*.

"Whoa, wait." Adora's heart falls to her stomach and she braces herself for the impending….whatever. Who knows? It's *Catra*. "Did you say 'Glimmer'? What kind of name is that?"

Adora blinks. Huh?

Catra leans forward, a mirth dancing in her eyes and a bemused smirk playing the corners of her lips. "Is that actually her name or just some dumb nickname?"

Adora furrows her brow. "It's her actual name."

Catra snickers, hand darting up to try and hold most of it in, but one more look at Adora's unamused stare and she breaks down completely. "Oh *shit*! Oh, her parents must *hate* her!"

"I think it's a pretty name," Adora huffs.

Catra wipes at her eyes. "Well, of course *you'd* think so."

Adora rolls her eyes and crosses her arms, leaning forward with a smirk of her own. "Does someone with the name *Catra* really have any room to talk?"

The look of offense is immediate and Catra's back goes ramrod straight, all merriment and hilarity flushed down the drain. "Hey! *Mine* is a nickname!"

"Oh right. My bad, Miss *Catari*-"

"Shut up shut up *shut up!*"

Adora laughs and shakes her head. "You are *such* a hypocrite."

Catra shrugs and leans back in her chair. "It's a coping mechanism," she sighs but flashes Adora a quick, shit-eating grin.

A much more comfortable silence settles over them this time and when Catra turns to look over the dance floor again, Adora mimics her. The throng of bodies are swarming and squirming drunkenly to the fast-paced music, so high-pitched and overlaid it hardly retains a melody anymore. Even still, most of them are so oblivious or far-gone that they probably don't even notice. They hear sound and they move to it. Sometimes it's that simple.

Adora spins her glass on the bar and looks forlornly over the dancing crowd. When did it stop being so simple?

"Hey." Catra's voice is quiet, so much so that Adora can barely make it out over all the noise. But she still does so she turns to face her, a sinking feeling starting in her chest and slinking its way down to her stomach. As soon as she takes in Catra's features -

drawn together in concentration, a certain level of wariness mixed with unbridled curiosity - Adora feels her chest give way and drop completely like a triggered trap door.

Adora swallows and clutches her glass a light tighter. "Yeah?" Her voice is small because she can't bring herself to be any louder.

The next set of seconds is agonizing as she waits for Catra to collect her thoughts. She sees the questions she wants to ask in her eyes, painted across her lips. She struggles to narrow them down, works to reword it again and again and again. Soon enough, it's so much and Adora can feel the stress building to a point that she wishes Catra would just blurt it out, anything to save her from her own mind.

"How old is she?" And then she sighs, shoulders slumped, like that's not the question she had wanted to ask.

But it's an easy start and somehow, Adora's thankful for it. "She just turned four about two months ago."

"Four," she repeats, eyes widening marginally. Then she rolls them upwards, flickering as she does the quick math. "So that means…?" She trails off, glancing warily at Adora, like she's suddenly *afraid*.

It's comforting. To know they're both unsure how to breach this. It makes her feel less alone.

"Senior year," Adora confirms with a simple nod. She brings her glass closer to her, looking inside and stirring the ice around with her straw. "She was born just after I graduated."

"Fuck," Catra says under her breath, barely audible enough for Adora to catch it. "That...must've sucked *big time.*"

It had. But it was long enough ago that she'd gotten over it mostly. "Kind of. But I made it out with my degree. Even if it's just collecting dust for the moment." She grimaces and knocks back

her drink, bypassing the straw entirely. "But it was still worth it to see the look on everyone's faces who thought I couldn't do it."

Catra laughs then and Adora feels warm (although that might've been the alcohol finally catching up) because it sounds like she's *proud*. "Yep. You haven't changed a bit."

"I have maternity photos that say otherwise," she jokes cautiously. But when Catra laughs again, Adora feels the tension that had slowly been accumulating release all at once and she wonders why she'd been so scared before.

Once their laughter had died down, Catra takes a sip of her water and dives in with another question. "So, what's up with the dad then?"

The sinking feeling returns, walloping her stomach until it's black and blue. Right. *That's why*.

Her eyes grow hot and she turns away to bore holes into her own glass, thinking of what to say and how to say it. She doesn't want to talk about this, not really. But she doesn't want to drive Catra away either, not when there was...*something*, some kind of promise to rectifying and closing the divide that'd come with five years of no contact. In such a short time of talking to each other, anxieties and worries aside, Adora had come to realize just how desperately she'd *missed* her.

Despite everything, however, she isn't sure that this is something she's ready to touch on again. Five years wasn't enough to lessen the sting. If she's honest with herself, she doesn't know when it won't hurt anymore.

Luckily (or maybe not so much), Catra seems to notice how torn she is and a look of remorse crosses her features. "Shit. Sorry. I shouldn't have asked."

Adora waves her off, turning to offer a strained smile. "It's okay. I'm just...it's not something I'm ready to talk about just yet."

When Catra only continues to look more and more guilty, she adds on, "I'll tell you one day." A promise. An affirmation.

They both realize at the same time the implications of that simple statement.

I'm not leaving again.

I'll be right here.

As long as you'll have me.

Catra smiles. "Yeah. Whenever you're ready." Then she glances over at Adora's empty glass. "For now, I think it's time to get you home. I don't know what kind of examples you want to set for your kid, but I doubt stumbling in drunk is one of them." She stands up and collects her jacket, throwing it effortlessly over her shoulders and waving for the bartender's attention. When she comes over Catra hands over her card. The bartender looks over at Adora expectantly and she scrambles for her wallet when Catra holds up a hand.

"I've got both tabs."

Adora's eyebrows raise before she frowns. "Catra I-"

"Can pay next time," she cuts in. Adora wants to argue further, but the bartender has already walked off with just Catra's card in hand, so she settles for glowering.

"Asshole."

"Is that how you thank someone who just picked up your bill?"

"I didn't *ask* you to!"

Catra only shrugs again and Adora knows that even if she tries to press it further, it'll only fall on deaf ears. So she resigns herself to accepting the gesture with the determination to make absolutely

sure that Catra doesn't pull this on her again the next time they meet.

Instead of wasting her breath and energy, Adora pulls out her phone and opens up the Uber app, scanning for cars in the area to take her home. However, just before she can select one, her phone is yanked from her hands. She looks up in utter surprise, finding Catra switching off her screen and dangling it above her head.

"No Ubers."

Adora frowns and snatches back her phone. "Do you expect me to *walk* home?"

"As amusing as that sounds, I think giving you a ride might be easier." The bartender returns with Catra's card and after signing the receipt, she tucks it away and turns away from the bar.

Again with the chivalry. Flashes of memories from high school bombard her: the time that Catra ate half of Adora's lunch on top of her own that Adora paid for; the time they'd been biking home and Catra ran her into some trash cans before speeding off down the street, laughter growing distant as Adora picked herself up and dusted herself off; the *numerous* times Adora would get up from her seat briefly only to come back to find Catra sprawled out across it, resulting in a wrestling match on the floor (that Adora *always* won).

Something isn't adding up somehow.

Maybe….maybe Catra's grown more than she had given her credit for.

They walk out to the parking lot and there, on the edge, Catra picks up a couple of helmets off her motorcycle, offering one out to her.

Adora smirks and takes it, weighing it carefully in her hands and turning it over to inspect it. Then again...maybe not so much.

"Why am I not surprised?"

Catra had already slipped on her own helmet and is now helping Adora adjust her own. "Why should you be? I only talked about getting my motorcycle license all of high school."

"And here I was, thinking you'd actually grown up a little."

Catra scoffs and rolls her eyes before swinging her leg around to straddle the bike. "Growing up is overrated."

Adora climbs on after her, looking down and carefully planting her feet on the footholds so they won't slip while they are moving. She hesitates, a split second but Catra looks like she *definitely* noticed, before she places her hands on Catra's hips, fingers curling around her belt loops for a firmer hold.

"We all have to at some point."

"Says who?" She starts up the ignition and Adora's a little ashamed to admit that she jumped a little when it roared to life.

"Life." She's a little more familiar with the notion of growing up. She'd had to do it a bit sooner than most of her peers.

"Yeah, well," Catra knocks back the kickstand and rolls the bike out of her parking spot. "Life can suck my dick." And Adora can't help the laugh bubbling up at the pure immaturity of the statement, a great testament to Catra's beliefs and values. It's something she wishes she still had the ability to do. To be so carefree in a world that was so harsh and demanding.

But then she remembers the little girl waiting for her at home, hopefully tucked into bed by this time of night. And how, despite the frustrations of parenthood, how that little girl had gotten her through thick and thin, trials and turmoils, her smiles brightening her bleakest days and her purity giving her the ability to feel something warm in a world so cold. To have someone love her so unconditionally, to be someone's *world*…

Adora would grow up endlessly to see her happy.

She snaps back to present-time when Catra turns to look over her shoulder at her. "You might want to hang on a bit tighter than that. I've been told I can be a bit of a reckless driver."

"Please don't orphan my child." But she obliges anyway, leaning forward so that she's pressed closer to Catra, arms wrapping loosely around her midsection.

"Now might be a good time to deem me the godmother then." She revs the engine, hesitating only to ask for Adora's address. After receiving it ("That's actually only ten minutes away from my place."), they're peeling out of the parking lot, flying through the streets with the night life passing them by.

Adora turns her key slowly, hoping to make as little noise as she can before creeping the door open enough for her to enter the apartment. Most of the lights are out save for one of the lamps in the living room where Glimmer's sitting on her couch, watching TV at a near silent volume. Her friend perks up upon her entrance and gives her a quick once over. Adora frantically pats down her hair, still messy from the helmet and the motorcycle ride.

"So how'd it go?" There isn't any weight to the question.

Adora shrugs and hangs up her keys on the nail by the door. "It was fine." When Glimmer doesn't respond, clearly waiting for some kind of elaboration, Adora sighs and pads into the living room, dropping down onto the couch.

"How long has she been asleep?"

"I put her to bed about two and a half hours ago." Then she quirks an eyebrow. Still waiting.

Adora chews on the inside of her cheek and actively avoids acknowledging Glimmer's gaze. "We're meeting again next Friday."

In the next few seconds, Adora's smothering Glimmer's *stupid* smug grin and boastful *I told you so*'s with a pillow.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry this one took a bit longer! I got crazy busy with school because I kept getting sick and missing class/having to make up work. And then once I'd gotten mostly caught up I got sick again and fell behind again.

It's been a vicious cycle.

I hope the length of this chapter makes up for the wait though. Almost quadruple the word count of last chapter. (Which still isn't terribly long but ya know...)A

I won't make any solid promises on when chapter 3 will be coming out because I'm a month away from finals and this is when everything happens so much so I'll just try my best to crunch it out soon! Who knows? Maybe I'll go into a writing fever during an all-nighter and have it out for y'all.

i know i'll stay, i know i'll stay (right there with you)

Chapter Summary

Catra is in desperate need of A/C, Scorpia is her normal cheery self and Entrapta's.....well, yeah.

Also Catra (apparently) likes kids? More research needed.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra drops the box she's carrying onto the ground in the front hallway before heaving out a long-winded sigh. She pulls the bottom of her shirt up to her forehead and wipes away the sweat accumulating on her forehead, groaning in despair at the heat prickling her skin.

"*Please* tell me you didn't get an apartment with busted A/C or I'll fling myself down the stairs." All twelve flights.

There's the sound of rummaging around from the door cut into the wall to her left and Catra leans against the opposite wall, eyes fluttering at the semi-coolness it impresses upon her bare shoulders and arms. "Uhhh, no! I don't think so." The sounds of more rummaging and a heavy thud hitting linoleum. Then, within the next few seconds of silence, Scorpia peeks her head out with a smile - so brilliant and appreciative that it makes Catra squirm a little. "It….should work. Just haven't had much time to fiddle with it yet."

A flash of purple catches both of their attentions, heading for the thermostat mounted on the wall adjacent to the open concept kitchen. Catra pipes up first. "Entrapta, *no*."

"But I could-"

"Back. Away. From the. Thermostat. *Now*."

Shoulders slumped and hair limp in total dejection, Entrapta swivels and turns back to whatever hole she'd crawled from and both Catra and Scorpia heave a shared sigh of relief. Then Catra pushes herself from off the wall, the coolness of it having lost its freshness, and gently kicks the box she'd dropped on the floor until it's pressed up against a wall.

"Whatever. We'll figure it out later. I think there's only a few more things left in the truck so we'll just finish that up first."

She's barely two steps out the door when she halts to swivel around on her heel, eyes narrowed dangerously. "*Entrapta leave the thermostat alone!"*

A purple blur darts into the kitchen again out of sight and after a few seconds of waiting to make sure that Entrapta stays put, Catra walks out of the apartment, leaving the door open. The summer heat sucker punches her lungs and drenches her in sweat before she's even down the hallway. How the outside heat has managed to seep its way into the building, Catra doesn't know but she somehow wishes there's a singular person responsible so she can gouge out their eyes.

You know. *Politely.*

Considering that she's the only one carrying up boxes at this point (Scorpia insisted the rest were pretty light and Catra, for once, didn't feel like arguing), she makes pretty decent time in emptying out the moving truck. By the time she's brought up the last box, Entrapta has moved from the kitchen to the living room, half-submerged in one of the larger cardboard boxes, intensely searching its contents. Deciding that is a sleeping beast she'd rather not prod, she turns into the kitchen and beelines for the faucet.

Unsurprisingly, Entrapta hadn't actually unpacked any of the dishes or kitchenware yet (so what she was doing in there earlier

was anybody's guess really). But that does little to deter Catra - she turns on the running water and cups her hands underneath the stream, letting it collect just enough to bring to her mouth and drink what doesn't spill through the cracks of her fingers. After repeating this process a couple of times, she splashes some into her face, not even caring that a little bit soaks into her curls. When she's finished, Scorpia emerges from their laundry-storage room, holding a box labeled "KITCHEN".

"This one got misplaced," she explains, setting it down on the counter. She uses the end of her hooked prosthetic to cut into the tape sealing it shut and procures a plastic cup from within.

Catra stares at it blankly as she wipes her hands on her jean shorts. "Right. Of course."

She takes the cup from Scorpia's outstretched hand and runs the faucet again, filling it about halfway before gulping more water down. Only when she's finished does she sigh and lean against the counter, drumming her nails against the cheap plastic counter and looking around the apartment.

It's small, but bigger it appeared in all the pictures Scorpia had sent her. A cozy fit for three people, for sure, but probably just right enough for two. She has a perfect vantage point of the living room from where she was leaning, the large double windows staring back at her and beyond that a neighboring apartment building.

The new apartment was hardly an improvement from their last one. Same size, basically the same price, only a different location further into the city. But Catra didn't comment on it. She knew the months of stressful searching that Scorpia endured to find this place and didn't want to mock all that time and effort. Scorpia claimed it was to be closer to Entrapta's job for a shorter commute. But Catra had the sneaking suspicion it had something more to do with their last landlord finding out about Entrapta's home-based experiments.

Instead Catra clicks her tongue as she assesses the wall to her right, particularly eyeing a large spot of white spackled to cover up damages - a rushed job. "Well, arguably better than the last dump you were at."

Scorpia beams at her and reaches into the box again, pulling out another plastic cup where the decorative paint is fading, but Catra can still make out the broken image of some TV show character on the side. "It's in such a nice neighborhood, too! We're only a couple blocks away from the park, you know, the one where I like to go and draw at on some weekend afternoons? I've been looking at places around here for awhile but a lot of buildings around here have been changing management so often that most of my other applications kept falling through. I've already talked to some of the people in this building though! Although, most of them seemed to be pretty busy when I saw them so I was only able to ask them a few questions but they seemed very nice! And they allow pets! At least, I *think* they do. I don't remember the application or website saying anything about not allowing them, but I've *definitely* heard some dogs around here so I think it's safe to say they do."

Catra cast a wary glance over to Entrapta, now practically hanging on the edge of the cardboard box which really shouldn't have been able to support her weight, and clicked her tongue again. Right. A dog and Entrapta?

Scorpia catches onto her drift immediately. "Oh no! Not for us, although I'd *love* to adopt a little Yorkie or Shih Tzu! Maybe a Pomeranian? I've also heard that Labs are really friendly and they're so *cute* and smart and….um, wait...Right! I just like seeing them around the building. They're so adorable, ya know?"

Catra scrunches her nose and hops up on the counter. "I guess. Never really been much of-"

"A dog person, right, I know. But I think I've seen some cats around here somewhere too! I think a cat would be-"

"A pet person," Catra cuts in, shutting down Scorpia's train of thought before she can finish it. "Never been one for pets really." She leans over to the faucet again and fills up her cup again, taking a small sip.

Scorpia pouts. "But they're companions for life!"

Catra scoffs at that. "Life? More like a few years before they get lost or die of old age…." But when she notices Scorpia's rapidly falling expression, she clears her throat and kicks her feet. "But yeah. I guess they're kinda cute or whatever. But they're too much work for me." She lifts her cup to her lips, giving the conversation enough pause to hopefully let Scorpia become distracted with something else.

She doesn't have to because Entrapta finally emerges from the cardboard box in the living room, hair slightly disheveled and hand triumphantly clutching some...weird techno-gizmo Frankenstein abomination. "But you seem fine with kids and from what I've heard and read, they're just as much work if not *more*. Although, from what I understand, kids and pets aren't really that different in terms of feeding, care, stimulation-"

Catra barely hears any of Entrapta's babble, however, because she's too busy recovering from choking on her water. Gasping for breath and eyes bulging, she rasps out, "I'm sorry, *what*?"

"Well in the most basic aspects, kids and pets are actually very similar when you take into account-"

"No no no." Catra shakes her head and rubs the ache in her chest. "What's this about me being fine with kids? When the hell did I ever say that?"

Entrapta is barely paying her any mind at this point, already fiddling with the contraption in her hands. She's deep enough in it that Catra has to repeat her question with a little more force, but even then Entrapta only gives a half-hearted shrug. "You didn't," she says simply and when she doesn't immediately follow up with

an explanation, Catra gets ready to say something, but then she twists something on the device and it lets loose a screeching alarm and they all flinch simultaneously. Catra raises her hands to her ears and Scorpia hunches her shoulders in pain. Mostly unperturbed, Entrapta nonchalantly pulls a screwdriver from her ponytail and messes with the device a little, before the noise finally stops.

Before anyone can make a comment or Catra can grit out some sort of annoyed response about what just happened, Entrapta continues where she had left off. "But you are in the process of talking to Adora again and she has a kid. So given both of those factors as well as previous evidence of your feelings for her, I've concluded that you are, on some level, fine with kids." She finally looks up from her device and tucks the screwdriver back into her hair. "Am I wrong?"

There's a moment where Catra struggles to process the absolute crazy ass-backwards turn this conversation has taken. Mentally she's sputtering for some kind of response, *trying* to come up with something snarky to deflect or derail the road she's fearing this is about to go down. Instead, she barely manages to stammer out, "I...what...*how* do you know Adora has a kid?" She looks to Scorpia and when she sees the girl's eyebrows raise in surprise before a shine falls over her eyes, she knows that was the *wrong* thing to say.

Deny everything. She should've denied *everything*.

But...they would've found out eventually so what good would that have done? And clearly Entrapta already *knew* so lying about it wouldn't have really helped her out any regardless.

"Adora has a kid?"

Entrapta tucks her device into the front pocket of her overalls and pulls out her phone. Even though Scorpia's question was directed at Catra - who was now hunched up on the counter trying to

make herself as small as possible - she takes the liberty of answering herself. "Of course. It's all over her social media."

"How are *you* Adora's friend on any social media?"

"I'm not."

A pause. Both women in the kitchen are struggling to process what's going on; Scorpia surely trying to come to terms with the fact that Catra has clearly been withholding information about her recent reconnection with her age-old best friend while Catra is trying her damnedest not to explode, something already increasingly impossible in the heat of the apartment. Then…

"Entrapta! Have you been hacking people's profiles again?"

Entrapta shakes her head vehemently, but is too busy scrolling through her phone to look up at Scorpia's decidedly disappointed expression. At least, Catra's sure that's what the older woman is trying to shoot for. Negative emotions aren't really something the big softie wears well.

"It doesn't really constitute as hacking, I think, unless-"

"Yes it does!" both her and Scorpia shout in unison.

Entrapta sighs. "I prefer to label it more as utilizing an already defunct security system to bypass a flimsy network to-"

"That's *hacking*, Entrapta!" Catra interjects. "And it's a total invasion of Adora's and *my* privacy."

"I didn't gain access to your account, though."

Catra rolls her eyes upwards and runs her hand through her hair, pulling out a few strands in her frustration. "It's still my life, Entrapta! You had no right! And if Adora finds out somehow, she'll be pissed and I'll have to start all over again or…" She shakes her head and sighs, deflating instantly. Lethargic from the heat and shock from the situation, she quickly realizes she actually doesn't

have the heart to yell at her friend. "Please just tell me you didn't do anything too bad."

The following silence isn't comforting. Catra slowly raises her head, dread weighing like sandbags in her heart, but she freezes when she sees that Entrapta is now leaning over the opposite counter, phone outstretched for both her and Scorpia to see. On the screen is Adora's social media page - Facebook apparently. But more compelling is the image displayed fully on the screen depicting a very haggard-looking Adora donned in a paper hospital gown printed with lame, desaturated flowers. Her hair is a mess and sweat-soaked to her forehead, eyes sunken with ten-pound bags underlining them. Regardless her eyes are bright and full of warmth and shining with life. A brilliant grin is nearly splitting her face in two, as full of resilience and shine as her eyes.

And a little further down, cradled in her arms is a tiny bundle of blankets. From within those blankets emerges a tiny flushed and rounded face, twisted in the discomfort of new surroundings and sensations, clearly unhappy to be there.

"Isn't it just so cute?" Entrapta trills.

Catra gulps, eyes glued on the screen until Scorpia snatches it from Entrapta's hand to gain a closer look. All traces of disappointment and exasperation have vanished from her demeanor - not that they had that strong of a hold to begin with - and is now replaced by a pure, unbridled awe as she's entirely captivated by the photo. "Ohhh, she's so cute! Is this her? What's her name? I still can't believe that Adora has a kid!" Then she looks up at Catra and she nearly flinches at the look of absolute adoration emanating from her. "Catra why didn't you tell us?"

Catra swallows and licks her bottom lip. "I…" Because she *knew* this would happen. She knew she would be bombarded with questions, some she isn't ready to answer, some she doesn't know *how* to answer. This is all new for her too, and she's still trying her best to process it as best she could while trying to rebuild decades of friendship lost in barely half that time. And

having to work through all of that *and* sate both Scorpia and Entrapta's unbearable curiosity…

"I didn't think it was my place to tell," she offers lamely instead.

That sobers Scorpia immediately and she hands off the phone back to Entrapta before taking a step towards Catra. "Oh gee, sorry, Wildcat. I didn't mean...if you don't want to talk about it anymore we can go back to unpacking and maybe when Entrapta gets the TV set up we can binge that new show I've been telling you about. You know, the one I've been trying to get you to watch for awhile now? The new season is supposed to come out in a couple more weeks which is just enough time to catch you up on the other five seasons-"

Catra holds a hand up and Scorpia halts immediately. "No. It's cool, it's fine, I...you already know so I guess we could talk about it or whatever." She sighs. "But I don't know a lot either so there's not really a lot I can tell you."

That cheers her up immediately and, as if her mood had never taken a dip at all, Scorpia dives back into her questions immediately. "What's her name? How old is she now?"

"Mara." She chews on her thumbnail. "And she just turned four."

It takes everything within Scorpia not to melt on the spot then and there. "Four! Oh gosh! She's probably even cuter now, *oh* toddlers are so adorable! Have you met her?"

"Er, once, yeah. The first time I bumped into Adora actually, at the grocery store."

Scorpia nods. "Yeah, yeah! Is she as cute as I think she is? Does she look like Adora?"

A flash of an image of Mara's scrunched nose flitters about in her mind. "Yeah, she does actually."

And of course, Entrapta chooses that moment to chime in with her own question, devoid of any and all tact. "Do you know who the father is?"

Catra noticeably tenses and Scorpia looks worried for half a second before Catra completely shrugs it off, playing it coolly. "Adora hasn't told me that yet."

Scorpia seems ready enough to accept that at face-value, but Entrapta chimes in again, with arguably less tact than before. "Does Adora know who the father is?"

Catra trips over her words for a second before hurriedly collecting herself. "Wh-Yes! I'm sure she does! What kind of-"

"Well I was asking because it's really not all that uncommon for the identity of the father to be unknown in these-"

"Look," Catra jumps in and her tone causes both women to snap to attention. "The father thing is...touchy. Adora doesn't want to tell me right now. I'm respecting her decision and so should the two of *you*," she says, adding emphasis by looking pointedly at Entrapta.

Entrapta looks ready to say something else but Scorpia cuts her off. "Right! That's only fair! It's her business after all and if she doesn't want to share that info right now that's her right!" She smiles at Catra. "Still, it's so amazing knowing she has a kid and I haven't even *met* her! You're her best friend, Catra. How do you feel about the whole thing?"

Betrayed. Confused. Hurt.

All those years they'd been best friends, shared their innermost thoughts and secrets, told each other everything and anything...and Catra finds out four years late that Adora has a child. When they were younger, Catra was the first to know everything about Adora: what she scored on tests, the clothes she bought at the mall, when Adora first realized she was bi...she was always number one on Adora's mind.

So one would think that Catra would've known about Adora getting pregnant and having a kid long before now, right?

But when she takes a minute to think about it, she realizes it's not that simple. They'd been having problems in their friendship long before this happened and it was a lack of effort on both their parts that led to them not speaking anymore. It wasn't that strange that Adora hadn't told her about this, but some reason it still hurt on some subdermal level that Catra couldn't reach, no matter how hard she scratched or deep she dived. After all, wouldn't something this big have broken their pact of silence? Shouldn't Adora have reached out and divulged everything, regardless of where their friendship stood?

Catra chews on her nails. Or maybe that's exactly why she hadn't said anything.

"I don't know," she says finally. "I'm still figuring that part out."

Scorpia nods in understanding which irks Catra a little because it makes her feel vulnerable and easy-to-read. But it's difficult to stay annoyed when Scorpia offers a smile. "Well, I'm sure you will, Wildcat. Always were a sharp one, I've said." She then begins rifling through the cardboard box in front of her and Catra takes that as a sign of the conversation ending. Though she's only just leapt off the counter to start rummaging through another box that she hears Scorpia exclaim loudly.

"Oh! Hey, so you know that Entrapta and I are planning on having a housewarming party-" They both ignore the way Entrapta perks up and tilts her head with a surprised "We are?" - "and I think that would be a *great* opportunity for us to officially meet Adora and her little munchkin! You should invite them." Her hands are clutched tightly to her chest, eyes full of brilliant optimism.

It almost pains Catra when she shuts her down with a hard, "No."

"Wh...why not?"

"Because," she sighs and throws both hands into the box she's rifling through, anything to avoid Scorpia's kicked puppy eyes. "We've only just started talking again and I wanna see where this goes before I fully let her back into my life. If I start introducing her to my friends who knows what kind of ideas that'll put into her thick skull?"

"Catra…"

"I said *no*, Scorpia. You're not talking me into this one."

Click. "New analysis entry: Subject appears to be scared of fully reconnecting with past friend. Multiple theories as to the reason behind this observation. Note to self: skim through previous social media posts dating back to the earlier years of their friendship to gather data on the nature of said friendship."

"Entrapta!"

The recorder clicks off and Entrapta stares at her, blatantly unaware. "What?"

Catra grits her teeth and clenches her fists, the pliable material of the cardboard denting beneath her nails. "My social life is not fodder for one of your experiments! Cut the crap!"

"But the dynamics are so interesting-"

"I don't care! Stay out of it!" She huffs and begins to rip things out of the box, plunking them onto the kitchen counter with more force than necessary.

Luckily, Scorpia is there to dispel the tension. "Hooooow abooooout we put on some music and have a fun little party while we unpack? No more talking or...experiments. Just emptying boxes while singing to fun songs!" Even though neither girl answers, Scorpia claps her hands together, taking it as permission to enact her suggestion and pulls out her phone, fiddling for a few seconds before selecting a playlist. Soon enough the apartment is filled

with some dated, upbeat 80s music that has Scorpia swaying happily, Entrapta hushed, and Catra not *as* annoyed.

A couple songs pass by and Catra's moving on to the next box when Scorpia steps closer, keeping her voice low so that Entrapta can't hear from her position across the apartment. "Will you at least think about what I said?"

"Scorpia I *told* you-"

"I know, I know." She holds her hands up in a surrendering gesture. "But will you at least *think* about it? For me?"

Years ago Catra would've snapped and stormed out of the apartment. She would've sulked back to her apartment and stewed over the clear overstep for days, ignoring all attempts at contact from Scorpia in pure spite until she'd calmed down enough to finally relent without apology, both women silently agreeing to never bring up the topic again.

But standing here now, under Scorpia's soft gaze, with sweat dripping down her neck and mind fuzzy from the heat, she feels too exhausted. And somewhere along the way, maybe she's changed.

"Alright. Fine. I'll *think* about it. But don't get your hopes up." Using the back of her hand, she wipes some sweat from her brow. "Now let's see if we can figure out that A/C situation. I'm melting."

Scorpia's smile is enough to burn her to a crisp.

Later that night, when she's messing around on her phone, her thumb mindlessly wanders over to her messaging app. The message is typed out and sent before she allows herself to feel any sort of remorse.

12:03 AM

Catra: Hey Trapta. Can I get that photo you showed us earlier?

Entrapta: [File sent]

Entrapta: I have others. Do you want those too?

Catra scoffs and rolls her eyes, downloading the photo.

12:06 AM

Catra: Nah. And stop hacking people's profiles

Catra: It's weird

Entrapta: It's SCIENCE

Catra: Same difference

Opening the photo, she finds herself staring at it for a few seconds. Then, without much thought or time enough to reconsider, she flips back to the messaging app and types out a short message with the file attached.

12:15 AM

Catra: [File sent]

Catra: Man you look like SHIT

Adora: Catra what the HELL

Catra laughs, only mildly surprised that Adora is still up at this hour.

12:19 AM

Catra: Relax. I stopped Entrapta from going too far

Adora: Catra this is a photo from four years ago!

Catra: And trust me, she wanted to keep going

Catra: And in her defense, you aren't very active on Facebook

Adora: How did she even get this?

Catra: You probably don't wanna know

Adora: ohmygod

Catra: Chill Princess. Entrapta's a super computer genius or whatever

Catra: No ordinary moron could manage what she does

12:27 AM

Adora: She's not the only computer genius out there

Catra: Yeah but she's the only one with a motive

Adora: And what's that?

Catra: Dude if I understood even half the things that go on

in her head I'd probably have to jump off the tallest

building I could find

Catra: Anyways, you free this Friday?

Adora: I have to do this thing for my dad actually

Adora: But I'm free this Saturday

Adora: Why?

Catra: Because from what I recall, drinks are on you

this time

Adora: Okay. Text me a time and place tomorrow

Catra: [Location sent]

Adora: Catra that's a STRIP CLUB

Catra: Geez. Motherhood really has changed you

Adora: Fine. Pay for your own drinks

Catra: Fine fine damn. When'd you stop being fun?

Catra: I'll find somewhere more appropriate XP

12:41 AM

Catra: [Location sent]

Adora: Now was that so hard?

Catra: Not as hard as my dick

Adora: And just when I was beginning to think

you'd grown up a little...

Catra: Where's the fun in that?

Catra: Anyway, see ya Saturday

Adora: If you're good

Catra: I'm ALWAYS good

Adora: Uh huh. Sure

12:52 AM

Adora: And stay off my Facebook

Catra: That was Entrapta

Adora: Her too

Catra turns off her phone and plugs it into her charger. Tucking herself into bed, she lays there for a couple minutes, unable to sleep with a myriad of thoughts racing through her head. Against her better judgement, she unlocks her phone and opens up the photo Entrapta sent her one more time, tracing Adora's tired features. The soft glow of mid-day sun illuminates her profile, swathing her in its light and illuminating her more defining features that Catra knew like the back of her hand.

And then her eyes drop briefly down to the flushed face peeking out from the bundle of blankets and something deep within stirs. Something she can't name.

She shuts off her phone and buries herself underneath her comforter, turning away from her phone entirely.

Something she doesn't want to name.

Chapter End Notes

> Ah jeez it's been awhile. Sorry about that. Once I finished up finals from last semester I went straight into working and prepping for my study abroad trip to Japan. And then once I got back I've just been too tired to do much of anything really.
>
> But finally! Chapter 3! And just in time for us all to be crushed by season 3. So here's some fluff content to mend our hearts :))))

ordinary day

Chapter Summary

> Adora needs a babysitter, Perfuma partakes in nature orgies, and Catra can't pronounce gyro....or CAN she???
>
> Even on her days off, Adora just can't catch a break.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"And….hold."

Adora lets out a rush of air. The muscles in her arms, legs, core….*everywhere* are being stretched to capacity. The familiar burn grows hotter each second she strains to keep still and she furrows her eyebrows in complete and total concentration.

"Adora….*hold*."

Adora groans and shuts her eyes, straining harder. "I *am* holding!"

Perfuma raises an eyebrow, holding her yoga pose with an effortless grace. Her long flaxen hair doesn't have a single strand out of place and Adora opens her eyes in annoyance, feeling herself beginning to wobble. No, no she can *do this*…

A sigh. "Okay. Release."

With a gasp Adora lets herself drop clumsily to the mat beneath her, letting all her crying muscles rest. She lays there, unmoving and internally groaning, watching Perfuma relax from the complicated pose with an air about her that has Adora practically seething with envy. How *does* she do it?

"You seem distracted today."

Adora blinks as she finally sits up, accepting her water bottle when Perfuma hands it over. Pulling open the nozzled top, she sucks down about three mouthfuls before setting it down next to her. Across the way on her own mat, Perfuma sips from her own bottle, legs crossed and back impeccably straight. Even when she isn't actively doing yoga poses invented by contortionists, she still manages to relax into something that makes Adora whimper just looking at her.

These yoga sessions are a recent development. Adora has always prided herself on her athletic build - playing sports since she could walk, making varsity her freshman year of high school on all the teams she tried out for, and being voted MVP for all the college teams she'd joined. All her coaches praised her natural talent and enthusiastic dedication to everything she put her mind to, hyping up her skillsets until her head was inflated enough to pop. She always made a point of staying in shape, going to the gym every other day to do weight training and going for runs on the days in-between. She remembered all her friends' initial disgust when she told them of her workout schedule, often starting before the rise of the sun itself.

So she has many accomplishments to be proud of. Yoga, however, is not her forte. It'd never been something she'd taken interest in, not until sometime shortly after Mara was born.

Perfuma had suggested it maybe about five months after the birth. Adora had been stressed to the high heavens and back over taking care of a newborn and job hunting which, combined with the onslaught of postpartum depression, dug her in such a rut that it was affecting her in every way possible: physically, mentally, and emotionally. Eventually, she had cut out her workout routine entirely, which only served to make everything worse. All of her friends and her family had noticed immediately, but besides Adora's mother, no one really knew how to help.

Until Perfuma.

"Yoga is a good way to release endorphins," Perfuma had explained. "It lifts your spirits and mood exponentially and can be very freeing spiritually."

She'd also gone on into a full-blown tangent about said spiritually and something dealing with...chakras? And a lot of other things that Adora couldn't follow. She eventually agreed to the suggestion if only to get her to stop.

But...it actually ended up helping. It was rocky at first, considering that Adora had to set aside time in her day specifically for Perfuma to come over for sessions. They had started out pretty sparse with them only meeting once a week since it was the most that Adora could spare. Overtime, Adora's overall mood had begun to slope upwards and in only a few months time, she felt like she was getting back to her old self before Mara's birth.

As more time passed, they upped their meetings to twice a week. Even after things had settled down and Adora began to slide more into the role of motherhood, going as far as to even land a steady job that helped regulate her daily routine, the yoga sessions never faltered. Fast forward four years and they were still meeting up one to two times a week.

Regardless, Adora just...isn't good at it. It isn't the same as all the stuff she could achieve with her natural-born athleticism, but she can't deny that it still keeps her mind healthy which ends up bleeding into all the other aspects of her life. All of which still can be *extremely* stressful at times.

"Adora?"

Adora whips her head up to look at Perfuma who's beginning to look exasperated. Oops.

"This is exactly what I'm talking about. Normally your balance is poor but today it's just…" Perfuma winces and that's all she needs to say.

"Oh. Yeah, sorry. I just...I've got a lot on my mind lately," Adora says vaguely.

Perfuma only hums in response before twisting to set her water bottle off to the side. Then she spreads her legs out in front of her, laying her body stomach-down in-between which Adora mirrors. It's one of the easier stretches so she doesn't struggle as much. It also makes talking easier.

"Anything you want to talk about? Yoga is all about freeing the negative energies from your body, but it isn't very helpful if you don't release them from your mind as well."

Adora shifts and she feels something in her lower back shift and pop which sends a shudder throughout her entire body. *Fuck* that felt good. "It's nothing major. I just need someone to watch Mara for me this Saturday. But Bow is going away for the weekend with his dads and Glimmer's doing something with Adam." She perks up and props herself on her elbows. "Hey, are you-"

Perfuma offers her a sad smile and Adora stops in her tracks. "I'm going on a retreat this Friday, I'm afraid. I'll be gone for two weeks."

Adora frowns. "What kind of retreat?"

Her friend visibly brightens and something tells her it was a bad idea to ask. "Oh, I heard about it on one of those Facebook groups I'm apart of! We're going to a mountain range not too far outside of the city, but secluded enough to really connect with nature and rejuvenate our spiritual energies. I've been told it's very enlightening for both the mind and the soul." Then her lips twist into a smirk. "And if I'm lucky perhaps I'll be *enlightened* in other areas as well."

Adora chokes on air and her face burns. "*Perfuma!* Oh my god! I don't need to know!"

Perfuma shrugs and rises up from the position, stretching her arms above her head. "I don't know what you're so fussy about.

It's all for the purpose of letting go of the daily stressors that weigh us down. Nothing to be ashamed of." Adora rises out of the position herself and reaches for her water bottle. Out of the corner of her eye, she notices Perfuma's mischievous expression.

"Speaking of enlightenment, Bow told me you went on a date last week?"

The comment startles Adora so much she knocks over her water bottles and she curses. Luckily, it's closed so nothing spills out, but she still scrambles to try and right it. "I...he said *what*?" Her face is burning again which doesn't do her any favors because now Perfuma looks downright *evil*.

"He didn't give me a lot of details, but he did mention something about you going out with that old friend of yours...Catra, was it?"

Adora rolls her eyes and scoffs, jerking open her water bottle with a little more force than necessary. "It wasn't a *date*. Bow's just exaggerating." She knocks back the bottle and gulps down her water, hoping that it'll cool her down somewhat.

"No judgement here, Adora. The body has many needs that can be addressed by different outlets."

She nearly chokes on her water as she rips the bottle from her lips and a little bit trickles down her chin. "What's *that* supposed to mean?" she asks as she wipes away the dribble with the back of her hand.

Perfuma hums again and drums her fingers against her knee. "Well, for instance, yoga can free up tension in the body and mind. Sex can do the same, just in a different way."

Just like that, her face is on fire once more, this time so fierce it creeps down her neck and burns her ears. "Perfuma shut up *it's not like that!*"

But her friend just shrugs again, standing up with a slight smile. "Like I said, Adora, no judgement from me."

Wanting to change the subject to anything *but* this, Adora decides to backtrack in their conversation. "So you said you were going to be gone for two weeks? I guess that means you're also missing Bow's birthday outing."

At the mention of Bow, Perfuma seems to sober up a bit. She sighs and bends over to begin rolling up her mat, prompting Adora to get up to do the same. "It's unfortunate, but yes. I have plans to make it up to him, though!"

There's a nervous air about her, something that's just so *off* in regards to Perfuma and Adora raises one of her eyebrows, frowning deeply. "You haven't told him yet, have you?"

Perfuma pauses and purses her lips. It's all the answer Adora needs.

"You should probably do it sooner than later. We both know how Bow gets if you just drop things like that on him."

"I plan to...sometime later this week." She picks up her mat and fastens the clasps around it to keep it from unrolling before stuffing it into her tote bag. It's an ugly shade of brown with a pink flower printed on it - biodegradable as Perfuma likes to remind them all every chance she gets. Got it from a farmer's market. Collecting her water bottle, she shoves that in there too.

Taking from Adora's book of changing subjects, Perfuma turns to her with a smile. "Soooo….you said you needed someone to watch Mara this Saturday? Is it another date?"

"For the last time, Perfuma, it's not-"

"You should check in with Mermista," Perfuma continues, completely ignoring her. Adora huffs and crosses her arms. "She might be free this weekend." She picks up her bag and slings it over her shoulder, shooting Adora a wink as she stands. "It'd be a shame if you had to miss it. You seem like you could use the release."

Adora bristled and rolled her eyes heavenwards, silently wishing that Perfuma gets eaten by a bear on her retreat. "Yeah. Okay. Thanks."

When she returns her gaze back to earth, Perfuma has her phone in hand, scrolling through something on her phone. "Well, I should be off then. I have a lot of preparations to make before this Friday. Oh! Also none of you will be able to reach me while I'm away, so I'll talk to you when I get back!" She begins to head towards the door and Adora follows to walk her out.

It isn't until she's out the door with Adora standing in the doorway that she winks at her again, a wide smile revealing her teeth and the tip of her tongue poking out between them. "Tell me all about your date next session?"

Adora narrows her eyes, hand already on the door to shut it. "Good*bye*, Perfuma."

She hears Perfuma laugh as she shuts the door and even still when it's closed and her friend is walking down the hallway. She locks the door with all the force she can muster before sighing and resting her head against the painted wood, taking a moment to revel in the peace and quiet.

She doesn't let the moment last too long, however. She has a few things to straighten up around the apartment before she has to go pick up Mara. It isn't too often she gets days off of work, but rather than using them as an actual break from the daily stressors of her life, she still tries to be productive around the house. Living with a four-year-old left little room for things like that, so she has to take advantage of the extra free time where she can.

She's about half-way done with wiping down the kitchen when she remembers Perfuma's suggestion. And no, not the sex thing but about asking Mermista to watch Mara. Setting down the spray bottle she's using to clean, she pulls her phone out of her pocket and dials Mermista's number and chews on her thumbnail as it rings.

It only takes about three rings before she hears Mermista's dry voice greet her.

"Hey, Mermista. How are you?"

There's a groan through the receiver, one full of agony and aggravation. "Don't get me started on any of that. Work has been a pain but Sea Hawk has been *insufferable* lately."

Adora smiles and leans forward on the counter. "You mean more than usual?"

Another groan. "I told him I'd be swamped with work all this week and to leave me alone for awhile. But he somehow got the bright idea to send me gift packages. Every. Day. I nearly threw the last one out the window of my office."

Adora's grin grows. "Nearly?"

There's a short pause. "It had my favorite chocolate and bath salts in it. I wasn't about to waste them."

Adora laughs. "Well at least you know he cares."

"Yeah, maybe a little *too* much."

"I think it's sweet."

Mermista scoffs and Adora can picture her rolling her eyes perfectly. "You would think so, wouldn't you? Anyway, what's up? You need something?"

Adora straightens up. "Yeah, actually. I was hoping you might be able to watch Mara for me this Saturday?" She doesn't mention why. And, thankfully, she knows Mermista won't ask.

She bites her lip nervously regardless. Mermista isn't the prying type, but she remembers how news of her rekindled friendship with Catra was already spread around so far without her knowledge. She'd only told Glimmer, the first night that she had

her babysit Mara, and she figured that Glimmer told Bow because they told each other *everything*. But now she knows that Bow let it slip to Perfuma which could easily mean that somehow Mermista knows…

Adora hears Mermista sigh and her body locks up in apprehension, her fingers anxiously drumming on the countertop. She starts conjuring up explanations, ready to argue her point…

"I can't actually, sorry. Apparently Sea Hawk has booked us some kind of mini vacay this weekend. At least, that's what the note on the last gift basket said."

Adora lets out a breath she wasn't aware she was holding and slumps over in pure relief. Then, the words register and she slumps even further. She's running out of options. "Oh. Alright then. Where are you guys going?"

Mermista scoffs. "Do you even have to ask? *Another* beachtown."

"Well, you two *do* love the beach…"

"Yeah well, at least it's not one of Perfuma's hippie retreats. Hey, speaking of, why don't you ask Perfuma?"

Adora sighs and props her head up in her hand, rolling her neck. "She was just over here, actually. She's going away for two weeks. In fact, *she* told me to ask *you*." Her friends had her running in circles. At this rate, she wouldn't have anyone to watch over Mara. And then she'd have to cancel her date - *outing* with Catra.

Dammit Perfuma.

"Figures she's going off on another orgyfest even though she *just* got back from one."

Adora winces. "I *really* wish you wouldn't call them that."

Mermista laughs, short and vaguely condescending. "I'm not wrong."

Adora opens her mouth to retort when she hears a door opening in the background and a distant voice addressing Mermista who, in turn, gives a short reply. Pushing herself off of the counter, she straightens up and gathers up her cleaning tools again, balancing her phone on her shoulder. "Sounds like you're busy, so I'll leave you to it. Have fun on your date this weekend," she adds with a teasing lilt.

Mermista groans, but there's no malice to it. In fact, Adora knows her friend well enough by this point to tell that she has a grin on her face (not that she'd *ever* admit that to anyone). "Yeah, yeah. Good luck with finding a babysitter. I'll talk to you later." Then the line goes dead.

Plucking the phone from her ear, Adora pockets it with a dejected sigh. Well, that's four friends out. Her own brother included.

Spraying down the counter with cleaner, Adora tears off fresh paper towels from the roll and begins scrubbing it down. Her thoughts drift to her friends' busy lives and how easily and carelessly they could make plans. How they could set their minds to something and just do it, without hardly any planning. She supposes it must be nice.

Her on the other hand? She doesn't get to go out very often. In fact, the only people she goes out with these days are aforementioned friends. Even then though, she always struggles to find a babysitter for Mara, always has to plan further in advance than the rest of their friend group. And when she can't? Well, she always had to cancel, waving them off with promises of a "next time".

Adora frowns and tosses the dirty paper towels in the garbage. Though she supposes that's just what comes with having a kid. Less going out. More staying in. Missed outings and opportunities.

She bites her lip and kicks her feet at the floor, frowning at the scuff marks. And Catra….

Could she accept that? If it ever came to Adora having to cancel on her, would she be able to handle that, or would she realize that Adora is just at a different point in her life now?

Would she feel abandoned again? Betrayed?

Adora raises her head up and sets her jaw. No. She wouldn't let it come to that. Not yet. Not when things were just starting up again.

She heads over to the broom closet and takes out the broom and dustpan, immediately setting to work on the kitchen floor as she runs over the rest of her options. She could always ask Frosta to babysit. She had babysitted for Adora before when Adora needed it. And now that she was starting her first year of college, Adora was sure she could use the money.

She chews on her lip. Then again, she's sure that Frosta also is still adjusting to her classes and load of homework and could be using her weekends for something more productive than watching a four-year-old. Plus, she knows what college kids *really* liked to on the weekends, and she just isn't sure if it's fair to ask Frosta to spend one of them watching over her kid.

Adora thinks back to how her senior year was dull and lifeless, consumed with doctor's visits and focusing on homework and staying on track, and realizes that's not something she wishes on Frosta.

That just leaves her parents then, really. They're probably the most reliable ones out of the bunch, with little need to party on weekends or go on extravagant vacations. They're parents themselves, and had likely gone through the same thing multiple times with her and Adam. Plus her mom was always telling her how much they *loved* spending time with their granddaughter, so it's not like she's really putting them out.

Still, she hates falling back on them when she doesn't have any other option. They already do so much for her and Mara both. Adora hates to think she's taking advantage of that kindness. Especially to go out drinking at a bar.

Even still, she finds herself digging into her back pocket again, dialing her mom's number. She doesn't answer as quickly as Mermista had, but as soon as she hears her mother's trilling voice she smiles. "Hi, Mama."

"Adora! Hey, Sweetie. How are you?"

Adora tucks the phone between her shoulder and ear so she can resume sweeping. "I'm doing okay. Work's kept me busy enough and Mara's kept me-"

Her mother's good-natured chuckle cuts her off. "Busier? How is my little baby doing?"

"She's good." She bends down to start collecting dust into the dustpan, balancing both her phone and the broom handle against opposite shoulders. "She's at school right now, though I'll have to go pick her up in a bit." Before her mom can interject again, she quickly dives into her question. "Hey, so we're still good to come up on Friday, right?"

"Of course, dear! Your father's been going *mad* trying to figure out how to update his website. I told him to just wait for you because he'll lose all his hair otherwise. But," she sighs and Adora laughs. "Well, you know your father. Stubborn. Doesn't want to burden you when he knows you're so busy with your own job. You're *just* like him in that regard."

Adora clicks her tongue and scrunches up her nose. "I resent that."

"Sound just like him, too."

Adora rolls her eyes and stands up, dumping the dirt into the trash. "Yeah, yeah. Just remember you *chose* to marry him. This

one's on you, Mom."

Call it mother-daughter intuition, but Adora can practically *feel* her mom rolling her eyes at that statement. "Whatever gets me into Heaven."

Adora hums and walks over to place the broom back in the closet. "Hey, so, I was wondering - when we come up this Friday - if we could just stay the night there? I, uh...I have something to do Saturday night and I need someone to watch Mara. So I was kind of hoping I could just leave her at your house and come pick her up on Sunday?"

"Well of course you can!" Adora smiles and sighs in relief. "You know how much we love having her around."

Adora nods and smirks. "Yeah, and I know she'd just *love* a weekend at Grandma's." She could already envision the way Mara's face would light up when she told her. "Just...not too many snacks this time, okay?"

"Well, if she doesn't eat them I will. And I know I need to start laying off the cookies."

Adora rolls her eyes and groans. "Then stop *buying* them, Mom!"

"Then what else will Mara eat when she comes to visit?" she asks.

Knowing that she'll just end up talking herself in circles, Adora decides to drop the conversation. Her mom is never going to listen to her so she's not even sure why she tries. She pulls on her ponytail. She wonders if this is what her mom went through with *her* mother when her and Adam were kids. "Fine, Mom. Whatever. Just promise me you'll feed her some real food in-between?"

Her mom hums in thought. "Well, I was planning on making some pastitsio for when you two came on Friday. And then your father and I were just going to have some leftovers after you left, but I

suppose I could go to the store and find something else to cook for Saturday. Does Mara still like spaghetti?"

Adora groans again and leans against the kitchen table. A quick glance to the clock tells her that she needs to leave soon to pick Mara up on time. "I'm sure whatever you make will be fine, Mom. To be honest, you don't have to make anything else but if you do just pick whatever you want out."

"Oh! What about Swedish meatballs? Does Mara like those? I'm sure your father has a family recipe around here somewhere…"

Exasperated, Adora grit out between clenched teeth, "I said whatever is *fine*, Mom. She's not a picky kid."

"Right, right. Just like your brother. You were always the more troublesome one."

Adora's jaw drops and she frowns. "I was not!"

"Oh yes you were. Ask your father. It was nearly *impossible* to get you to eat anything other than chicken nuggets and ravioli for a whole year!"

Adora groans and drags her hand down her face. At this rate, she would be late. She has to get her mom off the phone now. "Okay, Mom. Whatever you say. I'll call you later, okay?"

"Wait! Has Mara had baklava before? I can make some for this weekend!"

"*Bye*, Mother!"

She hears her mom huff over the phone. She would laugh if she wasn't so exasperated at this point. "Okay, fine. Just ask her and text me, will you? I'll go to the store tomorrow to pick everything up."

"Okay, yeah. I will. I have to go now or I'll be late picking her up. I'll talk to you later."

"Oh. Right. Yes, you should go and do that. I won't keep you any longer." *Then let me go!* "I'll tell your father you called. And I'll see you this Friday?"

"Yes, you will. I'll call you later this week, okay? Bye. I love you."

"Right. I love you too, Sweetie. Bye."

Before her mother can change her mind or catch her again, Adora hangs up. She throws her head back and exhales a long, drawn out breath, giving herself a moment to decompress. She loves her mom. More than anything or anyone in the world. But dear *god* did the woman know how to talk.

Giving herself just a few more seconds, Adora pushes herself off the kitchen table and goes to the door to pull on her shoes, grabbing her keys off the hook next to the door. After straightening her ponytail, she opens the door to leave her apartment and heads down the hall to the elevator.

Just as the elevator doors close, she gets a text. With a roll of her eyes and a quiet groan, she pulls her phone from her pocket, expecting to see a text from her mother.

Instead, it's Catra's name that pops up.

2:33 pm

Catra: Hey. Was wondering if you maybe wanted to

grab a bite before we go to the bar this Saturday?

Catra: I know a place just around the corner

that makes pretty mean gyros.

Catra: Well, not as good as your mom's but still

Adora smiles and pulls up the keyboard to type out her message.

Adora: Only if you promise to pronounce

gyro the correct way

Catra: Easy. Ji-rows

Adora: Fine. No homemade baklava for you

The elevator doors open and Adora rushes through the lobby to the door leading to the parking garage, beelining straight for her car. Once she's settled in and has turned the key in the ignition, she receives another text.

2:41 pm

Catra: No way. Mama Hart is making baklava and

you're not gonna SHARE?

Catra: You selfish whore

Adora bites her lip to reign in her smile. She types out a quick message and pulls out of the parking spot, heading to Mara's school to pick her up.

Adora: Play nice and I'll bring you some pastitsio too ;)

Chapter End Notes

Fun fact: I'm actually not a big fan of baklava

Man I really just have a knack for updating this fic after season premieres, huh? Welp, see you guys after season 5.

(I'm kidding)

(Probably)

This chapter was actually supposed to end after Adora called Mermista because that's as far as I had planned. I was originally just going to imply that Adora had gotten her parents to watch Mara next chapter, but something possessed me and I ended up writing Adora actually calling her mom. So you guys got bonus content. Lucky you.

Adora's mom is really just a combination of my own mother and grandmother. I, too, suffer because my grandmother talks forever on the phone. And some of those lines are taken directly from conversations my mom and I have had (my mother always makes the "whatever gets me into heaven" joke when I tell her that she made the choice to marry my father).

Also, Adora's full last name is Hartvigsen. Bonus points to anyone who can guess the origin/language AND what it means. Please humor me. I spent hours looking up surnames for all these characters. (Hint: if you look it up it's going to say it's German which isn't necessarily wrong but not what I found when I was looking up names for Adora's family. Happy hunting)

If you wanna stay updated on the progress of any of my fics (including this one!) take a look at my profile. I have all my

progress updates there.

throws me back to when i had you closer

Chapter Summary

Adora wets herself over muscles, Catra's short (but what else is new), and I kinda want the bartender to raw me on the bar top which is kinda sad because I made her up. RIP me

Also, the biggest question that everyone's been asking since the beginning is FINALLY ANSWERED: Why did Catra cut her hair???

(Oh and I guess Mara's dad is mentioned a couple times? idk)

Chapter Notes

HEY QUICK IMPORTANT ANNOUNCEMENT // TRIGGER WARNING

Okay, I just want to be safe and include a sexual assault//tw at the beginning of this chapter. Nothing actually happens and it's not even a description, there's just a super brief mention of it while Catra and Adora are talking towards the end of the chapter.

I don't think it's anything major but I wanna include it JUST IN CASE, so just know that it's mentioned around the part where Catra and Adora are standing outside Adora's apartment door.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The elevator dings off to her left just as she refreshes her Twitter feed for the fourth time in the fifteen minutes she's been standing there. Lazily she tears her gaze away from her phone screen, half-expecting to see another older woman shuffling into the lobby or maybe even another older man smirking at her unabashedly. Instead, the person she's been waiting for is walking towards her,

her steps quick and slightly awkward in wedge heels and adjusting her falling purse strap.

"Sorry! I couldn't find my phone and didn't know you were already here." Adora stops in front of her, a little out of breath but still making it look flawless. "You're earlier than you said you'd be."

"I take my role as the punctual one in this friendship very seriously, you know," Catra drawls, unable to keep the grin from creeping onto her face. She's just teasing. That's the reason.

Adora looks down at the phone limply clutched in her hand, pursing her lips and leaning forward. "Haven't you stalked my Facebook enough?"

Catra scoffs and pockets her phone. "That was Entrapta. I had no part in it. And I already told her to stop. That's about all I can do for ya." She twirls her key ring around her finger as she pushes herself from the wall she's leaned against. "Ready to go?"

Adora nods and they head over to the door that leads into the parking garage adjacent to the apartment building. When they reach Catra's motorcycle, Catra picks up a helmet and hands it over to Adora and watches as she adjusts her hair - styled into a top knot - so she can fit it to her head. Eyes raking down the rest of Adora's outfit, Catra bites the tip of her tongue to stifle a laugh.

Pausing, Adora sends her a look. "What?"

"You're all dressed up this time. Tryin' to impress me or something, Princess?"

As if she'd forgotten what she was wearing, Adora looks down at her sheer white, sleeveless blouse and high-waisted, loose black shorts, accented with a red leather jacket. She shuffles in place before looking up at Catra, an adorable pout on her lips. "I felt underdressed the last place you took me to. Just trying to dress for the location this time." Then her eyes fall onto Catra, giving her a quick once-over. "I'm not sure you're allowed to talk though."

Catra tugs on her red plaid skirt and kicks one of her legs up, revealing the fishnet stockings tucked into black ankle boots. "I'm *always* dressed to kill. Or have you forgotten already?"

Adora smirks. "How could I forget with how many times you got sent to the principal's office for a dress code violation?"

"Those rules were bullshit and we both know it, Adora!"

She shrugs and tugs the motorcycle helmet onto her head and gestures for Catra to put on her own. "Whatever. I'm starved, let's go."

Grumbling, Catra follows suit before climbing onto her bike, waiting for Adora to climb on behind her before starting up the engine. Predictably, the girl jumps and Catra laughs as she pulls out and drives out of the garage, taking to the road. As they pick up speed, she feels Adora's arms tighten around her midsection and her knees dig into the sides of her thighs as she scoots closer. Ignoring the way her heart stutters in her chest, she grins and turns the handles more, revving the engine and picking up speed.

Adora's frantic voice can hardly be heard over the wind rushing past them. "Is it too much to ask for you to *not* kill us?"

"What?" She revs the engine again, the bike stuttering for a second before picking up more speed. "I can't hear you!"

"Catra!"

Her shoulders shake with laughter as she lets off the gas to fall within the constraints of the speed limit once more. She feels Adora relax against her and has half the mind to speed up again.

There's no need, however. In just another two minutes they arrive at their destination. Nestled in the middle of a small shopping strip is a narrow brick and mortar Greek restaurant. A small outdoor seating area is sectioned off by a black iron fence, littered with spaced round tables topped off with blue and white umbrellas. A few groups of people are already seated outside, and at the far

end a separate group of people fiddling with a sound system. The people outside are all chatting with one another and the band members, laughing over buckets of beer and baskets of half-eaten food.

As soon as Catra parks Adora hops off, practically ripping the helmet off her head and breathing in deeply. Taking her time, Catra gets off as well, removing her helmet as Adora begins to fix her hair that was squished from the confines of the helmet. After putting change into the parking meter, the two women head towards the storefront where Catra holds open the door for Adora. Receiving an appreciative smile for the gesture, she follows Adora inside where both are immediately greeted with an array of smells of fresh, hot food.

One of the front employees standing behind the counter shoots them a smile, shouting out a greeting. "Welcome to Meat&Greek! Sit anywhere you like and when you're ready to order you can come right up here!"

Adora voices her thanks as they both walk towards the counter to parse through the menu hung above the counter. Catra shoves her hands into her pockets, lazily sifting through all the options until Adora nudges her.

"What do you recommend?"

Catra raises an eyebrow. "You're asking me?"

When Adora puffs out her cheeks in frustration it takes every ounce of self-restraint in Catra not to poke one of them and watch her deflate. "You're the one who's been here before."

She shrugs and looks back over the menu. "Honestly I've only had their gyros." She smirks at the way Adora bristles over the deliberate mispronunciation but doesn't address it. "Can't really vouch for the rest of their food."

"Okay then. I'll have a *gyro,*" Adora states, slowly enunciating the last word with a pointed look. Then her eyes flicker over to the

menu again. "Maybe a spanakopita too."

"You mean the spana-copeeta?"

"I really….*really* hate you."

She snickers as Adora brushes past her to go to the counter and place her order. The woman diligently types it in, only interrupting to ask clarifying questions. As soon as Adora's finished, Catra chimes in with her own order which is similar to what Adora requested, patiently waiting as the cashier rings it all up. Once she's finished, she looks up with a smile.

"Any drinks?"

Adora glances behind the counter and Catra follows her gaze to the beer cooler. She chews on her bottom lip, raising her chin to glance over and peruse all the options. "Do you have any Greek beers?"

"Of course! Though the only two we have are Mythos and Fix."

Silent as she ponders, Adora nods her head slowly. Then, "I think I'll take a Mythos."

The woman asks for Adora's ID and as she's digging through her purse to find it, Catra steps up again, ordering a soda for herself. After everything is sorted out, the cashier recites their order back before announcing the total.

Catra has her card ready before Adora can pry hers out of her wallet. When she receives a cold glare, she shrugs and smiles toothily at her. "You're already paying for our drinks later. I suggested we get dinner beforehand, so this one's on me."

"You're just trying to one up me. I can tell."

"Maybe I'm just better at this game than you."

The cashier tells them their order number and their wait time and hands Catra a cup for her soda. When she walks over to the soda fountain to fill it up, Adora follows her, beer in hand.

"Go find us a seat. If you go outside, I can stay in here until our food's ready."

"You sure?"

Catra nods and gestures for Adora to go along and, after only one more moment of hesitation, she complies. As she waits for the food, Catra sips on her soda and passively watches some football game on the screen, uninterested but without much better to do. Soon enough, her order number is called and she walks over to the window to pick up the tray with their plates of food precariously arranged on top. Keeping the tray balanced on just one hand with her drink in the other, she weaves through the tables towards the door leading to the outdoor seating. Adora is casually sipping her beer at one of the few unoccupied tables seated further from the band, head in hand as she watches them set up.

With a flourish, Catra dumps the tray onto the table, smirking at how Adora jumps at her sudden arrival. "Two *ji-rows* and a *spana-copeeta*."

Adora narrows her eyes and takes her two plates off the tray. "I'm banning you from anything and everything Greek from this point forward."

Catra rolls her eyes as she slides into the seat opposite Adora. "Oh please. Like you could properly pronounce even a fraction of the dishes my family makes."

Adora goes red at that and hunches her shoulders up. "Well...at least I don't mispronounce them on *purpose*."

"Yeah, but you look so adorable when you get all riled up." She gathers up her gyro and takes a huge bite of it, watching as Adora grows even redder. She chuckles around a mouthful of food as

Adora breaks eye contact and digs into her own plate, mumbling a quiet "shut up".

The girls eat in relative silence for a moment, but about halfway through her own gyro, Catra finally speaks up. "So we talked about me last time. I'd say it's your turn now."

Adora's eyebrows shoot up and she raises her hand to her mouth, trying to catch the lettuce dangling from her lips. It's almost a panicked look and it only takes Catra a second to realize what it must've sounded like.

"I meant about what you're doing now," she clarifies. "For instance, where are you working?"

Just as she thought, Adora seems to calm down and she slowly finishes chewing her food before answering. "I'm at this tech company uptown. Right around the business district."

Now it's Catra's turn to be surprised. She feels her eyebrows lift drastically and she leans forward on both her elbows. "Really? And what do you do there?"

A short laugh devoid of humor leaves Adora's lips accompanied by an eyeroll. "I'm basically an over-glorified secretary."

"Oh." Catra settles back into her seat and starts munching on her fries. "That sounds like it sucks."

"Well…" Adora takes a thoughtful sip of her beer, eyes looking past Catra. Something in her expression says that she agrees wholeheartedly with Catra, but then it softens. "It's steady pay."

Catra laughs and takes a sip of her own drink, picking up another fry. "I hear that." She pops the fry into her mouth, chewing for a second before asking, "Weren't you in college for marketing or something like that?"

The way that Adora's eyes widen conveys that she's surprised that Catra remembers that. "Um, yeah. Sports marketing, more

specifically."

"So what happened to that?"

Adora looks down at her plate, picking at her fries before picking one up and dipping it in her blob of ketchup. "I, er….didn't get any internships. So I wasn't exactly hiring material when I graduated."

Catra frowns. Adora? Miss Overachiever not getting any internships? "And why didn't you-" She cuts herself off abruptly, answering her own question in her mind. *Right*.

Adora nods, knowing exactly what conclusion Catra came to. "No one really wants to hire a twenty-one-year-old pregnant intern. And even less people want to hire a fresh-out-of-college graduate with a newborn."

"So...how did you land the job you're at now?"

At this point, Adora's switched over to her second plate and is picking apart the spinach pie with a fork. "Glimmer's mom had some connections. Got me a low-level entry position." She shoves a forkful into her mouth, eyes lighting up briefly. "Oh wow you should try this." She scoops up another piece onto her fork and Catra takes it, warily staring at it before taking a bite.

After chewing for a few seconds, she hands the fork back to Adora. "Not bad." Adora seems to take that as an acceptable enough answer - that or she really didn't care too much - because she's digging into it again. "Do they have a marketing team there? I'd imagine so if they're a tech company."

Adora grimaces and sets the fork down, returning to her fries. "Yeah, they do. But it's practically impossible to move up there without putting an ungodly amount of hours in and, well...I can't exactly do that right now."

Catra nods and decides to leave it there. Instead, she switches to another topic. "So why the long hair? I remember you

complaining all throughout high school if it so went so much as an inch past your shoulders."

Adora tugs on the bottom of her hair, twirling a strand between her finger and thumb. "Oh, yeah. Well, I actually kept it pretty short until somewhat recently. But Mara likes playing with it and braiding it so I guess I just...let it grow out to make it easier for her."

That's the first time that Adora has spoken so casually about her daughter. It sort of throws Catra for a loop, but she recovers quickly with a smile and picks up another fry. "Lemme guess: *Tangled*?"

Adora smiles back and giggles - honest to god *giggles* - before shaking her head fondly. "She loves that movie."

"At this point, what little tyke doesn't?" Catra runs a hand through her hair, bringing her bangs out of her eyes. "It's because of that damn movie that I decided to cut my hair. Paola couldn't wait to get her grubby little hands on it to try it on me and I shut that down immediately."

"Paola?"

Catra blinks before knocking herself in the head. "Right. Duh! I forgot you don't know." She digs into her back pocket for her phone, unlocking it and scrolling through her photo gallery. Once she finds what she's looking for, she turns the phone over to Adora, who takes it in confusion. "Paola's my niece. Carlos had kids - twins, in fact - a few years ago." She leans over to points with a manicured nail at the little girl sitting in Catra's lap. "That's Paola." Then she points to the boy hanging off Catra's shoulder, arms encircling her neck. "And that's Jay, my nephew." She plops backwards into her seat, watching Adora's eyes roam over the photo with an awestruck expression. "Well, his name is actually Carlos Jr., but we all call him Jay to avoid confusion." She sits and munches on another fry. "You know, they're actually about the same age as Mara."

Still staring at the photo, Adora smiles. "They're adorable." Then she looks up with a questioning look in her eyes. "Why didn't you tell me your brother had kids?"

"You didn't tell me *you* had a kid." Immediately, Catra kicks herself. That's probably pushing it too far. Her eyes warily watch Adora's expression, the way her eyes widen and how she's sitting there stock still. She rushes with a way to backtrack or apologize, remorse eating out her insides the longer she takes because *fucking hell* Catra, that's not fair at all!

But Adora purses her lips and shrugs, returning her attention to the photo. "Touché."

Floored by the fact that she somehow managed to dodge that bullet, Catra clears her throat and moves on. "Yeah, I don't get to see them too much since Carlos moved for his job, but they're aggressive little kiddos. Hence why I chopped my hair."

Adora smiles and hands back her phone. "Toddlers are like that," she agrees. Then she leans forward, a devious smirk on her lips and chin resting on her joined hands. "But to think...*Tía Catra*. That's so cute."

"Careful, Hart. Or my soda's going straight into your lap."

Adora takes her warning with a grain of salt. "Who knew you were actually a huge softie?"

"I guess you really wanna wear Dr. Pepper for the rest of the night."

Adora looks ready to say something else when a booming voice interrupts the atmosphere. Both girls startle in their seats before looking over to where the band has apparently finished setting up. There's a bit of banter between the guy with the microphone and the rest of the patrons sitting around them. Then they begin their set and music accents the street.

Catra cringes. It's not to her taste in the slightest. Plus it's so loud that conversation is more difficult considering she could barely hear herself think. When she looks to Adora, it seems she might be thinking the same thing. When she suggests they go inside, Adora agrees with a single nod. The two girls collect their trash and carry it back into the store, emptying it into the trash can right next to the door. They leave their tray and empty plates on the cart next to that and, with a goodbye shouted by the same cashier who rung them up, they leave the restaurant.

Admittedly, Catra's a little disappointed they didn't get to talk more about Adora, but she supposes they would have plenty of time for that later. Still, her curiosity was a bitch, and five years absent of one another held a plethora of untold stories. She almost has half the mind to skip the bar entirely and go somewhere else quiet, but she knows that Adora would probably pitch a fit because she is *determined* to pay for their drinks.

The two women hop back onto Catra's bike and after making sure that Adora's settled in, Catra pulls off to take them to the bar. She considers teasing Adora again by speeding through traffic, but - it must be because of the meal - she can't find it in her to do that again. So their ride is uneventful and, soon enough, Catra's parking in a lot just off to the side of the bar.

It's a different place than last time because, honestly, Catra really didn't like the vibe from the previous bar. Too many people barely pushed past their teenage years. And the music was pretty lame.

This time she took Adora to one of her regular haunts, a place she goes with to with Scorpia and Entrapta sometimes. She's even taken a few odd dates here. The atmosphere is just as lively, but far less tacky and neo-modernism. Plus, they often have live bands play there - *good* ones - so even the music choices felt a lot more grounded.

As they approach the door, Adora perks up upon seeing the sign. "Oh! I've been here before."

"Yeah?" She holds open the door and gestures for Adora to pass through. "Yeah this is one of my usual spots. The music's cool and the drinks are better, plus you can actually sit in these chairs without your ass going numb." Adora laughs and Catra smirks, her chest feeling light.

The bar is already pretty crowded, which isn't too odd for a Saturday night. The people littering the tables and booths are diverse, ranging from as young as college students to people in their mid-ages. The atmosphere is a little more rustic but far from the traditional bar setting. The lamps lining the edges of the room give off a toxic green lighting. The walls are made up of metal panels, adorned with minimal decoration - graffiti art mostly. The bar is situated against the far right wall, with the dance floor more towards the back, crowned with a low-rise stage where a band is already playing 90's alternative rock covers.

Catra grabs Adora's hand and leads her through the crowd towards the bar where they manage to find a few empty bar stools at the far end. As Catra looks at the drink menu, Adora turns in her stool to look around at the rest of the bar, her gaze roaming over the people clustered everywhere.

"I came here with Glimmer and Bow once," she pipes up, half-shouting over the music. "But they said it creeped them out too much, so we haven't really come back."

Catra raises her eyes over the menu, eyeing Adora carefully. Maybe this wasn't the best place to bring her. "And what about you?"

Adora turns back to her after a few seconds, slowly registering what she's asking. "I don't mind it." And then she smirks, leaning in close. Like she has a secret. Catra finds herself leaning in too. "It actually reminds me a little of that one bar we used to sneak into all the time our senior year."

Catra blinks to jog her memory before letting out a short laugh. "You mean *The Fright Zone*? Adora, I'd hardly call what we did

'sneaking in'. They never even carded us." Then she looks around the room, taking in the decor and aesthetic with a new set of eyes, before she nods. "But yeah. I guess I can see what you mean." Even though *The Fright Zone* was a little more underground...literally. It was in a basement underneath a restaurant and they had to go through a side door tucked into an alley to get in.

Adora is leaning against the bartop now, head in hand and leaning to look at the drink menu too. "I wonder what happened to that place."

"Shut down by now probably. I mean, I'd be surprised if they weren't, considering that they were serving underage kids and had a list of health code and safety violations about as long as I am tall."

"Well that's not very long at all."

Catra growls and reaches over to flick Adora's forehead who's too busy laughing at her own joke to dodge. "Shut up!"

Once they both decide on their drink orders - in-between their bickering - Catra flags down one of the bartenders. They're approached by a dark-skinned woman with a nose ring and undercut wearing a muscle shirt. From the corner of her eye, Catra swears she sees Adora turn pink. "What can I get for you two?"

Catra rattles off her drink order first, a simple enough rum and coke. When it comes to Adora's turn, she fumbles a bit with a shaky smile, eyes not meeting the bartender's gaze. Sure enough, though, she gets through it, hastily adding on an extra shot of rum to her order.

"Got a preference?"

Adora fumbles again, eyes darting down to the menu for a second or two before she waves her hand. "Um...no. Just...bartender's choice?" She looks up again and gasps when the bartender shoots

her a smile, promising them their drinks in a short moment before turning behind her to gather she what needs.

Catra watches as Adora visibly deflates from releasing the breath she was holding. She smirks. "You are *such* a muscle whore."

Adora sits ramrod straight again, the color in her cheeks full darkening before she shoves Catra's shoulder. "I...it's an *appreciation*!"

"A lot like how you 'appreciated' your softball coach's muscles?" she teased.

"I….*no*!"

Catra rolls her eyes and pokes Adora's forehead. "Adora, you can't even weasel you're way out of this one. With how much you used to gush over her whenever I came to pick you up after practice, I was actually beginning to grow a little worried I'd see her mugshot in the news one day."

"Oh come off it! I was not that bad!"

Just then, the bartender returns with their drinks, setting each glass down in front of the one who ordered it. She turns to Adora with a shot glass in one hand with a bottle of Bacardi's in the other. "This okay?"

Adora nods mutely in response, watching as she pours the shot and sets it down in front of her. "Let me know if you guys want anything else." And then she's gone again, off to tend to other waiting patrons.

When Adora looks over to Catra, she's met with a huge shit-eating grin. "You were saying?"

Huffing, Adora crosses her arms. "This changes nothing."

"You don't even *like* Bacardi's."

"You don't know that." And then, as if to prove a point, she takes the shot glass and throws it back all in one fluid motion. For a moment, Catra's actually sort of impressed, but sighs when Adora immediately starts coughing and pounding her chest with a closed fist.

"I don't know which is gonna kill you first: your stubbornness or your horniness for muscles."

"I'm not...oh whatever!" She reaches over and takes a long pull on her other drink, downing about a third of it in one go. "If you wanna play that game, we could always talk about your thing for airheads."

Catra hums and sips on her own drink, nodding sagely. "I do love me some Airheads. Especially the blue ones."

"The blue…?" Adora groans and shakes her head. "Not the candy, moron! You know *exactly* what I'm talking about."

Catra sets her drink down. "I don't think you give the girls I've dated enough credit. They weren't all as vapid as you claim them to be."

Adora laughs. "I guess it would've been hard for you to have an actual conversation with them with your head between their legs."

Catra fake gasps, placing a hand against her chest in mock hurt. "Adora, are you actually sitting here and slutshaming me in the year of 2019?"

"No. I'm just calling you fast."

"Fast?" Catra laughs and reaches for her drink again. "Jesus H. Christmas, Adora, what *century* are you from?"

"Coming from the one who just used 'vapid' not even five seconds ago?"

They go on like this for awhile, teasing and bringing up embarrassing past relationships and other stories from high school. It's interesting - and honestly a relief too - to see Adora openly joking with her like this. As if all the time spent apart were nonexistent or, at the very least, not as tensely filled with radio silence as it had been.

Some of their stories even dip into their early college years, where Catra describes a few of her flings here and there, making sure to share only the craziest and funniest stories to keep the mood light. With each new tale, Adora insists that her accusations were true, only for Catra to vehemently deny it all without much evidence to actually refute it.

So what if she has a habit of hooking up with ditzy girls? If nothing else, it makes things less complicated. And considering that, during all that time, she'd been juggling her own half-formed crush on her best friend - of *all* the people to crush on - complications weren't something she was looking for in a relationship.

"So what about you?" Catra asks, sipping slowly on her second drink. She's the designated driver after all. "Any crazy relationships while you were in college? Or was your nose buried too deep in your textbooks?"

Adora sticks out her tongue after knocking back another shot - her third one, Catra realizes languidly, and begins thinking about cutting her off. But with each shot she takes and each drink she knocks down, she's actually opening up. She's laughing and comfortably speaking to her - no pauses or hesitation or overthinking - and Catra doesn't want it to stop. She wants to know more, wants to know *everything* like she used to.

There's a voice in the back of her head that reminds her that this is cheating, technically. That getting Adora to open up by loosening her lips with alcohol is essentially bypassing the trust she knows she needs to build back up for this friendship to actually work in a healthier manner. If she wants things to go

back to normal, for Adora to actually stay this time, she knows she has to be less selfish.

But maybe - she thinks as she watches Adora sway on the barstool, her cheeks flushed a pretty pink color and unfocused blue eyes locked on her, clumsily pulling her drink straw to her mouth - she can be selfish for just a little longer.

"I had a few...flings, I guess? Nothin' too serious. Jus'…" She stops, drink falling slowly to her lap as she furrows her brow and bites her lip. Her eyes are hooded and her expression is darkening and Catra wonders what *that's* all about. But she decides not to press it, not that she'd have had time to anyway with the way that Adora's mood changes like a switch has been flipped. Her head jerks up, all traces of whatever memories she was lost in gone, before she relents, "Me 'n' Glimmer actually dated for a bit."

Now *that's* surprising. "Glimmer? That friend of yours who babysitted for you last week?"

"Uh-huh!"

Finishing off her drink, Catra switches over to her glass of water, deciding she's finished for the night. "So what happened there? I can't imagine it was anything too horrible considering you guys are still close enough that she watches your kid."

Adora shrugs and sets her drink down having finished it as well. "I think it was just...I dunno. Weird? Or somethin'. We just felt like we were better friends than girlfriends. Besides, now she's dating Adam so-"

Catra coughs and leans forward. "Wait, *excuse* me?"

"Oh." She turns around to face Catra fully but sways a little too dangerously and steadies herself by catching Catra's shoulders. "Yeah. They've been datin' for like….five years? Or somethin' like that."

Catra cracks a grin and laughs a little. "So she jumped from one twin to the other? That's….wow, that's weirdly funny."

"Yeeeeeah," Adora agrees with a giggle of her own. "It was kinda weird a' first, but they're happy together, ya know? So I'm happy for 'em."

Suddenly, Adora's in her space, using her hands on her shoulders as leverage to avoid toppling over. She's close enough that Catra can smell the saturated alcohol on her breath, and she begins to think that maybe *now* is the time to cut her off.

"I need," she pauses, screwing her brows together in concentration, "Can you do me a favor?"

Catra raises an eyebrow in curiosity and places a hand on Adora's shoulder to keep her steady. She's not entirely sure what Adora wants, and isn't really convinced that she's in a state to make any requests, but there's something in the way those blue eyes are looking up into her own that Catra can physically feel her resolve crumbling around her. "What's that?"

"I'm….I'm kinda drunk." Well *that* was a given. "But...I *really* wan' another drink. But if the bartender lady...if *I* try to order it, the bartender lady prolly won't let me have one." She straightens up enough to pull the drink menu closer to them. "If I tell you what I want, can you order it for me? Please? Just one more and then I *swear* I'm done. But *you* gotta order it or she won't make it."

Catra sighs and rubs her temple. "Adora...I'm not really sure that's a good idea."

And now she's *pouting*. "Please, Cat? I *promise* it's my last one." Her grip tightens and then Catra's being reeled in closer and she has to brace one hand against the bartop so they *both* don't fall over. "I don't get t' go out much anymore."

Shit. That's right. Of course Adora doesn't go out she has a fucking *kid*. And Catra's no parenting expert, but she's sure that

going out and partying on the weekends is one of the things one has to give up when caring for a child.

Even still, Adora already seems really far gone and she's just not sure that adding another drink to the mix is the wisest decision. Sure, Adora had mentioned that Mara was staying with Adora's parents for the weekend, but without even taking that into account she isn't sure that this is the best decision for Adora herself.

Just before she can shut down the request and suggest they head home, Adora collapses into her chest, lips brushing her neck. Her brain shuts down entirely.

"Please, Cat?" she whines, muffled by Catra's own burning skin.

Fuck her.

Just *fuck* her.

Ripping Adora away from her and only keeping her hands on her arms to make sure she stays steady, Catra blurts out, "Okay! Okay, fine! Just *one* more drink and then you're *done*." Ignoring how hot her face feels, she levels her gaze on Adora. "But you need to drink some water with it, okay? Otherwise I won't get it for you."

Adora giggles and her puts her hands on Catra's arms, mimicking her. "Yes ma'am."

Sighing, she slides the menu to Adora, refusing to look at her any longer otherwise her heart might just actually burst out of her chest. "What do you want?"

After Adora tells her, she waves down the bartender again and orders the drink and a glass of water. In less than a minute, she's presented with both and only when the bartender turns around does Adora reach over and slide the cocktail towards her. Catra makes a point of pushing over the glass of water as well, but

she's largely ignored in favor of the fruity concoction that Adora's practically cradling with both hands.

"Thanks, Cat. You're the *bestest*." She giggles and takes a sip of her drink. "The best bestest friend in the whooooooole worl'."

Internally groaning, Catra wonders just what she's done.

It's almost concerning how quickly Adora finishes this new drink and even more concerning how much quicker she would've downed it if not for Catra demanding she sip some water in-between. But once she's done and has set down the glass on the counter, Catra stands up and gestures for Adora to do the same so they can leave. However, Adora's attention is in the exact opposite direction, watching all of the people on the dancefloor with an awestruck expression.

Catra already knows what she's thinking. "Adora, no. It's time to go home."

Adora looks at her, face fallen like a damn toddler denied ten more minutes in the pool. "Awwww. Bu' I wanna dance too!"

"Adora, there's no way in hell you can walk straight at this point, let alone dance."

Adora bites her lip and twiddles her fingers in her lap, turning those fucking puppy-dog eyes to her and Catra feels her chest tighten. "Bu' I wanna dance with *you*."

Fuck.

Fuck her.

Determined to stay resolute on this matter, however, she stands firm. "Maybe next time."

Adora giggles and slides off the barstool, stumbling over the two steps stand in front of Catra. Already fearing what Adora was planning to do, Catra takes a cautious step backwards but is

immediately caught in Adora's grasp, being pulled forward so that Adora is pressing against her. She looks up into Adora's eyes, retort dying on her down as Adora leans down, giggling the whole way.

"One song," she murmurs. "Jus' one and then we can leave."

Fuck just *fuck*.

Shaking but not trying to show it, Catra grabs Adora's hands and slides out of her grasp. "Okay. Fine. *One* song and then I *swear* on all that is fucking holy, Adora, we are *leaving*."

Adora's cry of glee is barely heard over the rushing of blood in her ears as the drunken girl drags her over to the dancefloor. The band from earlier when they first came in was gone by this point, replaced by a DJ playing some generic pop hits. It's late, so most of the crowd that had been there have left by now, so the dancefloor is relatively empty compared to before. That makes it easier for Adora to pull her to the middle of the floor, already bouncing with the beat by the time they hit the floor and Catra just allows herself to be dragged.

Adora drops her hand in favor of moving to the music and Catra stands still, only bobbing her head to the beat when Adora looks at her in disapproval. She's more content in watching anyway.

And by god is Adora giving her a show. She was never the most eloquent person when they were younger, having all the grace of a newborn fawn and giraffe combined, so she'd never been much of a good dancer either. Catra's the more equipped person in that department, but it would've been cruel to say that Adora couldn't dance at all.

Just...mostly.

Being drunk with lowered coordination and balance surely doesn't help matters. Even still, there's something to her movements - for once actually on *beat* - that's….different. Changed. They're still a little jerky, but more fluid than she remembers them being. Her

arms - which she remembers used to flail around like one of those inflatable men outside of car dealerships - are more controlled, kept tighter to her body, moving with it in a way that doesn't make her look like a total crazed person.

She switches between dance moves sporadically, not seeming to be able to keep to one for too long, causing a sense of disconnect between motions. But even when she changes it up, she manages to stay mostly to the tempo.

Beyond all that she's actually, well, decent. Admittedly, Catra can't tear her eyes away, watching every roll of her neck, each dip of her shoulders, the constant sway of her hips…

Adora opens her eyes and looks at Catra, frowning. "You're not dancing."

Before Catra can argue, Adora's pulling her flush against her, hands on her waist and grinning down at her. "Don't tell me you forgot how."

Catra swallows nervously. "I…"

The words die on her tongue when Adora leans down to her ear, knocking into the side of her head and mumbling, "I can remind you."

And then she feels Adora's hands moving her in time with her own hips and she nearly overheats. She doesn't know what the make of the situation, doesn't know how to react to Adora's hands heavily resting on the small of her waist, hot and burning. Her mind is overwhelmed, overridden with Adora and the way her hands feel, how she smells, the way her hips are moving against Catra's own…

Hastily she separates the two of them, careful not to focus too long on Adora's hurt expression.

"I'm going to go pay our tab so we can leave once the song's over. You stay here. I'll be right back." And then she's walking

away, leaving Adora standing confused on the dancefloor.

The same bartender that had been taking care of them all night is now the only one at the bar now that the crowd has mostly dispersed. She's wiping down a stack of wet glasses before putting them up underneath the bar, but pauses when she sees Catra approach. Card already in hand, she raises it to eye-level. "I'm here to close my tab."

The bartender takes the card and shuffles over to the cash register, pressing some buttons. "You and that girl on the same check?"

"Yeah."

As the woman finishes closing out their tab, Catra leans against the bar, using the time to catch her breath and let her face cool down.

Just...what *was* all that? And no, Adora being that handsy and weird was normal and expected because she's drunk off her ass but...Catra's reactions?

Okay, yes, *fine*. She'd had the longest crush possibly known to mankind on her best friend for years. All throughout middle school, high school, and maybe even a little bit at the beginning of college too. She's a big enough person to be able to admit that much. She'd had more than enough time to process those feelings, even going so far as to almost act on them a handful of times.

But once college came and took over their lives and the distance between them grew - physically and emotionally - Catra began to get over those feelings. She moved on - admittedly a little forcibly with the help of alcohol and random one night stands - but she'd *moved on* nonetheless. She had lived out the rest of her college years and those following without ever moaning over what could've been, living her life just fine without Adora.

Even when the universe decided to drop the bomb on her when she ran into Adora and her daughter in a grocery store of all places, she had been fine. It was awkward, of course, but who wouldn't feel awkward of running into their childhood best friend and their kid that had magically come from nowhere?

Since then, she's mostly been trying to carefully navigate whatever painful history Adora had involving her pregnancy plus whatever happened between the two of them. It's difficult and she's had moments of dread that she's going to mess this up and lose one of the people closest to her all over again. In fact, the whole situation is just messy as hell.

And this….whatever *that* was on the dancefloor, would only make things messier. Whatever evoked that panic in her would just make everything *so much* more complicated. And this was a situation where she could not afford any extra complications.

"Here you go."

Catra looks up to see the bartender handing her back her card, taking it with a muttered "thanks" before replacing it in her wallet. She also signs the credit card slip almost absentmindedly, taking the customer copy then dropping a ten dollar bill into the tip jar. She's about to walk away but pauses, looking at the woman in thought. Before she can think better of it, she leans over the bartop again. "Hey, so uh...the girl I was drinking with earlier? She thinks you're really cute but she's also really shy about these things. She'd never ask you herself so I was wondering…"

The bartender smiles knowingly then gestures to her wallet. "My number's already on there. Tell her to give me a call whenever."

Catra nods and bids her a goodnight, smiling to herself as she heads back to the dancefloor. She *knew* Adora was obvious.

She briefly wonders if what she just did was out-of-bounds, but realizes that she can't afford the other option - of which she isn't

really sure what that is yet. She'd only just gotten Adora back and she couldn't afford to…

Her eyes scan the dancefloor, frowning when she sees that Adora's missing from it.

….lose her.

"God fucking *dammit*, Adora!"

She'd *told* her to stay there! Catra couldn't have even been gone for more than two minutes so *how* did she manage to lose a single woman? She whirls around, eyes scanning the rest of the bar, roaming over each face and zeroing in on every head of blonde hair. The bar is scarce now, with only a few stragglers lingering. People reluctant to leave without an arm piece probably. It's always the people the most desperate for a lay that loiter around closing time, hoping to reel in whatever catch is equally as desperate or even just drunk enough to get hooked.

Something in Catra's stomach drops at the thought and a white hot panic courses through her. Oh for *fuck's* sake.

She doubles down on her search, walking around the bar now in hopes to finding her stupid and drunk friend. Confusing feelings aside, Catra was well aware that Adora was an attractive woman. Like, *stupidly* attractive. Not only had she been the subject of Catra's years-long crush, but she'd been the crush of so many other people when they were in high school: no limits on gender, *everyone* who'd known her always admitted eventually to having even the tiniest crush on her. It would've been more annoying if Adora hadn't been so oblivious to it all (or maybe that actually made it more annoying).

And things certainly haven't changed since then. If anything, Adora probably somehow got prettier and Catra's dumbass had left her drunk and, worse, *alone* in the middle of the bar half an hour before closing. It's almost like she was begging for the vultures to descend.

Before she could dissolve into a full-blown panic attack, she spots Adora off in the corner next to the stage, mostly shrouded in shadow. In front of her is some guy caging her in, leaning against the wall with one arm and almost entirely shielding Adora from the rest of the bar. Being drunk (or maybe just being *Adora*) she doesn't seem alarmed with their position; in fact, she doesn't seem to mind it in the slightest.

Barely reigning in her anger, Catra stomps over to where they're both standing, ears finally picking up on Adora's voice rattling on about something or another about...swords?, slurring every other word or so. Catra steps in beside her, intentionally stepping into the other guy's space to force him to take a step back. He looks down at her in bewilderment, but she ignores that in favor for the way that Adora's expression brightens the second she sees her.

"Found you!" she cries out, lunging forward to wrap her arms around Catra's neck. She allows herself a breath of relief before tearing Adora away to look her in the eyes.

"More like I found you. What happened to staying on the dancefloor?"

Adora's pouting again - her heart aches and she pushes it down, down, down - and twirls a strand of hair around her finger. "You were takin' too long."

The guy, determined to not be forgotten, chimes in. "Um, hey, who's this?"

Adora blinks slowly and turns to look at him, staring for a moment as if she'd forgotten he was there entirely. Ha. "Oh! This is ma friend, Cashra! She's amazin' 'n' she drove me here!" She giggles. "Did you forget already? You said you were gonna help look fer her!"

Catra narrows her eyes at Vulture Guy, knowing that's the exact *opposite* of what he was planning to do. "Well, I've paid our tab now, so I'm taking you home."

Adora gasps and hangs on her again. Catra grunts from the weight. "On yer, um….on the bike?"

"Yes, Adora. On my bike. C'mon."

And then Adora flashes her with a brilliant grin and Catra physically can't stop the smile that pulls at her own lips. "Yaaay!" She turns around and gives a half-hearted wave towards Vulture Guy. "Byyye! It was nice to meetcha!"

He watches them in disdain as Catra leads her away across the dancefloor. Just before they get to the exit, Catra turns around to find him still standing there, stewing in rejection and denial of a warm body to warm his cock for the night. She shoots him a vicious glare and smug smile, flipping him the bird before helping Adora through the door.

As soon as they get outside, the chill of the night wrapping around them, Catra turns to Adora with a stern glare. "Adora, *what* were you doing in there? I told you to stay put and then I turn around and find you with some guy who was *clearly* trying to get in your pants."

Adora looks down at her legs with a frown. "Bu' I'm wearin' shorts."

Catra rolls her eyes to the heavens above, hoping they would grant her the strength she very clearly needs to get Adora safely home. "He was trying to take you home with him, Adora. He wanted to have sex with you."

A gentle breeze trickles past them and Adora shivers in place, pulling her jacket tighter around her. "I...No, he was...he said he was gonna help me find you. We were just havin' a convers...we were jus' talking."

Catra sighs. This is hopeless. "Whatever, Adora. I'm taking you home now, okay?"

But Adora doesn't seem so ready to let it go. "I told 'im, though! I told 'im about Mara." When Catra only looks at her strangely, she kicks her feet against the sidewalk. "He...Whenever I tell people abou' Mara, no one wan's to have sex with me. And he...I told 'im about Mara."

Oh. Ouch. Okay, that is probably a conversation for later, preferably when Adora has less alcohol in her system. Or, alternatively, if Catra has more in hers. "Yeah well, some people aren't as choosey. C'mon, Adora, you're cold. Let's get you home."

Finally, Adora obediently follows when Catra leads her away to the parking lot to where her motorcycle is. She picks up the helmet to put on Adora when two arms wrap around her midriff without warning. A warm body is pressed against her back and she can only stand there in complete shock for a moment.

She looks over her shoulder to see Adora hugging her from behind, face pressed into the space between her shoulder blades. "Ado-"

"I've missed you," Adora cuts off, nuzzling into the leather of Catra's jacket. "Lots."

Catra honestly doesn't know how to respond to that. She stands there speechless, feeling Adora's warmth seep into her back and her arms constricting around her midsection before she clears her throat. "Um, yeah. Me too."

And she really means it.

After a few more seconds of quiet, Adora slowly lets go and straightens up, looking at Catra with so much vulnerability that it makes Catra herself feel like she's been rubbed raw. Then Adora's hand comes up to cup Catra's cheek, chilled fingertips grazing equally chilled skin. Even so, Catra flinches as if she'd been burned, an electric shock coursing throughout her whole system, holding her there forcibly, gazing into the soft blues of Adora's eyes.

Complications….she *can't afford complications*.

But she also can't tear herself away, can't push her away when she's looking at her like *that*, like everything can be right again in the world if they just stand there, together, just like they are.

Adora's lips part and her gaze drops for a second, so brief that Catra almost misses it.

"I think I hafta puke." Her brows furrow together and her lips twist as she ponders it for a second. "Yeah I definitely hafta puke." And then her body is lurching forward and the panic that was holding Catra in place is now spurring her into action.

"Whoa, hey, *not on the bike*!"

She guides Adora a few steps away to the wall of the bar, holding her shoulders as Adora doubles over and lets it all out, right on the concrete. Her hands gather up her ponytail and hold it out of the way as Adora heaves, scrunching her nose and looking in another direction, *any* direction, except down.

When she feels Adora's breaths regulate and her body straighten, Catra finally looks over to Adora who looks a lot groggier and paler now. "Better?" she asks tentatively.

Adora wipes the corner of her mouth with the back of her hand before wiping that on her shorts, and Catra shudders. "Yeah. Think so."

Catra begins to lead Adora back over to her bike. "I told you to drink more water."

"I drank *some*."

Knowing it'd be fruitless to argue with her, Catra doesn't push it. "Think you're okay enough to ride home? Cleaning puke out of my helmet would be a bitch so I can always just call us an uber or something…"

"No!" Adora stumbles forward and catches herself on Catra's arm. "No, 'm good! I'm sooooo good!"

Catra nods and picks up one of the helmets, helping Adora put it on and adjust it. Once she's settled, she pulls her own helmet on and straddles the bike. After making sure that Adora's adjusted safely behind her and making *sure* that she knows to hold on tightly, she revs up the engine and pulls out of the parking lot, careful not to take her turns too harshly or jostle the bike enough to make Adora sick again.

Luckily they make it to Adora's apartment without incident. Catra parks in one of the guest spots in the adjacent garage, helping Adora off the bike and then helping to take the helmet off. She's still swaying in place, but Catra thinks that maybe the wind helped sober her up if only just a little (or maybe it was that she puked up most of the alcohol) because she looks really sleepy and calm compared to before they left the bar.

She leads Adora into the apartment building, getting her into the elevator and pressing the button for her floor. Adora leans heavily on her most of the way, blinking tiredly and giggling to herself occasionally, but ultimately says nothing.

Once the elevator doors open with a sharp *ding*, Catra leads them out into the hallway and starts heading down to what is *hopefully* Adora's apartment ("Room 413...wait, no...415?"). As they get nearer to Apartment 415 (*408….409…*) Adora giggles again and finally breaks the silence between them.

"I haven't been *this* drunk since that one night!"

Despite how tired she herself is and how badly she wants to hurry up and get home to crash in her own bed, Catra smiles. Now *that* sounds like a hilarious story. "Oh yeah? And which night was that?"

"Um…" *411….412….* "Halloween, I think? Or somewhere aroun' that time."

Halloween? Oh, even better. "Halloween last year?"

Besides her Adora frowns in thought and shakes her head. "No, the one with A-" she cuts herself off. Thinks better of what she was planning to say. *414 and…..* "The one with Mara's father."

415.

Oh.

Catra pauses in front of Adora's door, staring at the bronze numbers screwed onto the door. Her mind traces the lines and curves, struggling to process, struggling to catch up. Mara's father…

And then it all hits her and her heart stops in panic. She cranes her neck down to see Adora leaning against her, expression weighed down in deep thought, eyes clouded in memories, and realizes this is *not* how she wants this to happen. She wants to know - by *gods* she wants to know so badly - but she also doesn't want the way she finds out to be from an Adora in a drunken stupor.

She wants Adora to trust her enough to tell her. She wants Adora to make the conscious decision to divulge her past. And she knows that Adora would want it that way too. To retain control of her secrets, to only reveal them when she's really and *truly* ready to.

But not like this. *Never* like this.

Catra grabs Adora's shoulders and squeezes them to try and get her to focus. "Hey, Adora? Hey, look we need to get you inside, okay?"

When Adora doesn't respond for a few seconds, eyes still staring off into space, Catra begins to wonder if she even got through to her. Deciding that maybe she needs to unlock the door herself, her hand moves towards Adora's purse to find her keys.

And then Adora sniffles.

Catra looks up and is greeted with Adora's tear-filled eyes, still half-glazed in memories, but also somehow simultaneously there. They're watery and shaking, boring into Catra with the pain they hold. Catra's chest begins to ache and her head begins to pound.

No no no no. Not like this, *not like this*.

"Adora-"

She sniffles again which turns into a choked sob as the first tears roll down her cheeks. "He….he hurt me."

Catra goes numb. The colors of the hallway fade away as she stares helplessly into shimmering pools of blue, swirling with turmoil and lingering pain. Humiliation and fear and *so much fucking pain*…

She didn't want to know. She *doesn't* want to know but there's a lump in her throat and...and…

Her grip on Adora's shoulders tightens. Oh god...*Oh god*….

"Adora…" Her voice is shaking and she curses silently. She swallows and takes a moment to collect herself, to assure herself that *no*, *not that*. "Adora did he...were you…." Her body shivers violently. Goddammit *fuck* she can't even bring herself to say it. She swallows again, thinking of another way to phrase it. "You weren't….forced, were you?" The word is heavy on her tongue and she hates asking and she hates even more how scared she is to hear the answer.

"Huh?"

Adora blinks down at her, looking genuinely confused for a second. Then takes one of Catra's hands off of her shoulder, spreading apart her fingers before bringing it to rest on her chest. "No. No, he hurt me here."

Catra's heart begins to beat again and she lets loose a huge sigh of relief, choking down unshed tears. Oh thank *fuck*. She shakes her head and laughs breathlessly and hollowly. "Jesus fucking Christ, Adora, you just scared the everloving *shit* out of me."

For some reason, Adora looks sadder now as she plays with Catra's fingers on her chest. "You hurt me here too," she says lowly.

Catra freezes again and looks up to where Adora's still crying. Her eyes fall to where her hand is still nestled against Adora's chest, held there by Adora's own hands, and an overwhelming wave of guilt crashes down and wipes her out.

Yeah. That makes sense, she guesses.

She always knew how the break affected her, the hurt and anger that consumed her for the months to come. The way she threw herself into unhealthy habits, almost wrecking the rest of her friendships in her rampage to quell the pain. She had wanted everyone around her to suffer like she was, to hurt and choke and yearn that way she had.

Her self-destructive tendencies nearly cost her some of her closest friends. It had caused a brief rift in her relationship with her own family. And she remembered not caring at the time, only *hurting*.

It wasn't until afterwards, after she sat down and talked about it (her mother had arranged for her to visit a therapist a few times before she had done something *really* stupid), that she began to realize how her behavior was affecting those around her. How, in pushing everyone away, she was only making it worse on herself, isolating herself on purpose so she couldn't be left behind again.

Even then, it wasn't until a couple more years later, after she was out of college and had reconciled most of her relationships with those she had hurt, that she considered that...maybe Adora had hurt just as badly as she had.

Or at least, that was what she had always hoped. Not because she wanted Adora to suffer like she had, not like before.

But because she wanted to think their friendship had maybe meant something to her too.

And now, with just five words and two eyefuls of tears, she knows it had.

Then, something changes in Adora's entire demeanor and the sadness leaves her eyes, lifting from her shoulders and allowing her to stand up straighter. "An' Mermista was *pissed* when you did." She purses her lips in thought. "I think she might hate you."

Wait, Mermista? Who was Mermista? Another friend if she had to guess but why *her* in particular? Surely all of her friends knew about their falling out, so did the rest of them just not care? Or is Mermista the only one to hold a grudge?

"But don't worry," Adora says, smiling now and patting her on the shoulder. "I haven't told her yet!"

"Um, told her what exactly?"

"That we're talking again! I think she'd jus' get mad and she's kinda scary when she's mad sometimes." At that moment, Adora's eyes drift off to the side and light up when they land on the door. "Hey! This is *my* apartment!"

Still reeling from the emotional whiplash she just suffered as well as the dump of new information that Adora has a friend who apparently *hates* her, Catra can only find it within her to sigh tiredly and drawl out a dry, "How observant of you."

Adora giggles and points at the door excitedly. "I *live* here!"

Catra straightens up and nods while taking her hand back from Adora's grasp. "Yeah. And we need to get you inside and in bed so you can sleep the rest of that alcohol off. Where's your keys?"

Adora turns to dig through her purse, sticking her tongue out of the corner as she searches, before procuring a jingling ring of keys, shaking them proudly. "Tadaaaaa!"

"Good. Now go inside and get into bed."

Adora looks at the door and bites her lip before turning to Catra with a gasp. "You should stay over! We'll have a sleepover, like we always used to!"

'*You hurt me here too.*'

Catra rubs the back of her neck. "I...don't think that's really such a great idea. Besides, I have to get up early tomorrow and meet with a new client." At Adora's crestfallen expression, she sighs and offers a tired smile. "But we can talk tomorrow, okay? As long as you go inside and go to bed *now*," she says sternly.

Adora pouts but seems pretty resigned to spending the night alone because she doesn't try to argue further. "'Kay." Then she raises her hand, pinkie extended. "Promise?"

"Adora, what are you, four?"

Adora only extends her hand out further, looking at her with a determined glare to the point that Catra figures it'll be faster to comply than sit here and argue with her anymore. "Okay, yeah." She curls her own pinkie finger around Adora's. "I promise."

Satisfied, Adora beams at her before going to unlock her door, struggling momentarily to single out the key and get it inside the lock. Once she does, she gives out a quiet cry of victory, before swinging the door wide open and traipsing into her apartment. Before she can close the door, however, Catra steps into the doorway.

"Now I want you to go to bed okay? Drink some water if you can. And I'm also not going to leave until I hear you lock your door, got it?"

Adora hums and swings her hips back and forth, giggling while giving Catra a two-fingered salute. "Sir, yessir!"

Having completely given up on having any semblance of a coherent conversation for the rest of the night, Catra sighs and steps back into the hallway. "Okay. Goodnight, Adora."

"G'night, Cat!" And then the door is closing in her face. She waits the few extra seconds until she hears the lock turn and, finally feeling confident that Adora is safe and headed to bed, begins to trudge down the hallway back to the elevator with a yawn. *God* she's just aching to collapse in her own bed and pass out.

She calls the elevator and waits with hands shoved in pockets, climbing in when the doors open and pressing the button for the lobby. As soon as the doors shut again, she throws her head back against the wall, letting the silence soak into her bones.

'*You hurt me here too.*'

She frowns. Maybe she wouldn't be getting as much sleep tonight, after all.

Chapter End Notes

Heyo! Guess who uploaded chapter 5 BEFORE season 5 dropped?

This depressed hoe! [this is where y'all applaud]

I know it's only been 5 days since the last update, but I've been in a mental rut this past week and instead of being actually productive I decided to keep writing because it's the only thing I could get myself to do besides watching bridezillas clips on youtube (which is how you know you've hit rock bottom).

I realize this is a quick turnaround, but please don't get your hopes up. This isn't likely to be a regular thing. I just

happened to be really excited about this chapter.

Fun fact; I actually work at a Greek deli. So I ended up modelling the place sort of off my job. Does that make the cashier me? Did this just accidentally become a self-insert fic? Who fuckin knows

Also, if anyone wants to draw Glimmer wearing sunglasses and a shirt that says "I fucked both the Hartvigsen twins", I will not stop you. In fact, if you do, please tag me @technoskittles on tumblr. I will actually love you forever. It will make my entire year. (I'm literally begging y'all to do this I will get on my hands and knees I have no shame)

to distract our hearts from ever missing them

Chapter Summary

> Hangovers are a bitch but siblings really just take the cake on ruining your entire day. Glimmer regrets dating both people in a set of twins. And Catra is just a helpless victim to the madness.
>
> Also it's time for pie.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It's late.

She's late.

Her feet are killing her and she considers for the sixth time in three blocks of removing her heels. She can't remember why she chose them anyway. She had wanted to look nice. She doesn't feel that way anymore.

Adora had agreed to meet Catra at the bar at six. When she checks her phone, the numbers that blink up at her read 11:48 PM.

She shoves her phone back into her purse with a sound reminiscent of a desperate whine. No, no it was definitely *a desperate whine. Six hours. She's almost an entire six hours late. Is Catra even still at the bar? Or had she given up hours ago, opting to go home instead? Giving up on their date, on Adora herself…*

Adora shakes her head and takes a deep breath, ignoring the shakiness and casually wiping the corners of her eyes. She has to go. She can't turn back now. She has to see this through.

When she tries to send Catra another text, spilling with apologies and explanations, it bounces back. Just like the previous thirty. And then her phone shuts off, dead.

In a bout of anger, she throws it down on the sidewalk and steps over the broken pieces. The bar isn't too far off now and she doesn't really need it anymore anyway. It only taunts her.

Soon enough, she recognizes the familiar green neon of the bar sign protruding from a brick and mortar building and quickens her pace. There's no line to get in, thankfully, but as soon as she passes through the door, the space is packed with people. Adora tries rising to the balls of her feet to see over the massive crowd, looking for a familiar mess of curls, but comes up empty.

Disappointed but not entirely discouraged, she tries her luck over by the bar. It takes a tremendous amount of effort to swim through the sea of bodies, but she manages just enough to carve out a pathway towards her destination. The bar is just as packed as the rest of the building, but off to the right she sees two vacant barstools. She must have some luck after all.

Rushing towards them before they can be snatched up, she shoulders her way past more faceless patrons until she breaks free, collapsing onto one of the stools with a winded rush of air and groan over her sore feet. They actually feel swollen *with how much they're straining against the confines of her shoes.*

As she tries and fails to adjust them to alleviate some of the pain, the bartender comes over and looks down on her, his stature wide and towering. The lady that had serviced them the last time they had come here was nowhere to be found, but Adora pushes past the mild disappointment in favor of finding her friend.

"*Have you…-een….girl with cur-...-nd gold ey-...-s?" Her voice sounds garbled and is lost to the thundering music, so loud she can hardly hear her own thoughts anymore. Fortunately, the bartender seems to pick up on enough of what she's saying - whether due to actually hearing her or practice Adora would never*

know - and he juts a finger towards the hallway that houses the restrooms. Adora nods and gives him a smile of thanks that isn't returned before he stalks off to the opposite end of the bar to make drinks for slobbering customers.

Adora remains on the barstool for an extra moment, considering her options for her next course of action. Her first - and honestly, the most preferable - option is to stay at the bar and wait for Catra to come out. This way she could keep the two empty seats saved for the two of them so they wouldn't be forced to stand in the middle of a throng of people or squished against some wall, drinks clutched close to their chests and hoping that some drunkard wouldn't knock into them and spill it. This would also mean that Adora could rest her feet for awhile given that she had walked about five miles to get here.

However, she reminds herself that she's already six hours late, without a phone, and without anyway to let Catra know she finally made it. When Catra leaves the bathroom, there wouldn't be any way to ensure that she sees Adora sitting at the bar and it's not like she would be able to hear if Adora tries calling out to her. And after waiting for so long already, who's to say that she wouldn't decide to leave after coming out and not seeing Adora anywhere?

With a grumble, Adora collects her belongings and tentatively slides off the stool, taking care to put as little pressure on her aching feet as possible. Hobbling through the crowd once more, she makes it into the surprisingly empty hallway, pushing the swinging door open into the even more surprisingly empty women's restroom.

Well, almost empty.

A girl stands hunched over in front of the sinks. She's alone and the bathroom seems otherwise unoccupied from the deafening silence within. Even the blasting music from the bar can't be heard once the door has closed.

Just total….silence.

Except for the quiet sobs from the girl. Adora stands awkwardly by the door, wondering if it's best to leave the girl be and continue looking for Catra (who doesn't seem to be here after all). She takes in the girl's disheveled appearance - pajama pants that hung loose with frayed drawstrings that are more decoration than functional; a stretched and faded tie-dyed t-shirt with peeling letters on the front that now spelled "E GY N TI S U D" *with prinpicked holes dotting the sleeves and bottom lining the shirt; mismatched socked feet; and a red jacket two sizes too big but still in relatively good condition. Her blonde hair curtains her face, hiding what is surely a sheen of tears and snot from the dim bathroom lighting. She's young, even if just by a few years. Just barely old enough to be in a bar.*

Adora almost leaves, she really does, but there's something about the oddness of the girl - both her crying and her outfit choice in a bar restroom that has her inching forwards, slowly as to not startle the girl.

She calls out. "Hey honey. What's wrong?"

The girl doesn't answer her. If anything, she begins to sob harder, bringing up one of her hands that had been white knuckling the counter to her mouth to try and muffle the sounds. Adora bites her lip, hesitating, before pushing forward with more resolve than before. She doesn't stop until she's standing next to the girl and placing a comforting hand on her shoulder.

The girl's hand falls from her face back to the counter as she begins to hyperventilate. "I can't…" Her voice is warped, from the crying, from the breathlessness, and something else that twists it into something that Adora can't place. It echoes in the silent bathroom, repeating back to her, drilling into her skull. "I can't do this alone."

Adora leans in, trying and failing to get the blonde to look at her. "What's wrong? What can't you do alone?"

The girl shudders beneath her and there's a quiet clack *on the counter that draws Adora's attention away from her shrouded face to the slender, white stick now resting on the counter. She recognizes it immediately, knows the shape and size well enough, and is even drawn back to when she had held one between trembling fingers, tears building up and rolling off her cheeks to her parents' bathroom tiles.*

The screen reads positive.

And her heart shatters. Suddenly she feels a deeper bond with the girl, despite not knowing who she is, what she's doing there, or even not having seen her face. Her hand squeezes her shoulder, a reassuring thumb stroking the fabric of her thick jacket.

"*Hey….hey I've been there, ya know? Right where you are. And it's...it's tough and things are really gonna suck for awhile but I* promise *you'll get through it. No matter what you choose to do."*

The girl's breath hitches. "I...I don't know what I'm going to do." Adora opens her mouth to say something else, something resembling advice or maybe some kind of encouragement, when the girl cuts her off again. "I can't do this alone! I can't….I **can't**
."

A memory of wire-framed rims, crooked and bent….spiced apple scent wafting through the air of a small home-kitchen….the clacking and rustling of beaded bracelets and necklaces that sang with each movement….

"*Maybe...maybe you don't have to," she whispers. She's not entirely sure what spurs her to offer her assistance, but she remembers being in that position, desperately wanting a hand to hold hers.*

The girl wails and digs her nails into the counter. "They've...they've all left me. They've all abandoned *me!" And then she looks up.*

And Adora is looking at herself.

Her twenty-year-old self. Lost and confused. Scared. Small.

Adora, her *Adora not* other *Adora, takes a step back, reeling in confusion at just what is currently going on. How is that her? How is her past self here? Why?*

Other Adora - past *Adora - sniffles and her lip is wobbling, arms curling around her stomach protectively. "I'm...alone."*

Before Adora - the current one, not the other one - can respond to that, there's a loud clamour from one of the stalls to her left coupled with a loud shriek. Adora looks over with wide eyes, startled briefly, as the shriek turns into a string of loud moans, increasing in tempo and crescendo. She turns to see past Adora's reaction to this new development, but…

She's gone.

Adora turns to the bathroom door but it's shut just as tight as it was before, and she hadn't heard the cacophony of music from outside that would've indicated it being opened. Young Adora has just...vanished, it would seem.

Heaving a great sigh, Adora places her palms flat on the sink counter, hunching her shoulders over to try and gather her thoughts. Had that just been some weird kind of hallucination? A figment of her imagination? A corporeal image of her stress manifested? It's difficult to say.

Even more so with the non-stop moaning and sexual screaming berating her eardrums.

Smoothing her hair back, Adora prepares herself to walk out of the restroom, determined to find Catra elsewhere or maybe find some way to contact her since her phone is still out of commission. (Maybe smashing it on the ground out of anger wasn't her most rational decision.)

But when she raises her head, a set of piercing blue eyes stares back at her, underlined with a cruel smirk framed by a clean-

shaven square jaw. The blood in her veins turns to ice and she finds that she's rooted in the spot, locked into those eyes...eyes that had once looked at her so kindly…

"*Hi, Adora." The sound of his voice squeezes her heart to a pulp and she can feel her airways twisting on themselves. "It's been awhile."*

She doesn't even question what he's doing here. The women's bathroom or anywhere near her*. "That's because you left," she grits out, feeling nearly five years of pent up anger thawing her blood, boiling it.*

He leans closer and she flinches away, shudders at the closeness of his lips to her ear. "Only because you didn't listen to me. If you had behaved…" His right hand slides down Adora's right arm and she wrenches it away, swiveling around to fully face him.

"*Cut the shit, A-"*

He's gone too.

After giving the room a cursory glance and seeing nothing, Adora slumps backwards against the counter and takes a deep breath. Well. It's official. She has *to be going crazy now, right? First her past self. And then…*

Maybe coming out tonight was a mistake. She obviously isn't in the right headspace for it.

Before she can settle on the decision to leave however, the door to the stall on the far end is being ripped open. A woman with blonde hair and dark skin exits, pulling up and readjusting her top with one hand while the other works on smoothing down her miniskirt. Adora stares at her in an embarrassed sort of awe before having the sense to look away. Though her gaze immediately darts to the stall with the door blown wide open, waiting for the second participant to step forth and reveal themselves.

They never do.

The blonde woman knocks into Adora, deliberately from the way the force makes Adora stumble. "Move whale."

Adora's annoyed retort dies on her tongue as she looks at the woman in confusion, wondering just where that *had come from. She hadn't been called that since…*

A slow sense of horror dawned on her and she felt a chill run down her spine, mouth going dry, face growing hot. The woman, who had been fluffing up her hair in the mirror, smirks and turns to face her, eyes drifting down before settling back on Adora's face.

"*No wonder she chose me instead of you."*

The words echo in her skull...or the bathroom...or fuck maybe both? There's something in the woman's eyes, her painted lips or the stiffness of her blonde curls that seems familiar, like she's seen them before….somewhere….

A lawn chair by the pool...the chill of the night warded by alcohol coursing through her bloodstream...heart shattering, shattering to pieces...those curls trampling on the pieces...

Instead of figuring it out, she dares a glance down, confirming what she's already feared. Her stomach, flat only moments ago, was now round and protruding, just like it had during her pregnancy with Mara.

But how…?

The woman laughs, a cruel and resounding thing that claws her eardrums, but when Adora looks up, she's gone. Just like the first two spectres.

Her chest feels tight. Her eyes are burning. Her feet are definitely *swollen.*

Feeling an intense bout of nausea coming along, Adora lunges into one of the bathroom stalls, letting the door slam shut behind her while she drops to her knees. The tears are already falling as the nausea climbs and climbs, threatening to spill out of her until there's nothing left….

Nothing actually comes.

She sits there, dry heaving into the bowl of the toilet, gasping through her tears as all the voices converge into one, pounding inside her head again and again….

"*I can't...if you had behaved...alone...move….me instead of you….alone...left….didn't listen….whale…"*

Adora clutches her head, moans echoing in the toilet as she cries out. "Just leave me alone!"

Obediently, they evaporate. Just like the spectres that had embodied them.

And Adora is left with silence once more.

She doesn't know how long she sits there. How long the bite of the cold bathroom tile digs into her skin. How long her body wracks itself with tremors as a dull pain nestles in-between her eyes, pounding and pulsing. Doesn't know how long she stays curled within herself, bombarded with pains from her past.

Then a voice. Quiet and shaky, but it sounds like home.

"*Mara? Mara, dearie, are you in there?"*

She uses the heel of her hand to wipe away some of the tears. "Adora. It's Adora."

"*Yes, yes! Isn't that what I said?"*

Adora laughs, quiet but authentic, because they both know it isn't.

"*Anywho, come on out now. It's almost time."*

Adora blinks and sits up, upper body leaning towards the stall door. "Time for what?"

"*What else, dearie? The* pie*. It's almost time!" She knocks on the door twice. "Come, come now! You promised to help!"*

Adora grips onto the walls to pull herself up, breathing slowly and hissing at the monumental task it turns out to be. It's been awhile since moving has been this difficult. "Razz, we're at a bar I don't-"

When she opens the door, she's in Razz's home. There's a stack of old newspapers on the sofa, each turned to a different crossword puzzle, all only partly finished. The kitchen is towards the back, a heavenly scent of cinnamon and apples lilting in the air throughout the house, weaving through the furniture and adding warmth. To her right, she sets down her bag, next to the hall table bending beneath the weight of an assortment of potted plants - some healthy and some on the verge of death.

As she heads towards the kitchen, she passes the line of photos nailed to the wall, each of a young woman with dark, wavy hair.

Razz is by the oven, bent at the waist, squinting through her thick lenses into the window. "Not quite…" she mutters to herself.

Adora smiles to herself before pulling open one of the kitchen drawers to grab the oven mitts. They aren't there, but then again, that's not surprising. Nothing ever stays in the same place for very long. She starts rifling through more drawers, listening to Razz mutter to herself.

"*You have to wait for the timer to go off, Madame Razz."*

"*The timer?" The older woman stands upright, scratching her head before snapping her fingers. "Right! The timer! Now...where did I put that darned thing….?"*

"*You'll find it when it goes off." Ah. There's the oven mitts. When she lifts them out of the drawer, she finds a picture underneath. A little girl, blonde, blue eyes soft like the ocean waves. Adora reaches out.*

Razz's hand cuts her off. "Aha! The timer!"

As soon as she touches it, it begins to go off, an incessant beeping that spears through Adora's temples, making her head pound. She grunts and tries to swipe it from Razz to turn it off, but finds it just out of reach.

Razz is wagging a finger at her now. "Ah ah ah! It's time, dearie!"

Adora winces as the beeping grows louder. "It's loud…"

"*It's* time*, Adora! It's time for the pie!"*

Adora squeezes her eyes shut and pinches the bridge of her nose. "Razz, it's so…"

…..Loud.

The first thing she's able to register is the blaring of the timer directly into her ear. The second thing is a blinding light that pierces through her eyelids straight into her brain, giving her what is surely the headache of the century. The beeping doesn't help.

Groggily, she pries her eyes open, taking in a deep breath as she tries to focus on her bleary surroundings. When that doesn't work immediately, she turns her head towards the sound she's sure to hear in Hell itself and finds her phone, the alarm she's set daily going off.

Oh.

Her hand swipes haphazardly at it, once, twice, three times and gets it on the fourth. The quiet that follows is a blessing and her head falls back into the suffocating softness of her pillow. A few

seconds pass like this, with her quiet, shallow breaths as sleep seduces her back into her sweet clutches, slowly and gently…

With a gasp, Adora jerks upright in bed, only pausing to wince at the rush of pain that sends right to the front of her brain before she snatches up her phone to look at the time.

It was noon. It was already *fucking* noon!

Scrambling out of bed is a more dizzying task than she bargains for, but she manages to plant her feet on the floor and rush over to her bathroom nonetheless. The mirror reflects back a mess. Her hair is askew, eyes sunken in, face pale and shiny with some sweat. Her shirt is on backwards, but she supposes it's the effort that counts.

Opening one of the sink drawers and procuring a bottle of pain relievers, she shakes out two and pops them, already on her way to the kitchen to wash them down with some water. As she halves a water bottle from the fridge, she reboots her mind, running through the events of the previous night, sliding pieces together that had been jostled.

Well, for one, she *clearly* had a lot to drink the night before. Enough to give her a hangover, though that might not be saying much considering it's been awhile since she's let loose like that. She isn't sure what it was that gave her the incentive to do so: Mara's absence or Catra's presence.

She reaches back to fix her ponytail, finger combing her hair to get it to lay somewhat flat. It had to be the second one. It wasn't the first time Mara had spent the night by herself at her parents' house. But it had been the first time in a long time that she'd thrown away her inhibitions like that.

Which brings her to her next thought: *Mara*. She'd promised her parents that she would pick Mara up around...one? Two? No, definitely one. Which means that if she wanted to get there on time she'd need to leave around…

She looks over at the clock. 12:18.

Right. She'd have to leave right now this very second. Without changing. Without shoes. Drive for over an hour total with a hangover worthy of a Hangover Hall of Fame slot. If those even existed.

Adora slumps against the counter and groans which fades into a whimper. There is absolutely no way she's going to make that drive without wanting to blow her brains out. Not a chance in Hell.

Still, she shuffles back to her bedroom anyway to find maybe a hoodie she can slip on and some slippers or something she can leave the apartment in and still be considering a barely functioning adult member of society. As she opens her closet doors, she spots her phone laying innocently on her bed.

She bites her lip. Or…

Or maybe her brother kind of owes her?

She's plucking her phone off the bedsheets and dialing his number before she can reconsider. Because of course he does. Even if she didn't have a specific reason, she grew up with the little twerp and allowed him to *live* throughout all that time, so really, he kind of owed her until the day he died.

He would say otherwise, but in the end his opinions didn't really matter.

Adam picks up on the fifth ring. His voice is groggy and tired and Adora knows that he's just woken up himself. "Adobo?"

Adora rolls her eyes. "I need you to do me a huge favor."

She hears the rustling of fabric - his bedsheets, no doubt. "Err...this isn't, like, a 'bury a body' type of favor, izzit? 'Cause...my shovel's kinda out on loan right now."

Adora blinks and shakes her head, briefly wincing at the sudden motion. "What? No! I just need you to pick up Mara from Mom and Dad's." When a few seconds go by without any sort of response or indication of recognition, she pushes on. "Mara? My daughter?"

She hears a hum across the line. "Right. Mars Bar. My favorite niece."

"Your only niece."

"And thus, by default, my favorite."

Adora begins massaging the bridge of her nose in an attempt to alleviate her headache. In retrospect, calling Adam was the opposite of curing her ailment. "Look, can you get her? I don't think I can drive right now."

"Could you ever?"

Adora grits her teeth and tightens her grip on her phone. "I dunno, could you *shut it*?"

He makes a tutting sound which doesn't really do much for quelling her impending anger. "Now, now, Adobowl, that's not how you treat someone you want a favor from."

Adora inhales a quick breath through her nose before stating in a slow, calm tone of voice, "So help me you bastard...keep up the shit and mouth fucking will take on a totally new meaning for you once I'm done shoving your dick so far up your ass it comes out of your mouth."

There's a pregnant pause, and then, "Kinky."

Adora nearly shrieks. "Put Glimmer on the phone. I know she's there so *put her on*."

"Fine. I don't want to talk to your grumpy ass anyway." Then there's a brief lull with a muffled exchange of words in the

background before she hears the higher but still sleepy voice of one of her best friends.

"Hi, Adora. What's up?"

Adora collapses onto her bed and lets her head fall into her hand. "I need someone to pick up Mara because I'm too hungover and I feel like my brain is going to burst out of my skull and I *swear* I'm going to kill Adam I swear I am." Her voice tapers off towards the end and she realizes then just how badly she wants to cry from the pain. "Can you two *please* go pick up my kid before I decide to fling myself out of my bedroom window?"

Glimmer yawns that ends in a soft chuckle. "And leave this knucklehead Mara's new caretaker? Even you're not that cruel to do that to her."

"Bold of you to assume I'm letting that son of a bitch anywhere *near* my kid when I die."

Glimmer's laugh is cut off when Adam shouts loud enough to be picked up by the receiver in the background. "I'm telling *Mom* you called her a *bitch*!"

"I *fucking* dare you, bitch baby!" Adora shouts back.

Once again, Glimmer cuts in, trying to break up a fight before it even begins. If it already hasn't. "Okay, you relax, lay down and drink some water. We're going to get ready now to go pick up Mara. Do you want us to watch her for the rest of the day?"

Adora shakes her head. "No, no you can bring her here, it's fine. I can take care of her, I just don't know if I can stomach driving right now. Especially not that long of a drive."

"Got it, babe. We'll see you in about two-ish hours?"

"You have a key. Feel free to let yourself in if I don't come to the door."

"Alright then. See you in a bit."

She wishes that she could say that she'd been productive after that call. But the reality is otherwise, because roughly two hours later, she's only managed to change into a clean set of lounge clothes before slipping into a restless sleep to try and nap away the rest of her headache. When she wakes to the sound of her front door opening, she's happy to say that she was mostly successful.

Rubbing the sleep from her eyes, she scrolls through her notifications absentmindedly as she slides off her bed, seeing a couple of texts from Glimmer and some odd notifications from various apps she has installed. Filing all of that away for a later time, she shuffles from her room into the main space to see Glimmer and Adam in her living room, the latter cradling a sleeping Mara against his chest.

When Adora points wordlessly towards Mara's room, Adam follows directions with a nod, ruffling her hair as he passes. Adora turns to give him a piece of her mind, when a cardboard coffee cup is shoved into her peripheral.

Glimmer smiles at the end of her extended arm. "Figured you could use a pick-me-up?"

Adora takes it with a grateful smile, feeling the warmth of the coffee vibrating beneath her fingertips. "You are truly a saint."

The two women go over to sit on the couch when Adam re-enters the room, his grey-blue eyes zeroing in on Adora. He looks her up and down for a brief second before letting loose a dramatic sigh. "Really, Adobo? You know you're not in college anymore. You can't just drink without abandon like this. You're a stuffy old mom now. Your liver will shrivel up in pure shock."

Adora pulls the cup from her lips, quelled by the slight bitter taste of her basically-black coffee. Fortunate for Adam really and

possibly the main reason that Glimmer brought her some. To keep the arguing to a minimum. Still, "I will give you approximately half a second to shut your face before I dropkick you out of the window." Generous on her part, if you asked her. Coffee really was a miracle worker.

Before Adam could fire back with his own response, Glimmer is leaning into her space, a dangerous smirk on her lips. "Well looks like *someone* had a wild time last night. I take it the date went well?"

Adam sputters and gapes at her like a dumb fish out of water. "Whoa, hang on, rewind. Date? You went on a *date*? What, planning for kid numero dos already?"

Adora scoffs and waves him off. "Knock it off, will you? It wasn't a *date*," she looks pointedly at Glimmer at this part. "I was just catching up with Catra and I guess I got a little carried away. No big deal."

For some reason, that only shocks Adam more. His jaw is hanging by a thread, eyes bugged out like a cartoon character. She can only look at him neutrally, unimpressed by his exaggerated theatrics. "Hold up, *rewind*. Catra? You mean *Catra* Catra?!"

"How many people named Catra do you know, doofus?"

"No, I…" He walks into the living room and plops down onto the armchair adjacent to the couch where her and Glimmer are sitting. "Since when have you two been on speaking terms with each other?"

Adora gives Glimmer a quick questioning glance. "Wait, I thought you told him?"

"I've only told Bow."

Shit.

Well, honestly that would explain the radio silence from her brother. She figures that if Glimmer had told him about any of this, he would've dropped everything to call her and demand to know everything. After all, Catra had practically lived at their house growing up. She was around enough that Adora was sure that Adam basically considered her his little sister or something to that extent.

And now she has to deal with his barrage of questions. While still slightly hungover.

She takes a long swig of her coffee, ignoring how it burns her tongue and leaves it tingling afterwards.

"Um, hello?" Now he's waving his hands frantically to regain her attention. "Since when has this been going on? When did you two even meet up again?"

Adora drums her fingers against the side of her cup. "Just a couple of weeks." When his jaw drops again like she'd divulged the secrets of the universe in those five words, she takes a pillow and tosses it at him. "Quit being a drama queen! It's not that serious."

"Not that-" He shakes his head and throws his hands up. "Adora, you idiots were practically ready to jump each other's bones all throughout high school! *Of course* this is serious!"

Next to her she feels Glimmer shift and when she looks over she sees that Glimmer has this kind of dumbstruck expression on her face - eyes wide and lips parted in shock. "Wait, seriously? I was just kidding about all the date stuff. Adora do you actually-"

"No!" She takes another pillow from behind Glimmer and chucks that one at Adam too. "Shut up! We were not! We were good *friends*," she turns to Glimmer and shoots her a glare for emphasis, "and we still are *just that*." She bites her lip. "Well, um, sort of. We're working on that part right now actually."

"On being more than friends?"

"On being *friends*. Plain and simple. Just *friends*."

"Yeah, friends who *totally* wanna bone each other."

"Adam, I *will* dump this hot coffee on your dick. Keep it up."

Glimmer frowns. "That coffee was four dollars."

Adora raises up the cup and takes a sip, keeping her gaze on Adam. "And it will be four dollars well spent."

"Well if you're going to waste my money like that, could you at least refrain from damaging his dick? I like that part of him and want it fully functional."

Adora chokes on her coffee and is sent into a coughing fit, tears pricking the edges of her eyes. "Oh, god, Glimmer *stop*. It's bad enough knowing that heathen is bedding someone I don't need to hear about it too."

She sees the smirk creep onto his face and shoots him a dangerous warning glare that he blatantly ignores. "Why? Jealous that I'm sexing her better than you ever could?"

Now *that* is a low blow. "Bullshit!"

"Oh? Then let's ask her." And then Adam is turning towards Glimmer, a sweet look in his eyes that makes Adora gag and sends Glimmer into a panic. "Sweetheart, the light of my life, who would you say fucked you better?"

Adora turns to Glimmer too, and sees the look of desperation in her eyes that's focused on her, like she expects Adora to get her out of this or be disgusted with the entire conversation. Which, frankly she sort of *is*, but that competitive streak in her that is brought out like a wild beast whenever Adam is in proximity is already loose and raging and, truthfully? She's kind of curious.

Plus, with all of the teasing she's endured from Glimmer over the past two weeks, it's cathartic to see her squirm.

So, she calmly takes a sip of coffee, keeping eye contact with her the whole time before nodding. "Yeah, Glimmer. Enlighten us."

Pale pink eyes drift between the two of them and Adora swears she can actually see Glimmer breaking out into a sweat. "You guys cannot be serious right now."

"I mean, we already know it's me, but I figured you may as well confirm it for my dumbass of a sister."

"Bold words from someone who wet the bed until he went off to college."

"Hey! I only did that until I was *ten*!"

Adora smirks in victory. "Oh? So you admit you wet the bed?"

Realizing his mistake, Adam growls and jumps up from his seat. "Glimmer! Babe! Just tell her I fuck better!"

Said girl sighs and slumps against the back of the couch, closing her eyes and shaking her head sadly. "You know, Bow warned me years ago that dating one twin after another would have repercussions. I think I'm starting to realize what those are."

Someone, somewhere - a higher being maybe - must've been looking out for Glimmer because at that moment, Adora's phone rings, bringing the conversation to a grinding halt. Confused, Adora picks it up from the coffee table. For a moment, she's worried it's her mother, who has a tendency to overreact. And Adora sending her brother to pick up her daughter was exactly the type of thing to send her into worried, helicopter mom mode.

She takes one look at the caller ID and realizes that would be far preferable.

Before she can silence the call, Glimmer is looking over her shoulder and gasps. "It's Catra!"

Adam, who had been sulking off to the side, perks up and seems to completely forget about the previous conversation. "What? No way! Answer it!"

Adora narrows her eyes at him. "Promise to behave."

"When have I not?"

Knowing that simple question could lead to another lengthy argument, she opts to drop it in favor of swiping to accept the call and pressing the phone to her ear. "Um, hi."

"Hey." Surprisingly, her voice is enough to make her forget the craziness of her already hectic afternoon. "Just thought I'd call and check up on you. Make sure you didn't suffocate yourself in your sleep or something."

"Nope. I'm fine. Relatively speaking, that is."

"Put her on speaker!" Adam demands.

Adora shoots him a look. "You! Shut it!"

"Um...okay? Jeez, Adora. Who knew hungover you was so grumpy?"

Dammit. "No! Not you." She looks over to Adam, seeing how over-the-top excited he was acting as he inched closer in an attempt to eavesdrop on the other half of the conversation. "...Adam's here and he's being his usual annoying self."

"Shit, really? How's he doing?"

"Besides being seconds away from having my foot shoved down his throat?" Adam gives her a look and she only responds with a grin. "Fine, I guess."

Catra hums over the line. "Well, I was planning on dropping by to see if you needed anything, but it seems you're in somewhat capable hands."

"How'd you know Glimmer's here too?"

Beside her Glimmer lets out a laugh and Adam's shoulders slump in the most dejected and offended way possible.

Then, before she can hear Catra's response, Adam lunges forward and snatches the phone from her ear. She shoots forward to try and take it back, but he's already skipped off to the other side of the living room and talking at Catra a mile a minute.

"Catra! Hey, how's it going? What've you been up to lately? Heard you got my sister plastered last night. How'd that go for ya?"

"Adam give that back!" She pushes herself off the couch and tries to chase him down, but he darts out of the way at the last second, leaving Adora to trip over her own feet.

"Hmm? Yeah that was her. Yeah, no, she's fine. Oh! Hey, I have a question for ya." He takes the phone from his ear and presses one of the buttons on the screen. "Can you still hear me?"

A slight pause. Then, loud enough for everyone present in the room to hear, "Yeah I can. Wanna tell me what's going on?"

"I'm getting to that." And then Adam shoots her a shit-eating grin and Adora can feel every organ in her body shut down simultaneously. "So hypothetical question for ya. Who do you think fucks better: me or Adora?"

"Adam!" She's not sure who shouted louder - her or Glimmer.

Part of her - a large part - urges her to lunge forward and snatch the phone from him and apologize to Catra profusely, with vague attempts at an explanation, but she can only stare in horror at the phone as the silence stretches on.

Then, "I'm sorry but *what*?"

"We're in the middle of settling a debate," he explains without missing a beat. Adora considers jumping out the window for the

umpteenth time that day and taking him with her. "So, hypothetically, who do you think is better in bed? Me or my sister?"

Another lengthy pause. "I mean...I'm kind of gay dude so I might be biased…"

Adora groans but slumps in relief thinking that blow to his ego might mean the end of this mortifying conversation. But of course, with Adam, it never is. "So if you were to test that theory-"

"Okay, Adam, that's enough!" She barrels into him, throwing him off balance long enough to snatch the phone from him and take Catra off speaker. "Catra I am *so* sorry. Adam is a dumbass which I know you already knew but somehow he's gotten worse over the years. If you wanna just, like, forget all of this or maybe not even talk to me ever again I'd understand completely and wouldn't even blame you."

Catra chuckles. "Relax, Adora. I can't even say this is the craziest thing your brother has asked me."

"Now I'm afraid to know what else he's asked you."

"That's probably for the best, yeah." She hears some shuffling over the phone. "Anyways, I just wanted to call and make sure you were okay. But now I can see you're not so I guess the best I can do is pray for you and hope I don't see Adam's corpse on the news in the next few hours. I'll talk to you later, okay?"

Adora hums and nods. "Yeah. Sounds good."

Then Catra hangs up and Adora is left standing there, hoping against hope that little incident hadn't set them back fifty paces. Not when she was so sure they'd made decent progress. Maybe. Last night was kind of a blur so it's hard to say whether or not it did them much good. But she hopes that it wasn't all bad and that they still had a chance at fixing things.

Then she rounds on Adam and the look in her eyes must've been dangerously terrifying because he actually shrinks into himself.

"I….am going to *fucking* kill you."

When one of her neighbors comes to the door a couple minutes later, Glimmer has to explain in exasperation that it's just a sibling squabble over Adam's loud pleas for mercy.

Chapter End Notes

> Hey guys! Finals are over and another piece of my soul has been chipped away. But on the plus side I didn't FAIL any of my classes so...new chapter!!
>
> I had too much fun with this chapter. Writing Adam & Adora's sibling dynamic is my new favorite thing. Sorry Catradora banter, but you have some competition.
>
> Also I'm still patiently waiting for someone to draw that fanart of Glimmer wearing that t-shirt. Please y'all. It's Christmas. Think of the kids. (It's me. I'm kids.)
>
> If it helps, it was also my birthday two weeks ago. Food for thought.
>
> And I have an announcement! I have officially made a twitter account solely dedicated to fic writing. So if you want more real time updates, out of context spoilers, snippet previews, and general fuckery why not follow me over there? Please? I don't want to have made it for nothing. Indulge me. Feed my ego. It's fuel for writing future chapters. That and constant validation.
>
> Anyways, until next time where we celebrate Bow's birthday. That's right folks. We finally get to see everyone's favorite boy....SEA HAWK!!!
>
> EDIT: the link won't work for some reason and it's 4 AM here so I don't feel like fucking with it but my twitter handle is

@technoskittles so I'm not hard to find. I have a baby yoda icon. Because baby yoda.

i took your words and i believed in everything you said to me

Chapter Summary

> This chapter's got everything: a birthday celebration, heartfelt conversations between friends, adorable mother-daughter bonding, subtle hints to an angsty backstory, and Sea Hawk.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"*Don't ever think about talking to me again, Adora."*

Her eyes are on fire. Burning and leaking molten lava and her throat is constricting tight, tighter, until she can't breathe. The room around her is spinning and so is her whirlwind of thoughts as she tries to place when things had taken this turn. When things had gone so horribly wrong…

"*Catra, wait. Don't do this...*please….*Just talk to me..."*

"Why can't *I* go to Uncle Bow Bow's birthday party?"

Adora looks up from where she's pouring Goldfish crackers into a plastic Ziploc bag to see her four-year-old daughter standing in the living room. Her arms are crossed and her face is scrunched up in a dramatic mix of a pout and pure, unadulterated anger. Adora has to fight not to laugh or even crack a smile.

"Because you're spending the night at Grandma and Papa's house, remember? And if you go to Uncle Bow Bow's birthday party, you'll make them sad because they're so excited to see you."

Mara relents for just a brief moment before shaking her head so violently she twists her entire torso with each shake. "But they get ta see me *all* the *time*!"

"They do *not*." Adora finishes packing the snack bag and throws it into her bag to give to Mara later during their drive up to her parents' house. "Before last week they hadn't seen you in at least a month. They miss their baby girl."

And her mother is always sure to remind her of that every time they talk on the phone. From the way that her mom sighs and moans, you'd think that Adora is holding their poor grandbaby hostage. Maybe that's exactly what her mom thinks, too.

When Adora looks up again, Mara is now lifting the bottom of her shirt over her head, shrouding her face with the cloth. She sighs and leaves her be. She has to make sure that Mara's packed and ready to go and making sure her daughter is *currently* wearing clothes and wearing them properly is surprisingly low on her list of priorities.

"They should come down here then and then we can *all* go to the party!" She yanks her shirt back down, a wide grin on her face full of pride like she had just solved all the world's problems. Her hair is messed up and somehow the ponytail is loose, but once again, *priorities*.

"Honey, I told you," Adora grabs two water bottles from the fridge and the carton of apple juice, "Bow Bow's party is at a place where they don't allow little girls like you."

Mara stamps her foot and scrunches her nose while twisting her mouth. "I'm a *big* girl!"

"Or big girls under the age of twenty-one," Adora corrects herself. She walks into the living room just as Mara whines and drapes herself over the coffee table, flailing her arms and knocking coasters and coloring books to the floor. She places her hands on her hips.

"Mara Noelle Hartvigsen, you are making a *mess*." Her stern voice captures Mara's attention but the toddler doesn't move to get up. In fact, she doesn't move at all. Just blinks up at her.

"Clean this up *right now* or no sweets for a week."

Adora has never seen anyone spring to action so quickly.

In just under a minute, the floor is cleaned and all the things knocked off the table are haphazardly stacked back on it, but she figures she can straighten it up at a later time. Right now, her main priority is getting them out of the apartment on time so she's not late to Bow's party.

"Good girl. Now go get your jacket."

"But is not *cooooooold*!"

She sends Mara a warning glance laced with the remnants of her previous threat and Mara complies with a groan. As she's helping her into it and threading the buttons through the holes, Mara has her chin tucked to her chest with a massive pout. By the time she's finished, it's gone and now she has this sort of pensive look on her face. At least, as pensive as a hyperactive toddler can manage.

"Mommy?"

"Hmm?"

"Is Cashra gonna be at the party?"

Adora pauses. The question doesn't register for a few seconds. Mara looks at her expectantly the whole time her brain reboots to process the question.

"No. She's not." She straightens the twisted hood of her jacket. "Why do you ask?"

Mara shrugs and Adora waits for some kind of explanation, but it never comes. She doesn't press further. They don't have the time.

"Okay then. Did you pack everything you needed?" It's a courtesy question mostly. Adora had already packed Mara's bags earlier

that morning with all of her actual essentials. A four year old couldn't actually be trusted to pack what she needed - say, a *toothbrush* - but she knows that Mara still likes to be asked. She's at the age now where she adheres to the illusion that she has her own sense of agency.

Mara nods vigorously and gives her a thumbs up. "All of the stencils!"

Close enough.

Adora hums in mock thought, rolling her eyes back for extra flare. "Toothbrush and toothpaste?"

"Check!"

"Pajamas?"

"Check!"

"A change of clothes for tomorrow?"

"Check, check!"

Adora hums again, a smile creeping onto her lips as she glances down. "I guess that's everything…" Then she frowns. "Actually, I think you forgot one thing."

Mara's eyes widen, innocently large, at the very notion before she shakes her head, her ponytail whipping from side-to-side. "Nuh uh!"

"Uh huh," Adora counters. "And it's the most important thing of all, too."

Now she's pouting, clearly insulted. "I didn' forget *nothing*!" she insists.

"You absolutely did." Adora creeps forward, smile growing. "You forgot…" And then she lunges, wrapping her arms around her

daughter's tiny waist before showering her face with a rain of kisses. "All of my love for you!"

Mara squeals and squirms in her hold, giggling under the ferocious attack of affection peppered on her. But Adora's hold is solid and she doesn't let up until Mara's face is flushed a vivant red and her laughter turns breathless. When she pulls away, they're both laughing.

She's getting ready to stand up when Mara catches her cheeks with both of her hands, holding her in place. Completely captivated by her open-mouthed grin, Adora lets herself be pulled down so that Mara can place a wet, open kiss on her forehead.

"There!" she proudly proclaims. "Now you have mine too!"

Adora hums and places a gentle, chaste kiss on Mara's forehead, mirroring her actions. "Thank you, baby girl. Now let's go before Grandma gets worried."

"Okay!"

After gathering all of their things, they exit the apartment, pausing only long enough for Adora to lock up. And as they head down to the apartment's garage, hand-in-hand, Mara rambles about all the things she's excited for in the upcoming weekend while Adora listens wholeheartedly with a smile.

By the time she arrives at the bar they'd agreed to meet up at, it's already a half hour past the designated time. Even so, it's relatively empty.

Adora briskly walks to the table all her friends are gathered around, gift bag swinging on her arm and wisps of her flying around her face. "Hi! Sorry I'm late. Traffic was awful on the way back."

Bow offers her one of his signature grins and holds his arms out. "No worries! What matters is that you made it!" She easily falls

into his embrace and his arms wrap around her tight. When they pull away, she holds out the bag for him to take.

"Happy birthday!"

"Adora, you know you didn't have to get me anything," he says, taking the bag anyway.

"Of course I did. You've reached the big two-five." She smirks and crosses her arms. "How's it feel being a quarter of a century old?"

"Forgotten already, old woman?" Adam pipes up.

Adora sticks her tongue out at her brother. "Shut up. We're the same age, you dingus."

"Ouch. Someone's clearly going through menopause."

If she had something to throw at him she would've.

"Guys it's Bow's birthday. Can we try to keep all sibling violence to a minimum?" Glimmer cuts in, trying to keep the peace. Per usual. Though Adora supposes *somebody* has to.

"Yeah, like, this is one of the *only* decent bars in this city. I'd like to be able to come back here," Mermista remarks dryly, sipping from her glass.

Adora looks to Mermista's left, smirk returning to her face. "Then why'd you bring him along?"

Knowing where her gaze has landed, Mermista groans and slumps forward onto the tabletop. "Ugh. Don't remind me. I'm still not convinced I should have."

Sea Hawk, for what it's worth, doesn't seem the slightest bit offended at their jabs towards him. In fact, he almost seems delighted at the attention being brought to him. He puffs out his chest, one hand pulling at the end of his mustache, turning his smolder towards the group and letting it linger on the woman

next to him. "No party is complete without the legendary *Sea Hawk*!"

The whole table laughs save for Mermista who only hunches over more, hand wrapped in a death grip around her drink as she brings it closer to cradle it to her face. And though Adora imagines that some of Mermista's annoyance was genuine, she could see the underlying softness within it, could tell that she's simply playing up the act for the sake of keeping up their ritual dynamics.

Her suspicions are confirmed when Sea Hawk places an arm around her shoulders and she leans into the touch.

By the time that Adora's settled and seated, a server comes around to take her drink order. She quickly skims the cocktail menu before ordering a simple rum-infused drink with a glass of water. When the server walks away, she looks over in time to see Adam looking at her with a raised brow.

She could smell the trouble stirring in his brain even from across the table.

"Wow. You'd think after last week you would've learned by now to take it easy, Adobo."

She rolls her eyes at him. "For fuck's sake...knock it off, Adam. I'm more than capable of handling my liquor."

His expression says that he doesn't quite believe her and she knows he's just dying to say so too until Glimmer nudges his side with her elbow. And from the way he recoils and presses his lips together, promising silence, Adora can safely say it was none too gentle.

Unfortunately, she's too late. Bow, Mermista, and Sea Hawk all give her questioning glances and she tries to shrink to a microscopic size, hoping that maybe if she can make herself small enough they'll leave it be.

Sea Hawk's the one to voice the question because *of course he is*. "What happened last week, Adora?"

She tries to play it off with a shrug. Nonchalant. Cool. "Just went out for some drinks with a friend." Smooth and simple.

Bow's eyes light up and she curses inwardly. Right. He knows.

Before he can say anything, she reaches for the bar menu and buries her face in it. "Did you guys order anything to eat? I'm starved. Just drove about two hours and haven't eaten anything since this morning." Well, okay, technically that was a lie. She had about a fistful of Goldfish crackers when she was packing Mara's snack. But they don't need to know that.

When she risks a glance up, she sees Bow's gaze still locked on her. But being the saint he is, he says nothing and for that she's eternally grateful that he's so gifted in picking up on her cues. Truly an A-plus friend.

"Appetizers, mostly," says Mermista. "Cheese fries, nachos, calamari - ew, by the way, and hot wings."

Adora is already salivating and she feels the painful twist in her stomach as she sets the menu down. "Awesome. So I know what Adam's getting but what about everyone else?"

Glimmer smiles. "We ordered double of everything."

"Smart thinking." She turns her attention to Bow. "So how'd your weekend with your dads go?"

Bow smiles with a lazy shrug. "Pretty good. Though they kept asking about school which is the exact opposite of what anyone wants to talk about on their birthday."

She reaches out a hand and places it over his. "They're just proud of you. We all are."

"I know. But the one day I *don't* have to worry about my thesis or any of that stuff and it's *all* they wanted to talk about." He sighs. "But yeah, it was a good weekend overall so I can't really complain."

At this moment, Sea Hawk slams his hands on the table, drawing the attention back over to him. "Mermista and I's weekend of romance and fiery love was amazing, too! In fact, I was just about to tell you all about how I absolutely swept Mermista off her feet when I was challenged to a duel." He pauses for dramatic effect, eyes sweeping over their group. "Which I won, of course."

All of their eyes turn to Mermista for the real story. She sighs and yanks Sea Hawk back into his seat. "It was a game of darts at a bar and the other guy passed out before the game even finished."

They all nod. That made more sense.

Unfortunately, Sea Hawk seemed to have sparked a little competition because now Adam's leaning forward, his arm draped around Glimmer's shoulders. "Well, *our* weekend was spectacular too, if you were wondering. And the *sex*," he looks pointedly at Adora, "was *mindblowing*."

Adora hardly rises to the obvious bait. "Did you consult Glimmer on that or did you come to that conclusion all on your own?

"Oh I consulted her *thoroughly*. All night long. And she seemed to agree with me *pretty* enthusiastically." He takes a smug sip of his beer while Glimmer burrows her head into her hands in shame.

Bow is looking between the two with a look of pure confusion. "I'm….missing something, aren't I?"

Glimmer sighs and turns to him, head hung low. "You were right. About the dating twins thing. Five years and I'm only just now realizing you were right."

Off to the side, Mermista's face is scrunched up in disgust. "Jesus Christ, could you, like, *not* do this? My drink is going sour."

"Well if we're talking about *romantic evenings*-"

"Shut *up*, Sea Hawk!"

Adora rolls her head to her left and is met with Bow's gaze and, in that moment, there's a mutual understanding. She raises her fist and he taps it with his own.

"Couples, right?"

"Single squad."

"Shame Perfuma isn't here. Our squad would be complete and the night might be just a tad more bearable."

Mermista rolls her eyes. "Perfuma may be single but at least she's still getting some. Even though she's an annoying hippie about it." She takes a sip of her drink and gestures to Bow and Adora with a wave of her hand. "Can't say the same for you two."

Adora frowns. "There's nothing wrong with-"

Adam cuts her off. "Well, *actually*," His smirk is dangerous and Adora knows that he's trying to circle back to the conversation before. The warning glare she sends him doesn't land. "If all goes right, Bow and Perfuma might be the only single ones left in our little group."

Everyone looks to Adora, eyes wide with surprise, and she briefly considers stabbing herself in the throat with a straw.

"Adora, what is he-"

Their server comes by with her drink and she practically snatches it from their hand and closes her mouth around the straw, sucking it down hard and barely taking the time to taste it. "So Bow, how are George and Lance doing?"

He shakes his head, eyes full of determination locked on her, and she knows that she's lost him. "They're fine but *you're* deflecting

now. Glimmer told me you were reconnecting with your friend but didn't mention anything about it going in *that* direction."

Adora groans. "Because it's *not*. Adam's full of shit and you all should know this by now." She shoots him another glare which bounces right off his asshole armor. "He's just trying to mess with me and you're all playing right into his hands."

Mermista holds up her hands. "Wait, I'm lost. What's going on here? Adora, are you actually seeing someone?"

"It's like you guys aren't even listening to me!"

This is bad. This is really, really bad. It's one thing to have Adam teasing her. It's another to have Bow and Glimmer jump on board with their millions of questions. But she had been hoping to keep all of this smothered and under the radar from the rest of her friends until her and Catra's friendship is on solid ground. She doesn't want everyone in her business and putting thoughts into her head while she's still figuring out how to fix things.

But, more than any of that, she is *not* ready for Mermista to know.

She tries to downplay it some more. "Look, you guys are all blowing this out of proportion. I met up with an old friend and we decided to catch up over some drinks. That's *it*." Her voice must've had more of an edge to it than she intended because everyone's looking at her kind of shocked. "Now...can we drop it? It's Bow's birthday, isn't it? Why are you all focused on me all of a sudden?"

"Because," Bow draws out as he leans forward. "I, as the birthday boy, am *hurt* that you've been keeping this all from me! I've had to hear everything through Glimmer." Adora's glare turns towards Glimmer who only responds with a sheepish shrug.

Mermista leans back in her seat, arms crossed. "Yeah, not to mention that you sounds *really* defensive right now. Come on, girl, spill. If you're officially back in the game, we wanna hear about it."

"I'm not back in the game!" She sighs and pulls at the bottom of her shirt, rolling the fabric between her fingers. "You guys know I don't have time for any of that, anyway."

"But does Catra know that?"

She's going to kill Adam. Right here. Right now.

As *soon* as she can move her limbs.

A hush falls over the table. Everyone's still looking at her. She's beginning to wish she'd just stayed home. She looks over her friends' expectant faces, her eyes slowly rounding the table. When her eyes land on Mermista, her stomach sinks and she feels...guilty, somehow. Like a toddler caught with their hand in the cookie jar.

Unlike everyone else, Mermista's face is fairly neutral, but Adora can see the hardness in her eyes. They're difficult to read, but she can only imagine the thoughts swirling behind them, and each one is a jab to Adora's chest.

"Catra, huh?"

So much for not telling Mermista.

Adora sighs. Well, the game was up. "Catra doesn't need to know anything because it's *not like that*. We just haven't seen each other in awhile. I don't know what else to tell you guys."

Once again, Adam doesn't seem convinced at her statement, but luckily for her, Bow is there to save the day. "Well, even if that's all, I'm happy you guys are talking again. I remember you talking about her a lot in college, so it must be nice reconnecting like this."

That's one way to put it. "It is. Thanks Bow."

At that time, their server approaches their table holding a tray loaded with plates of food, with another server behind them

holding a tray piled up as well. Both of them beginning setting down plates across the table and everyone's, thankfully, distracted by the sizzles and smells.

All save for Mermista who's still watching Adora with her sharp gaze, cutting into her paper skin. She tries to ignore it by diving headfirst into the plate of cheese fries, letting the grease burn her tongue because she forgot to blow on it to cool them down.

It doesn't work.

The conversation tilts to something normal and, best of all, not focused on her. They're back to laughing and harmless teasing in no time, joking at each other's expense with cheek-splitting grins and raucous laughter. Sea Hawk nearly spills both his and Mermista's drinks a few times telling his outlandish stories that are laced with half-truths and exaggerations. But they all decide to play along, throwing in the occasional question for clarification or in hopes to trip him up and make him contradict himself. And he does. Multiple times.

Despite all his talk about wanting to keep grad school and his birthday festivities separate, Bow even tells them a little bit about the thesis he's working on. Most of it's lost on them, especially when he accidentally slips into some of the heavier jargon. But they indulge him, not only because it's his day, but because they love seeing how excited he is about his work and want to support him in every way they can, even if that means having psychological mumbo-jumbo being thrown into their faces while nothing actually sticks.

"Can you explain that last part again?" Adam pipes up through a mouthful of calamari. Mermista, off to his left, grimaces and looks ready to gag.

"Which part?"

"The last five minutes."

Bow reaches back and rubs the back of his head, clearly not thrilled over the idea of repeating himself with only a minimal possibility of Adam picking it up this time. "Maybe I'll wait until I have a more structured outline before I try explaining what I'm studying."

There's a quiet collective sigh from the whole group.

Then, Sea Hawk perks up. "Who's up for a game of impeccable precision that only someone with the sharpest of wits and most polished of skills has ever a hope of beating me, *Sea Hawk*?"

When the table is silent, most of the party still trying to process what he said, Mermista sighed and leaned her elbow on the table. "He wants to know who wants to play pool."

Everyone turns to just behind them where three billiards tables sit, two of them unoccupied. Oh. Right.

Adam is the first one to accept Sea Hawk's challenge. "Oh you are so *on*, Jack Sparrow!"

Bow and Glimmer murmur their agreements, neither looking too enthused about the suggestion but not really nonplussed about it either. Mermista only shrugs, committing neither way.

Adora stands up from her chair. "I think I'll watch first round. But first I actually have to go to the bathroom, so I'll meet you all over there in a sec, 'kay?" Sea Hawk and Adam are too busy trading playful taunts to have heard anything she said, but she receives grins of acknowledgement from Bow and Glimmer.

Mermista only watches her leave, expression unchanged.

And a couple of minutes later as she's exiting the restroom, Mermista is standing in the hallway, leaning against the opposite wall with her arms crossed. Her gaze was turned in the direction of the pool game starting across the bar floor, but upon hearing the creak of an opening door she turns to face Adora.

Adora swallows around the ball of nerves jammed in her throat. "Oh, sorry, I didn't know you were out here waiting." She gestures behind her. "It's free now though."

"Adora, we need to talk."

Right. Adora knew this was coming. Granted, she had also figured that she would've had a little more time to prepare herself for this conversation. One she isn't so sure she wants to have standing outside of a bar restroom.

"Mermista, is tonight really the best time? It's Bow's birthday." She hates using such a cop-out excuse at the expense of her friend, but truthfully it's the only thing that Mermista would probably back down for. Because when Mermista has a goal in mind, there's little on this earth that can keep her from doing what she's set out to do.

"Adora, have you even thought any of this through?"

Guess that didn't work then. She's truly in for it now. "What's there to think through? I already told you guys, nothing's going on. We're just two friends catching up."

"That's the part I'm worried about." She moves her hands to her hips and suddenly Adora feels like she's about to be scolded like she used to be by her mother when she was younger. And probably how Mara feels now when Adora does it to her. Irony? Or karma? "Everything's fine now, but what about later? How do you know she won't pull something like that again?"

Adora bites her lip. She doesn't. "She won't." Her voice wobbles and she knows that Mermista notices. She licks her lips and tries again, doing her best to keep her voice steady. "She *won't*, Mermista. She's...We've *both* grown up since then. Things are different now."

Mermista doesn't seem the slightest bit convinced. "Yeah? Have you even talked to her about it?"

Adora presses her lips together. She hadn't even thought to bring it up, really. The reason as to why is unclear and she's not exactly sure she wants to dwell long enough to figure it out. "I….Look. All of that is in the past. There's no reason to-"

"Adora." She doesn't look up, even though her voice commands it. "You were an absolute *wreck* after that night. You wouldn't eat." She begins ticking off her fingers, one-by-one. "You wouldn't go out. You'd *barely* get out of bed. And how do I know?"

It's a rhetorical question, but Adora answers anyway. "Because you stayed with me. I know, okay? And I already told you how grateful I am but this is *different* now, alright? Things have changed."

"Yeah." Mermista leans back, leaning all of her weight on her back foot while crossing her arms again. "Yeah because you have a kid now. So if Catra decides to do that again and you spiral just like you did then, you know who's going to be impacted the most?" She leans forward, not even waiting for Adora to think of an answer. "Your daughter."

Adora wrings her hands together and looks down at her shoes. Right. Mara. One of the largest parts of her life and she'd barely factored her into any of this besides a secret to veil. The padlock to the Pandora's box that was her past. A reminder. A question.

Her fucking kid that she loves more than she thought she love anything. The light she would cradle close on her bleakest of nights. The comforting heartbeat in the pitch that reminded her that she wasn't alone, no matter how it felt sometimes. The girl she would give anything and everything for, so long as she could grow up happy knowing she's safe, warm, and loved.

And...Mermista is right. If Catra were to leave again, to walk out of her life as swiftly as she'd entered it, and if it were to send Adora into the same spiral she slid down back in college she'd be an inconsolable mess. For almost an entire week, she'd let herself slip deeper and deeper into an ocean of self-pity, not caring what

became of her. Not caring if her wallowing spawned a dark void that would suck her in, vanishing her from the world that had allowed her best friend to be ripped from her in such an unfair turn of events.

If that were to repeat itself, then who would be able to take care of Mara? Who would her little girl look to for love and affirmation and the basics that she needed to live a full life? Who could she count on if her own mother drowned herself in her sorrows, too apathetic to care for herself, let alone a toddler?

But…

But she wants to trust Catra. Like she had just told Mermista, the both of them have changed considerably in just six years time. Catra has matured in places Adora never thought she would. She's still the same old Catra from before, her snark and her humor untouched trademarks of her personality, but she's calmer. More patient and emotionally aware. Considerate. Responsible.

So Adora wants to believe that Catra wouldn't even have it in her to pull the same cruel stunt twice. Not when she's grown so much. Not when she seems so happy to be back in her life.

And if she's wrong? If, say, everything is a charade and Catra's playing her for a fool as some sick way to pass the time? Or if Catra decides that maybe she's outgrown Adora and would rather go her own way, leaving her behind again?

Well, it wouldn't matter. She wouldn't spiral. Because she's done some growing up too. She's not the same girl from college who's too emotional for her own good. She's not the same girl who was naive to the bigger problems coming her way, blissfully unaware of the series of hardships she would soon have to push through to prove them wrong, *prove everyone wrong*.

She isn't the same girl who clutched her phone to her ear, hard enough to hurt, calling to no one to come back and talk to her. She's not the girl who soaked her cheeks with tears, chest cracked

and lungs wrapped in burning hot coils as
she *yearns* and *begs* and *wishes* for her phone to light up, to be called back and assured it was all a mistake, to hear her voice saying "*I'm sorry*".

She's not the same girl who once harbored feelings for her best friend, only to have them shattered to dust and shards with one phone call.

She's moved on. Grown and learned from her mistakes. Became stronger and smarter.

All for her.

All for Mara.

Adora raises her head finally, jaw set and a firmness in her eyes. It throws Mermista off guard a little bit.

"It won't happen again. I would *never* do that to Mara." When Mermista looks ready to say something, she jumps in again, cutting her off. "And I don't think Catra would do that again."

Mermista looks her up and down. Settles on her face. Twists her lip in thought. "And how can you be so sure about that?"

She isn't.

Adora bites her lip and looks past Mermista, out into the bar, deep in thought. Trying to come up with an acceptable answer. One that Mermista would buy and one she could believe in.

Because she was there for her. Both times. And the thing about Mermista is that she's perceptive. Scaringly so. In fact, she was the first one to say something about…

Adora's eyes light up as she realizes something. She has her answer.

She turns back to Mermista, who's still waiting. Looks her in the eye, sure not to waver, to give Mermista any room for doubt.

"Because she's the one that came back."

It takes a second, maybe two or three, but Mermista's face pulls down in understanding and with just a nod, Adora knows that they've reached a settlement of sorts. A place where they can both be content, if only for the time being.

Adora goes to walk past Mermista to return to the bar area, but stops when she hears her name called out. She turns around, brows raised in waiting.

Mermista looks at her only for a moment, before averting her gaze to trace patterns on the wall. Her shoulders are hunched. "Just...be careful, okay? Cleaning up your mess the first time was *exhausting*. And I blew nearly all my money on ice cream."

Adora smiles. Just like Mermista to brush off her concern with passive aggressive comments like that. "I will. And thanks Mermista. For everything; then and now."

She sees the color blossoming on her cheeks before her shoulders hunch further up. "Yeah, whatever. It's just another reason I'm the best." She ends her statement with a flip of her hair and stands up straight. "Now come on. I have to make sure my boyfriend hasn't set the pool table on fire yet."

Adora smiles and offers her arm out to Mermista who takes it only after a roll of her eyes. They begin heading back over to the rest of their group, but then something catches up to Adora and she smirks.

"Boyfriend, huh?"

The dark flush returns with a vengeance and she shoves her body into Adora's, making the latter girl laugh uncontrollably.

"Shut up! You didn't hear anything!"

Adora flashes Mermista a smile, genuine and full of understanding. "Hear what?"

The smile of gratitude she receives from Mermista, small and almost a smirk if she didn't know better, assures her that everything between them is alright again.

She's brushing out her hair when her phone buzzes with a text.

The rest of their time at the bar had mostly been uneventful, save for Sea Hawk and Bow being absolutely demolished at billiards by Adam and Glimmer while Adora and Mermista laughed from the sidelines. There had been tears (Sea Hawk), weak threats (Sea Hawk), demands for a rematch (Sea Hawk again), and a nearly broken pool table (that was Bow, surprisingly, but in his defense, it'd be completely accidental).

By the time the game and Sea Hawk's theatrics were over, the entire group decided that it was late enough to go home. As they were gathering their things and paying their tab (Adora was tasked with *physically* restraining Bow from chipping in since they were supposed to be treating him for his birthday), Bow asked Adora when they could meet Catra.

When she had blinked at him like a frozen doe, he pressed on. "You never actually introduced us in college. We always heard about her but never actually got the chance to meet her."

Adora licked her lips and tried to think of a polite excuse. She didn't want to share Catra yet. She wasn't ready. Not when she wasn't even sure if they were in a stable place yet. And maybe...she was being a *tad* bit selfish, too.

"I dunno, Bow. We've only been talking for a couple weeks now and meeting you all...that'd be a lot for her. I don't want to overwhelm her and scare her away when we're still on shaky ground."

Bow, of course, understood immediately. It was crazy how quickly he picked up on things. She wasn't sure if that was due to the future psychologist in him or if he was really just that attentive of a person. "Yeah, that makes sense. Meeting close friends is always nerve-wracking and a big deal for everyone involved. But we do get to meet her this time, right?"

She sure hoped so. "Yeah, of course you will. Just maybe a little later. When I think she's more ready for it."

Now she's at home, dressed in a loose t-shirt for pajamas and threading her hair into one long, neat plait down the center of her back. Once she's done and satisfied with it, she heads back into her bedroom, plucking her phone off the nightstand to see who had texted her.

Catra. Because of course it is.

Bow may be some kind of psychologist big brain, but Catra has to be some kind of psychic mind reader because of her uncanny ability to reach out just at the moment Adora's thinking of her.

11:34 PM

Catra: Hey you busy next Saturday?

Adora: Not that I'm aware of. Why?

Catra: So my friends Scorpia & Entrapta

are having this housewarming thing

thing and they said I could invite you

Adora blinks down at her phone. Stares at it blankly as she struggles to process, tries to connect the pieces and make sense of it all. Housewarming party? Her friends? Invite *her*?

She types the first thing that flounders in her swimming thoughts.

11:37 PM

Adora: Entrapta? Isn't that the one

who hacked my facebook?

Catra: If it's any comfort, Scorpia's the

one who planned the party and suggested

I invite you

Catra: But if you don't want to come it's

okay. I told Scorp you might not bc it's

kinda soon and short notice

Catra: She also mentioned something

about other kids being there, so you can

bring Mara too. If you want.

Catra: So you don't have to go through

the trouble of finding a babysitter

Each of the texts are sent in quick succession. Adora's barely finished reading and processing the first one by the time the last two are sent. She reads through each of them once, then twice, and then a third time as she wracks her brain, trying to figure out what's going on.

The obvious and short answer? Catra wants her to meet her friends.

The longer and more complicated answer? She can't decide. She's not sure what this means. The texts are nonchalant enough for this to be a casual offer, a way for them to make up for not hanging out this weekend. But she's known Catra long enough to

know the offer is almost *too* nonchalant for that to be the case. Catra hasn't ever been one to send multiple texts, not when she can just get everything out in one go. She only ever sent texts like this when she was nervous which meant…

Which meant she's nervous. She's nervous inviting Adora to this party. She's nervous for her to meet her friends. Because this...is a big step for them. Especially so quickly after finding each other again. When everything is risky and nothing is sure.

But Adora also knows that Catra wouldn't have extended the invite without seriously considering it. Adora has always been the overthinker in their friendship, but Catra is always the one to carefully consider her options, to think about the possible repercussions and whether they were worth going forward.

And this time...they are. Because Catra wants her to meet her friends.

And then it occurs to her: as much as she wants to trust Catra, to trust that she'll stay this time, she doesn't. Everything she had said to Mermista earlier had been a facade. Wishful thinking and pretty wrapped up words that she couldn't even convince herself of. She wonders if Mermista saw through her. She's almost sure she did.

But this invite, Catra's desire to have Adora step into a part of her life that had been foreign to her ever since their college years, meant that maybe….she has no intentions of leaving. She's setting down her roots.

She trusts Adora enough to let her in.

And...maybe it's time for her to do the same. To put aside past feelings and grudges and offer Catra the courtesy of trusting her too.

Something in her stomach twists, but she can't place whether it's a good or bad feeling. She might not figure it out until next weekend.

She types out a quick response before her feet go cold.

11:43 PM

Adora: I'll need an address and a time

Adora: Also, should I bring anything?

Catra: Just yourself

Catra: And Mara, like I said, if you

want. But be careful, Scorp might try

and kidnap her

Adora: So one of your friends is a

hacker and the other is a child thief.

Anything else I should know?

Catra: Babies are born without kneecaps

Adora: ....Okay then

Catra: It's true. Look it up if you don't believe

me

Adora: Goodnight Catra

Catra: You can't run from the truth Adora

Catra: But you could probably run from babies

Catra: Bc they don't have kneecaps

Adora rolls her eyes but doesn't stop the grin from creeping onto her lips. She turns off her phone before she climbs into bed,

turning off her night lamp and nestling herself underneath the covers.

Before she can drift off to sleep though, a thought comes to her and she reaches for her phone, typing a quick text message.

11:58 PM

Adora: So Catra might be ready to meet

you guys sooner than I thought

Bow: :)

Bow: That's great! We should set

something up sometime soon then

Adora: I'll be sure to let you know

Chapter End Notes

It's true. Babies ARE born without kneecaps. Now I've cursed you all with this knowledge as well.

Currently on a roll with writing right now. I know I just posted a chapter *checks watch* three days ago but I'm currently on winter break and haven't started working yet so I've had a lot of time on my hands. So count yourselves lucky because once the new semester starts up, updates will probably be slow again because THIS BITCH is GRADUATING THIS YEEEEAR. Which means school will become an utmost top priority. Enjoy the frequent updates while they last.

Another reason updates are frequent is because I currently have up to 15 chapters planned out. So I have a lot of material to work with and it's a lot easier to move from one chapter to the next. Which is...a first for me lol. I normally never plan so far ahead.

Anyways, I wanna give a quick shout out to nyn11 for drawing Glimmer wearing the shirt (https://technoskittles.tumblr.com/post/189723482830/nny11 writes-i-have-no-idea-what-im-doing-but-i) You da MVP. But if other people want to draw it, it's not too late. I will accept all artwork with childlike glee. I'll start a collection. Mark my words.

Also, I'm currently working on and planning out another AU. The premise of that is that Adora is a princess who was taken from her family by SW who made her forget her life before and keeps her locked away from the world to make sure she can't remember who she was because she wants to use her for her own nefarious purposes. But one day, a knight named Catra comes by the tour to escort her to a new location per SW's orders, which gives Adora the opportunity to escape. Afterwards they go on an adventure to find out the truth behind Adora's past and who she really is and maybe, sorta, kinda fall in love along the way?

Think of it as a Tangled/Anastasia mashup basically. If you guys are interested in reading that story, please let me know because I've been worried that it might not be something people would care about if I posted it. If enough people want to read it, I'll try and get the first chapter out sometime before my winter break is over.

And a general reminder that I've started a twitter account for my fic writing stuff. So if you want updates, preview snippets of stuff I'm working on, behind-the-scenes things, or pictures of my dog....you know where to go (twitter.com/technoskittles). I also have a curiouscat set up, so if you ever have questions regarding this work or any of my others (or you just wanna say hi), hmu

Until next time~

in your lights i'll always be

Chapter Summary

> Catra's stressed the fuck out, Scorpia's determined to go down in the history books, and Adora's the Jennifer Love Hewitt of babies.
>
> But at least there's tiny cupcakes.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She shows up two hours early to help set up.

Catra *never* shows up early.

Scorpia is the one who greets her at the door. She worries her bottom lip. "The party doesn't start for another three hours. Oh jeez, Wildcat, I didn't tell you the wrong time, did I?" She gasps. "Oh I hope I didn't tell *everyone* the wrong time!"

Catra waves her hand and pushes past Scorpia into the apartment. "No, Scorpia, you're fine. I just...look, we need to talk. You, me, and….where's Entrapta?" She hasn't been bombarded yet and the apartment is eerily quiet. No tinkering. No loud crashes. No half-crazed mutterings. Not even the sound of scuttling about.

Scorpia shuts the front door and comes to stand next to her. "I sent her on a last-minute errand run. Just some extra snacks and stuff. I feel like maybe I didn't get enough yesterday."

On the kitchen counter is a pile of food ranging from vegetable and fruit platters, a cheese and cracker tray, bags of tortilla chips, and choice other packaged snacks that was nearly high enough to rival the Eiffel Tower. She raises a singular eyebrow and looks up at Scorpia.

"Did you invite the entire building?"

"Should I not have?"

Catra sighs and shakes her head, deciding not to get into all of that when she has more pressing matters on her mind. "Well when is she supposed to be getting back?"

"She left about twenty minutes ago so...maybe another half hour?" She walks into the kitchen and starts sorting through all the snacks already laid out. "In the meantime, we could start getting some of this stuff ready?"

"Scorpia, you said yourself the party isn't for another three hours. Maybe wait until later to get all that sorted out?" Her friend always had a tendency to over prepare or try to get the jump on things way earlier than necessary. Before they had moved in together in college, Scorpia already had Catra's room picked out and was getting it ready - while her current roommate was still *sleeping there*.

Clearly, nothing has changed. Regardless of reason, she looks unsure of Catra's suggestion, her eyes lingering too long on the mass of confectionary goods and the salty snacks that surrounded them. It takes Catra snapping her fingers to regain her attention.

"Here. Let's put away those platters so they can stay chilled. In the meantime, I need to talk to you."

With a plan of action, Scorpia finally moves and begins doing as Catra suggested, collecting the vegetable and fruit platters and balancing them on her arms while Catra goes behind and gathers up the cheese tray and drinks to store them into the fridge until they need them. The rest of the snacks that don't need to be put away are sequestered off to the far end of the counter to make an easy grab for later when they start to set up.

"Sooooo…" Catra looks up to find Scorpia looking at her warily, though her gaze does flicker to the stack of snacks every few seconds or so. "What was it you wanted to talk about?"

Right. That.

Catra takes a deep breath and smooths back her hair. Her gaze drops down to the countertop. "So I told you that Adora is coming-"

"Oh! Right!" When Catra glances up Scorpia is positively *beaming* and she almost winces from the sheer brilliance of it. "I'm so glad you asked her! I mean, I thought you were gonna hide her away from us forever or something but when you told me I just...ohhh we get to meet her! Finally! And her little girl too oh *gosh* I bet she's gonna be so cute!"

Patiently, she waits for Scorpia to finish her tangent, though in the meantime she shifts her weight onto her back foot and crosses her arms over her chest. As soon as her friend pauses to take a breath, Catra clicks her tongue as a signal for Scorpia to pause long enough so she can speak. "Yeah, this? This is the reason I wanna talk to you."

"Oh." She almost feels bad seeing the way the woman deflates, rubbing one prosthetic arm with the other, but she's got way too many worries and too much ground to cover to revel in the guilt. She can save that for a later time.

"Look, Scorp, you *know* you're my friend," she starts out, doing her best to soften the blow. The words are sort of gritty on her tongue, not because they aren't true but because she's not used to saying them so bluntly. The way that Scorpia's eyes widen a fraction only enhances her discomfort. "In fact, you're one of my closest friends." Her tongue feels like sandpaper but she *has* to get through this.

"But so is Adora. And...things are still *weird* between us and I just…" She chews on her bottom lip and lets her arms fall to her sides, shoulders slumping as the tension leaves her when something else slips in to wrap her in its vice instead. Something that has her hair standing on end and every nerve in her body buzzing with an uncomfortable energy and *fuck* she wishes she

could just get this all over with. "I want things to go right. I *need* things to go right."

Thankfully, Scorpia has enough emotional awareness to stay quiet as Catra bores a hole into her countertop, sorting through her array of emotions carefully to avoid any snags, as she tries to piece together the words she wants to say without coming off as harsh.

"So...you and Entrapta? You two *really* need to….tone it down." The next words come out in a rush because she's still not used to this. She tries to remember the echoes of the words spoken to her in a room encased in soft blue walls, pulling angrily on hair still long enough to reach the middle of her back. "There's nothing wrong with you guys but I just don't want to overwhelm her when things are still so unstable between us and I can't risk anything tipping her over the edge. I really wanna fix things with her because I don't know if I…" She can't do it a second time. The first was hard enough to deal with, overturning the rubble of the destruction she caused and realizing that some things just couldn't be rebuilt. Couldn't be salvaged.

She can't go through that heartbreak again because she isn't even sure how she got through it the first time.

As she's choking on words tangled with memories, Scorpia finally steps up to the plate. Her expression is soft and voice softer as she circles the counter to come stand by her. "Catra, I promise you won't have to worry about anything going wrong." She raises her right hand, placing her left over the space above her heart. "As the host of tonight's party, I solemnly swear that tonight will be so perfect that...that…" She screws her lips up in thought. "That they'll have to put it in the history books!"

It's an exaggeration, of course, but Catra's lips quirk up into a small smile nonetheless. "Oh yeah? Which ones?"

"Um...all of them! Yeah! Generations from now your great-great-great grandkids will still be talking about it!"

Catra raises a singular eyebrow. "Great-great-great grandkids? Scorpia, I don't even have children. Nor am I interested in having any."

Scorpia gives her this look, one she can't precisely decipher which is a first because she's one of the most readable people Catra knows. Her mouth opens like she's about to say something, but at that moment they both turn to the door when they hear the telltale sound of keys jingling in the lock. When it opens, Entrapta walks in, heralding two handfuls of plastic bags above her head and grinning like a Coliseum victor.

"Scorpia! I found sooooo many tiny cupcakes at the store!"

Abandoning their conversation, Scorpia walks over and aids Entrapta in setting some of the bags on the kitchen counter. "Did you get the paper plates and napkins like I asked?"

Entrapta's expression says she did not.

Catra sighs and gathers up her keys. "Alright, I'll go get some. Hang tight." She walks past the two women, one of who looks exasperated and the other too immersed in unpacking the cheap plastic containers of a vast assortment of mini cupcakes to look even remotely remorseful. When she reaches the door, she turns at the last second, looking pointedly at the both of them.

"This conversation isn't over," she states firmly. Then she narrows in on Entrapta. "And you and me *especially* have a lot of things to talk about."

Entrapta looks between Scorpia and Catra before breaking out into a large grin. "About what?"

Catra sighs and shakes her head, finding no use in getting into it now. "Just wait until I get back."

When she returns from the store about twenty minutes later, the two women are cleaning up the living room. Well, mostly it's

Entrapta cleaning the living room while Scorpia scrolls through her phone, listing possible songs for a party playlist while Entrapta chimes in her own suggestions every once in awhile. The amicable atmosphere shifts when Catra drops the bags of plates and other cutlery essentials on the counter and beelines for the living room.

"Okay. Listen up." Scorpia tucks away her phone and Entrapta pauses in straightening up the coffee table. "I already told Scorpia this, Entrapta, but I need you two to do me a huge favor and keep your eccentrics to a minimum tonight. Adora's coming and you already have a strike on your record for hacking into her social media-"

"But I didn't-"

"*Save it!*" Wincing at the high strung tone she's taken on, Catra takes a deep breath and counts to ten, smoothing down her hair to regain her composure. "Okay. Fine. Whatever, just….*please* try and not freak her out, okay? You guys are cool but I want her to see that, too." She ignores the way that they both visibly brighten at her word choice and chokes down the awkwardness she feels voicing the compliment to press forward before she loses steam. "That means *no* personal questions."

Entrapta pipes up. "But how else am I supposed to gather data for my sociological analysis?"

"No data!" She grits her teeth. "She's not an experiment subject, Entrapta, she's my friend! No psycho or sociological analysis. Just...look you can ask her stuff and talk to her but *don't* turn it into another one of your experiments, okay? Can you do that? For me?"

Entrapta looks to Scorpia, who gives her a reassuring smile and head nod, before nodding - albeit a little solemnly. "Okay. I suppose I can hold off on experimental observations for the night." She looks up with a hopeful gleam in her eye. "But perhaps later I can conduct some research?"

Catra rolls her eyes but shakes her head and throws up her hands in defeat. "Fine. With her *permission*."

Something tells her she's going to regret that later, but she has bigger fish to fry right now so she pushes it aside. "Number two: absolutely *nothing* - and I mean ***nothing*** - about Mara's father. Don't ask about it, don't talk about it, don't bring it up. At. All." She's thankful when neither woman offers a rebuttal and both nod their heads in simultaneous understanding.

At least she's safe in that department.

"*He hurt me*."

Ugh. Yeah. Super thankful.

She shakes off the memory and dives into her next rule. "Okay, next, do *not* pester her kid. Tonight isn't just about not scaring off Adora, but Mara, as well. Because if you make her kid uncomfortable, that might just be worse than making Adora uncomfortable." She turns to Scorpia. "That means don't be too smothering." And then Entrapta. "And no showing her any of your botched experiments."

Scorpia raises a hand. "Actually, I vote we keep all of your experiments away from the party." She gives Entrapta a smile. "At least until we get to know everyone better. Because I'm sure they'll love them as much as I do, but for now maybe we can just...talk to them?"

The longer this conversation goes, the more and more dejected Entrapta's beginning to look. "Can I at least have my recorder?"

Catra's initial reaction is to shut that down, but she looks to Scorpia instead, knowing that Scorpia has a far better chance of reasoning with her in a softer manner than anything she can achieve.

And just as she thought, Scorpia comes through. "Maybe...you can keep your recorder in your pocket, but only bring it out if

people say it's okay?"

Fortunately, that's all it takes. Entrapta nods in acceptance and turns back to her task of organizing the coffee table contents, collecting what needs to be removed and arranging what can stay (with Scorpia's occasional guidance).

But she can't just let it go. Not yet. "And guys?"

They both turn to her and she swallows, feeling suddenly nervous. She's never really been good at this talking thing. Especially not when it comes to asking for help or the emotional stuff. Years of therapy can only fix but so much. It's a constant effort, but lucky for her, Scorpia and Entrapta are two of the most understanding people she knows. So that's made it somewhat easier.

Except now. Right now, she feels like something's caught in her throat, irritating her airways and making her feel like she could keel over any moment. But she tries to swallow around it and presses on.

"This is really important for me. I want Adora to like you guys. And I want you to like her, too." She pauses, in case either wants to interject, but when neither does she takes another deep breath and keeps going. "So I really need you guys to help me tonight. I already fucked this up once." She bites her lip. "Please don't let me fuck it up again."

The two women share a look. It's quiet, soft and understanding, wise. Scorpia turns to her with a smile and places a hand on Catra's knee, the physical touch startling her slightly but she reigns it in enough to return Scorpia's gaze.

"We're here for you, Wildcat. Whatever you need."

Catra grins, genuine and unhindered, and feels like she can finally breathe.

Half an hour in and the party's in full swing. Catra had originally thought that Scorpia had been exaggerating when she mentioned inviting the entire building, but with the initial crowd that shows up, she begins to worry.

It's a tall task trying to keep the refreshments replenished. The moment they put more out, they've already vanished, piled onto plates and devoured by the partygoers littering every inch of space in the small apartment. Clusters have formed in the kitchen, the living room, and the hallways. Tenants who know each other and have been neighbors for years, Scorpia's friends and Entrapta's colleagues mixing together in odd combinations, all gathered in a way that certainly has to be a violation of a list of fire safety codes.

In the living room Scorpia has her phone hooked up to some speakers going down a list of pre-selected music, but over the din of conversation and voices it's nearly inaudible. Scorpia seems to count it as a success, even though she pouts every now and again when she realizes that one of her favorite songs has played and passed without barely picking out the melody.

Catra is currently sequestered in the kitchen by the fridge, clutching a solo cup of soda (no ice because Scorpia forgot to turn on the ice maker before everyone arrived and didn't think to buy bags), sipping it slowly and barely catching blips of the different conversations surrounding her. She's distracted, looking over the sea of unfamiliar faces, feeling awkward and somewhat claustrophobic.

She fishes out her phone, checking her messaging app for the umpteenth time in ten minutes only to see that nothing has changed. With a grumble, she shoves it back in her pocket and leans against the wall, half-tuning into a conversation between the group of people closest to her. Something about some entertainment news gossip regarding some big local CEO of some company she'd never really paid attention to.

"...heard about his new girlfriend?"

"I'm less interested in his romantic partners and more in his business partners. Did you hear about all those recent lay-offs in the news?"

"Well, I don't know about all that. But I heard this girl he's dating is…"

Ugh. Gross. Boring. She doesn't *care*. It's all asinine nonsense.

Her nails tap against her cup as she tries to suppress the tangled ball of emotions rolling within her. Tries not to be overcome by nerves as she waits for Adora to arrive. What's taking her so long anyway?

"*You try getting anywhere on time with an uncooperative toddler.*"

Right. And then there's that. Mara's coming too.

She looks out into the living room, seeing a group of small children seated in a circle on the floor, playing with toys their parents brought to keep them entertained and out of the way. Said parents are sitting on the couch or standing off to the side, engaged in conversation whilst dividing their attention enough to keep an eye on their children. She imagines Adora standing amongst them, attention flickering to a mess of platinum blonde hair squished between the ring of toddlers.

A mini cupcake being shoved into her periphery brings her back to the kitchen. At the other end of the offering is Entrapta, her twin tails tucked into two chaotic buns, smiling while she chews on her own cupcake.

She gingerly takes the cupcake from Entrapta's outstretched hand with an attempt at a smile. It passes, because next Entrapta presses to the wall next to her, looking out at the assortment of people littering her apartment.

"It's all so fascinating, isn't it?"

"If by 'fascinating' you mean 'migraine-inducing', then sure." Out of the corner of her eye, she sees Entrapta tapping the front pocket of her overalls where a box-like outline breaks the flat surface. Her recorder, surely.

"Find anyone willing to see your recorder?"

Entrapta quirks her mouth to the side, scanning the area. "I haven't found the ideal participant yet."

Catra's a little afraid on what the qualifications for that would be. Instead of asking, she hums like she understands and things are quiet between them again. She tries tuning in to the other conversations again, only to find that the group is *still* talking about that dumb CEO.

"Well, he's always been sort of a playboy, from what I've seen."

"All rich folk are. When you have that much money, any girl would throw themselves at you."

Fucking hell…

She turns to Entrapta again. "Hey, where's Scorpia?"

Wordlessly, Entrapta points to a spot in the living room where said woman is in the middle of a group of women, none of whom Catra recognizes, animatedly talking about something. Great. No use in trying to talk to her at the moment then.

Just then, her ears pick up on the sound of the doorbell ringing. She notices Scorpia stop mid-sentence and look towards the door. She turns back to her group, looking to be excusing herself, but Catra calls out above all the noise.

"Don't worry! I've got it!"

It takes her longer than she likes to weave through the compress of people on her way to the door, but she's able to reach her destination without major incident. She takes a deep breath,

ready to plaster a grin to greet whatever guest has arrived (another tenant she fears).

But when she opens the door, it's Adora standing there.

The ball of emotion turmoiling within picks up speed and she can't find her words.

Adora herself looks almost breathtaking...*breathless*. Her hair is in that half-up, half-down style she remembers from running into her at the grocery store. She's wearing a sleeveless blouse with some plain black slacks and flats. Generally unremarkable but so Adora it's ridiculous.

Adora smiles at her. "Sorry we're late. Mara insisted on dressing herself and then couldn't make up her mind on what to wear."

We. *Mara*.

Catra looks down to see the four-year-old at Adora's side, clutching onto her hand and head thrown back to look up at Catra. Her hair is thrown up into a messy top knot and she's wearing a t-shirt, jeans, and a skirt over her jeans. But she looks proud of herself, so Catra fights back her laughter.

"It's cool." Her voice is surprisingly level despite the spike in anxiety she feels. "Scorpia bought enough food to feed an army so I'd say you're safe." Then she looks back down at Mara. "We have a *bunch* of mini cupcakes."

Mara's expression immediately brightens and she starts bouncing up and down, tugging impatiently on Adora's hand. Adora shoots Catra an exasperated look which Catra only laughs at and shrugs before turning her attention to her daughter. "Mara, food first."

"Cupcakes *are* food, Mommy."

"*Real* food."

Realizing they're all still standing in the doorway, Catra moves aside to give them space to step into the apartment. "Here, come on in. There's a lot of people, um, sorry about that. I didn't know Scorpia was inviting so many people."

Adora chuckles and bends down to pick Mara up, cradling her to her chest and following Catra in. "I've been to plenty of childrens' birthday parties at this point. This is nothing."

The two navigate their way through a conglomeration of people into the kitchen where Catra shows Adora the array of food set out for everyone. "We have mostly snacks and stuff like that, but help yourselves. We also have soda, juice, and water to drink." Once she's finished she hangs back, almost uselessly, as Adora skims over the assortment of snacks laid out. She's a little surprised when Adora turns her back on the food, but tries to cover it up.

"Hey, where are your friends? I figured I'd say hi before doing anything else." She holds up a gift bag that Catra hadn't noticed before. "I brought a small housewarming gift."

Catra frowns. "Adora, I said you didn't have to bring anything."

"That's why I didn't tell you." Her gaze looks over the crowd of people as if she would be able to pick out Catra's friends out on her own despite never having seen them.

They find her first.

Scorpia, finally noticing who had arrived, tears herself away from the group she was talking to and heads over to them. "Adora? Hi! I'm Scorpia, Catra's friend! She's told us so much about you!"

Catra internally groans. No. No, someone kill her now.

Adora looks over to Catra, a teasing smirk on her lips. "Has she now?"

End her.

"Good things, I hope?"

"Oh, the *best* things!" She begins to go through the motions of a hug, but one look from Catra stops that immediately. She coughs to cover it up and takes a step back. "I don't know if she told you, but we used to be roommates in college!"

"She's mentioned it a few times." Then she holds out the bag to Scorpia. "Here, I brought you a housewarming gift. It's kind of generic, sorry, but I don't know too much about you. Either way, I hope you like it."

"Awww!" Scorpia takes the bag from Adora with an almost entirely too emotional expression. "No worries! That's so thoughtful of you, so I'm sure I'll love it!" Then she gives Catra a look, eyebrows raised and smile bordering on a smirk, as if to say "yeah, I like this one".

Catra shifts her feet uncomfortably and begins questioning her better judgement. She'd always been warned to avoid acting on her impulses and she knows this is one of the major reasons why. But it's too late to back out now, so she grits her teeth and bears it, hoping against hope that everything turns out for the better.

"Friends!"

That hope shatters the instant she conjures it.

Entrapta skips up to them, adding another party member to their little circle. Her eyes are trained on Adora, the glint shining in them that screams curiosity that preludes all of her scientific ramblings and thought experiments, and Catra fears that she's already lost her. And it didn't even take two seconds.

"Hi! I'm Entrapta! And you're Adora!" She looks at the toddler still cradled in Adora's arms, who looks almost completely lost and confused in her surroundings. "And this must be Mara!"

"Entrapta," Adora repeats. Then it clicks and she gives a wry smile. "So you're the one who hacked my Facebook."

"Well, technically, I didn't-"

"Entrapta." Her tone gives the woman pause and redirects her attention over to her. "Drop it."

Entrapta puffs out her cheeks, clearly displeased with the constant slander against her, but in all honesty Catra doesn't have time to placate her right now because she can feel the waves of dense adoration pouring off of Scorpia, smacking her in the back of a head like a Louisville Slugger. When she turns around she see exactly what she had expected to see; Scorpia is fawning over Mara who, once again, looks absolutely bewildered to be there to begin with.

Eyes still focused on Mara, Scorpia begins talking to Adora. "Oh isn't she just *precious*! Catra told us a little bit about her. I mean, not *really*, just a couple things like her name and her age but I promise that's really all we know. Oh, *and* that she's your daughter but I guess that one is sort of a given at this point."

To give Adora some credit, she seems to take most of the rambling in stride. Her smile never falters and once Scorpia pauses to take a deep breath at the end, she even chuckles. "It's all fine, really." She cranes her neck to look at Mara who has completely lost interest in the conversation at hand and jostles her a little to regain her attention. "Mara, can you say hi to Catra's friend, Scorpia?"

Two round blue eyes swivel to land on Scorpia who seems to be standing there with bated breath. Her eyes analyze her for a moment, much like they had when she'd first seen Catra those few weeks ago. As if to somehow assess the kind of person Scorpia is and whether she's worth her time. Science said something about kids having some kind of natural inclination for that kind of thing, right?

And then she breaks out into a wide grin, arm outstretched and wrist swiveling in a wave. "Hi, 'Pia!"

Catra's sure that if it were physically possible, Scorpia would've melted into a puddle of goo on the spot.

Entrapta traipses up closer, pout gone and replaced by a sparkling grin. "Oh! Oh! Me next! Hello Little One!"

Mara blinks at her dumbly, eyeing her just as she had Scorpia before turning to Adora for help.

"That's Entrapta."

Then she turns back to Entrapta, grin back in full force and hand opening and closing in another kind of wave. "'Trapta! Hiiiii!"

Both Scorpia and Entrapta look at each other with a shared expression of awe and delight, somehow completely elated at being greeted by a toddler. It's a little ridiculous, if you ask Catra, but she supposes some people are more easily excited by small things like that.

And then she notices Adora looking at her before she ducks her head in close to Mara. "Baby girl, do you remember Catra? From the food store?"

Mara finally turns to look at her, eyes lighting up in recognition and she giggles to herself, squirming a little at seeing a familiar face. "Cat! Cashra!" Immediately she tucks her head underneath Adora's chin but her smiling eyes are still trained on Catra.

Catra ignores the way her heart stutters and clears her throat. "Hey, kid. How've ya been?"

Instead of answering, Mara only hums and brings her head back up, reaching up to pull on Adora's bangs. "Mommy, I'm huuuuuungryyyyyyy!"

Those three words knocks Scorpia out of her cuteness stupor and back into action. "Oh! Right! How rude of me!" She gestures to the kitchen counter behind Adora. "All of the snacks and drinks

are laid out here. Plates are at this end and cups at the other. Help yourselves!"

Adora thanks her and with one last glance to Catra, moves to do just that. Deciding to not crowd her, Catra hangs back, taking a leisurely sip from her cup. Entrapta and Scorpia close in on her from both sides, both wound up and gushing without even opening their mouths.

"Wildcat!" The party is already loud but somehow Scorpia's voice rises above the rest. "Why didn't you tell us she was so cute? My heart wasn't ready!"

"I'm really not sure how I can describe how cute a little girl is without you having seen her," Catra remarks dryly, watching Adora fixing a plate for Mara. When they reach the vegetable tray she see Mara make a face, only for Adora to mutter something to her before piling some on anyway. "Also this is only my second time seeing the kid myself. I don't know what you were expecting from me."

"Well, it's possible for you to have compared the features she has that she shares with Adora, since we have seen a photo of her." Catra refrains from commenting on the fact that Entrapta obtained said photo immorally because she doesn't feel like opening up that debate again. But she thinks it. She absolutely thinks it. "For instance, her hair - though a few shades lighter than Adora's - is still blonde and darkening at the roots, which means that somewhere as she ages down the line it'll be similar to Adora's current hair color. Her nose and eyes are the same shape as Adora's as well, though her eyes are strikingly more blue than Adora's, whose eyes have a more grayish tint to them. It's possible she inherited that trait from her father-"

Catra whirls around and presses her face close to Entrapta's, lips pulled back to bare her teeth as she hisses. "Entrapta! I told you *not* to bring up Mara's father! Remember?" Her eyes drift over to Adora again, as if somehow worried she may have heard, but Adora seems completely oblivious as she pours a drink for Mara.

Entrapta presses her lips together and brings her hands up to fiddle with the straps of her overalls. "Oops. My bad. I promise that's the last time." And even though Catra's heart is beating a mile a minute and she can still feel the dregs of anger coursing through her system, she sees how remorseful Entrapta actually looks and decides to cut her a break. At least Adora hadn't heard.

"Just…" She takes a deep breath and brings a hand up to smooth down her curls. "Don't let it happen again." And she leaves it at that.

Scorpia decides to step in at the moment to alleviate the tension and, presumably, give Catra a chance to properly calm down. "Hey, Entrapta. How about you help me set out some more of those tiny cupcakes? They're running kind of low." They're fine, really, but she supposes this is Scorpia's way of distracting Entrapta or giving her a chance to take her aside and talk to her.

Entrapta, probably unaware, looks ready to protest and point out the observation Catra herself had made when Scorpia places a hand on one of Entrapta's arms, eyebrows raised, and Entrapta understands. "Right! Okay!" And then the two head into the kitchen, sidling past the groups of people scattered about to reach where they had stored all of the extra snacks.

Leaving Catra by herself.

Not that it's such a bad thing. She takes the moment of quiet - well, as quiet as she can get in a room full of chattering people - to simmer down her rising emotions. She inhales deeply, counting slowly just like she'd been taught, before exhaling while counting off again, letting the frustrations and anger ebb away with the air she's expelling.

Alright. Alright, she's got this.

She looks over to find Adora leading Mara over to the living room area where the two take a seat on the floor by the coffee table. Adora sets Mara's plate down in front of her and the little girl

dives in posthaste, devouring the saltier and more savory of snacks, leaving the vegetables completely untouched. Clearly, disappointing Adora to some extent if her expression is anything to go by.

She thinks about going over to join them, but realizes she still doesn't know how to act around Adora's kid. She's never been great with them, save for her own niece and nephew, but they're family and that's different. Somehow.

So instead, she decides to stall by going over to the counter to refill her cup with more soda. Of course, for as slow as she is in pouring it out, it doesn't take nearly long enough for her to work up enough nerves to make the trek over. And even though her stomach is twisted in a tangle of knots that's making her physically nauseous, she decides to grab a plate and pile it with some food, hardly paying mind to what she adds on.

Once that's done, and she figures she can't stall anymore otherwise Adora will think she's avoiding her at a party that she invited her to, she grabs her plate and cup and heads over to the living room, pausing when she reaches where Adora and Mara are sitting.

Adora's head tilts up to look at her and she gives a weak smile, hoping that those blue eyes can't see right through her like they used to be able to.

"Room for one more?"

And Adora smiles at her, warm and bright, and she feels like a teenager again, when it was the two of them against the world.

"Always."

She takes a seat in the space that Adora shifts over to make for her, setting down her own plate and idly munching on some chips. Somewhere halfway through her own plate, she realizes that Adora doesn't have one.

"You're not hungry?"

Adora smirks and gestures to Mara, who has by this point significantly slowed down in her eating and is staring at the circle of children a few paces over, leaning back and kicking up her feet in her restlessness. Her plate is only half-finished but obviously abandoned.

Mara turns to Adora and tugs on the bottom of her shirt. "Mommy, can I go play now?"

As soon as she receives a nod of affirmation, she leaps up and runs over to the other kids, plopping down without a word and immediately interjecting herself into whatever game they're playing. As she does, Adora slides the plate over in front of her and begins eating what Mara left behind.

"No need. It'd just be a waste."

Catra nods, somewhat familiar from seeing her niece and nephew and their eating habits, but still unable to quite relate. "Right. Makes sense."

Even still, she knows that a half-filled plate of mostly veggies won't be enough to quell Adora's hunger, especially since she grew up always teasing her for her bottomless pit of a stomach. So she slides her plate closer in a silent offering and looks the other way when Adora's fingers deftly snatch up a few slices of cheese.

They eat in silence for a couple moments, Adora's attention mostly directed towards her daughter, watching to make sure she got along with the other kids without any major issues. Seemingly satisfied, she turns to Catra and finally speaks. "So how was your weekend last week?"

Catra shrugs and pushes her plate over for Adora to finish off. "Nothing too exciting. Met up with a new potential client. Might be starting a new project soon, but gotta fine tune some details and all that to establish some ground rules. Who knows how long

that'll take though." She runs her fingers through her curls, wincing when she snags on a few tangles. "What about you? You had that birthday party thing, right? How'd that go?"

It's nearly imperceptible, but Adora stiffens and Catra's stomach drops when she realizes she probably prodded something sensitive. Fuck. *Shit*. How is she supposed to do this? For all her efforts to make sure that Scorpia and Entrapta stay on their best behavior, she's already fucking it all up on her own.

But Adora shrugs off the tension in seconds, nonchalantly waving as she muches on a carrot. "It was fine. Had some drinks, played some pool, nothing too drastic. No arson, which is always a plus."

Catra can't determine if that's a joke or not. She decides not to ask. Better to not risk it. She decides to change topics, carefully treading in hopes to steer them away from any awkwardness. "And your parents? How are they doing?"

And things go like that for a little while. Most of their conversation is small talk, mostly because Catra's too afraid to stray any further than that. Best to keep things simple. She's not sure if her nerves can take anything more.

And if Adora notices, she doesn't comment on it.

They actually manage to pass most of the time away like that. The longer they talk, the more the crowd around them shifts - people come and people go, some only lingering for barely a half hour while others remain slightly longer. An hour passes and a good majority of people have left, though a few people remain here and there, talking to each other or chatting with Scorpia.

Entrapta has been bouncing around from group to group, engaging in conversation for a short while before growing tired of the topic and moving onto the next. Neither of them approach the two of them the entire time. Catra wonders what Scorpia said to Entrapta, but decides to let it be, thankful that whatever it had been, it kept the two from overcrowding Adora anymore.

They're on the couch now, chatting lightly about some memories from middle and high school, neither daring to breach into college territory. It's nice. It's safe.

Mara is off somewhere running around with the few children that remain, laughing and playing while Adora keeps a passive eye on her. Catra watches her too, but less with the intent that Adora has and more out of a casual curiosity. Sees the way she runs around, her little legs dancing around the other children in the midst of their game and imaginings.

Every so often, she catches a glimpse of Adora - in her grin, her laugh. The way her voice - high-pitched and lively - captures the attention of the others. A natural-born leader.

Just like her mother.

So lost in her thoughts, she isn't able to stop herself from saying, "She's a lot like you, ya know?"

Adora blinks, stunned by the sudden confession. As her mind finally catches up to her words, Catra's ears burn and she clears her throat, taking a long swig of her drink.

Great. How does she recover from that one?

Adora doesn't give her the chance. "What? Bossy?" she says, and there's a smirk on her lips that says she's only teasing, but Catra is still scrambling for something to say.

She doesn't have to.

A baby's piercing cry interrupts their conversation and both of their attentions are drawn to the armchair perpendicular to the couch they're seated on. There, a mother clearly struggling to calm her wailing child, bouncing the bundle gently and softly shushing them in hopes to placate them. But her efforts are fruitless and the baby continues to cry, their screams growing in pitch as their face twists and pinks in clear discomfort with their situation. It's loud, especially now that most of the crowd has

dispersed, and Catra winces and feels the beginning throbs of what is a potential headache.

She feels sort of sorry for the mother, but also kind of wishes that she'd leave already and take the crying child with her to spare them all the trouble of having to endure it.

Adora seems to have something else in mind.

The couch shifts as she stands and Catra watches her approach the mother slowly, waiting silently and patiently for the mother to take notice of her presence. When she does, Adora offers a gentle smile, one full of understanding and sympathy. She nods towards the baby.

"I don't mean to intrude or anything but...would it be alright if I try?"

It seems like the mother couldn't hand off the child any faster. In seconds the baby is cradled to Adora's chest, still wriggling in their swaddle of blankets and somehow kicking up a bigger fuss than they had been previously. Regardless, with the baby no longer in her hands (literally) the mother looks just the slightest bit relieved. Her shoulders slump as Adora backtracks to her spot on the couch, lowering herself slowly so not to disrupt the baby too much.

Catra frowns as she watches Adora bounce the baby in the same manner their mother had been, a little irritated that her attention was stolen so easily. Just when things were going great without any more hiccups.

The mother chimes in. "I've already fed and burped her, her diapers clean...I just don't know what to do at this point." Her voice is breathless, exasperated, and Catra notices the dark circles punched underneath her eyes and the slackness of her dark curls that are noticeably frizzed. She wonders why she even bothered turning up to this thing when she obviously looks so bedraggled.

Attention still focused on the child in her arms, Adora smiles. "Sometimes babies just cry. She might be feeling a little overwhelmed being a new environment." As she says this, she cups a hand to the baby's ear, never faltering in the gentle bouncing. Catra grimaces as the cries continue to split her eardrums. It's all useless.

But then…

By some miracle, the baby's cries begin to wane. They soften to gentler cries rather than screams, then even more into whimpers, before eventually...they cease entirely.

Adora smiles. "There you go," and her voice has taken on that tone that people always use when talking to babies. "It's not so bad now, huh? Everything's okay. You're okay."

Both Catra and the mother are stunned. But the mother recovers much faster, smiling in utter relief and disbelief. "Wow. You're a natural at this."

Adora hums and finally raises her head to give it a gentle shake. "I wouldn't say all that. I've just had plenty of practice and sleepless nights of my own." Her eyes scan the living room, pausing on where the group of toddlers are acting out some dramatic scene on the floor before jerking her head towards them. "See the blonde one wearing the skirt and jeans? That one's mine. She insisted on dressing herself."

The mother's eyes follow where Adora's directed them. "She's adorable."

Adora hums. "She is now. But once this one reaches that age, you'll almost miss these days." Her thumb strokes the baby's cheek and she responds with a contented gurgle. "How old is she?"

"Five months."

"She's precious."

Catra sucks in one of her cheeks and clenches it between her teeth. She doesn't really know what to say in this situation. Babies aren't her forté. They never really have been. So she just sits there, an outside to the conversation, sidelined to just listening and watching. Mostly Adora.

And...she almost has to agree with the mother. Adora's always been humble about her talents (mostly anyways). But watching the way she cradles and rocks the infant in her arms, petting her gently and carefully, cooing at her and receiving some in return, Catra can't help but think that she looks like she's completely in her element.

And yet, she's never looked more like a stranger.

"I can hold her for a little longer if you want to get something to eat," Adora offers.

The mother perks up and leans forward, but denials spill from her lips. "Oh you don't have to do that! I'm thankful enough you managed to calm her down."

"No, really. It's fine, I don't mind. You should take some time to yourself." The familiar stubbornness begins to shine through the cracks in her mask, and Catra knows that though things have changed, Adora is still Adora. And she always would be.

It's a small comfort, if nothing else.

The mother looks longingly towards the kitchen and all the remaining snacks still laid out, gnawing on her bottom lip before returning her gaze to Adora. "Are you sure?"

Adora nods with a smile. "I'm positive. Go take a break. I'm sure you need one."

With only a smidge of reluctance, and a million thank you's pouring from her lips, the mother stands up and walks over to the kitchen where she begins the process of making herself a plate.

Leaving the two of them alone once again, with an additional third member still cradled and softly gurgling in Adora's arms.

Catra watches her for an additional moment, thinking of a million things to say, before settling on, "Huh. Adora: The Baby Whisperer."

Adora's eyes roll with a snort and she gives Catra a look, one that's oozing sarcasm and exasperation all at once. "Oh knock it off. I just learned a few things along the way."

With Mara. Of course. "Still, it's kinda funny. Back in high school you'd freak out if you were within even fifteen feet of a baby. Now look at you; patron saint of new mothers and their crying kids."

Adora shrugs, clearly not impressed with Catra's humor hype and smooths back the child's hair. "I guess I just remember how difficult it can be. That's all."

Catra isn't sure how to respond to that, not without the potential of unlocking unpleasant memories, so she doesn't.

The baby in her arms opens her mouth wide, making a little squeak as she yawns and Adora chuckles, stroking her cheek with her thumb again. "Looks like someone's sleepy." And then, completely catching Catra off guard, she begins to hum.

It's a soft, lilting melody not reminiscent of any song she knows. Chances are, it's not based off any song at all and is just something that Adora's making up as she goes, something only meant to soothe the child into the lull of sleep. She's stopped bouncing her at this point, settling for a slow rocking motion. In moments, the child's eyelids begin to droop closed, flickering open every now and again as she desperately fights off sleep, but eventually it all becomes too much and she succumbs. Even once it's apparent she's fallen asleep, Adora hums for just a little longer, to ensure she doesn't wake.

Catra watches the whole thing in a weird sort of awe, amazed at how gentle and unafraid Adora is approaching the situation. She

briefly wonders what's changed. That is, beyond the obvious answer.

And her face. It's so serene and calm, a soft smile painted on her lips as she continues humming, a gentleness and faint tinge of nostalgia in her eyes. It's mesmerizing somehow.

She's a stranger, but suddenly it's not a bad thing anymore. If anything, it makes Catra more curious. Like there's a whole new person wearing the skin of her best friend, someone she gets to meet and learn all about. To pull apart the strings wrapping her tight, unraveling her and getting to the core of someone she once knew, pulsing with a new vitality of someone she doesn't.

So she sticks her hand in and begins the process of untangling the knots, pulling at the seams with the care and precision of a surgeon.

The question burns her throat and scorches her tongue. "Do you miss it?"

It throws Adora off, if only for a brief moment, but despite all her worries, Catra notices it's not in a negative way. Just one that's genuinely surprised. Unexpecting.

Adora licks her lips in thought, gaze drifting over to where Mara is sitting calmly with the other kids. They're all just talking now, exchanging vibrantly colored tales and stories, brimming with exaggerations and playful innocence.

"Sometimes," she admits quietly. Her eyes never leave Mara. "But watching her grow up...it's all part of the fun." She turns the same time that Catra does and when their gazes lock she's feels something stirring, something that's difficult to decipher or pick out in her own tangled ball of emotions. "Don't you think?"

Catra's gaze drops to the baby cradled in her arms before turning back to Mara just in time to see her throw her head back and let out a fit of raucous laughter, shimmering like gold and free of

worries and darkness, and is briefly drawn back to when her and Adora used to laugh like that.

Adora…

When Catra turns back, Adora's gaze has dropped down to the bundle in her arms, her blonde hair spilling over her shoulders and and framing her face, so bright and full, soft and yielding...vulnerable. Her eyelashes kiss her cheeks while her hand busies with adjusting the blankets wrapped around the child.

Catra's heart stutters and the first word to come to mind is: *beautiful*.

"Sure," she says, voice faint with confusion. The grit in her mouth has returned. She doesn't know how to make sense of anything at that moment, so she chooses not to. "Why not?"

Another hour later and Catra's standing at the door with Adora who's cradling a sleeping Mara. It's only just beginning to darken outside, but it's still late enough that it makes sense that the small thing is knocked out cold.

"Thanks again for inviting me, by the way. I had fun."

"Yeah." She scratches at her cheek. "Yeah, no problem. Scorpia's really glad you came. She's been pestering me about meeting you."

Adora gives her a smile that borders on a smirk and Catra worries that she's been read like a book. She drops her hand to her side. "Well tell her thank you for me, yeah? Entrapta too."

"Yeah. Okay."

They stand there for a moment longer. Long enough that Catra's beginning to wonder what Adora's waiting for.

Leave. Leave so she can break down from all the pent up stress already.

But she doesn't. Instead, she readjusts Mara in her arms, placing a supporting hand behind her head. "Hey, um…" Her teeth dig into her lip which draws Catra's attention down. "Maybe next time we hang out we could do something...quieter?"

Catra groans. "Yeah, no. Sorry. I tried to tell them to not be so….well, *them* and I swear it just goes in one ear and out the other."

Adora's eyes widen and she shakes her head. "Oh gosh, no! No! Your friends were great, really! Promise." When Catra doesn't seem convinced, she finally decides to clarify. "I just meant that maybe next time we could do something less...I don't know...public? A movie at my place, maybe? Or something like that. You know, to give us a chance to actually talk without too much going on in the background."

Oh.

"Oh." She doesn't know how she feels about that. She feels like she'd just lied down on the freeway during rush hour and gotten run over by hundreds of speeding cars. Having a more intimate conversation, opening up even more possibilities to screw things up….it's not the most appealing thought in the world.

"Yeah, okay. Sure. Sounds great."

Adora smiles, seemingly relieved. "Great. Besides, Mara's just about *dying* to actually get to know you. She keeps asking about you."

Now *that's* a surprise. And she's less sure how to feel about that than the inital suggestion. "Mara's going to be there?"

Adora's face falls and she takes a step back. "Oh. Um, I figured it would be alright, yeah. But if you want I'm sure I can find someone to watch her if that's too much."

Catra panics and takes a step forward. "No! No, it's fine. I'm just...a little surprised, I guess. Figured you weren't…." *Ready to let me into that part of your life yet*. "Yeah, no. That sounds great, actually. I'd love to get to know the Mini Adora."

Adora snorts. "Okay. Yeah. Whatever." She bites her lip. "Um, is next weekend good for you?"

Catra tries to think if she has anything planned. She realizes she doesn't actually care. "Next weekend is perfect."

"Great!" She clears her throat and readjusts Mara yet again. "Great I'll, uh, text you the details later this week?"

"Sounds good." She places a hand on the door. "Drive home safe."

"Yeah. You too." And after a second's pause, she turns away and heads down the hallway. Catra watches her go for a moment, still shocked at the turn of events, before she notices two brilliant blue eyes, half-lidded and glossed with sleep, watching her back.

She quickly retreats into the apartment, shutting and locking the door. The wood is cool against her forehead and for the first time in hours, she feels like she can breathe again.

When she finally turns away from the door, she see Scorpia standing in the hallway, looking almost expectantly at her. Waiting.

Catra rolls her eyes and lets the smirk tug her lips upwards. "Alright. Go on and call the history books authors. My great-great-great grandkids are gonna love hearing about this."

Scorpia beams at her, prosthetic hands pressed together with barely concealed glee. She opens her mouth to say something, but is interrupted when they both hear a crash from the kitchen. All is quiet for a few moments, before Entrapta's voice trills out.

"Nothing's broken!" A slight pause. "I think."

Catra sighs where Scorpia frowns in worry. She heads back into the apartment. "Well, at least she waited until after the party."

Chapter End Notes

I promised myself I'd have this chapter up before the year ends and I actually managed to keep that. 5 points to me.

This chapter ended up being a lot longer than I thought it'd be. It was initially supposed to be a quick "hey adora meets scorpia and entrapta" but then it got away from me so...whoops. Sorry.

Also, I wanna thank suricata-passer from tumblr for drawing another Glimmer wearing the t-shirt. Y'all are killing it. I love you all. (Here's the art btw: https://suricata-passer.tumblr.com/post/189926854067/but-i-dont-know-which-one-was-better-so-ive)

Remember, if you guys ever draw art of this, please tag me on tumblr or twitter. It will make my fucking day. Truly one of the highest compliments you can pay me.

Speaking of tumblr and twitter, if you aren't following me on those, go do that! I post about this fic sometimes. And other fics. And the occasional bomb selfie.

Also, 400 kudos???? You guuuuuuuuuys. I love y'all. Each and every one of you. Y'all are truly the best. Thank you so much for supporting this fic I'm so happy you can't believe.

And because I won't be updating again until 2020, Happy New Year guys! Hope your final days of 2019 are great.

P.S. If anyone gets my reference in the chapter summary I will cry tears of joy. Please don't make me feel old. Please.

Until next year~

i'm not in this movie, i'm not in this song

Chapter Summary

> In which Adora is Princess Buttercup, Mara is a budding cosmetologist, and Catra is a cooler Michael Jackson.
>
> Also Jordin Sparks returns from the void to impart some wisdom on Catra. (Dadada mmm dada, dadada da mmm dada)
>
> Buckle up kids! It's movie night!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

This is a horrible idea.

A thought that's a little late to occur to Catra given that she's currently standing in front of Adora's apartment. She supposes all the nerves that had been chipping away at her leading up to this moment had finally accumulated into one coherent thought that told her to turn tail and run and never look back. It would be easier that way, safer and less panic-inducing, but her feet won't move and she's still standing here, looking at the yellow ochre paint on the door that clashes horribly with the bright red frame.

She has vivid flashbacks to the last time she stood in front of this door, two weeks before, with a blubbering drunk Adora. Those blue eyes had looked so sad and hollow, beaten and drained and her words had pierced Catra straight through, each recollection of that moment and the echoing of her voice twisting the knife a notch, slowly and painfully.

"*You hurt me here, too.*"

Her hand raises to rub tenderly at her own chest, circling the center of her breastbone, and she scoffs. She wants to note that

Adora wasn't the *only* one who got burned in the course of their deteriorating friendship. Catra herself had gone through a lot - bitter and lonely nights, attempts at filling the hole in her heart with parties and women and catatonic Netflix binges. Hell, she had to go to *therapy* in order to right herself again, to fix what had been shattered, or rather, to learn how to stop deliberately cutting herself on the jagged pieces left behind. Her mental state had completely plummeted in the aftermath and if not for DT and her mother's intervention, she's not entirely sure she would have ever recovered from it.

Catra winces and drops her hand back to her side. But that isn't fair to Adora, is it? Catra's own pain didn't negate what Adora had gone through, just as Adora's didn't negate her own. It was easy to blame Adora for the pain she was feeling, easy to say that she had it worse than the other girl when she had no idea what Adora had felt. What Adora thought or did after the dust cleared.

Her own pain was valid. Is *still* valid. But that doesn't mean that Adora suddenly isn't allowed to feel her own.

Catra groans internally, knitting her brow together and pressing her fingers to her temple. Great. Now she's starting to sound like her old shrink.

Whatever. It's movie night. A night to gorge herself on popcorn and soda while dancing around old, painful topics and uncomfortably confronting a toddler. Adora's toddler.

Brushing aside all of her thoughts and feelings, she decides to focus on the actual task at hand: Making sure that Mara doesn't hate her. Kids are difficult to impress and once you fuck up in the beginning, there isn't any going back.

Juggling the plastic bag to her opposite hand, Catra finally raises her fist and knocks firmly on the door. And waits.

The doorknob jiggles, agonizingly slowly, as if someone is struggling to turn it. This goes on for a few seconds before Catra

hears a set of footsteps approach the door and Adora's muffled voice. Then the door is opening and in front of her is her best friend, beaming at her. Her hair is loose, even a little mussed up, trailing down her back in rolls of golden silk. She's wearing a white racerback and grey sweats, simple lounge wear, but there's something so clean and flawless about it that it makes Catra pause and stare longer than she should.

"Hey! Come on in! Mara was just painting my nails while we were waiting for you, but most everything is already set up." She moves aside, hand on Mara's shoulder - who Catra notices now has been grinning and bouncing in place this entire time - a clear indicator for her to enter the apartment.

Catra manages a grin and takes a step inside, cracking a joke rather than focusing on the fact that she's in Adora's apartment, her *space*, *just like that*. "Sorry, didn't mean to interrupt spa night."

Mara lunges forward and grabs her hand, nearly ripping it out of her socket while pulling Catra down. The little tyke has quite the grip, surprisingly. "I can do yours, too!"

Catra smiles and gently extracts her hand, palm facing her as she wiggles her fingers. "Sorry, kiddo. Mine are already painted. Next time, maybe."

The resulting pout is, no lie, sorta adorable. Even more so when Mara points a chubby finger at her with her other hand on her hip. "Next time," she says, almost ominously, and Catra would laugh if she weren't genuinely somewhat concerned.

Adora reaches over to gently pinch Mara's cheek and the little girl immediately flinches away, obviously voicing her disgust before escaping to the living room. She watches her go with a knowing smirk before turning back to Catra. "We still have to pop the popcorn and pick the movie, but I figured we'd wait until you got here."

Catra nods. "So then what are we watching?"

"I figured you could pick, since you're the guest and all," Adora says, shrugging. She walks over to the kitchen directly to the left and starts gathering an abundance of snacks and sweets laid out on the counter. Then, as if something has just occurred to her, she raises her head to give Catra a pointed look. "Just keep it PG."

"So no *Saw* marathon then?"

"I *will* throw this popcorn bag at you."

Catra walks into the kitchen and sets down her plastic bag, smirking as she invades Adora's space, clearly unaffected by the threat. "Unpopped? You could at least pop it and cushion some of the blow."

"That's a *waste*!"

Both women look over at the outburst from the adjacent living room to see Mara standing on the couch, fists on her hips and frowning at the two of them. Catra has to fight back a laugh as Adora's face twists up beside her, clearly agitated.

"Mara Noelle! Sit *down*!"

With a guttural groan, Mara complies, bouncing up before kicking her legs out and letting herself fall onto the sofa with a couple of extra bounces. Adora, still none too pleased about her daughter's behavior, sighs and shakes her head as she scoops all of the snacks into her arms. As she walks past, she leans into Catra's space, keeping her voice low. "Just pick a movie before I strangle her."

Leaning forward on her elbows, Catra watches as Adora sets out the snack on the coffee table while Mara throws herself onto her back to kick her feet in the air. "What are my options?"

Adora straightens up and tosses her hand back over her shoulder. "Well, like I said we need to keep it PG so-"

"We have *The Lil' Mermaid*, *Beauty and da Beast*, uhhhhhh….*Inside Out*, *Tangled*…" While neither of them were looking, Mara had climbed off the couch and run over to the TV stand and was now pulling out each movie as she read off the titles. Realizing that she is about to be subjected to hearing a long list of every children's movie in existence, Catra steps in.

"Hey, Mara? How about you pick three of your *favorite* movies and I'll choose one of those. Okay?"

Mara blinks at her behind a copy of *Frozen* before breaking out in a grin. "Okay!" And then she turns back to the shelf, pulling out more movies but, thankfully, silent this time.

In the meantime, Catra steps in and helps Adora set out some drinks for the three of them, both of them occasionally looking over at Mara who is studying their movie collection with the utmost concentration on her face. Her eyes were fiercely trained on all the DVD's, pulling one out and looking at it, turning it over, before tossing it aside with a grunt. Though she can tell that the mess is somewhat frustrating Adora, Catra can still see a glimmer of fondness in her eyes as she watches her daughter pick through the movies.

"She's really been looking forward to tonight, you know," Adora states simply, as if that's not something that would give Catra anxiety hearing.

She swallows and manages a, "Yeah?"

Adora hums and moves closer, lowering her voice so that Mara can't hear (not that she probably is even paying attention). "I think she wants to impress you or something like that."

Catra wants to laugh but restrains herself. The kid? Impress her? *She's* the one supposed to be making a good impression here. "What for?"

"Well," she says, but pauses as she screws her mouth in thought. "I think...you're the first friend I've had that hasn't known her

since she was a baby. Maybe she wants to prove she's worth your attention or something."

Catra hums and tears her eyes from Mara to look at Adora who's still looking at her daughter. She notices the length of her hair, the fullness of her body that is a stark contrast to her thin, almost gangly form she remembers from high school. Different from the girl she knew growing up, hard-working and strong, so desperate to please others she nearly ran herself ragged in fear of being on the receiving end of their disappointment. Striving higher and higher, ignoring how the higher she climbed the harder it was to breathe, lamenting on how much scarier it would be to fall…

She has a joke lined up, to diffuse the tension she feels building within, but that's not what comes out. "Sounds familiar, doesn't it?"

Adora gives her a look - not angry or defensive, just pensive, but terrifying all the same. Catra's breath catches in her throat and she wonders if she's already overstepped. She's ready to apologize, the words jumbled on her tongue, ready to book it out of there, but Adora smiles at her, albeit with a touch of sadness.

"Too familiar," she admits. "It worries me sometimes, actually."

Catra doesn't really know what to say to that, but thankfully she doesn't have to struggle to figure it out. Mara is bounding up to the two of them now, clumsily juggling three DVD's in her hands. The pride from completing her task is oozing off of her in waves, and Catra can't help but mirror Adora's grin at her approach.

"Here!" She shoves the DVD's into Catra's chest, barely giving her the time to catch them before withdrawing her hands and bouncing excitedly in place. Looking over the titles, Catra notices a pattern and looks up to Adora with a raised eyebrow.

Adora's noticed too, and gives Catra a simple smile and shrug. *It is what it is*.

As she skims over the three titles - *Tangled*, *Anastasia*, and *The Princess Bride* - Catra realizes she's not particularly partial to any of them. Though her eyes linger on one of them for a little longer, memories flooding her head unprompted.

Sleepless nights, a bowl of popcorn only half-eaten with most of the remaining kernels scattered around them from an impromptu food fight, the blue screen of the TV illuminating Adora's sleeping form - disproportionate from the beginning stages of puberty yet oddly beautiful in her eyes - as her own eyelids grew heavier and heavier, reluctant to sleep but comforted by the soft breaths of the girl beside her…

She lifts *The Princess Bride* into the air, making her choice. "You know, this used to be your mom's favorite movie when we were kids," she tells Mara. She glances sideways at Adora's expression, too blank to read but there is a slight arch to her brow line, like she's somewhat stunned. "Wouldn't be surprised if it still is."

Mara giggles and takes the case back from Catra to hug it to her chest. "It's my fav'rite, too!"

At this point Adora stands up and reaches over to pluck the movie from Mara's grasp. "Well, then it's decided! We'll watch *The Princess Bride*. I'll go ahead and set it up and you two get comfortable on the couch." As she moves over to the TV to get the movie started, Mara runs over to the couch and climbs onto the seat next to Catra, wiggling herself backwards and smiling the whole time. Once she's settled, she grins up at Catra and something uncomfortable shifts inside her again.

Brushing it off, she leaps off the couch. "I almost forgot something." Rushing back to the kitchen, she procures the plastic bag she had set down earlier and heads back into the kitchen with it, swinging it hypnotically in front of Mara. "No movie night is complete without…" She reaches into the bag and pulls out a couple of boxes, "...movie theatre candy!"

Mara gasps, her eyes big and round like dinner plates, before she thrusts out her arms and making grabby hands for the candy. Catra relents after a moment, flinching back when they're nearly ripped from her grasp as Mara buzzes with unbridled excitement and immediately sets to work on ripping them open.

Adora walks back over, unamused, and crosses her arms. "Are you trying to bribe my daughter into liking you with sugar?"

"Only if it's working." They both hear a squeal as Mara successfully opens one of the boxes and begins working on the plastic packaging with increased vigor. "And I think it just did."

Adora sighs, drawn out and defeated, before shaking her head. "That's low, even for you."

Catra smirks and raises her hand to her chin, bent at an angle to rest her head as she gives Adora a half-lidded smirk. "Awww, you know nothing's too low for me."

She can tell that Adora wants to keep up the annoyed act, but there's a hint of a smile on her lips, and they both know she's lost it before it's ever really gone. She shakes her head again, rolling her eyes, before turning her attention back to Mara. "Okay, Mara, what do we say to Catra for bringing you candy?"

Having finally wrestled the package open, Mara's cheeks are stuffed with peanut m&m's and she looks up with wide eyes. A chipmunk. She looks like a damn chipmunk. Forgoing one set of manners for another, she manages a muffled "thank you" before being lightly reprimanded by her mother for talking with her mouth full.

Soon enough they're all settled on the couch, Mara sandwiched between the two of them, and fastforwarding through the previews to get to the title screen. It isn't until they've started the movie that Adora realizes she forgot to pop the popcorn and excuses herself to the kitchen to do so. Catra panics a little being left alone with Mara, even if she's not *actually* alone given that

Adora is literally only ten feet away, but that doesn't quell the anxiety anymore than gasoline douses a fire.

"Who's yer fav'rite?"

Catra looks down to see Mara finishing off her first pack of candy, looking up at her expectantly. She chews on the question for a second, briefly wondering if this is some kind of test she's supposed to pass. As if a four-year-old possessed the wits to play mind games with her.

She shrugs. "Inigo's pretty cool."

Mara gasps and beams at her, and somehow (even thought this *wasn't* a test), Catra feels like she passed.

"I'm Inigo," Mara states matter-of-factly. Catra waits for some kind of elaboration, knowing that kids her age love to explain every detail of their thought process to anyone with ears, but a moment passes and none comes.

"Oh?" she prompts.

Mara nods. "Yep. And Mommy's Princess Buttercup." Once again, failing to explain what she's talking about or thinking.

Deciding to play along, however, Catra hums like she understands. "Okay then. So who am I?"

Tearing her eyes from the TV, Mara looks at her, eyes giving her a quick once-over before breaking out into giggles. "You're Fizzini!"

There's a snort and Catra looks up to see Adora's returned with a bowl full of popcorn. Her hand is covering her mouth and her face is pink, struggling to hold in her laughter. Meanwhile, Mara is lost in her own fit of giggles, unabashedly laughing as Catra balks.

"What? Why him?" she asks incredulously, trying to insert herself into the mind of a four-year-old to understand what connections she made to come to that conclusion.

Instead of answering however, Mara giggles harder and points at her. "Fizzini! Fizzini!"

Now, Catra is a grown enough woman to not be bothered by most things. She's certainly been tossed her fair share of insults throughout her life, ranging from minor offenses that genuinely had no affect to the really hurtful that she had to brave through. But somehow, none of those even compared to what she assumes is supposed to be a wicked burn from a *toddler*. And yeah, she's not proud of it, but maybe she *is* pouting over it, but so what?

I mean, in her defense, she just got compared to a guy who *dies* in the first twenty minutes of the movie. Kids truly are ruthless.

Adora sits back down next to Mara and sets the popcorn bowl down, petting her hair and shushing her as she is still chanting mockingly in Catra's direction. "Okay, okay, Mara. I think it's time to leave Vizzini alone." Catra shoots her a glare and receives only a mirthful smirk in return. "Let's watch the movie now. Quietly."

And they do. Mara quiets down and begins shoving fistfuls of popcorn into her mouth and Catra sulks for a few more minutes, for good measure, before finally relaxing and easing herself into the movie. Throughout the movie, she mostly sips on her drink, hardly indulging herself on the array of snacks set out. At one point, she feels a tap on her arm and looks over to see Mara looking at her. They stare at each other for a few seconds, Catra's confusion growing more as it stretches on, before Mara reaches over and takes Catra's hand into her own. Turning it over with her palm facing up, Mara places her other fisted hand inside, before dropping a handful of slightly crushed popcorn.

Catra stares at the offering in bewilderment. It isn't until Mara shoves her hand back to her body, slightly upwards, that she plucks one of the kernels to chew on it. Seemingly satisfied, Mara nods and returns her attention to the movie.

Was that...an apology of sorts? Who knows. No sense trying to dissect the actions of a four-year-old.

Even still, she notices that Mara is leaning more towards her now, head barely resting against her arm.

They make it to the halfway mark of the movie before Mara kicks her feet over the edge of the couch and taps incessantly on Adora's arm. "Mommy, can I do your hair?"

"Sure, Sweetie."

With a cry of joy, Mara immediately leaps off the couch and runs back into the hallway behind them, returning in a short moment with a gel-bag colored a translucent pink sprinkled with glitter. She unzips it and begins pulling out an army of hair supplies, setting them on the table amongst the snacks, before grabbing a plastic brush. Getting up on her knees, she begins running it through Adora's hair. Catra watches this strange little ritual, chuckling when Adora occasionally winces when Mara pulls too hard, but is fascinated by how...unaffected Adora is by this act.

Then again, she *did* mention before that Mara liked to play with her hair a lot.

Soon enough, Mara's doing her best to twist Adora's hair into a braid. Her work is sloppy, but that's a given due to her age and small hands, Catra supposes. It takes a minute, and Catra's attention alternates between paying attention to the movie to watching Mara work on Adora's hair. Eventually she gets to the end of the braid and ties it off with a dark blue scrunchie. Though she doesn't stop there. Next she begins working on tucking a barrage of gaudy hair clips into the braid, a conglomeration of butterflies, flowers, and neon colors shoved in haphazardly.

Finished, Mara pulls back and looks proudly at her creation. "Done! You can look now!"

Obediently, Adora pulls out her phone with her front facing camera and looks at her hair. If she's upset by the mess that her

hair was turned into, lopsided braid and all, she doesn't show it. Instead she smiles brightly at Mara, tucking her head forward to plant a kiss on her head. "Thank you, baby girl. It's beautiful."

"Like a princess!"

"Like a princess."

The moment is cute, admittedly. The sort of thing you'd probably see in some sappy commercial advertising a bank or something from a family sitcom drama. Cringingly sweet. The kind of sweet that made you grit your teeth because you aren't sure how to process it. But that moment melts away when Mara looks over to Catra, eyes flicking up to her own mop of curls, and Catra shrinks back.

Mara, oblivious to Catra's obvious discomfort, swivels around, picking up her brush again. "Okay! Your turn!"

She leans forward, brush beelining straight for her hair and Catra pulls away, hair coming up protectively to clutch her hair to her head. Persistent, Mara chases after her until Adora's arm wraps around her waist from behind and pulls her back. Ready to complain, Mara whips around to serve Adora a pout, but Adora seems to not be having any of it.

"Mara, Sweetie, do you remember that talk we had? About touching people without their permission?" she says gently.

Solemnly, Mara nods as she deflates in Adora's grip.

"And what did Mommy say?"

Mara's quiet for a moment, fidgeting in Adora's hold and playing with the bristles of the brush. "You said to ask dem if it's okay first."

"And?" she said, prompting a further response.

"And...an' that I should'n' beg them ta say it's okay."

Adora nods approvingly. "So what do we say if we want to do someone's hair?" And then she nods her head towards Catra, gesturing for Mara to address her next. She relaxes her hold enough to let Mara swivel back around to face Catra. Her face is calmer and she actually looks a little ashamed (or maybe she's just pouting?).

"Um…" Still fidgeting with the brush, Mara refuses to look up at her. "Can I do your hair too?" She looks back at Adora when the woman squeezes her arm and whips around, tacking on a hurried, "Please?"

Still not entirely comfortable with the idea, Catra's initial gut reaction is to say no. Her hair is a very delicate and complicated monster, one that even *she* can't tame most days. It's a touchier subject for her, one that used to be the epicenter for most of the ridicule she received in her early childhood that pushed her to ruin her hair with perms and flat irons. Thinking about it, she's pretty sure that outside of herself and her own mother, she's never been comfortable with anyone touching it except Adora.

"*Your curls are so pretty*," she had said once when they were nearing high school. "*Why do you hide them?*"

It'd taken a couple more years of frying her hair and building up her confidence, but sometime in high school, she finally let her hair down - sorta literally. Even still, it's one of the things she's more sensitive about and she's still harshly selective of who can touch it and when.

But...she supposes that if there's anyone else who can touch her hair besides Adora...it *would* be Adora's own kid, right?

Catra sighs and raises her hands in submission. "Okay, kid. You can do my hair." She points at her, firm and unyielding. "But no brushing."

The smile that Mara hits her with feels like a semi-truck. It's so...so *Adora* it hurts. Aches deep in the marrow of her bones.

She wants to see more of it.

Dropping the brush back on the table, Mara instead picks up two bright orange scrunchies. Neon eye-sores. She grimaces but chokes back her retort, realizing she's already surrendered herself to her fate and decides to just allow herself to drift through the course of events.

When Mara's hands initially touch her hair, she flinches, an instinct reaction, but forces herself still so the little girl can work. It surprises her when she finds that Mara's grip isn't harsh and she doesn't tug mercilessly on it like she had expected her to, like how all the salon ladies used to pull on it without a thought to how it made her feel. It's soft, slow and careful as she bunches up one half of her hair and wraps it up in one of the scrunchies on top of her head, before shifting over to repeat the process on the other side. It's quick, a lot quicker than it had been for Adora's hair, but she supposes that's because she has far less to work with.

Not done yet, Mara goes into her bag and procures a red headband, topped off with a red-sequined bow, and uses it to push back Catra's bangs. After making sure it's secure, Mara steps back to admire her work, clasping her hands together with a grin.

Click.

Catra whips around and sees Adora pointing her phone at her, a wicked grin on her lips and lunges forward. "You did *not*!"

Holding the phone out of her reach, Adora keeps her at bay with her other hand. "Oh come *on*! It's cute! See?" She turns the phone around and Catra is face-to-face with herself, hair bunched up in pigtails and bangs sticking up behind the headband.

"Adora delete that picture or I *swear*-"

Easily, almost embarrassingly so, Adora shoves her off and sets up the camera for another picture. "Here. Let's take one of all of us with our little stylist." She scoops Mara to her side, hand outstretched for Catra. "Come on!"

She has half the mind to tear everything out of her hair and sulk on the other end of the couch, grumbling to herself and watching the rest of the movie stewing in her bitterness. But then Mara looks to her, all grin and expectant eyes, and she loses her nerve. Grumbling, she scoots closer until she's pressed closer to Mara and waits as Adora lines up the shot.

"Catra, you have to *smile*."

"Like this?"

Mara giggles and puts her fingers at each corner of Catra's mouth, pushing them up and turning her scowl into something manic. "Like dis!"

Click.

"I can't believe she fell asleep so quickly."

The title screen's music was softly lilting out of the nearly muted TV. Hair supplies and snacks were littered about the coffee table, like a teenage slumber party had exploded all over it. Catra was lounging against the arm of the couch, one knee tucked to her chest with the other leg stretched out on the couch.

At the other end sat Adora, facing forward with her feet on the floor, braid thrown over her shoulder, and Mara's head resting in her lap as she dreamt.

"Despite what she says, she *is* just a little girl. She tires out pretty easily," Adora chuckles.

"Still," Catra mumbles, careful to keep her voice low enough to avoid waking her. "About twenty minutes ago she was bouncing and playing hair salon. Now she's totally conked out. Kids are weird."

Adora laughs, almost silently, and runs her hand down Mara's side, thumb brushing against the fabric of her shirt. "Can't argue

with you there." She looks up at Catra, something sly shining in her eyes. "In fact, I'd say you were one of the weirdest kids of all."

"Was not!"

"What other kids did you know that chased live mice around trying to catch them?"

Catra groans and throws her head back. "Okay, that was *one time*. Are you ever going to let it go?"

Adora tilts her head up, eyes to the ceiling, as if she's actually considering it. "Hmmm….nope!" And she laughs again, hand coming up to muffle most of the sound. If it weren't for Mara being in the way, Catra would've kicked her.

They sit there for a moment, Catra stewing in her surface-level anger and Adora grinning while stroking Mara's hair. Then Adora speaks up again, her voice soft.

"I liked it, though. Your weirdness. It was one of my favorite things about you."

Choosing to ignore the weird comment, Catra leaned forward, curiosity piqued. "'One of'?"

Instead of answering her question, Adora smirks at her. "What? Fishing for an ego boost?"

Placing a hand against her chest, Catra feigns hurt. "I'm appalled you'd accuse me of such a thing! Can't a girl just be curious about what her best friend liked about her?" She sits in thought for a moment before offering her own smirk. "It was totally the wicked sense of fashion, wasn't it?"

"Oh, please! You thought wearing a single glove was cool!"

"Michael Jackson did it and everyone *loved* it!"

"You're not Michael Jackson!"

Catra sits back, thinking it over. "You're right." She smirks and rests her elbow on the arm behind her. "I'm *way* cooler."

Adora rolls her eyes with a scoff, but ultimately decides not to grace that with a response. Unfortunately for her, Catra takes that as a win, and sits back reveling in it.

They sit in silence for a few moments. It's comfortable at first, a wind down from their banter, but as the seconds pass, Catra begins to get more fidgety. What's she supposed to do in this sort of situation? Before her and Adora never ran out of things to say. They could have conversations for hours, both of them breathless and wary and still having more to say. This silence….she's not used to it.

She looks around the apartment instead, trying to find something to spark the conversation again, to bring them back around. When nothing immediately jumps out, she ponders leaving. The night's still young, but with Mara asleep and the movie over, she's not entirely sure what to do with herself anymore.

She bites the inside of her cheek. No. Running away wouldn't help anything. It didn't work before and it isn't going to work now. The only way to fix this, to get back to how they used to be, is to tough it out.

And that meant they couldn't always play it safe.

Catra looks at the door, remembering the events that happened on the other side. Slurred words and drunken confessions, something that's plagued her for weeks as she tries to forget, tries to avoid it at any and all costs. Maybe that's where she's supposed to start.

Taking a deep breath, she braces herself….

"Hey."

And dives in.

Adora perks up, lifting her gaze from Mara's sleeping form. She probably notices how tense Catra is and frowns, concerned. "Yeah?"

Gnawing on her lip, Catra tries to think of the best way to go about this. After seconds of deliberation, she realizes there isn't. Just jump in. Rip the bandaid off. Don't overthink it.

"Remember that night you got drunk? And I had to take you home?"

"Um...yeah." Pause. "Why?"

"You…" She trails off and goes to run her fingers through her hair, but instead her fingers knock into the headband. She scowls and settles for pulling on one of the pigtails instead. "Well, I got you here and before you went into your apartment, you, uh…" She bites her lip and pulls harder, curling and uncurling her toes. "You said...some things."

There's silence, thick and suffocating, and Catra doesn't dare to look at Adora. Not if she's going to see this through. Not if she wants to stay composed enough to do this.

"What...what kind of things?" Her voice is hushed, wobbly and edging on nervous.

For her sake, Catra knows she needs to get straight to the point.

"You brought up Mara's father." Finally, she looks over to Adora. She owes her at least that much.

She's greeted with Adora, pale, eyes blown wide with anxiety. Her eyes drop to Mara's form, frantic, shoulders relaxing in the slightest in seeing that she's still sound asleep.

Catra rushes in, saving Adora from her self-destructive, anxiety-fueled thoughts. "You didn't tell me anything, not really. Just...that

he hurt you." She mimics Adora's actions from that night and places a hand on her own chest, patting it for good measure. "Here. Emotionally."

Still quiet, Adora's now looking down at Mara somberly, her expression guarded yet somehow still vulnerable. Like a fortress revealed in the dawn of day after a night's battle to reveal just how much damage done to it in the siege. Standing, but just barely.

"I just...thought you should know," Catra said lamely. She licks her bottom lip and drops her hand back to her lap. "I didn't want you to think I was keeping it from you or something."

"I-" Adora chokes on whatever she's about to say next, pressing her lips together as she struggles to build herself back up. Catra can see the confliction dancing in her eyes, wavering between her and Mara, lost. Searching.

"You don't have to tell me anything right now," Catra assures her. "Not until you're ready. I'll wait for however long you need me to. I just figured it wouldn't be fair to you that you mentioned it and you might not have even remembered doing so."

"I want to tell you." Her voice, though meek and small, is firm and when they lock eyes, Catra can see just how much truth there is to that statement. "I want...God, Catra I want to tell you everything. But I don't know if I can handle it right now." She takes a shaky breath, deep inhale and exhale. "I'm sorry."

"No need to be. I told you I'll wait. And if you decide to never tell me, that's okay too."

And as much as she wants to know, as much as she wants to be let in fully by Adora and resume their friendship from where it left off, she knows she can't force it. What they had was broken. They'd drifted apart and so much has changed since they did. It wouldn't be fair to Adora - to either of them, really - to strongarm her way back in and force something that wasn't there.

She wants to know, but she knows that's a selfish thought to have. And this isn't just about her. It's barely just about them anymore.

Catra looks down at Mara's sleeping form, oblivious to everything, living in ignorant bliss. So soft and sweet, too young to be marred by the cruel complications of life. She voices a question she already knows the answer to.

"Does she know?"

Adora shakes her head. "I...I don't know how to tell her yet. She's so young and I...I'm afraid she won't understand or she'll take it the wrong way." She gives a short humorless laugh. "I mean, I barely know how to tell *you*. How am I supposed to explain it all to a toddler?"

"So what are you going to do when she starts asking?" Adora's silent and Catra sits up, tucking both of her legs in and crossing them. "Because she's going to start asking."

Adora sighs and cards her fingers through Mara's hair, letting the motion relax the tension in her shoulders. "I haven't figured that out yet. I don't want to lie to her, but I can't tell her the truth either. Not yet."

She's not sure what to say to that. She assumes that Adora has her reasons, but without knowing what happened, it's difficult for her to offer any advice. Besides, it's not even her call to make. She only just got here, back into Adora's life, introducing herself to Mara's….she has no place in anything involving them, not like that.

But...that didn't mean she wouldn't be there to help.

Catra shifts on the couch again, crawling forward to place a hand on Adora's shoulder, soft and comforting. "Well, whatever you decide, I'll be here to help you through it. Okay?"

There's something in Adora's eyes when she looks at her, flitting about so quickly it's hard to pin down, but then Adora offers her a small smile full of relief and gratitude, and somehow, Catra knows this was the right move to make. All of it.

"Thank you, Catra. I'm so glad you're here."

One step forward.

Chapter End Notes

crawls out of the trenches I'm alive....somehow.

Sorry guys for the wait. I started school again not too long after the last chapter and immediately my mental health went to shit. So I've been working on keeping up with school, organizations, and making sure I don't completely lose it. It's been a real struggle lately and I'm working on it. (I won't go into too much detail 'cause I'm better now but in the first week of the semester alone we'll just say I made some poor choices and my bf had to snap me out of it)

Anywho~

Hope you enjoyed this chapter. I don't think I'll be putting this back on a hiatus, but updates are probably going to be a lot slower from here on out because I only have about 2ish months left until I graduate and I'm stressed about finishing and finding a job (and possibly moving out of state to said job wherever it is). So this fic isn't dead, but updates will be sparse. I'll get them out when I can basically.

In other news, more fanart!!! Yet another Glimmer wearing her iconic t-shirt that I'm determined to now include in the fic somehow. Thanks mellorine91!! You're the best!

Remember, if y'all ever draw something for this fic (or any of my fics really) PLEASE do not hesitate to tag me on tumblr or twitter. I love the stuff you put out. It makes me feel like y'all really care about my fic.

Until next time~!

come over and say nothing (silence is everything)

Chapter Summary

Crazy exes, lost children, and painful memories, oh my!!

Also...the girls are fightiiiiiiiiiiing!!!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The rain outside patters against the window, droplets painted in panning whites and pulsing oranges as they descend slowly down the glass pane. White noise in the background to rival the chaos in her heart and mind, toiling and shivering and shaking, barbed wire caught in her throat and tearing it bleeding and raw.

Her face is stiff with previously shed tears, mouth parted as she stares at her phone in a semi-vegetative state, trying and trying and trying *to process. Sort through her thoughts and apply them to reality, to reach across miles and miles and call out for the one person she wants to listen but no willingness to do so.*

Time passes. Half an hour maybe. Next to her, Mermista is sound asleep in an ice cream-induced coma. An empty carton on the nightstand, spilling with used tissues and empty soda bottles like a depression waterfall.

Her fingers are tapping away on her phone screen without thought. Without abandon. Typing, deleting, retyping, pausing to catch her breath.

She hits send.

The response is immediate.

Message Not Delivered:

This person is not receiving messages at this time.

It takes a few seconds to register fully. And then, all at once, there's this crushing weight of helplessness, an innate desire to reach out and scream to be heard, to undo, to take it all back.

A quiet sob rushes out of her and she digs her teeth into her lip, deep, to keep from waking Mermista.

Talk to me.

It's the first cool day in September, a promising prelude to the relief of autumn from a sweltering summer. It's temporary, of course, as the weather forecast for the following week features climbing temperatures and still humid afternoons, but if they are allowed some reprieve until the new season really sets in, Adora is glad it's today.

She's wrapped in a light cardigan to shelter her from the gentle breeze, serenely sitting on a wooden park bench in the direct sunlight to soak up the midday warmth it provides. Her hair, pulled into a low, side ponytail, picks up with the breeze every so often, brushing across her face. She wraps the cardigan tighter and keeps her arms crossed over her chest, eyes following a hyper little bundle across the playground with a small smile.

The park is alive today, as expected of those taking advantage of the weather and getting in their time before the impending winter months drive them into their homes. Mothers trying to exhaust their children are stationed around the perimeter of the playset - some on benches, some standing, some chatting with others, and others still on their lonesome, reading or scrolling through their phones. The children are radiant and bursting with energy, running without abandon around the playground, screaming and laughing as their imaginations run wild and their hearts wilder.

Her own child, little Mara, has integrated herself into a small group of children playing some sort of game. It's vigorous work, if

one could guess by the breathless laughs they let out or the occasional flop onto the ground as they regain their breath, but their youthful exuberance has them back on their feet in seconds as if they didn't know the definition of tired.

And every so often, Adora catches Mara looking her way, as if to check if she is still there or right before she does something to show off, to impress her. Adora smiles and waves at her every time, heart light when Mara grins back and waves tenfold.

"How are you not exhausted just watching her? I only just got here and I'm ready for a nap."

Adora finally tears her gaze from the playset where it's been trained for the last fifteen minutes to see Catra standing next to her at the edge of the bench. Her hands are shoved into her jacket pockets - leather, because of course it is - and she's looking towards the playground with a slight frown. Her hair, always unruly, is shoved underneath a black beanie this morning, probably a lazy decision due to her impromptu "hair appointment" the night before. Her jaw is moving, a repeated motion, and Adora only realizes she's chewing gum after she pops a bubble.

"My main consolation is that after this it's nap time."

Catra takes a seat next to her, slouching a little and legs spread out. Their knees knock together. "For you or her?"

"If I'm really lucky? Maybe both."

After a quiet grunt of acknowledgement, things are quiet between them. Adora goes back to watching Mara on the playground, eyes searching for a few seconds until she finds her at the very top, clutching the metal bars and shaking herself against them, like a prisoner trying to get out of their cell. She's calling down to one of the kids below who's pretending to fight off another one of the kids from the same group. As the battle commences, Mara is up top, screaming to be released and saved.

Catra speaks up again. "How are you?"

A simple enough question, but her tone is loaded. Adora hums and thinks about it, settling on "I'm good."

"Sleep well?"

"Well enough."

Last night was...well, tense may have been too strong a word, but she feels like that generally sums things up. What she had expected to be a straightforward night of just watching a movie and hanging out together, Mara included to make things less awkward, took a sudden nosedive when Catra dropped *that* bomb on her.

Now Adora remembers why she doesn't drink anymore.

Of course, it's not to say that she doesn't appreciate Catra's honesty, especially because their absences in each other's lives is such a sensitive topic to breach and she knows it couldn't have been easy to bring it up. In fact, she almost admires Catra's ability to push past all of that for the sake of letting her know, to ensure that no more secrets were kept between them. She got to see a different side of Catra last night. More….emotionally mature, perhaps?

Not to say that Catra has always been insensitive or emotionally blind to other people's feelings just….well, no that's pretty close. They'd been friends for such a long time that Adora had sort of just gotten used to it, how reserved Catra could be at the drop of a pin, shutting people out to shield her own emotions or to avoid being affected by others'. She had her moments growing up, of course, where she could be empathetic and caring - even if it was just mostly for Adora - but there were times where even the two of them would struggle to get past the barriers she was subconsciously putting up. Adora always wanted to tear them down in one fell swoop, to feel trusted and special about being the one Catra could feel she could open up to about anything. And Catra, most times, just wanted to be left alone.

So last night was….well, surprising was certainly one word that could cover it. Then again, it was also so on par for Catra, to totally pull out something like that to catch her off guard, to showcase a part of herself that Adora never knew was there. It was a reminder just how much they've grown without each other, how much each woman has changed in just a short span of five years.

Adora wonders what's changed about her. Besides the obvious.

She laces her fingers together on her lap and chances a look over to Catra who's watching Mara being "rescued". She chuckles good-naturedly and through the grin, Adora spots the familiar canines that always awed her in their youth. Her face….is so open. Unhindered and unburdened. Like she has nothing to hide anymore.

Adora looks down at her lap, thumb stroking her finger absentmindedly. Maybe that's what's changed between them. Catra has learned to be more open, to say what's actually on her mind or what she's feeling.

And now Adora's the one keeping secrets. Putting up walls and barricading herself because too many times she's let people in, openly and freely, wholly and thoroughly, just to be let down each time. Over the years, she's come to understand why Catra was so abrasive back then.

Protection.

And it's not like she *wants* to keep all of these secrets from her (sort of?) best friend. She'd give almost anything to return to the days where she could be unabashedly open about anything and everything that crossed her mind. Catra was never much of a talker back then, but that meant that she was an excellent listener in turn. It made their friendship somewhat one-sided, but it's what had worked for them at the time - Adora would talk and Catra would hear her out.

She wishes she could go back to that. Back to when it didn't hurt to divulge her deepest secrets, when she didn't feel like she had to hide integral parts of her life to keep people around. So she wouldn't be left behind ever again.

Sharing and oversharing is exactly what got her into this mess. It left her vulnerable, easy prey, and now she's stuck in a limbo of being too afraid of scaring people away and shutting them out completely to compensate.

It's frustrating. Her own personal hell she's inflicted upon herself.

Her attention is ripped away from her thoughts when she hears someone calling her name. Her eyes immediately scan the playset for Mara, assuming that's who's grabbing for her attention, but is blocked by a waving brown hand in front of her face. Blinking, she flinches back and turns to Catra, who looks half-amused and half-annoyed.

"Jeez. Thought I'd lost you to space permanently. Everything good?"

"Yeah, I'm fine." And the walls are going up again, she feels the bricks sliding into place with every inch of a smile that creeps onto her face. "I just get lost in my thoughts sometimes."

Catra hums and settles back into a relaxed slouch on the bench. "Thought you would've grown out of that. You know, mother paranoia or something like that. Don't tell me you do that when you're alone with Mara out in places like this." Her eyes cast warily towards her and it doesn't take a genius to pick up on what she's putting down.

"Not normally, no." Then again, she's never had reason to before. Catra is the catalyst to most of her quandaries these days, but that's not something she'd admit out loud to the woman. No need to worry her or make her feel guilty. "I suppose I just have a lot more on my mind than usual today." And it's the truth, even if she omits the reasons why.

She almost expects Catra to pry. She's a little disappointed when she doesn't. The walls cement and they're both plunged back into silence. Adora watches as the opportunity for her to throw caution to the wind vanishes as the walls block it out.

Maybe it's for the best. After all, she doesn't want to scare her away. Not again. Once was painful enough.

Adora digs around for something to say to alleviate the silence. Something to craft the relaxed front she wants to etch out, mold and carve a deceitful (oh gosh that that sounded too harsh - temporarily misleading?) mask to keep the progress from last night rolling. Most of her thoughts are filled with Mara, which isn't a bad topic per se, but too close to their discussion of Mara's father last night. And Adora's *certainly* not ready for that yet.

She chews on the bottom of her lip and searches for something else, wobbling on a narrow tightrope, sweat beading on her forehead and heart pounding against her temples. Scared to fall to the fate that awaited her underneath. Mangled limbs or a pit of acid or crocodiles or…

A shattered heart.

Adora sighs quietly and tucks her cardigan around herself. She's clearly more sleep-deprived than she'd thought before. Her imagination is getting the best of her and having an absolute field day. Metaphors blended with reality and reality lost to metaphors. That or she's just too inside her own head. Maybe she just needs something to help her get out of it. Turn the attention away from her entirely.

"Any new clients lately?" Safe. Unrelated to her. Perfect.

Catra shrugs, her eyes never straying from the playground. "Just one right now. Tryin' to work out some of the contract details but they're being less than cooperative. I'm half-tempted to just walk, but I don't have any other clients lined up so I feel like that'd just be dumb." She sighs and throws her head back, mouth line

turning into a dramatic frown and brow furrowing. "But this company head is *also* so dumb. I feel like the stress isn't worth it."

"How are they being dumb?" she asks, leaning closer.

And then Catra gives her this look, one that speaks of badmouthing and stories galore and Adora knows that this was the perfect topic to jump on. Catra dives into her complaints immediately, holding nothing back, and Adora nods along with a few grunts of acknowledgement. Most of this is foreign to her, so she doesn't entirely understand every problem for the magnitude it probably is, but she can see that Catra's pretty worked up about it so she tries her best to be understanding. Her attention is occasionally torn away back to the playset to check on Mara, but Catra trucks on with her stories, even going as far as to bring in similar situations with other clients as a way to illustrate just how often these things come up.

"It's just *so* goddamn stupid that most of these companies don't respect artists but still expect the world and beyond from them. And then when we mess up or don't agree with them two hundred percent, they suddenly think that *they* can do it so much better. Like...I'm sorry, did *you* go to art school for four years? Slaved away in a studio with only a thread of sanity and a pack of RedBulls keeping you from falling apart before your deadline in three hours? I think the fuck *not*, Jeffrey!" Catra rolls her eyes and swivels on the bench to fully face Adora, one foot propped up between them and one of her arms resting on her knee. "Everyone wants an artist until we ask for money and then *they* think they're fucking Da Vinci or Manet or some shit. No one takes us seriously and it's so *stupid* because without artists, do you have *any* idea how bland the world would be? Movies? Done. Architecture? Have fun with a grey block for a house. Clothes, house decor, music...anything you think of? Kiss 'em goodbye. Artists are responsible for most of what we use or interact with in the world and the people who take us for granted would be *shit* out of luck if we all decided to just up and…."

Catra trails off there, the heat from her rant doused as a faraway look encroaches on her eyes, stealing her attention away to somewhere past Adora's head. Puzzled, Adora searches Catra's face for a moment, trying to decipher what had captured her attention so abruptly that it was able to cut her off mid-tangent. Because once Catra got worked up about something, it was hard to bring her back and calm her down.

When she still fails to say anything, staring blankly (almost in mortification?), Adora turns to try and spot whatever it is that rendered her to such a state. She doesn't see anything immediately, at least, nothing that she feels would cause immediate alarm. There's people all around the park today, going about their last day of the weekend peacefully. No apparent threats or causes for concern.

Turning back to face her friend, Adora gives her a little nudge. "Hey, Catra? Are you okay? What's wrong?"

Blinking herself back to reality, Catra immediately ducks her head down and turns her face almost completely away. "Shit. *Dammit*." Her hand comes up to her hair to fan it out to cover most of her face.

Adora frowns. She's *hiding*. "Catra, what's going on?"

"Uh…" She chances a glance at her from the corner of her eye through her hair. Adora can barely see her expression past the curls, but from her hunched over shoulders and shrinking body language, coupled with the tell-tale nervousness in her tone that Adora could pick out from anywhere, she knows that something has her on edge. She moves closer, whether to encourage her to speak or to aid in blocking Catra from whatever she's trying to shield herself from, she's not entirely sure. "It's not, like, a *huge* deal just…" She peeks around Adora again, teeth gnawing on her bottom lip.

The longer she drags this out, the more it makes Adora squirm herself. "Catra…"

"It's uh…." Then her eyes widen and she jumps, cursing again. "Ah, *fuck*. She saw me. She definitely saw me that time."

Adora blinks. She?

Then Catra's looking at her, somewhere between determined and panicked and tugs on her cardigan sleeve. "Okay so, my sort-of obsessive ex - well, she's hardly an ex it was just a casual thing - but she's here and she just saw me and I think she's heading over here right now." Adora struggles to process this onslaught of new information when Catra's hand slides down to hold her own, gripping it firmly. "Play along, yeah? Please? I just need to scare her off."

So in shock at the turn of events and the fact that Catra's hand is in hers, thumb stroking the back of it tenderly, Adora nearly misses the approach of the woman that Catra mentioned.

"Oh my, *god*! Catra? Is that really you?" The falsetto of her voice grates against Adora's eardrums and she's jerked back to the situation at hand, questions still fluttering about in her head but no way to voice them because she can't form the words.

Catra plasters on a grin - so obviously fake - and greets the woman in kind. "Alison? Yeah, it's me."

The woman laughs. "Oh, *wow*! Who would've thought I'd run into you here? Such a small world, huh?"

Catra hums, the smile on her face looking borderline painful. "Yep. Super tiny."

Barely giving Catra another chance to speak, the woman starts talking again at nearly a mile a minute. "I was just going on my daily jog. I like coming to the park because it's so much nicer than running through the city streets. A lot greener and aesthetically pleasing. The air also just feels *fresher* here somehow, yanno? And it's definitely a lot quieter here." She props her hip against the back of the bench, her ass dangerously close to Adora's face who leans away in response. It's like she doesn't even *exist*. "So

what brings you here? I didn't think you were the "Sunday afternoon at the park" type of gal."

Catra clears her throat and shoots Adora a look, pleading and pointed, and Adora figures this is where she's supposed to come in. The problem though is that she has *no* idea what Catra has in mind and doesn't know what to say. She figures she might just tell the truth, but apparently Catra is too impatient and jumps back in herself. "Oh, you know, just a relaxing afternoon with my family."

Her….her *what*?

Either Catra doesn't notice her look of surprise, or she's choosing not to address it, because she doesn't offer Adora a line and lets her flounder in her thoughts.

Alison's demeanor, bubbly and obnoxiously upbeat, falters for a split second. "Family?"

Catra grins again, toothily and smug, like she's finally gotten some kind of upperhand. She gestures towards Adora, putting the spotlight on her. Adora's stomach suddenly drops out underneath her when Alison turns towards her, and she'd be lying if she said that she doesn't break out in a light sweat when cold eyes turn towards her. "Alison, this is my wife, Adora."

…..*Wife?*

"*Wife*?" Alison parrots Adora's inner thoughts, with every ounce of disbelief that she's feeling herself. "Oh. I wasn't aware you got married."

Catra nods. "Yup. We haven't talked much recently though, so that might be why."

Alison nods, but she's definitely more upset than she had been when she initially came over. "Well, you *did* change your number, so I guess that would make it more difficult to reach out to you."

Catra thunks a hand against her head, feigning naiveness. "Right! That's my bad. I could've sworn I'd told you about that. Things just got so crazy I probably forgot."

The longer this conversation goes on, the more uncomfortable Adora is. Being the subject of this strange woman's ire, a pawn in Catra's lie...all without barely knowing what's even going on just doesn't sit right with her. But she looks at this woman, sees how upset she is, at how flippant Catra's being about the whole thing, and she begins to feel sick to her stomach.

Because, for some reason, she feels more for Alison than she does for Catra - her own best friend - in this situation. She knows what it's like to be in that position.

Adora wriggles her hand free from Catra's grasp and tucks it into her lap to prevent her from reaching back out. She receives an odd look from Catra in response, but remains mostly impassive.

Alison's lips are pursed and she gives a quick glance towards the playground which is right next to them, before looking between the two of them. "So you said 'family'?"

Catra nods again and looks off to the playground, eyes roaming before settling on something and smiling. Adora follows her gaze and feels her veins go cold for two seconds in realization before her anger heats them back up to a boiling point.

Oh *hell* no.

Before she can object, Catra's already turned back to Alison and spewing more of her bullshit farce. "We're here with our daughter, actually. She's the little blonde girl at the top of the slide." She points to Mara and it takes *everything* within Adora not to explode right then and there.

"She's….cute," Alison offers lamely. "I'm surprised, though. Didn't think you were the type for kids." She gives Catra a scrutinizing glance that the woman brushes off easily.

Meanwhile, Adora is boring holes into Catra's dumb, *lying* face, teeth grit and nails digging into the soft flesh of her palms. *That's because she* isn't*,* she wants to scream. Ruin the whole facade.

She should've known. Catra only cared about *herself*. That's how it's always been, hasn't it? She'd already learned her lesson, or at least she *thought* she had, but apparently she'd let herself be fooled again. Fooled by sweet words and kind glances, the promise of staying, the promise that this time would be forever…

A lump forms in her throat and she takes a deep breath to push down the tears she knows are soon to follow. She's no less naive than she was the first and second time this happened to her. One would think that having a kid and being a single mother would open her up to some wisdom, but here she is, making the same mistake for the third time in a row. How does the saying go?

Fool me once, shame on you. Fool me twice, shame on me.

Fool me thrice…?

Fuck everyone.

"Well, I guess I should really get going and continue my jog," Alison says abruptly, pulling Adora away from her heated thoughts. "Congrats to the two, er, three of you. Wish you the best." And with one last lingering glance at Catra, she kicks off into a jog, disappearing down the path, brunette ponytail bouncing.

As soon as she's out of earshot, Catra lets out a breath of relief and slumps heavily against the bench. "Oh thank *God*. I thought I was done with all that bullshit months ago. You'd think changing your number would be enough of a hint but I guess fucking not. Hey, thanks for - Adora? What's wrong?"

With Alison finally gone, Adora's dropped her own mostly pleasant face, her anger coming out in full force. She raises her eyes to meet Catra's, burning into them, doing her best not to cry and

turn her entire hardened pissed off look soggy. "What the actual *fuck* is your problem?"

Catra blinks, stunned probably by Adora's one-eighty in demeanor. She opens her mouth and closes it, eyes scanning her face as she fishes for something to say. "I...what are you talking about? What did I do?"

Adora scoffs and rolls her eyes. "So typical. You don't even have the self-awareness of what you're doing or how it might affect people. You know, I *really* thought you'd changed."

That puts Catra on the defensive and she rises up to meet Adora with her own budding anger. "Hey! What the hell are you even on about? I told you I needed your help and you agreed-"

"I did *not*! You roped me in without explaining *shit* and didn't even give me a chance to respond!"

That makes Catra pause and shrink back. "I...yeah, I guess I did. Shit. Look, I'm sorry. I guess I was just panicking 'cause she was on her way over." She reaches up to tuck some of hair behind her ear. "But I mean, I figured you wouldn't have a problem with it. We used to do this all the time in high school to get gross guys to back off."

"That was high school, Catra! Things aren't the same as they were then! I'm a mom now and…" Adora frowns and crosses her arms. "Also how *dare* you bring my daughter into your little charades?"

Mirroring Adora, Catra crosses her arms too. "Look, I said I'm sorry. I *really* don't get why this is a big deal all of a sudden! I thought we…" She trails off, seeming to think better of what she was going to say. "What are you *actually* mad about? 'Cause this seems like a dumb thing for you to get pissed about."

The fire boils over and Adora can feel her skin burning and mind clouding with the toiling steam and fumes of her anger. She jumps up from the bench, fists clenched because of course, of *fucking* course this was going to happen. She was naive and

stupidly hopeful to think that it would go any other way, to think that maybe Catra had changed and grown up and actually learned how to be a better, more considerate person. She had put so much faith into her, but now she's less sure if Catra gave her a reason to do so or her unfathomable loneliness and wishing had caused her to believe that things could get better.

She had vouched for her. Defended her against Mermista. Mermista, who was *there*, who knew everything, tried to warn her and Adora didn't listen because...what? There was good in everyone? Anyone could be redeemed?

She already knows that's not true. And she's *tired* of doling out second chances only to be burned over and over and *over* again until she's nothing but a pile of ash.

"If you think I'm so dumb then why the hell did you come back? Were you just bored? Ran out of hearts to break in the city so you figured you'd start back at square one?"

Catra's face fell and her posture relaxes enough for her to reach out towards Adora. She steps back just out of reach. "Wait, Adora...I didn't mean it like that. I'm...you're just being *really* confusing right now and I'm just trying to understand what I did wrong, okay? I'm not a mindreader. I need you to tell me why you're upset."

It's a mature response. One that causes Adora to falter in her anger if only for a brief moment, but it returns with a fiery vengeance, consuming her whole and burning all sense and reason along with it. She *wants* to be angry. She's earned that much. Catra deserves that much. Because she's been pushed around too long, batted back and forth like some toy or doll to abuse and play with and she's so *sick* of it all. After Catra, after *him*...she promised herself never again. For Mara's sake. For her own sake.

"I already told you. Maybe it's time you learn to start listening." She doesn't want to be here anymore. Not here with Catra, or in

public as she can feel the foundation of her walls crumbling and turning to dust in the heat of her anger. The lump pulses, bigger and larger, and the heat behind her eyes that she thought was solely her fury turns out to be tears beginning to spring forward.

She needs to get out of here now.

Turning to the playground, she calls out for Mara. When she receives no immediate response, she calls out Mara's full name and takes a step towards the playground, ignoring Catra scrambling behind her still trying to pry her open. She pulls the cardigan tighter and blinks rapidly, scanning the playground for her little girl.

She's nowhere in sight.

The heat is doused instantly with a cold wave of fear and she calls out again, voice wobbling and frantic, "Mara! Mara, come here *now*!"

A hand rests on her shoulder and she flinches away, on instinct, only to find mismatched eyes coated in the same anxiety she feels toiling away in her chest. "Adora, I don't see her."

"No…" She takes another step up to the playground, peering around the colorful towers and chipped blue metal of the foundation. Other children run circles around each other, laughing and giggling, oblivious to the growing panic rising within a mother on the outskirts, unable to find her baby girl, her walls and entire life shaking and crumbling to the ground. "No no no *no*, she was just here!" She calls out for Mara again, this time garnering some glances from the other mothers hanging out the playground, but she doesn't pay them any mind. They can think what they want, say what they want; all that matters is Mara, safe in her arms.

Catra steps up behind her again, hand reassuring on her shoulder again. Adora doesn't have the wits to move away this time, too overcome with worse-case scenarios, imagining all the horrible

things that could've happened and how it was all her fault, her fault, her fault….

"Adora? Adora, listen to me. She can't be far, okay? We'll find her. We can split up and go in opposite directions and one of us is bound to come across her, okay? Everything's going to be alright."

It takes a second to snap out of her stupor, but when she does and sees Catra's face, so comforting and sympathetic, something within her snatches back that earlier anger, desperate to grab ahold of something solid again. She needs some kind of control. For *once*, she needs some sort of control in her life. She rips her shoulder away from Catra and steps back, ashamed at the way her lip wobbles but too angry/scared/helpless to stop it.

"I think you've done enough," she manages, before turning away and walking briskly in the opposite direction. She ignores the calls chasing after her, mind narrowing in on finding Mara so they can just go *home*.

She's barely a few steps from the play area when the anxious-riddled thoughts fully set in. Her body is buzzing and her mind is fluctuating between being high-alert and muddled from panic, making the search stressful and so much more difficult. Adora begins to scan the immediate area, eyes never resting on one place too long in fear of missing her if she isn't looking everywhere at once.

The first thing to catch her eyes is every head of blonde hair. She spends maybe half a second on each one before deciding it's not Mara, while trying to remember what she was wearing earlier. A...red jacket? No, no she threw a fit over the red one that morning because it had a zipper.

'*I want something with* buttons*!'* she had insisted. What jackets of hers had buttons? One...two? What colors were they?

Adora makes a turn and scans the area she just came from one last time before continuing to trek forward, her breath short and

labored as she struggles not to collapse from the weight of her anxiety. Where could she have *gone*? Mara typically isn't the type to just wander off on her own, which meant that...oh god, did someone *take* her? Wouldn't she have noticed? Wouldn't Mara have shouted or screamed or called out for her if someone was trying to take her away?

Unless they coerced her away? Adora had given a few crash courses on stranger danger, but nothing too in-depth, not that she's certain that Mara even retained any of the information she tried to drill into her. Could someone have tempted her away from the playset while she was distracted with Catra? Promised her with a treat, as long as she stayed quiet, as long as…

Fuck! ***Fuck!***

Her hands are shaking and she picks up her pace, finally calling out Mara's name and looking around frantically. What if she's too late? What if Mara's already gone? The *one* good thing in her life, the one thing she thought she hadn't fucked up…

Her fault, her fault, her fault - *what the fuck was the color of her damn jacket?*

Her phone is ringing in her pocket and she digs it out, looking at the screen and seeing Catra's name flashing. She's tempted to turn it off, shove it away and keep looking, but somewhere in the back of her head, she remembers Catra mentioning something about looking for Mara together.

"Hello?"

"Adora? Hey, I found her. She was over in the little grove of trees right next to the playground." Adora heaves a sigh of relief and realizes that all of her limbs have gone numb.

Catra's saying something else but Adora just hangs up and rushes back in the direction she came from, her pace a light jog, until she's back at the playground. She rushes past the playset and all

the mothers, still curiously watching her, before she dips into the little grove of trees that Catra described over the phone.

And there, just a few skips away, are Catra and Mara. Unharmed. Clutching a fistful of flowers.

Mara's grin is so brilliant the moment she spots Adora who openly weeps upon seeing her daughter, safe and sound, happy and oblivious to all the horrors that Adora had been imagining in her moment of terror. "Mommy! I picked dese fer you!" She holds out the handful of flowers, some of them weeds now that Adora looks closer.

Adora sinks to her knees next to Mara, gathering her up in her arms and burying her face into Mara's shoulder, unable to stop the tears from flowing. The relief is addicting, it's liberating. She never wants to feel it again if it means having to go through the preceding panic.

"Mommy? Why are you crying?"

Adora pulls back and brushes some of Mara's hair back. "Mara, you *scared* Mommy so bad. I thought I lost you."

Mara seems largely unaffected by Adora's worry. "I was just right here, Mommy."

"Well, I didn't *know* that. Next time you need to tell me, okay?"

Mara groans, like it's somehow an inconvenience to her to have to take time to notify her own mother of her whereabouts, but she finally concedes when she receives a warning look from Adora. After accepting the handful of flowers from Mara and placing a firm kiss to her forehead, Adora rises to her feet and reaches out for Mara's hand. "It's time to go home, baby girl."

Mara looks appalled. "Is this 'cuz I didn't tell you I was pickin' flo'ers?"

Adora shakes her head and reaches down to grab Mara's hand. "No, of course not, baby girl. It's almost nap time and we need to get home to lay you down."

Somehow that's even worse as Mara whimpers and stamps her little feet, but she knows a losing battle when she's in one and doesn't say anything else to protest, thankfully. Adora's not really sure she's in a mood to argue with a four-year-old.

Speaking of arguing…

For the first time since being reunited with her daughter, Adora looks over to Catra who's awkwardly standing a considerable distance from the two of them. She's watching them, but mostly Adora herself, like she wants to approach but doesn't want to intrude.

Adora clears her throat. "Thank you. For finding her." She owes her that much, right? Maybe an apology too but...well, she remembers *why* she was angry, but she doesn't have the energy to bring it back. So she stands there dumbly as Catra fidgets across from them.

"Adora, can we please talk? I...I don't want you shutting me out again."

Adora frowns. "*Me* shut *you* out?" After everything that happened between them...and somehow Catra thought that *Adora* was the one who shut her out? "That's not exactly how I remember it."

It's clear that's not the response Catra was expecting, but she recovers fairly quickly, hurrying forward to stand in front of her. She lowers her voice, not that she necessarily needs to because Mara is preoccupying herself with muttering out some imaginary plotline about princesses and magic swords. "Look, Adora...I don't want to lose you again. I don't know what I did to you, but I want to apologize for it if you'd just *talk* to me."

Talk to her?

Talk to me.

Why wasn't that same courtesy offered to her all those years ago? Sitting alone with her thoughts in the dark, crying over an automated text message, heart yearning and begging to reach out and be held, to have her apologies heard, to just *talk* to her best friend who wanted nothing more to do with her.

Where was Catra when *she* wanted to talk?

She's here now.

The first calm and collected thought she's had in the past twenty minutes rings out in her head, and she feels annoyed at how true it rings. Catra is here now. She can talk to her now, air out all of her grievances from the years before, say what she never had the chance to.

And this time, it seemed like she wanted to listen.

Against her better judgement - possibly due to fatigue and weariness - Adora agrees. "Meet me back at my apartment. We can talk after I lay Mara down for her nap."

Somehow, Catra doesn't seem to be expecting that response either. But she's quick to get over her initial shock, nodding fervently and agreeing to see her soon.

And as Adora leads Mara back to their car to take her home, she hopes that she's not making the same mistake a third time.

Now that she's here, Adora isn't quite sure what to say anymore.

Years ago, she had been spilling with questions and strings of apologies. Her chest had been bursting to say them aloud, to share them with the person she truly needed to hear them the most.

An hour ago, she had let some of her frustrations and anger, built up from the years of being abandoned and neglected, trickle out, a crack in her stronghold, an imperfection in her defenses. And even still, she hadn't said enough, hadn't said it all, because she was bursting with more to say, more to scream and shout and lament.

Sitting on her couch now, a cup of cooling tea cradled in her palms, she's at a loss for words. The irony isn't lost on her for a moment. The moment she's waited years for, stagnated because she can't form the words.

Where is she even supposed to begin?

Catra clicks her tongue and Adora turns to look at her. She's fidgeting again, fingers tapping against her knee. At first glance she seems impatient with Adora's own lack of initiative, but the more rational part of her tells her she's just as worried and doesn't know what to do about it.

They sit there for another minute, neither knowing how to proceed.

Catra is the first to say something. "So...do you wanna tell me what earlier was all about? I know you got upset because I used you and Mara, which once again I am sorry about that. I got caught up in my own issues and I dragged you guys in with me." She takes a deep breath. "But I know that doesn't excuse my actions, so I want to say sorry for that. I didn't mean to upset you and I certainly didn't mean to make you feel like you were being used flippantly or...whatever. I'd never hurt you like that on purpose, Adora, you *have* to know that."

Adora chews on her lip. Except she doesn't. Because...well, it *couldn't* be true, could it?

The words escape her lips before she has time to think better of it. "You already have."

Quiet. Fidgeting. Then, "What do you mean by that?"

This is it, isn't it? After all this time…

Adora takes a deep breath and strokes her thumbs across the ceramic of the mug in her hands. She turns the words over in her head, the ones she never got to voice, and contemplates how she wants to phrase them now, years later, when so many things have changed and so many things haven't. She considers turning back, keeping it inside because she's used to it, has done so for so very long that she's afraid of what will happen once she finally lets it all go.

Will her walls come crashing down? Will she lose the defenses she's struggled to build, labored over endlessly to never be deceived, hurt, or abandoned ever again? Or is this the first step to a path of recovery, closure, reconciliation?

How can Catra trust her if she doesn't trust Catra too?

"Do you…" She bites her lip, reconsiders, and dives back in. "Do you remember why we stopped talking? All those years ago?"

Catra scratches at the denim of her jeans, her nails scritching in the silence as she seems to contemplate her own response, possibly choosing her next words carefully to avoid another blow up. Adora wishes she'd just be out with it already, so that she doesn't lose her own courage. "You just...shut me out one day. No calls. No texts. Nothing." But she sounds unsure of her own answer, like she doesn't necessarily believe it herself. As if it's something she's conjured to tell herself over the years in lieu of an actual explanation.

Adora shakes her head and sees Catra deflate from the corner of her eye. "I wasn't the one who shut you out." Her throat is starting to itch and her eyes are beginning to burn. The phantom weight of her phone, glowing in a dark room weighs in her hands while the echoes of distant rain berate her eardrums.
"*You* shut *me* out.

"No calls.

"No texts."

She looks up at Catra, the sorrow she's held back finally leaking out and staining her heart. "Nothing."

When Catra says nothing, she takes that as her cue to press forward. "It was junior year. I was studying with Mermista late one night and...I get a call from you." She swallows around the lump that's returned to her throat, leaving her sore and gasping for breath. "I...think you were drunk. I *hope* you were drunk. Because...well," She looks up to Catra and has to look away again, tears springing to her eyes as the memory plays out in her head. "You said, *a lot* of awful things to me."

"Adora-"

She cuts her off with a shake of her head. She can't have Catra interrupting her now. Not when she finally has this chance to say everything she never got to. She needs to power through this or she feels she'll lose this opportunity forever.

"I won't go into all the details of everything you said. But essentially you accused me of being an awful person and an even worse friend. You told me you never wanted to speak to me again.

"I almost figured you didn't mean it. That you were just drunk and angry and needed to rant your frustrations. But, you hung up on me. And when I tried to call you back, it kept going straight to voicemail. Eventually...I got the message that your number couldn't be reached."

She's starting to shake and she feels her defenses breaking down with each word. It's panic-inducing honestly. To rely so heavily on keeping your feelings pent up that once you start to release them, it leaves you vulnerable. Something she never wanted to feel again. Something she has always felt she never *could* afford to feel again, because of Mara.

But Catra returning to her...it had to be some sort of blessing or sign, right? That she had finally earned the closure she'd been wanting for since that very night, to let go of everything she was holding onto so she could stop feeling so sick with herself all the time. So…

She'd get through this. She'll let go.

"I tried...*all* night to reach out to you. But you had blocked me from everything: your phone and all of your social media. I wanted to tell you how sorry I was. I wanted to know how to make it all better but you just...shut me out. So I sat there, all night, thinking of everything I wanted to say and how much I wished you'd let me say it.

"Time passed and you never reached out. Never came to apologize or even yell at me again. Eventually, I figured that you really hated me and wanted nothing to do with me ever again." She takes a deep breath. "So I moved on. Sort of. But all this time, I kept all of it inside, everything I've wanted to say, everything I wanted you to hear. Some of it apologies. Some of it nasty words because I was so angry you just abandoned me."

Adora taps her mug once. Twice. "And now…

"I have nothing to say."

Beside her, Catra blinks in disbelief. Adora's almost stunned by her own words and revelation herself. She's been searching for closure for so long and this is her chance to get it. But as she digs deep, searches within the depths of everything she's kept in for so long, she realizes something that jumps out amongst the rest of everything.

She doesn't want closure.

Closure means letting go. It means there's an end to reconcile. Something to take with you as you move forward on opposite paths and…

She doesn't *want* that.

She wants Catra.

A smile creeps onto her face and she lets out a huff that's not quite a laugh. "None of it matters anymore. Because you're here with me again. And you promised you wouldn't leave me again. So as long as that's true...I don't have anything to say."

Adora's content to leave it there, but it seems as though Catra feels otherwise. The couch shifts as Catra moves closer and there's a burning warmth at her side as Catra presses close.

"I know you said you have nothing to say," Catra begins quietly, "But I just want you to know that I am...*so* so sorry for what happened that night. It probably doesn't help and it's definitely not an excuse, but I don't even remember that phone call. I don't remember anything from that night." A warm hand rests on her thigh and Adora finds herself, naturally, instinctively, leaning into Catra's warmth.

"But I promise you, I will do *anything* I can to make it up to you. I fucked up; I know that. And I can't erase what I did or take back anything I said to you." Her thumb brushes against the fabric of Adora's pants and, strangely, she feels an odd jolt shoot through her system. "But like you said, I'm here now and this time I'm *not* leaving. I'll do whatever it takes, whatever you want, to prove that to you."

She wants to cry again. Wants to bawl and wail the way she denied herself that night. But this time, because she is relieved. Relieved to have her friend back, to realize that despite everything, Catra still wanted her in her life and would be willing to do anything to keep it that way.

Adora smiles, watery and gross but she ignores that for now, and reaches to place her hand on top of Catra's to give it a light squeeze.

"You already have."

Chapter End Notes

Oh gosh this chapter absolutely kicked my ass. Sorry if it sucked y'all. I struggled for 2 weeks with it and just wanted it done and over with so I could move on with the rest of the plot. (And yet it somehow still reached 8k wtf...)

Also, want to apologize for the wait you guys. I've been through a lot lately. Not only am I about to graduate in about a month and a half now and am currently looking for jobs, but I've had personal health issues (both mental and physical) that I've been dealing with. Including one (1) heart attack scare (not exaggerating on this, I genuinely thought I was having one and was about to go to the ER), and a week after that I actually DID go to the ER (but that one's because I'm a dumbass and stuck my arm in sulfuric acid....I'm okay now though).

So yeah. It's been quite the past month for me. I'll try to be better with updating in the future, but I can't make any solid promises.

Moving on~ I wanna make some shoutouts because I have received some WONDERFUL and MAGNIFICENT art over the past month. We have Adora and Mara being cuties; a scene from the last chapter with Catra, Adora, and Mara; and Adora's and Catra's outfits from chapter 5!!! Thank you mellorine91 and shuckel from tumblr!!! Y'all are amazing!

Remember, if you draw any art for this fic, please message or tag me on tumblr and I will reblog the SHIT outta that. And gush over it forever.

Something I want to start doing by the way is including songs that I use while writing chapters (since a few people on tumblr have expressed some interest in the songs I have in my playlist for this AU). So for this chapter we have Monochrome by Daktyl and Collect Call by Metric

Another announcement!!! So this fic is about to reach 500 kudos (in fact I'm just 4 away!!!) which is SUPER exciting and I can't believe I've received so much support for this fic. I love all of you with all my heart <3

As a sort of milestone/celebration type thing, I figured I'd do a Q&A of sorts. I've gotten a lot of interesting questions throughout my time writing this - some here, some on tumblr through asks and PM's. But I figured I'd do a Q&A video answering everyone's questions they might have about the fic. This could be anything ranging from how I write certain things, what my process is, music-related asks, plot-related asks, etc. I figure I'll select a handful of questions I'll use in the video so if you have any please leave a comment below or send me a message/ask on tumblr with your question specifying you want it answered in the Q&A video! (If not, I'm more than happy to answer them more immediately in your message if that's what you'd prefer) I figured this would be a fun thing for you guys to have those questions answered and for me to talk more about this fic that I love so dearly.

I'm not entirely sure when I'll get the video up, but I'll try to have it out as soon as I possibly can! I'll probably accept questions for the video up until March 17th (a week from now), that way I have time to compile the ones I'll include in the video and do the actual recording :) I'll be posting the video to youtube, but I'll be including the link on tumblr and possibly my twitter, so look out for that soon(ish)!!

Until next time~!

sayin' all the things you've never done

Chapter Summary

> The girls are fightiiiiiiiiing pt 2!! Cataract vs Glitter Cheeks. Place your bets now.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

By all means, this should be a positive sign, right?

After the scare of last week where Catra had genuinely thought her and Adora's friendship had failed a second time before it could even be fully repaired, she was surprised when Adora had invited her to an impromptu lunch date - *outing*. Even as an "over-glorified secretary", as Adora had so generously put it, she still had a small allotted time window to go on lunch breaks, though she did confess to normally bringing her own lunch so she wouldn't have to worry about straying too far from the office. Where most people worked hard, Adora always worked harder. It was partly what made them so compatible throughout their shared childhood - both girls were willing to always go above and beyond to prove themselves, which ignited a competitive streak that would serve as a fuel for everlasting friendship.

Well, mostly. Bumps in the road aside.

Regardless, she had been sitting at some posh cafe-restaurant mix on a Wednesday afternoon, rolling her eyes over her iced macchiato at a trio of trust fund hipster babies when Adora had dropped a second invite.

Back at her apartment. This time with friends in tow.

"They've been dying to meet you," she'd explained, sipping on her own plain black coffee - Catra's tongue recoils even at the

memory of Adora's lack of taste buds. "And I know Adam wants the opportunity to catch up on all the teasing you're owed."

It made sense, of course. All throughout college Adora had gone on and on about her newfound friends she'd made at her university and, with the risk of sounding conceited, she's sure that as her best friend, Adora must've given said friends the same treatment and told them all about her as well. Back then, they'd both made thinly-veiled promises to come and visit each other and meet each other's new friends, but...well….

Then, of course, there was the fact that Catra had already initiated this whole thing by introducing Adora to Scorpia and Entrapta. So it was entirely understandable that Adora wanted to return the favor by bringing her own friends into the mix and indoctrinating Catra into a part of her life that she'd been a stranger to for so long.

It should've been an exciting proposal.

On Wednesday, it was. She'd agreed to it rather quickly, maybe even embarrassingly so. Not so much because she was actually looking forward to meeting Twinkle and Rainbow, but because she knew that after everything that had happened between them, Adora still wanted Catra in her life. So much so that she was going out of her way to include her in every aspect of it. It was a sign that Adora wanted her to stay. That she was just as serious about reconciling as Catra was.

But now it's Saturday and the elevator ride up to Adora's floor is actual Anxiety Hell. The last time she was here things had seemed to go smoothly, only for it to very narrowly blow up in her face the next day. She's not sure their flimsy friendship can survive another near-disaster like that. Especially not so soon.

Once the elevator doors open, she juggles the six-pack of wine coolers in her hand and marches towards Adora's apartment door without giving herself a second thought. Doubts lead to anxiety,

which can easily slope downwards into miscommunication, which seems to be how they got here in the first place.

She frowns as she raps gently against Adora's door. Then there was *that* whole thing.

Catra honestly doesn't recall calling Adora that night. Adora had surmised that she'd probably been drunk, which is really the only possible explanation on how she was able to have that conversation and not recall a single second of it. Because if she'd been angry enough to call Adora and tell her off while simultaneously ending their friendship? She'd *remember* that.

Regardless, she also can't use it as an excuse for her actions or behavior. Maybe in the past she'd opt for the easy out, blaming her budding alcoholism on her rising anger issues. To be fair, she's pretty sure she used it both as a coping mechanism and as a preemptive excuse for any of her behavior. Something to fall back on should someone call her out on the way she was acting towards them. A way to play herself off as the victim without taking any responsibility for herself or her actions.

A shitty thing to do, but at this point in their lives,
who *hasn't* done something shitty to the people they care about?

The important thing - however difficult it proved to be - is that she's atoning for those actions. She'd gotten help, gone through the whole confronting her inner demons shebang and now here she is, *still* fixing what she'd ruined. It's a long, winding road, one that she can't see the end of, but she's trekking on nonetheless. The knowledge that even if she doesn't reach the end, or that it won't be what she's imagining it to be, is somewhat discouraging. But she can see the progress she's making, how far she's already traveled, and that's what keeps pushing her onwards.

Adora answers the door and with a smile that could melt the biggest of icebergs and coldest of hearts, welcomes her inside. Their fingers brush when Adora relieves her of some of her

baggage, taking the snacks to the kitchen and splaying them out on the counter.

Turns out, she's the last one to the party. In the adjacent living room there's three other people: Adam - who, of course, she recognizes immediately despite the buzzcut that's replaced his unruly hippie hair from high school, and then two others that she assumes to be Adora's friends, Glitter and Arrow. Glitter is on the couch next to Adam, hand on his thigh and shoulder brushing against his. She's short, probably shorter than Catra, with bi-colored pink and purple hair that's cropped short and swept to the side. Arrow is seated on the floor by the coffee table, generously helping himself to the salsa and chips. His hair is shaved as short as Adam's, though contrasted in the fact that: a) he has curls, b) he has a much cleaner fade, and c) there's a slight tint of purple that Catra can just barely make out when he shifts his head in the low light of the apartment.

Adora's rushing back to her side, one of the bags of sweets that Catra bought on her way here in hand, before she wraps her arms around Catra's and pulls her into the living room. Everyone is staring at the two of them. No, they're staring at Catra.

"Guys!" Adora nearly shouts, unnecessary because they already have the attention on them. "This is Catra! Catra, this is Glimmer and Bow. And, well, you already know my disaster of a brother."

"*Proud* disaster." Adam shoots her a smile and despite the fact his hair is chopped off and his jaw has squared out in the time that's passed, Catra is all-too-familiar with the warmth and brilliance contained in it. "'Sup, Cataract. Long time, no see."

Catra rolls her eyes. "Really? Still with that nickname?"

Adora rolls her eyes too and shakes her head. "Oh he's gotten a lot worse, believe me."

"What you call 'worse', I call 'stronger'." By now he's stood up from the couch and Catra already knows what's coming when he

takes two large steps towards her, arms outstretched. In less than a second she's wrapped up in his arms, pressed against his chest and having the life squeezed out of her. She wheezes out a couple half-faked coughs until he finally releases her, but not without mussing her hair first. She swats at him which he avoids easily with a laugh before returning to his place beside Twinkle.

Glimmer speaks up next. "Hey, Catra! Adora's told us a lot about you over the years. Good to finally have a face to a name." Her voice is pretty high-pitched on the grating side, but Catra's bites back any negative thoughts for now because she can *not* afford pissing off Adora's closest friends.

Another time, maybe.

Arrow jumps up now, squinting his eyes at her and Catra takes a miniscule step back in precaution. She doesn't appreciate being hyper analyzed so soon into meeting someone. Before long, his face lights up and he steps closer, recognition plain on his face. "Hey! I know you! You help instruct those hip-hop dance classes, right? At the studio over by the Plumeria yoga studio."

Catra is a little taken aback at being recognized from there, of all places, by one of Adora's friends, of all people. "Um...yeah. Sometimes. You go there?"

Her confirmation only adds to his excitement. "Yeah! Well, I mean, sometimes. My roommate, Perfuma - the one who runs the yoga studio - told me about that place about a year ago. Once she saw that yoga doesn't really help me with my stress from school, she suggested it as an alternative outlet for all my bad energy and negativity. I've seen you there a few times!"

Huh. Small world. "You don't say?"

Adora seems just as shocked. "You never mentioned you teach dance classes."

Catra shrugs. "It's a side hobby, at best. Instructor there is a somewhat friend. I help him out sometimes. Him and his

boyfriend comp my tab when I visit their bar sometimes. It's a win-win."

What she *doesn't* mention is that she'd been recommended by her therapist years ago for the same reason that Arrow decided to start taking the classes - as an outlet for all her frustration and anger. It just so happened that the one dance studio she came across was owned by an old friend of hers. Soon enough, she'd gone so often that he offered to let her start helping around in exchange for discounted drinks at the bar he owned with his boyfriend.

Like she said, it's a win-win situation. She had a side gig that pays her with free drinks and a way to let out the underlying anger that still festers around where all her other therapy tactics fall short.

"You actually might know them, Adora. Remember Rogelio and Kyle?"

Adora's eyes bug out and she blinks. "Wait, they're *dating* now?"

Catra nods and fights back a laugh. Yeah. Small world indeed.

Bored from being out of the loop, Adam inserts himself back into the conversation. "So is that booze just for show or are we gonna be having fun sometime tonight?"

"I dunno. Did you bring your own drinks or were you planning on mooching off of mine?"

"You just said you get free drinks!"

Catra rolls her eyes and throws her head back. "From the *bar*, you dipshit. I got these at a convenience store."

Adam laughs but next to him Glitter seems a little taken aback by the supposed animosity between the two of them. Not that Catra can find enough fucks in her to explain, but that's just the relationship her and Adam have always had. She'd learn soon enough. And if not...oh well.

After a few minutes of laying out more snacks and distributing out drinks - Catra is thankful to say that all of her wine coolers but the one in her hand is chilling in Adora's fridge - they're all seated in the living room, chatting somewhat amicably. Her and Adam mostly toss back jeers and taunts, returning to a semblance of normalcy that they had before...well, everything. Adora interjects every now and again, though both of her friends are mostly quiet in watching the spectacle. Catra almost feels bad, leaving them out of the loop like that, but she knows that if it isn't them, it would've been her. So she doesn't have any real complaints.

After some conversation goes by, Adam sits up, a mischievous gleam in his eyes. "Hey, we should totally play a drinking game."

Catra scoffs and knocks back a swig of her drink. "Are you stuck in college or something?"

"Is that your way of saying you're too scared?"

Catra gives a short laugh and returns Adam's look of mischief. "No, that's my way of saying that if we go through with this, someone's gonna have to scrape your drunken sister off the floor by the end of the night."

"Hey!"

Catra shrugs as if to say "Well, it's *true*."

"What kind of game did you have in mind?" asks Rainbow. He's the only one of the group to have barely taken any sips of his own drink, so Catra's somewhat surprised at his intrigue. If there's anyone Adora could outlast, it might be him.

Clearly not having thought this through, Adam sits back and rolls his eyes up in thought. He clenches his jaw, like Catra's always noticed he does when stumped on a question, and watches him languidly over her own bottle as she takes another swig.

Glitter surprises them all. "How about 'Never Have I Ever'?"

Catra grins and leans forward on the coffee table. "Okay Adam, you might be stuck in college, but I think your girlfriend here," she jabs a thumb in her direction, "is stuck in middle school."

She receives a glare for her comment, but she shrugs it off easily and shoots back a challenging grin in return.

Adora, always the hero, jumps in at this time. "I think that's a fun idea, Glimmer. I'm game."

Tapping her nails against the wood of the coffee table, Catra looks over to Adora. "You know this game is just going to divulge into people targeting each other, right?" And Adora should know that Catra has *a lot* of dirt on Adora. Well, and Adam would too.

Adora grins at her and Catra can't deny the excitement that shoots up her spine at the devilish implications behind it. "Scared?"

"In your dreams."

"Never did I ever drink underage."

Everyone in the room, save for Bow, takes a swig from their bottles. Meanwhile, he watches all of them with a look of horror and disappointment, hyping the dramatics with a hand placed delicately against his chest.

"Heathens. All of you."

Catra shrugs as she reaches for the salsa bowl, scooping up a heaping pile on her broken chip and throwing it into her mouth. "Not our fault you didn't know how to have fun."

"What about getting sloppily drunk is 'fun'?"

"You're playing a drinking game, are you not?" she counters.

He's silent for a moment, considering her rebuttal, before nodding his head in admittance of being bested. "Touché."

"Okay. My turn!" Adora announces, bouncing in her seat. "Never have I ever...broken a bone."

Catra and Adam both drink, which Adam follows up immediately with a handful of semi-melted Hershey kisses that he's been cradling. "I can fix that for ya if you want, Adobo."

"Come near me and I'm telling Mom."

Adam laughs, a sound that's both harsh and contagious. "We're not five anymore! Your threats don't scare me!"

Adora huffs and sticks out her tongue at him, which he returns in kind, which makes Catra wonder if they really *are* five years old.

"Can we keep the violence to a minimum, please? We're all reaching a state where none of us can drive anyone to the hospital," Arrow pleads, though Catra notices that out of everyone there, he's certainly had the least at barely emptying half his drink. That needs to change.

And Glimmer comes through. "Never have I ever had siblings."

All of them drink.

Catra rests her bottle on the coffee table and drags the bag of Hershey chocolates away from Adam and closer to her, ignoring his yelp of protest. "Oh? So we have a prissy only-child on our hands, do we?"

Glimmer crosses her arms, raising her chin with a smug grin that, no lie, sort of pisses Catra off. "And proud of it."

Oh, she is *so* going down.

Adam's up next, though he has to take a moment to think of one because he'd been so distracted with all the banter he didn't

already have something lined up. They all watch him as he thinks ("Stop looking at me! I can't think like this!" "You're actually capable of coherent thought?" "Shut up, Adobo!") and munch on their snacks. Eventually, he snaps his fingers and leans forward, "Never have I ever fucked a dude."

Adora, Bow, and Stick-Up-Her-Ass all drink, while the latter gives Adam a light flick to the temple. Catra offers her hand up to Adam with a fanged grin and the two high-five.

"See? Catra's the only one who really gets me."

Next up is her turn. And she knows *exactly* who she's gunning for. Eyes boring straight into Glitter's, she turns her grin up a few evil notches and revels in how Glitter squirms. Oh this is going to be *rich*.

"Never have I ever…" She pauses, deliberately, watching how everyone else leans forward in anticipation, but she knows that none of them have anything to worry about. "Fucked a set of twins."

One….two...thr-

Glitter's mouth drops and her face turns an undignified red (and, she notices from the corner of her eye, so does Adora's).

There. That ought to knock her down a few pegs.

Disgruntled, Glimmer takes a sip of her drink while Adam howls in the background. Catra meets Glimmer's glare with a not-so-innocent grin of her own, and ignores the heat coming from her left where she knows Adora is sitting. She can hear Rainbow off to her left stuttering to come up with something to take them off the topic, but she catches the promise in Glitter's eyes, the one that says 'this isn't over' before he can put anything out there.

Oh, she's betting on it.

"Never have I ever!" Bow shouts, his voice cracking in the effort to diffuse the tension. "Um...been out of the country?"

It's a safe one, not necessarily targeted and completely diverging from the topic at hand. Nonetheless, he manages to get all four of them to drink. She expects them to move onto Adora's turn, but it seems that Bow's not done playing mediator because he turns to her. "Hey, where have you been to?"

Catra shrugs. "My family's from Puerto Rico. We still have relatives there so when I was younger we'd take trips out to see them. Haven't been in awhile, though."

"Oh wow! That's pretty cool! Is it nice there? I've never been to Puerto Rico or….anywhere really, but I think it'd be a nice place to visit."

Catra's a little surprised, if mildly offput, that Bow's still engaging with her like this, but from the little time she's spent with him, he seems pretty genuine. She's also not entirely sure how to feel about that, given she's never been one to be so trusting of someone to think all their intentions are pure, so while it's a breath of fresh air, it's also...just odd.

"Well…" She takes another swig of her drink to give herself time to think. "I guess it just depends on which part you go to. Though that could go for anywhere, really. If you're really interested, I might be able to show you a few nice places to go later on."

Bow thanks her and promises to take her up on that offer. Behind him, Catra can see Adora beaming at the two of them, her blue eyes alight with pride and it takes Catra a second to realize that it's because Catra's being so amicable with one of her closest friends. She's happy to see them getting along. And having that silent praise makes her feel warm inside, excited that Adora's pleased, and knows she's on the right track.

Her eyes drift over to Glitter. Maybe….

No. Another time. Rome wasn't built in a day.

She turns back to Adora who's still stupidly smiling at her. "Hey, Blockhead. Your turn."

Adora jumps, snapped out of her grinning stupor and fumbles for something to say. "Right! Um….gosh, what haven't I done?"

"Possessed more than two braincells?"

Adora picks up a balled-up chocolate wrapper and chucks it at Adam. "Shut it, jackass!" Then she goes back to thinking, but not without throwing a few more wrappers at Adam as he continues to laugh at his own joke. "Okay, here! Never have I ever dyed my hair."

One, two, three, four….All of them drink. Catra knew that Bow and Sparkles were knockouts from the beginning and she remembers her own cringe-worthy decision in eighth grade to put blonde streaks in her hair, but she's admittedly a little surprised when she watches Adam knock back the rest of his drink and get up to go to the kitchen for another.

She calls out after him. "Wait, when did *you* ever dye your hair?"

And for the first time since she's ever known him, Adam is...quiet. He grabs his beer bottle without a word, popping open the cap on the counter and takes a drink from it, all without looking at her. His actions and demeanor are almost...sheepish, which is not a look she ever expected from the loudmouth.

In her seat Adora is grinning like the devil, watching Adam with an uncontained glee. "You wanna tell her or should I?"

At this his head whips up and he points a warning finger at her. "Adora, I fucking *swear*-"

Without bothering to listen to the rest of his threat, she turns back to the group in the living room. "Great! I'll tell it. So this goes back to when Catra and I were in middle school, right?"

"Adora!"

"And one day Adam comes up to me and asks, 'Hey, do you know if Catra likes anyone right now?' So of course I said, 'Well, she hasn't told me about anyone so I don't think so.'" Her giggles start to become far too much for her and she has to take a moment to collect herself. "So, so he tells me to ask you and I ask him why he even wants to know. And then *that's* when I figured out that my very own baby brother had a *crush* on my best friend!"

She's...shocked, actually. Out of all the scenarios she could've pictured, that was not anywhere close to any of them. She furrows her brow, trying to go back and remember when this could have happened, coming up with only a few. "Wait, is this around the time I told you I'm a lesbian?"

Adora claps and laughs harder. "Which was the best part!
Oh *man*, he was so heartbroken about it!"

"I was not!"

"He locked himself in his room for two weeks listening to nothing but all those sad Ne-Yo songs."

"Shut! Up! Adora!"

Catra shakes her head. "Wow. Ne-Yo? Seriously? Even if I was straight, dude, I'm not sure it would've ever worked between us."

Bow - who, like Glitter, had been quiet for the whole story - brings them back to how the whole conversation started. "Wait, so what exactly does that have to do with Adam dyeing his hair?"

Adora nods. "Right. Well, we had made a bet. You know, when I realized that he had a crush on Catra. I tried to tell him that he wasn't even close to Catra's type and he kept arguing how I didn't know that for sure. So we ended up making a bet - loser had to dye their hair." She waves her arms outwards in a swooping motion and falls against the back of her chair. "And you can imagine who won."

Twinkle, for once asking the important questions, "What color?"

Adam sighs and rejoins them in the living room, falling down onto the couch in utter defeat. "Green."

Her, Bow, and Twinkle collectively wince.

"Yikes, dude. Well, hey," Catra shrugs and raises her drink to Adam. "Maybe in another life if I liked guys. I always did have an appreciation for blondes."

Adam raises his head to look at her, his eyes flickering off to the side - her left - for a moment before fixing on her again with such a *knowing* look. "Oh, I'm *well* aware you do."

Catra nearly chokes on her drink and has to pound on her chest to breathe again. She glances off to her left quickly to see that Adora is far too preoccupied with balancing a heap of salsa on a chip to her mouth to have noticed anything. Then she shoots him a cold glare, one full of warning.

Don't.

He shrugs and zips his lips in a show of keeping quiet and Catra decides to leave it at that. Besides, that had all been in the past. It wasn't like that anymore.

She looks over at Adora again, who had somehow missed her mouth and salsa on her chin. And instead of wiping it off with a napkin, she had another chip in hand, scraping it off before tossing that into her mouth next. She rolls her eyes and huffs out a short laugh. Dork.

Yeah. It was all in the past now.

"So who's turn is it now?" asks Bow.

"Mine!" Glimmer chimes in, setting her drink down on the table. "Never have I ever…" She turns her eyes to Catra and this is where Catra figures the payback starts. Let her try. "Done the Walk of Shame."

Ha! Catra grins and makes a show of putting her drink of the table, clearly not about to drink. Meanwhile, Adora picks her up with a groan and knocks back a swig.

Catching Glitter's incredulous stare, she simply shrugs and says, "I don't feel shame, Glitter Cheeks." Because yeah, *of course* she's had to walk home after one night stands wearing the same clothes from the night before, albeit rumpled and smelling like a bottle of tequila. But not one of those walks involved her feeling shameful for her actions or her state of dress as she sat on a bus fighting a hangover.

She isn't ashamed to be sexually active. Even with strangers. Anyone who wants to shame her can shove it up their prudish asses.

So, Catra: 1; Glitter Cheeks: 0.

Adam's up next and it seems that Glitter isn't the only one with payback in mind. "Alright. Never have I ever been pregnant."

Lifting up her bottle again and groaning, she flips Adam off before downing the rest of her bottle, making her the second to do so in the game so far. "This is *harassment*!"

"I call it 'due justice'," Adam snickers.

Catra waits until Adora comes back from getting another beer from the kitchen to do her turn. Not that she had to, because her next one was directed for none other than the Prissy Princess herself. "Never have I ever been named after an object."

Glitter groans and drinks, with Bow following after. Shame he got caught in the crossfire, but a necessary sacrifice considering that she doesn't actually *know* enough about Glitter to single her out.

Of course, then Adora has to open her *big*, *fat* fucking mouth. "Wait, weren't you named after-"

Catra cuts her off. "That's a *place*, not an object and we don't *talk about that*."

Glimmer smiles, sly and sickly, and Catra almost wants to claw her eyes out. "Ooooh, now *that* sounds like a fun story."

Catra sighs theatrically and shoots her a fake apologetic pout. "Sorry to disappoint, Glitter Cheeks, but it's Hawkeye's turn."

Slow on the uptake, Bow sits still for a moment before realizing she's talking about him. "Oh! Right. That's me. Er...never have I ever been blackout drunk."

Her, Adam, and Glimmer all drink. Catra gives Adora a curious glance and receives a head shake. "I've gotten close, but never quite blackout."

Catra rolls her eyes. "Uh huh. Alright, keep telling yourself that, babe."

"It's true!"

"Riiiiight." Her and Adam share a look and both smile when Adora releases a shriek of frustration.

"Fine! My turn. Never have I ever caught a live mouse."

Catra gasps and whips around to face her. "Oh my fucking *god*! Are you *ever* going to let that go?"

Adora smiles, sitting back, knowing *exactly* what she's done. "Only when it stops being so funny."

And, of course, off to the side Glitter's having a field day. "Oh now *that* also sounds like a funny story!" She turns to Adora, silently asking to hear it.

Catra cuts in before Adora can dive down memory lane. "What? Can't think of something for your turn?"

She almost doesn't expect the taunt to work. But, sure enough, Glimmer turns forward in her seat again, eyes narrowed at Catra who almost laughs at how predictable the woman is. "Never have I ever been in a threesome."

Whoa. Presumptuous, much?

She shrugs and holds her hands up, palms out. "No dice."

What's more surprising is when Adora shrieks again, face red and bottle raised. "Glimmer!"

Blinking for a second, Glimmer stares at her confused before realization washes over and she looks at Adora sheepishly, hunching her shoulders and wincing. "Whoops?"

With a roll of her eyes and refusal to make eye contact with any of them, Adora knocks back her drink.

Oh.

Where she, personally, is at a loss for words, Adam steps in. "Wait wait wait...you've done *what* now?"

"Oh come off it, Adam! I'm a grown woman and I can do what I want!"

Bow jumps in too. "Wait, when was this? Why didn't *I* know about this?"

Squirming Adora drops her bottle to her lap and starts drumming her fingers against the neck. "I...didn't think it was that big of a deal. Glimmer only knows because she...uh, dropped me off?"

Adam turns to Glimmer next. "Wait you *knew* about this and still let her do it?"

"What do you mean 'let'? I told you! I'm an adult and I can make my own choices!" Adora fires back.

"Who?"

Adora blinks. "Excuse me?"

"Who were they?" Adam clarifies.

"Why in the *hell* would I tell you that? You don't even know them!"

"So then why can't you tell me?"

"Because why do you even need to know?"

"Because I'm your brother and I *will* call Mom and tell her if you don't fess up."

Adora scoffs and crosses her arms. "*Now* who's the five-year-old?"

Throughout all of this, Catra's...well, sort of speechless. Adora had never been the most outgoing when they were younger. That was Catra's role in the friendship. She'd never been big on dating, let alone having sex, so it was never a topic that came up outside of the occasional jokes. And, sure, Catra knows now that Adora seemed to have dated a little bit in college, Glimmer and Mara's father included, but...this? This is totally out of left field.

She can feel her face heating up at the thought of Adora riding to someone's house, with the full knowledge and awareness that it was for a *threesome*. Adora and two other people. Adora...in bed and *naked* with two other people.

Catra knocks back her bottle, chugging down what's left, and excuses herself to the kitchen to grab another. Clearly, it's her alcohol intake that has her so caught up over this. It's the *alcohol* that's putting images in her head, images of Adora sandwiched between two other bodies, lost in bliss…

She takes a deep breath and opens her bottle, chugging down about a third of the contents. Yeah. It's *definitely* the alcohol.

By the time she rejoins the group in the living room, the conversation has somewhat died off - thankfully. She's ready to move on. Or maybe even go to bed at this point.

'Course, they're still playing the game. And now it's Adam's turn.

"Never have I ever had a foursome." He's looking directly at Adora who glares in return but doesn't move to drink.

"Alright, just checking," he says.

Catra heaves out a sigh in relief. She's not sure she could handle anymore of that. She decides to change the topic entirely. "Never have I ever cried at a Disney movie." All four of them drink and when Bow's done, he's looking at her like she just confessed to running over his puppy.

"You're heartless," he says.

Catra only shrugs. "And you guys are pussies."

"Not even *Bambi*?"

She shakes her head. "Not even *Bambi*."

He whines, high-pitched and distraught, before shaking his head and deciding to move on. "Okay, okay. Never have I ever….been in a physical fight."

All four of them drink and the look of disappointment that Bow gives them all is almost heartbreaking. "What is *wrong* with you guys?"

"Hey, in my defense, everyone I've ever fought with was totally asking for it," Catra clarifies and reaches for the bag of chocolate, only to have her hand swatted away by Bow himself. Incredulously, she blinks at him before snatching the bag to her chest.

"Mean people don't get sweets!"

"I said they all deserved it!" She grabs a handful of candy and drops the bag back onto the table. "Swat me away again and you're next." She's kidding. Sort of.

But she sounds serious enough to shut him up and make him withdraw. Across the way Glitter is glaring at her again, and Catra wonders if maybe she'll be fighting someone after all.

Adora stops that motion before it lifts off. "Never have I ever worn a leotard."

Her tactic works. Her attention is torn away from Glitter in order to take a drink. Across from her, Adam does the same. "Wrestling."

Catra nods. "Gymnastics," she clarifies when they turn to her.

Glimmer's up again, and Catra watches her, wondering if she's going to try and come after her for a third time considering she's failed stupendously the previous two. However, given the uproar that her last turn raised, it seems she's deciding to play it safe this time, because she isn't even looking at Catra this time. "Never have I ever been in a car accident."

Bow drinks and Adam laughs at the glare that Adora shoots his way before they both take a drink as well.

Alarmed, Catra turns to Adora. "Wait, what? When did this happen?" In all their time of being friends, Adora had *never* mentioned a car accident. Which means that it must have happened after they broke off.

Unfazed, Adora waves off her concern. "Relax. It was minor. Adam was driving me home from the store and crashed into a curb. Knocked down a street sign too."

"What? You didn't even tell her the best part!"

Rolling her eyes, Adora sighs and starts picking apart a candy wrapper. "Yeah, yeah. The accident was small, no injuries. But it

was just enough for my water to break."

"Wait," Catra interjects. "This happened when you were *pregnant*?" She turns to Adam next and leans over to swat his leg. "What the hell, dude?"

"Hey! Like she said, no injuries! If anything, you should be mourning my car seat. Took *for-ev-er* to wash the smell out." He shrugs and takes another sip of his beer. "But all's well that ends well. Few hours later and," He makes a popping noise with his mouth. "Out came my niece!"

The image of Adora, freshly out of labor, cradling a newborn Mara comes to mind, and something in Catra's heart clenches. She's always known, but the fact only really hits her right there: she'd missed it. All of it.

She wasn't there for any of it.

Adam claps, bringing Catra back. "Alright! My turn! Never have I ever gone into labor and ruined my brother's car seat."

"Adam! Knock it off!" shouts Adora as she lifts up her bottle to take another drink.

"You never even offered to clean it!"

"I had just shoved a *baby* out of my-"

Adam holds his hands up. "Right. Right. You're right. Sorry."

Catra laughs and taps her bottle lightly against the table. "Okay. Never have I ever kissed anyone in this room."

She knew that she was going to get Adora, Adam, and Glitter with that one, but she's a little shocked when Bow takes a swig as well. Across from him, Glitter is a shade of pink that matches her hair.

"We were in high school!" she rushes out in defense.

"Yeah, we were both curious and just wanted to make sure!" Bow adds on.

Adam immediately jumps in to tease his girlfriend, asking who she *hasn't* kissed by this point, and Catra's so busy laughing that she just barely notices the way that Adora's gone quiet. She's sitting there, nursing her bottle of beer to her lips, and when Catra catches her gaze they look...sad? Hurt? Disappointed?

She's not sure what to make of it.

She's less sure she wants to ask.

Once the teasing has died down, they all turn to Bow since it's now his turn, but he winces and places his - finally empty - bottle down on the table. "Actually, guys. It's getting kind of late and I already texted Perfuma for a ride home. She's gonna be here soon so I think I'm gonna call it a night."

Glitter hums and nods, patting Adam's leg twice. "Yeah, I guess we should probably head out too then. Do you think Perfuma would be willing to drop us off at home on the way?"

Arrow smiles. "Yeah, of course. No problem."

They spend the next few minutes saying their goodbyes to each other. Adam wraps Catra up in a hug again, less constricting than last time but still firm and kisses the top of her head. When he pulls back, he points a finger at her. "No running off and vanishing again, you hear me?"

Catra grins. "Whatever you say, lover boy." She laughs when the look of utter dread and embarrassment takes over his face, his cheeks flushing just the slightest. "And hey, lay off the Ne-Yo. Shit's not good for ya."

He waves her off with a smile. "Yeah, whatever. At least I don't deny my feelings for people." He gives her a pointed look before his gaze drifts off. She follows it to where Adora is hugging Glitter

and Bow bye, laughing with them over something that Bow has said.

Shaken, Catra turns back to Adam and shoves him. "I do not. You don't know what the hell you're talking about."

He raises his eyebrows and laughs, giving her a playful shove back. "Right. Sure I don't."

Catra glares up at him. "I mean it. Now go home, you drunkard."

"Pfft. I'm barely buzzed." He raises his hands up in defeat and backs off. "But whatever. You're not ready for that conversation yet, I guess. But I'll be here when you are." Before she can retort with something else, he gives her a two-fingered salute before walking over to the door with Glitter and Arrow, giving his sister a slap on the shoulder and stern warning for "no more threesomes". After a quick shouting match between the two, the three of them are gone, and Adora closes the door, leaving just the two of them.

Catra shifts awkwardly in her spot when Adora turns to her heaving a huge sigh. "Um, I'll help you clean up."

And then Adora smiles at her, a little weary and wobbly. "That'd be great. Thank you."

They clean up the living room in silence mostly, throwing away empty bottles and discarded candy wrappers. As Catra closes up the bag of tortilla chips and Adora's scooping the leftover salsa into a plastic container, she hears her ask, "So….?"

She knows what Adora's insinuating. "Your friends are okay." She quirks her lip. "Not too sure if Glitter likes me that much, though."

"Well," Adora puts the salsa into the fridge. "You *were* kind of antagonizing her the whole time."

Catra blinks and feigns innocence. "Moi?"

Adora gives her look that she is not buying it. "You don't have to be so confrontational all the time, you know that? I mean, you and Bow seemed to be getting along pretty alright."

"Because he wasn't trying to stab me with his eyes the whole night."

"Glimmer's…" She trails off, trying to consider her next words. "Protective. She may not know exactly what happened between us, but...she does know what happened with Mara's dad. Ever since then she's just been-"

"Kind of a bitch?"

"Cautious," Adora says pointedly. "She doesn't want to see me go through something like that again."

Well, when she put it *that* way….

She supposed she could lay off Glitter a little bit. Out of respect.

After all, it isn't like Catra was there to fill that role after that whole debacle. So she supposed if it had to be anyone, she was glad that Sparkles was the one to step up. And for that, she could give her a little credit.

But she wasn't going to let everything slide so easily. Anger management be damned, something about that girl just raised her hackles. And she isn't the easily forgiving type.

Catra straightens up and smooths out her shirt, giving the living room a cursory glance to make sure that everything had mostly been picked up. Satisfied, she walks over to the kitchen where she left her keys. "Well, I guess I should be heading home too."

Adora perks up, giving her a wary glance. "Didn't you drive here?"

"Yeah? And?"

Adora shakes her head and walks over, snatching the keys from the counter and holding them at a distance. "You shouldn't be driving right now."

Catra rolls her eyes and reaches for the keys, growling with Adora yanks them out of reach again. "Relax, *Mom*. I only had two drinks. I'm fine."

"I don't care. You shouldn't be driving."

Catra blinks incredulously at her. "You *do* realize I drove us home from the bar that first time, right? *And* the time after that where I had to drive both you and myself home."

Adora purses her lips together, but doesn't waver. "Well, that was then. But now you have the option of not having to drive." When Catra doesn't pick up on what she's saying immediately. Adora fidgets, looking anywhere but here. "You can stay here for the night."

A sense of panic shoots through her that she decides not to dwell on. "I didn't bring anything to sleep in."

"I have some old clothes you could borrow."

"Where would I even sleep?"

"Well, you could take my bed and I can sleep on the couch…"

"I am *not* kicking you out of your own bed, Adora." She lunges for the keys again but Adora sidesteps her just in time that she misses. "Ohmygod, I'm *fine*! Do you want me to do a cartwheel and prove it to you?"

Adora doesn't answer that. Instead, she steps forward, being sure to still keep the keys out of reach, and brushes her hand against Catra's cheek. The touch shocks her and keeps her still, and she can feel her lungs struggle as she tries to remember how to breathe.

"You're warm," Adora mutters. Catra's not sure if she should bother telling her that it wasn't from the alcohol. Actually, no, it *has* to be from the alcohol. No other reason. "Stay the night. Please? Put my mind at ease?"

How could she say no?

With a defeated sigh and slump of her shoulders, Catra relents. "Okay. Alright, fine. I'll stay. But *I'm* taking the couch, got it?"

Adora nods, giving her a small smile before dropping her hand to her side and placing the keys back on the counter. "Let me go get you some clothes then."

She comes back with a pair of sweats and an old, off-white t-shirt with the letters peeling off. "The bathroom is just down the hall. You can change there."

Following her directions, Catra shuffles down the hall and locks the door, setting the change of clothes on the toilet before making work of stripping out of the clothes she's wearing. Once she's stripped down, she pulls on the sweats first, carefully tying off a knot on the strings that were frayed and nearly torn to shreds. Then she holds up the shirt, recognizing it as one of her old gymnastics shirts from high school that had gone missing years ago.

Catra chuckles quietly to herself as she pulls it on. "Little thief." It's loose on her, having been stretched and pulled from what must have been a million washes. Absentmindedly, she pulls the collar up to her nose and takes in a breath, inhaling Adora's scent.

A moment passes before her brain catches up and she realizes just what she's done. Regardless of the privacy of being alone in a bathroom - *Adora's* bathroom - Catra drops the shirt in horror, gathering up her clothes in a ball and quickly exiting as she runs back to the living room, trying not to think too hard about it.

Adora's by the couch, setting down a pillow and folded blanket. She lifts her head when Catra enters, biting her lip when Catra

pulls on the shirt. "Really?"

She shrugs and laughs. "You never asked for it back."

"Should I have to ask for my own shirt back?"

Adora shrugs again and walks over to her. "Well, if you're that worked up about it, you can always take it home with you."

Catra is a little ashamed to admit how enticing that offer is. Not that she's ashamed of reclaiming ownership of her own shirt, but rather because she knows that it smells like Adora. She shakes her head. "Nah, keep it. You already stretched it out." She walks over to the living room and drops her ball of clothes on the armchair.

Adora hangs around for a moment longer. "Um, do you need anything else? Something to drink? Or another blanket? I have plenty if you think you'll be cold."

"I'm fine, Adora. You should get to bed yourself. Don't worry about me."

Adora smiles. "Someone has to."

She also won't admit how that simple sentence has her feeling warm inside. For the thousandth time that night, she's blaming the alcohol.

Adora excuses herself to go get dressed for bed and Catra begins making work on setting up her bed for the night. By the time she's set up her pillow, laid out the blanket, and crawled underneath it, Adora walks out again, dressed in nothing but her underwear and an oversized shirt. Her eyebrows raise and her mouth goes dry, but she brushes it off with a quip.

"Have you always had an aversion to wearing pants to bed or is that just the alcohol?"

Adora looks down, as if she somehow forgot she isn't wearing anything, before a light blush breaks out across her cheeks and the bridge of her noise. "Well...the further along I got in my pregnancy, the more miserable I got wearing sleeping pants. After that it sort of just stuck and I haven't gone back."

She doesn't really know how to respond to that. "I see." She's *totally* not too busy staring at her best friend's legs. Coughing, she finally averts her eyes and focuses on readjusting her pillow. In the kitchen, she can hear Adora moving about, getting a glass of water by the sound of it. She half-expects Adora to leave as soon as she's finished, but when there's no more movement, Catra chances a glance up.

Adora's still standing there, behind the counter thankfully, sipping on her glass of water. She's watching her and Catra can see the gears turning in her head. She almost snaps at her to spit it out already, when Adora finally decides to speak. "So...hip-hop dance classes, huh?"

Right. The conversation from the beginning of the night. "Yeah. What about it?"

Adora shrugs and takes another sip of water. "Nothing. Just…" She bites her lip. "Nothing."

At this point Catra decides to sit up, propping herself up on her elbows. "No, really. What's up?"

She's silent for a moment, eyes drifting over her face. Her mouth opens, but then she seems to think better of it and snaps it closed again. She twists her lips in thought, teeth coming out to clamp down on her bottom lip before, finally, she dives in. "Think I could drop in on a class?"

Catra cackles. "Want to fix your pathetic dance moves?"

"They are not pathetic!"

"Babe, I was there at the bar a few weeks ago. I saw *everything*." Adora puffs out her cheeks in dejection and Catra only revels in it for a few seconds before asking, "You free this Friday?"

"Um…" Adora clears her throat. "Yeah."

"I'll pick you up at three then. Sound good?"

"Y-yeah."

Catra hums and settles back into the couch, laying her head on the pillow and pulling the blanket up to her chin. "Great. Goodnight then."

"Yeah. Goodnight." And then Catra hears her shuffle out of the kitchen.

"Oh, and Adora?"

Adora pauses and hums to show she's listening.

Catra turns to look at her, eyes lingering on her legs for maybe a second longer than should be normal. "Wear something cool and comfortable. It's quite the workout. Don't want you overheating or anything."

"Got…" She clears her throat again. "Got it."

Chapter End Notes

Sup, guys? Hope y'all haven't gone crazy in quarantine yet. Here's a little something to help out with that hopefully.

As I mentioned last chapter, this fic has now surpassed 500 kudos!! Like....WOW! I'm so amazed and honored you like this fic so much. It warms my heart to know that this dumb little idea I had a year ago would reach this point.

I also mentioned last chapter that, to celebrate, I'd be doing a Q&A video. I'm still planning to, but I currently don't have

enough questions to go through the trouble of planning, filming, and editing it yet, so please please PLEASE send in any questions you might have for me! The sooner I get more questions, the sooner I can do the video! It doesn't even have to be about this fic. It can be about any of my fics, regardless of fandom, or about my writing process in general. PLEEEEEASE send me questions!!!! You can send them to my tumblr, twitter, or comment here!

On another note, I've received more WONDERFUL art from you guys!!! For instance, check out this awesome piece by shuckel from last chapter! Y'all rock! If you guys ever draw art for this, feel free to throw it at my face on either my tumblr or twitter (both listed on my AO3 profile).

Until next time~! Stay safe, stay healthy, and PLEASE practice social distancing so I can graduate! I've worked really hard these past 5 years and as of now, my graduation has been postponed. Please don't make me sad guys :((((

(Obviously that's not the ONLY reason you guys should be practicing social distancing but it's an added bonus for me)

i could fall in love again (but i wanna forget that)

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Adora Break A Sweat, Perfuma has the hots for Catra, and the ice cream shops are preparing for the enigma that is Mermista
>
> Oh and there's a kiss? Or maybe not quite....

Chapter Notes

> Quick notes at the beginning of this chapter that you're welcome to ignore but are important to me:
>
> Listen to Break A Sweat by Becky G during the dance sequence and imagine a fun little montage with quick cuts and time lapses because fanfiction doesn't work like visual media
>
> Listen to Would You Let Me by Folded Dragons, AKACIA & ethanuno at the end of the chapter if you wanna maximize those feels
>
> Cool? Cool. Proceed.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

If Glimmer was here, she'd certainly tell her she's overthinking things.

But Glimmer isn't here. It's just Adora and her big, dumb brain that's been staring at the same pair of short for the past fifteen minutes.

Catra had said that they'd be getting 'quite the workout', but are shorts overdoing it? Would she be fine wearing sweatpants or fitness leggings? There's always the option she can swap out her

workout tank with a t-shirt and jacket to balance out the shorts so she's not showing too much skin. Not that she minds showing off her body, per se, especially since she pretty much got back to how it was before her pregnancy, but would that be sending the wrong message? Or is she just *assuming* that Catra might read it a certain way?

Groaning she tosses the shorts to the corner of her room and opens up her dresser drawer full of sweats. Looking down into a sea of washed out grey, maroon, and brown, she slams it shut again and picks up the discarded shorts from the floor, yanking them on with a frustrated finality.

No. These would work. But she's *definitely* changing her tank top to something else.

As soon as she yanks it over her head, her phone goes off. Tossing the shirt onto her bed, Adora picks up her phone and reads the text that Catra just sent her, saying that she's in the lobby, heading up to her apartment now.

"Aaahhhhh." Rushing over to her closet, she yanks the first t-shirt she sees off of one of the hangers, looks at it for a second, then drops it to her feet before reaching into the row of shirts again. The next thing she pulls out is a loose, off-the-shoulder dark red pullover which she pulls over her head, mussing up her already messy bun. She shuffles over to her full-length mirror to fix it and, after finishing, gives herself a quick once-over.

And realizes her shirt is on backwards.

There's a knock at her apartment door just as soon as she readjusts herself and she heads out of her room to answer it, only pausing long enough to pluck her phone from her bed.

She opens the door, breathless, and ushers Catra in with a smile. "Hey! I just need to put on some shoes and then I'll be ready to go."

Catra grins at her and slings her duffel bag over her shoulder before walking past her into the apartment. "Should I sit down or…?"

Adora scoffs and makes a flicking motion at her. "Oh quiet, you. It'll only take me a minute."

Catra props her hip against the kitchen counter and Adora takes that as her cue to run and get her running shoes from her room. After pulling them on and grabbing the essentials (keys, wallet, an extra hair tie, and a duffel bag of her own) she comes back out to the apartment's living space to see Catra scrolling idly through her phone.

No longer blinded by a panic-fueled haze, she finally notices what Catra's wearing. A pair of worn, dark red sweatpants hugs her hips, the kind that gives plenty of room in the crotch area by dropping down to mid-thigh. Peeking above the waist band is what appears to be high-waisted, bright red spanx of some kind. A backwards-facing cap sits on top of her head with her mess of curls peeking from the bottom and brushing her jawline. She's also wearing a black racerback that says "I prefer cooking, but sometimes eating out with my girls is fun" in all dark gray text, save for "I Prefer Eating Out Girls" printed in bold white lettering that's larger than the rest.

Adora smirks and nods at the shirt when Catra looks up at her. "Cute."

Catra returns the smirk and flips the ends of some of her curls in an overdramatic fashion considering it doesn't achieve much and bats her eyelashes. "Aren't I just?" Then she pockets her phone into her pocket and pushes off the counter. "Now c'mon, loser. We're losing daylight."

The studio is quiet and empty when they arrive.

Adora looks around the room, watching her reflection in the floor-to-ceiling mirrors lining the right wall. Catra's off in the far corner, messing with a sound system and her phone.

"Are we early?"

A grunt from the corner and then the hum of the sound system coming to life. "Early for what?"

"The class." Adora frowns. "I thought I was joining one of the classes."

Catra scoffs and hops up from the ground. "Why join a class when I can give you a free lesson?"

"O-oh." She bites her lip, not really sure how to respond or what to make of the whole situation. "I wouldn't have minded paying."

Catra shrugs. "Eh. My way's better." She claps when she finishes setting up the speakers. "So I figured I'd teach you some choreography that we just finished up teaching. It's a pretty basic routine and I think even you could handle it."

She knows she should be insulted (and she is, just a little bit) but she's still a little preoccupied trying to wrap her head around the fact that she's about to receive a private lesson from Catra. Alone. Just the two of them.

That should be fine, right? After all, she had asked for this, hadn't she? Maybe not the private lesson part, but all they would be doing is dancing for the next hour or so. It isn't anything to worry about.

So why is she already sweating?

"So I'm gonna run through the choreography once to show you what we'll be doing, and then after that I'll break it down step-by-step with you. Sound good?"

"Um, yeah." Adora swallows and takes a step back, closer to the wall. "You're the expert here."

Catra nods and messes around with her phone a little bit more, scrolling through what looks like a playlist. Once she makes her selection an upbeat pop song begins playing on the speakers and she skips over to her place in the center of the room, right in front of the mirror and Adora. She bounces on the balls of her feet, gauging the beat for a few seconds, swinging her arms in a rhythmic motion as she begins to loosen herself up.

And then she starts to move.

The first thing Adora notices is that this is *hardly* beginner's choreography. She watches the motions carefully, wondering just how in the hell she's supposed to replicate them. She's never been overly confident in her dancing and this dance was only serving to prove exactly why that is.

The second thing she notices is that Catra's...really good at this. Not that she didn't expect her to be, given that she has the gig of being a dance instructor in the first place. Plus, she remembers growing up that Catra had a natural inclination when it came to moving her body, a combination of doing gymnastics most of her youth and just the simple fact that she could place any beat and move her body in a complimenting rhythm. Adora knows that Catra has always been a gifted dancer, but this….

This is amazing.

She recalls going to parties and Catra being the center of attention in the middle of a crowd, or trips to the bar where she awed and amazed the patrons with the motions of her body. She remembers always being one of them too. Watching from the sidelines, heart beating with each pop and roll of her hips, the way she could mesmerize an entire group of people as soon as she took the floor. She'd always been proud of her best friend for being so confident in her body and moves to put herself out there

like that and shared her exhiliration at being cheered on by onlookers.

And yeah. Maybe even a little bit in love with watching how she moved.

The music fades off and Catra's stopped dancing, hands resting on her hips. She looks to Adora with a raised brow and smirk and Adora feels her stomach drop out underneath her.

"Ready?"

Adora bites her lip and fidgets with her hands, still plagued with those memories of their youth. "You said it would be easy and *that*," she motions with her hands towards Catra, "did *not* look easy."

"I said it would be basic, not 'easy'," Catra corrects. She walks over to pull Adora to the center of the room and turns her around to watch the mirror. "Look, just follow my lead, okay? I'll go slow and gentle, just for you."

Adora licks her lips and watches her reflection do the same, seeing just how tense she really looks. Ugh. "If you say so. Just promise not to laugh."

Breaking the promise already, Catra does. "I make no such promise."

"You're too stiff. You're not letting your body move as freely as it should be." They had already run through the routine, step-by-step, about a dozen times by this point. Adora is beginning to realize just how not cut out for this she is with each passing minute and each misstep.

Adora rolls her eyes. "Thanks, Coach," she says dryly. "That's really helpful."

Catra sighs and interlocks her fingers, placing them on top of her head. "Okay. How about we take a quick breather, get some water in ya, and then start back from the top?" Without even waiting for Adora's response, she heads over to her duffel bag shoved off to the side of the room and procures a water bottle, squeezing a stream into her mouth.

Adora dumbly follows after her, taking out her own water bottle and twisting off the cap before gulping down about a third of the bottle. "You know I'm not cut out for this kind of thing."

Catra tilts her head and falls down to the floor on her ass, propping her arms on her knees. "Then why did you ask?"

Adora shrugs. Truthfully, she's not actually all that interested in learning how to dance. She has long since accepted that she's not particularly good at it. But she's also not about to confess where her real interest lies; she wanted to see Catra in action, in her element. It's been awhile since she's seen Catra dance and this seemed as good an excuse as any to be given the opportunity.

She takes a seat across from Catra, resting her back against the wall and gently nurses her bottle of water.

There's one other thing too.

She had wanted to ask Catra a question from the night they'd played that drinking game. She had planned on asking after the class, maybe over a light dinner or something, but now that they have this whole studio to themselves…

She's starting to chicken out. Because of course she is.

But truthfully it's sort of been bothering her. When Catra had said how she'd never kissed anyone in the room…

Did that mean she didn't remember?

It's highly likely. Adora knows that a lot of that night is a blur for her as well and Catra had had a *lot* more to drink than she had.

Originally, after the whole incident, she had just figured that Catra was feigning ignorance in order to avoid confrontation or talking about it. And Adora had been so mortified and heartbroken at the time she had allowed it. She let it all slide, wanting to forget the whole thing herself. Risking their friendship wasn't worth bringing it up.

But now...could she really have forgotten? Or is she, after all these years, still refusing to admit to what happened between them?

Adora takes another sip of her water and grimaces. Well it would've been cruel to bring it up like she had if that is the case. If she really did remember, why bring it up at all like she didn't?

A sprinkling of water hits her face and Adora's ripped from her thoughts to see Catra staring at her. "Yo, you good? I didn't, like, fry your brain or something, did I? We've barely done anything."

Adora looks at her, wondering if she should just drop it. After all, it happened *years* ago when they were still in high school. Did it even matter anymore? Both of them are grown up now - she has a kid and Catra has...well, better things going for her, obviously. They're past all that high school nonsense, aren't they?

But could this be the closure she needed, all those years ago? To finally have an answer to the question that kept her up at night, shedding tears on her pillow as she replayed the night's events over and over, trying to figure out what went wrong, what *she* did wrong?

Adora shakes her head. No. It's no use bringing up the past now. That opportunity had come and gone in an instant, and those feelings from long ago have since faded. Resurfacing old memories would only ruin what they have going for them now.

"Not yet." She stands up and drops her water bottle on top of her bag. "C'mon. I'm ready to give it another try."

Catra grins and stands up after her, clapping a hand on her shoulder. "That's my girl. From the top, yeah?"

A few more run-throughs and Adora thinks she's finally beginning to get the hang of this. Her missteps are fewer and further in-between and she can even keep up when Catra speeds up the tempo a little bit. She's warm from all the movement and they take a couple more short water breaks, but for the most part, she's feeling better about all of this.

"You know," Catra says in-between sets, "You're a lot better at this than you give yourself credit for."

Adora freezes.

"*You know, you're way better at this than you give yourself credit for*." She'd said those same words then, too.

"Y-yeah?" Her mouth is dry and she wonders if it's time for another break.

Catra hums and heads back over to the sound system. "Think you might be ready to try it with the music?"

"Um…" She blinks rapidly, trying to ground herself in the present. "Yeah. Sure. I could try."

"Great." The music starts playing over the speakers and Catra jogs back to her side, hopping back into her place. "Remember, stay loose and do the steps like we practice, 'kay?"

"Right." She pushes those thoughts and memories out of her head so she can focus on the task at hand. Later.

They repeat the routine again, with only a few faltered steps on Adora's part, but she chalks some of those up to still being distracted by her own thoughts. Luckily for her, Catra doesn't see anything necessarily out of the ordinary. She probably thinks it's the fact that Adora still doesn't have the routine down pat.

Once they finish the final steps and the music begins to fade, Catra turns to her with a grin and hand raised high, which Adora slaps her own against. "You got it! Who knows? A few more workshops and you could be an honest-to-god dancer."

Panting, Adora lets her gaze drift over to their bags. "Water."

Catra snaps and points where Adora's looking. "Right. Break time. You earned it, babe."

They're sitting next to each other this time, backs to the wall and sipping on their respective water bottles. It's mostly silent, as the two women regain their breaths and Adora tries to sort through her thoughts.

Screw it.

"Hey," she says, grabbing Catra's attention. "I have a question to ask you."

Catra grunts around the lip of her water bottle mid-sip. "Okay. But I get to ask you a question too."

Adora frowns, trying to think of what she could possibly want to ask her. One thing comes to mind. "Is this about the threesome?"

"Of *course* it's about the threesome! You've been holding out on me, babe! We used to tell each other everything and you've been keeping this from me?" She leans forward, fanged grin pinning her in place and Adora knows there's no running from this now. "So? Spill!"

Adora gnaws on her bottom lip and tosses her water bottle from hand to hand. "I mean, I'm not really sure what to say about it. I met someone on tinder. She had a girlfriend and they were really just interested in sex with someone else to spice up their own sex lives and that suited me just fine. I went, we had fun, I left that same night."

Once she's finished, she notices that Catra is staring at her. Like, *staring* at her. Mouth sort of parted, eyes hazed over, and she'd be lying if she says it isn't a bit off-putting. She clears her throat to try and snap Catra out of it and she does, even if it takes a couple seconds. She briefly wonders what was on Catra's mind to put her in that state, but decides she doesn't want to dwell on it that much.

Catra coughs and nudges her shoulder. "Gee, way to undersell an exciting story. Where's the *passion*? The zeal!"

"I'm sorry. Did you want a play-by-play of everything we did?" she laughs. Catra doesn't respond immediately, only raising her brows. "No. Absolutely not. I am not detailing my sex life for you."

"What are best friends even for then?" Catra groans, slumping against the wall. Regardless of her dramatic dejection, she drops it with a sigh. "Okay, fine. We'll work on that later. What's your question?"

Oh. Right.

Adora sits there, contemplating whether or not she really wants to go through with this after all. It's her curiosity - her *stupid* curiosity - that's pestering her to bring it up. Ultimately, none of it even matters anymore. It won't change anything knowing the answer now. It won't fix anything from back then, either. It's just some dumb question that has been rattling about in her brain for years, dormant and small enough until just recently that it's begun ringing like a gong.

Not to mention that bringing it up will not only fail to fix things, but they might even ruin them. Everything they've built up, the shaky ground they're standing on...what will happen to all that if she voices her ponderings out loud?

It's not worth it.

It's on the tip of her tongue.

Do you really not remember when we kissed?

"What's the next choreography routine you're going to teach?" she asks quietly. She's relieved and ashamed all at once.

Did it ever mean anything to you at all?

Catra blinks as she clearly wasn't expecting that to be the question. There's a moment where she stares at Adora, eyes slightly narrowed, as if she can somehow see straight through her and knows that she's hiding something. Eventually, the moment passes, and she stretches her arms high above her head, giving Adora a smirk. "Do you want to see it?"

Did you ever see me the way I saw you?

Adora smiles, but it feels a little strained. "Well, duh." She hopes that Catra doesn't notice.

And she doesn't. Or, at the very least, she doesn't make any comment on it. Next she's jumping up from the floor and skipping to the sound system in the opposite corner to select a song. "We'll actually be workshopping this one next week. It's Friday at noon if you were interested in coming to watch."

"Think I could bring Mara? I'm sure she'd love it."

"Yeah, no problem! Though I'm sure Rogelio is going to *choke* when he sees you have a kid, so fair warning there."

Did you have any idea how horribly heartbroken I was that night?

The music starts. It's a different tune and beat from the previous song. Whereas the last one was far more upbeat and fun, this one had more edge to it. In fact, this certain sounded much more like hip-hop than the last one. It's what Adora had always imagined hip-hop dancers actually danced to if she's thinking of the more stereotypical aspects of it.

Even Catra's dance moves to this song are a little more aggressive. Whereas with the dance she'd been taught it had been much more fluid and light-hearted, the vibe to this song was entirely different, almost like a switch was flipped. Catra's body language is more aggressive, more in-your-face than previously. Her shoulders and hips pop with more edge and purpose, her footwork is quicker and louder. Even her facial expressions, which had been so relaxed and happy-going before, are more serious and intimidating.

Nonetheless, it's all still just as mesmerizing to watch. To see how diverse her style is, to see all that she's capable of and the different styles she can adopt with such ease that it hardly looks like she's even trying. This truly is her element.

And then she's finished. The music keeps going and she runs over to turn it off before turning around to Adora expectantly. "So? Whatcha think?"

Would you even care if I told you now?

Adora laughs, breathlessly. "I think I'd fall flat on my face if I tried that one."

Catra nods. "Yeah, well, this is for our intermediate and advanced classes, so that makes sense. I don't even think your friend, Arrow, is at that level yet."

Adora frowns and furrows her brow. "What...do you mean *Bow*?"

"To-may-to, to-mah-to."

"Is learning my friends' names really that difficult for you?"

"Oh, I know their names." She unplugs her phone from the sound system and Adora winces at the feedback that screeches out. "I've just made the conscious decision not to use them." Next, she begins turning the entire system off, pocketing her phone as she walks over to where Adora's sitting to start gathering her things.

Adora hums and bites her lip, drumming her fingers against her thighs. "Think you could stand to make the decision to use their actual names tomorrow night? Say around….eight-ish?"

Catra freezes and turns to her slowly. "What? Are we playing another drinking game?"

"Not quite." She lets out a breath and decides to just go for it. "It's Mermista's birthday party tomorrow and...I was wondering if you would maybe want to go with me?"

The silence she receives in response is a bit unnerving. Not like she'd expected Catra to go head-over-heels in excitement or even accept the invitation to begin with. But the way that Catra is staring at her, face nearly impassive, puts her a little bit on edge.

It was a stupid idea, really. But she figured that since last week wasn't a total disaster, maybe Catra could handle meeting the rest of her friends. It's short notice, of course, so she can't blame her if she has other plans or just isn't mentally prepared to be thrown into that situation, but she figures it's worth a shot.

Finally, Catra sighs and zips up her duffel bag, throwing it over her shoulder. "I need a drink."

Adora frowns. "What? At," she checks the time on her phone, "five o'clock?"

Catra shakes her head with a smirk. "I was actually thinking more along the lines of an iced coffee. But I do like where your head's at. C'mon, Footloose, I'll treat. We can talk more about this once I get some caffeine in me."

"So run this by me again: you want me to go to this chick's birthday party-"

"Mermista," Adora cuts in, though it doesn't matter because Catra keeps going as if she hadn't heard.

"Who *clearly* hates my guts?"

"She-" Adora purses her lips, trying to choose her words carefully. "She doesn't...*hate* you, she just...look, you have to be honest, would *you* be very happy with you if you were in her shoes?"

Catra takes a sip of her iced coffee and throws her arm over her chair, lounging casually. "Of course not. Which is why the part that I really don't get is why you think it's a good idea for me to meet her."

She understands what Catra's saying. Her concerns are perfectly valid and she can't blame her for one second of being wary of the one person who knows what really happened between the two of them. But she remembers her conversation with Mermista at the bar that one night. The woman might have her reservations, but her trust in Adora's judgement could pave the way to a willingness to forgive, if only presented the opportunity.

"I don't want the past to hang over us anymore, Catra. If we're going to fix this, I'm not the only one you have to apologize to."

Catra jerks up and leans across the table. "Wait, *apologize*? You didn't mention anything about that. I don't even *know* this girl! Why the hell am I apologizing to her?"

A flash of irritation makes her temple throb. "Because *that girl* is the one who cleaned up *your*," she jabs a finger into Catra's chest for good measure, "mess." She watches Catra slink back into her seat. "After that phone call, she was the main one who checked on me and made sure I got through it. In fact, that night alone she spent an almost ridiculous amount of money on ice cream while I *cried*," she notices Catra flinch and almost feels a little sorry, "because you wouldn't return any of my calls or texts."

Catra holds her hands up in a truce. "Okay, okay! Jeez, I get it. I fucked up real bad. I already told you-"

"Well now it's time you tell *her*," Adora cuts off. The tension melts from her shoulders and she leans her torso forwards, dropping her

voice to something softer. "Look, I know that you said you were going through a lot at that time. I already forgive you, but if you want to keep this going, there's more that you're going to have to atone for. Mermista is one of my closest friends and I would appreciate it if you two weren't at each other's throats." She sits back to take a sip of her coffee. "I'm not forcing you to do anything, Catra. But I *am* asking you to take this opportunity to make things right."

Catra grimaces and moves her straw back and forth. "Great. Now you're making me sound like an asshole if I *don't* go to this dumb party and apologize."

Adora taps her thumbs against her own cup and tilts her head. "Well…."

Catra throws her hands up. "Alright! I get it! I'll go. Just give me an address."

Bringing out her phone, she opens up her messaging app. "I'll text it to you so you don't forget." She types out the address quickly and presses send. A couple seconds later, Catra's phone goes off and she swipes her phone open to read it. She frowns and looks back up at Adora, confusion written all over her features.

"Adora, this is an address to the docks in the harbor."

Adora can't stop the smile so she hides it behind taking a sip of her coffee. "Hope you have your sea legs, sailor."

She's late. Or maybe she isn't coming, after all.

The party is already pretty much in full-swing. Granted, it's a rather small group of people that Sea Hawk had invited - just their close friends and a couple of Mermista's co-workers that she claims to "tolerate more than the others". But they're already an hour in, music blasting and drinks passed around and there still isn't any sign of Catra.

Adora had briefly debated sending her a text earlier that morning to ask if she was really coming. Ultimately, she had decided against it, not wanting to pester or guilt her into it when she had, in fact, said it was Catra's decision in the end. But now she's wondering if she should send a text for some kind of status update, even if that update is a simple and curt "fuck off".

"Mommy?" She feels a tug on her slacks and looks down to see Mara looking back up at her. "When do we get to eat da cake?"

"Not until we sing 'Happy Birthday' to Auntie Mistie, baby girl," she says, smoothing down her daughter's unruly hair. "Where's Frosha?"

"Potty!" Mara begins bouncing up and down to the point that Adora wonders if she needs to make a trip herself. "She said she has to potty!"

Adora hums and finishes smoothing down her hair. "Okay then. Do you want to get some snacks while you wait for her?"

Mara throws her hands up, opening and closing her fists to make grabby hands. "Cake!"

"Not yet," Adora reminds her and takes one of Mara's hands in her own. "Here, let's go over to the snack table and see what looks yummy, okay?"

It would seem that Catra has to wait.

After filling up a plate that consisted mostly of chips and mac 'n' cheese along with a cup of fruit punch, Adora leads Mara over to one of the couches in the lounge area so she could eat without making too much of a mess. As Mara's munching on her food, Adora pulls out her phone to check for any new messages.

Nothing.

Well, sending status updates has never really been Catra's style. She shouldn't think too much on it.

Except *of course* she is. Because that's her style.

"There's my little Peanut! I was wondering where you'd run off to!"

Mara gasps and swivels around in her seat, giving Adora just barely enough time to drop her phone on her lap and catch her plate before it's knocked over onto the couch. "Frosha!" Mara shouts, bouncing uncontrollably in her seat.

Sure enough, Frosta had returned from the bathroom. Adora smiles up at her. "Hey, she was just having some snacks."

Frosta leans over the back of the couch, propped up by her elbows. "Whoa, no way! Whatcha got there, Peanut?"

"Cheese 'nd chips!"

"Cheese and chips? And you weren't going to share with me?"

Mara swivels around and grabs a chip off of the plate and offers it out to Frosta. "Here you go."

Frosta smiles and ruffles Mara's hair as she takes the chip. "Aww, thanks, Peanut."

"You know if you ever want a break, you can send her over my way, right?"

Frosta dusts the chip crumbs off her hands before waving her off. "It's fine, really. I haven't seen Mara in forever, so it's nice being able to hang out with her again. Been busy with school and all that."

Adora hums. She understands that all too well. "How's it going, by the way? You adjusting well enough?"

"Well," Frosta picks Mara off of the couch to hold in her arms after being consistently bombarded with pleas to "Up! Up! Pick me

up!", "besides my roommate being one of the rudest, sloppiest people I've ever met, everything's pretty okay."

Adora twists enough to prop her arms on the back of the couch, brow quirked and a knowing glint in her eye. "Any fun parties?"

Frosta bites her lip and looks behind her where Glimmer is talking with Perfuma and Bow. "A few." Then she turns back to Adora with wide eyes. "But you *cannot* tell Glimmer. She'll freak."

Adora chuckles good-naturedly. "You have nothing to worry about from me, hun. I've been there, done that, even got a nice little souvenir." She juts her thumb at Mara. "Just be careful, okay? I doubt you want a little *souvenir* of your own."

Frosta laughs, a little on the nervous side, and bounces Mara on her hip. "Yeah, no worries there. My mom would *slaughter* me."

"I'm not too worried about you. You're a smart enough girl." She looks towards where Glimmer is standing and smirks. "Also, if it's any consolation? Your cousin had her fair share of parties when we went to college together. She doesn't have much room to scold you for the same thing."

Frosta rolls her eyes, leaning her head away as Mara begins to grow more restless in her arms, flinging and rocking herself about. "Yeah, try telling *her* that."

Having had enough of the grown-up's conversation, Mara begins squirming even harder in Frosta's grasp, pointing wildly in the opposite direction towards the space set aside as a dance floor. "Dance! Dance wit' me, Frosha! Dance!"

Frosta chuckles. "Well, it seems I'm wanted elsewhere. Talk to you later." And with that, she whisks off Mara to the dance floor, setting her down to grab her hands so they could dance together. Adora watches them fondly from the couch, picking off the rest of Mara's forgotten plate.

Eventually though, her mind drifts back to Catra. Like it always seems to do these days.

She checks her phone again fruitlessly, gnawing her lip as she contemplates sending a message. She's about to type one out too when she hears a familiar voice.

"This seat taken?"

Adora looks up from her phone abruptly to see Mermista standing over her holding a half-empty wine cooler. She smiles and pats the seat next to her, an invitation to sit down. "Well hello, Birthday Girl. How's your night so far?"

Mermista groans in perfect-Mermista fashion. "Sea Hawk is being overbearingly annoying as always. I managed to ditch him when he and Adam started arm wrestling." She takes a sip of her drink and kicks up her legs onto the low-rise table, crossing them at the ankles. "How about you?"

"No complaints here. Food's pretty good." She takes another bite of the mac 'n' cheese.

Mermista glances at the phone still resting in her lap, seeing through her immediately. "She gonna show up?"

Her shoulders slump and she sighs tapping the couch cushion. "I don't know, honestly. She can be...pretty unpredictable and stubborn sometimes. And don't tell her I told you this but I think she might even be a little nervous to meet you."

Mermista nods and takes another sip of her drink. "She should be."

"See, this?" She points a finger at Mermista and draws a circle in the air. "This attitude is exactly why and it needs to go." At Mermista's unwavering expression of disinterest, she leans forward, putting on her best "give Adora what she wants face". Admittedly, the only person it's super effective on is Bow, but a

girl can try, can't she? "Mermista, she's *trying*. Can you cut her just a *little* bit of slack?" Still nothing. "For me?"

A moment passes and finally, she sees it: a small crack in Mermista's defenses. "Alright, fine! I won't bite her head off as soon as she steps on the stupid boat." She holds a finger up to stop Adora from being too pleased with herself. "But she gets *one* chance to make it up to me. I'm not about to forget what she did to you and what the resulting mess did to my bank account." Then she shrugs and looks away, making a point of not making eye contact. "Besides, you're like, one of my friends, or whatever. What she did to you sucks. You might be ready to let it slide, but anyone who hurts my friends has to do a whole lot more to impress me."

Adora smiles and scoots closer to Mermista who grunts at the proximity, clearly regretting saying anything at all. "Thanks, Mermista. You know how much this means to me."

"Hmmm." She takes another sip of her drink and finally turns back to face Adora. "Which also means that the *second* she does something to piss me off or upset you again, I'm throwing her off the boat."

"Mermista, Catra can't swim."

"That sounds like a 'her' problem."

Adora sighs and leans back against the couch, deciding not to argue it any further. Mermista is just as stubborn as Catra is sometimes. Honestly, if not for this whole incident, she thinks they'd make great friends. "I guess I'll just have a life-preserving ready then. Just in case."

"Well," Mermista says while standing up, "I guess I'm going to go find Sea Hawk to make sure he hasn't started any fires or isn't setting up some other ridiculous stunt. I'll catch you later." And then she walks off, leaving Adora alone once again.

Instinctively, Adora looks back to the dance floor to check on Mara. Her and Frosta have disappeared, but upon further searching she sees them at one of the tables watching videos on Frosta's phone. Assured that her daughter is okay, Adora decides that it's time to stop worrying and throw herself into the party.

If Catra comes, she comes. If not….well….

That's her decision.

And right now, she's making her own decision to mingle with her friends. She spots Perfuma, Bow, and Glimmer still grouped up and thinks that she'll head over there. Getting up from the couch, she makes her way over to a trash can over by the snack table to throw away her plate and empty cup. Making a quick stop by one of the coolers to snag a beer, she turns back around to head over.

A voice behind her stops her in her tracks.

"So I know you went to a school for rich kids but still...a party boat? Just how loaded are these people?"

Her heart stutters as she whips around to face Catra, standing there dressed in slim black jeans and a red, shoulderless and cropped dress shirt. The twinkling lights shine off the silver hoop earrings adorning her ears, big enough to touch her shoulders. Her hair is pushed back by a grey bandana knotted at the front.

Adora grins and walks over to her, pulling her in for a hug. "You came."

"I said I would, didn't I? Making amends and all that." She pulls away from the hug and peeks over Adora's shoulder at the rest of the party-goers. "Speaking of which, where is the birthday girl? Figure I'd go ahead and give her my present now. Get it over with and everything."

Adora blinks. Well it seems like Catra's not wasting any time. Then again, that shouldn't really surprise her. She never has been the type to beat around the bush. "Um, yeah I was just talking to her

actually. But I can find her again. Just follow me." Looks like Bow, Perfuma, and Glimmer would have to wait.

Turns out that Mermista had found Sea Hawk after all. They're over by the DJ stand and it seems like Mermista is annoyed about something. If Adora had to place a bet, it might be on some of his music choices. She walks swiftly over to the couple, Catra in tow. Standing so close to the speakers means that she has to shout a little and she wonders if maybe they should move somewhere else for this conversation.

Mermista looks in their direction just as they're coming up to the table. Her eyes train immediately on Catra and Adora steps to the side to introduce everyone. "Mermista! This is Catra. Catra, these are my friends Mermista and Sea Hawk."

Catra gives her a look, brow raised as if to make some silent comment on the names, but she shakes her head. Not now.

Luckily, Catra gets the message clearly enough, putting aside any comments for later. She offers the two a smile, one that is only returned by Sea Hawk. Mermista, on the other hand, has her arms crossed over her chest, hip cocked to the side as she eyes Catra up and down, not even bothering to hide it.

Adora steps in again before things can get too tense. "Mermista, Catra has a present for you. And I think she wants to say something, too." She looks over at Sea Hawk, then back to Mermista. "Maybe somewhere quieter?"

Nodding, Mermista turns to Sea Hawk, leaning in to mutter something into his ear. He gives them all a thumbs up before scrolling further down the playlist on his laptop. Having dealt with that, Mermista gestures for them all to go over to where she and Mermista had been sitting and talking earlier.

Once again, Catra decides not to waste any time. As soon as they're out of earshot of most of the party-goers, she holds out an envelope to Mermista. "Mermista, right? Adora's told me about

you." She glances over to Adora who nods encouragingly. "And, uh, what you did for her. So I just wanted to say…." She takes a deep breath. "Thank you. For being there for her when I couldn't." She presses her lips together and shakes her head. "When I wouldn't be there for her. I know that I can't go back and fix things. And I guess I can't even be mad if you blow me off completely. But I figured if nothing else, I might try to make it up to in whatever way I can." Then she nods towards the envelope, a cue for Mermista to open it.

Eyeing Catra warily, Mermista does. Inside is a birthday card, pretty generic and - frankly - impersonal in nature, though that's a given considering the two women hardly know each other. When Mermista opens it up, however, something nearly falls out onto the ground. Catching it just in time, Mermista holds it up to study it more carefully, her brows raising in surprise.

"Adora told me that you spent an ungodly amount of money on ice cream after I called her that one night. Except I'm not really sure what kind of places you go to, or even what kind of ice cream you like, so I figured a gift card to one of the more popular places around here would work."

Mermista doesn't say anything. Meanwhile, Adora is off to the side panicking, wondering just what in the *hell* had possessed Catra to pull a stunt like this. She knows that Catra can be snarky, but she wonders if now is really the time for that. Something like this could just serve to piss Mermista off more. Adora's eyes drift around the boat, searching for life-preservers.

Then, surprisingly, Mermista cracks a smile. Albeit, a small one, but even that tiny gesture means that a disaster has just been averted. Adora breathes again, relieved she didn't have to perform an emergency rescue.

"Cute." Her smile grows into a full-on smirk. "Maybe you're not half bad, after all." Then she points the gift card at Catra, schooling her expression into something more serious. "But don't think this means you're off the hook yet."

Catra fires her own smirk back at Mermista, hands on her hips. "Wouldn't be fun otherwise."

Pleased (somehow?), Mermista nods at the two of them and mutters something about needing to check on Sea Hawk again.

"Help yourself to any drinks or food, Catra. I'll be seeing you again." And then she's gone, leaving one very shocked Adora and a smug Catra.

"Well, that went better than expected," Catra comments.

Adora turns to her, face incredulous. "Ya *think?*"

Catra shrugs, seeming unfazed by how close of a situation that had the potential to be. "Figured she might've decked me or something." She turns to Adora with a smile. "So, drinks?"

Adora shakes her head and rolls her eyes to the heavens. "You're incorrigible."

"And you can insult me with more big words on the way to the snack table. Let's go."

The party goes pretty smoothly after that. Well, as smoothly as a party can go when Sea Hawk's the one who organized it.

After Catra stocked up on a plate of food and a drink, they begin to make their rounds to talk to all of Adora's friends. Though she had already met Glimmer and Bow the week before, they still make sure to greet them. Bow, of course, is enthused to see her and is even granted a high-five. Glimmer is...less so, but at least she's cordial.

Perfuma, who has yet to meet Catra, is over-the-top with her own enthusiasm. "So you're the wonderful friend that Adora's been telling us all about."

Catra shrugs, snacking on some cubes of cheese. "Seems like my name is in a lot of mouths recently, yeah." She gives Adora a dirty look when she's elbowed in the side.

Of course, however, Perfuma doesn't seem fazed by Catra's abrasiveness. "You're also *much* more beautiful than I had imagined."

At this, Catra flushes and begins fidgeting with her plate. Adora quirks an eyebrow at Perfuma, wondering exactly where *that* had come from. Then again, it's not like it's totally unusual for her. Perfuma often says what's on her mind. Not in a malicious sense, but more in a way that she doesn't ever feel the need to hold back compliments.

"If everyone would share the positive thoughts they have about others more often, the world would be a much brighter place," she had once said.

Even still, the compliment has Catra unsure what to do with herself. But there's no use in asking Perfuma to tone it down; it would go against every part of her nature.

And of course, she doesn't stop there. "You also have a *magnificent* aura. It's fiery, but passionate."

Catra blinks and casts a questioning look at Adora who shrugs and mouths "Just go with it".

"Um...thanks? I guess."

Perfuma, once again oblivious now that she's on a roll, tilts her head and clasps her hands in front of her. "Are you an artist?"

"Let me guess. Adora told you?"

Perfuma giggles and shakes her head. "No. You just have a very creative spirit. I can tell. What kind of work do you do?"

Catra shrugs. "Freelance, mostly. Illustrations and stuff like that."

Perfuma's eyes light up at that and she claps her hands together. "Do you do logos and things like that?"

"Sometimes, yeah. Why?"

That just adds to Perfuma's excitement. "Oh! Well, you see, I own a yoga studio and I've recently been contemplating on doing some rebranding to try and bring in more people. Adora's already agreed to help me with some of the marketing aspects, but I was actually in the process of looking for someone to help me redesign some of the more visual and artistic aspects."

Catra rubs the back of her neck. "I mean, I don't know-"

Perfuma holds her hands up, halting Catra's thoughts. "Of course, I fully understand I would be taking up your precious time, so I'm willing to pay for it. If you'd like, maybe we could even start with a consultation? Which I am also willing to pay you for."

Catra smirks and nods, holding out her hand to Perfuma. "Sounds like we might be in business then."

Instead of shaking it, as Catra is expecting, Perfuma takes Catra's hand in both of hers. "You are *truly* a wonderful soul! Do you have some way for me to contact you to discuss details at a later date?"

Catra points her thumb over her shoulder. "I actually have some business cards in my jacket. Let me go to where I parked my bike and I could give you one."

Perfuma nods eagerly. "That would be lovely!"

Walking over to Adora, Catra holds out her drink and plate. "Hold these for me until I get back?"

"Yeah, of course." Then Catra's running off the boat and up the docks to the adjacent parking lot.

"I can see what you see in her."

Adora blinks and turns back to see Perfuma grinning at her. She groans and rolls her eyes. "Not you too, Perfuma."

"There's nothing to be ashamed about, Adora! She's a very beautiful and attractive woman!" Adora groans again, wanting anything to get out of this conversation. One of Sea Hawk's infamous fires would be welcomed at this point. "In fact, if you weren't so clearly interested in her, I might-"

Adora's eyes bug out and she whips her head back to give Perfuma a stern stare, coupled with a pointed finger. "*No!* No hitting on my friend!"

Perfuma giggles and holds up her hands to show she means no harm. "It's alright, Adora. Catra's very handsome, but I wouldn't disrespect you or our friendship by doing something like that." She holds up a finger, like a warning. "But don't take too long. Any person out there would be all too quick to snatch someone like her up."

Adora deflates, biting her lip. She's all too aware of that fact. Had seen it happen right before her eyes on multiple occasions. "It's not like that, Perfuma." Not anymore, at least.

Perfuma hums. "Then I guess you don't have anything to worry about."

At that moment, Catra returns, a little breathless but otherwise looking as perfect as she did before she left. She offers Perfuma one of her business cards, who thanks her in kind with promises to be in touch, and then Adora makes the executive decision to drag Catra elsewhere.

"There's still people I want you to meet," she explains when Catra gives her a questioning look. She doesn't bother mentioning her and Perfuma's conversation. It's not relevant.

Next they run into Frosta and Mara. Or rather, Mara runs into them with Frosta not too far behind. Gunning straight for Catra, Mara barrels into her legs, nearly knocking her over.

"Cashra! Cashra, you're here!"

Catra chuckles, shooing off Adora who's gearing up to reprimand Mara for just knocking into people like that. "What's up, little tyke? How ya been?"

"I learned how to do a cartwheel! Wanna see?"

"Do I?"

Adora reaches out as Mara moves away from Catra and raises her hands above her head. "Wait, Sweetie, you're wearing a dress!"

Not hearing, or perhaps just ignoring, her mother's warning, Mara rolls herself into a cartwheel. Or a half-wheel. Her feet don't quite go as high as they should to make it a full cartwheel, but by the time she's landed on her feet, posing with her hands high above her head with all the pride she can muster in her small little body, no one would *dare* try to critique her form.

"Whoa! That was pretty cool! Maybe if you keep practicing, one day you could be a gymnast."

At this Mara crosses her arms and pouts. "Mommy says I'm not allowed to do 'nastics."

"Is that so?" Curious, she turns to Adora.

Adora gives her a look. "You are aware that I was friends with you in high school when you were on the gymnastics team, yeah?"

Catra gasps and points at her. "You mean that dorky little blonde with those crummy handmade signs that showed up to all my meets was *you*?"

"I was thinking more along the lines of the panicked best friend who saw you carted away in an ambulance when you slipped off the bars and broke your arm."

Unconcerned, Catra shrugs her off. "Hey, I lived, didn't I?"

"*So* not the point."

Having been quiet this whole time, Frosta picks that moment to intervene. "Hey, Adora? Who's this?"

"Oh!" Adora faces Frosta and quickly puts on a smile. "Sorry about that, Frosta. This is my friend, Catra. We've been best friends since we were kids." She turns to Catra next. "Catra, this is Frosta, Glimmer's cousin. She babysits Mara for me sometimes, but she's mostly busy with college right now."

Catra nods in Frosta's direction. "Freshman?"

"Yup."

"Been to any sick parties yet?"

Frosta turns to Adora with a laugh. "Wow. You guys really are best friends."

Unhappy with being ignored, Mara starts jumping up and down. "Cashra! Dance! Dance wit' me!"

"Mara, sweetie, Mommy was going to take Catra to see some more of her friends."

Mara pouts again and stamps her foot. "Bu' I wanna dance with Cashra! You got to! It's my turn!"

Before Adora can argue further, Catra hands off her drink for Adora to hold. "It's fine, Adora. We'll be back in about one song. I'll catch up, okay?" Then Mara's dragging her off to the dance floor, leaving Frosta and Adora behind.

"Catra's pretty cool," Frosta says once they're out of earshot. "How come I haven't met her before?"

Adora sighs, wondering if it's worth getting into at this point. "It's...complicated."

Rolling her eyes, Frosta puts one of her hands on her hip. "I'm eighteen years old and you guys *still* treat me like a kid sometimes."

Adora chuckles and pats her shoulder. "Well, you kind of are. But I get what you're saying." She leans against the table they're standing near. "But it's not like that. To be honest, I don't even know if the whole situation makes sense to me."

Frosta clicks her tongue against her teeth and purses her lips. "Well that doesn't sound fun."

Adora chuckles again. "It's not." She bites the inside of her cheek. That might not be entirely true, though. She's happy to have Catra back in her life. Already in just the two months since they've reunited, she feels much happier. Getting your best friend back can do that to a person.

The part where it gets really confusing and complicated are all the unresolved feelings and unspoken things between them. Things from their past. Things that Adora doesn't know how to talk about yet. Secrets she's keeping. Things she's afraid to bring up.

And of course, her biggest secret of all: the identity of Mara's father and what exactly happened between them.

From years of knowing her, Adora knows that Catra isn't huge on gossip or anything like that. She never really followed tabloids dishing out celebrities' secret lives, didn't care who had slept with who in high school, had no interest in the lives of her neighbors. She liked to keep to herself mostly, save for Adora. She had always been good at minding her own business.

And it's not like she thinks telling Catra who Mara's father is will even be that big of a deal to her. Truthfully, she doubts that Catra will care or even know who it is. Which, theoretically, should make it easier to tell her, right?

If only it really was that simple.

If only *any* of this was simple.

As if Frosta could somehow hear her thoughts, she pats Adora's arm. "I'm sure you'll figure it out."

Adora blows out air and takes a sip of her own drink. "I sure hope so, kid. I sure fucking hope so."

The next, and last, person that Catra meets is Sea Hawk. And it goes...well it goes just about how you imagine it would.

A few of them are standing in a circle. Perfuma and Mermista have run off somewhere with Frosta and Mara for the time being, leaving her, Adora, Adam, Glimmer, and Bow.

"So I heard you're the captain of this boat?" Catra asks jokingly. Except, as everyone but her knows, Sea Hawk takes it one-hundred percent seriously.

"Ah, she's a beaut', ain't she?" Sea Hawk looks out fondly at the expanse of the boat, a loving look they normally only see directed at Mermista. "Bought her earlier this year after I tragically lost my last one."

"Um...do I wanna know?"

"No," Glimmer deadpans.

"Alas! *The Dragon's Daughter Three* went down in flames!" Sea Hawk cried out, placing his arm over his eyes for added flair.

"I'm sorry....*three*?"

Sea Hawk nods. "Yes, named after *The Dragon's Daughter One* and *Two*."

One look at Catra's face and she already knows that she's fed up with him. She jumps in, trying to save the situation somewhat.

"He was able to afford the others from the insurance payout."

"What kind of insurance company lets this guy keep buying boats?"

Adam laughs. "Hell, if we knew that I'd have about four boats myself."

The explanation helps, though Adora does notice that Catra's disgust has only somewhat alleviated. So she tries changing topics altogether.

Bow beats her to it. "By the way, Adora, how did yesterday go?"

She groans and flops onto the table, held up by her arms. "I'm *still* sore."

Adam perks up. "Sore? What from?" The question is directed at Catra who scowls at him in turn.

"Shove it. I taught her some choreography at the dance studio yesterday."

"Choreography?" He laughs. "Is that what the kids are calling it now?"

Adora wants to hit him. She really does. Thankfully, Catra and her snark comes to the rescue and saves him from gaining a new welt on his head. "Why? Haven't done some 'choreography' yourself lately?"

Adora laughs at the priceless look of annoyance on his face while Catra stands there smugly. And, surprising no one, Sea Hawk is left totally out of the loop.

"I'm...not sure what's going on here. Did I miss something? Were we talking about-"

"Dancing," Catra cuts off. "I teach dance classes. That's what we're talking about."

"Oh! How dashing! Would you care to demonstrate?"

Catra shuffles her feet, clearly unsure how to feel about being put on the spot like that. Unfortunately, it seems that Sea Hawk's requests has garnered some attention from the rest of the group, who now all look eager to see Catra show off. Adora turns to her, trying to be a beacon, assuring and comforting.

"I mean, if anything, you could show them one of the dances you showed me yesterday. Those were really cool." She moves one of her arms from underneath her to reach out and place a hand on Catra's arm. "Or you don't have to at all, if you'd rather."

"Naw, c'mon Catfish! Flaunt them sick dance moves!" Adam hollers, trying (and failing horribly) to snap in a Z-formation.

Catra points at him. "I will dance...if you promise to never do that again."

Adam gives her a two-fingered salute. "Roger that."

Then she turns to Sea Hawk. "You know how to work the sound system, right? I need to hook my phone up to it."

And...wow. She's actually going through with it. Adora couldn't lie; she's a little excited to see Catra in action again. Yesterday she got to see it up close and personal, which was a treat in and of itself, but having another chance to see it so soon? Well, she certainly isn't complaining.

Sea Hawk follows Catra over to the DJ table (which honestly is just two speakers hooked up to his laptop) to help her set up. The rest of them follow at a bit more of a distance, preparing for a show. Out of everyone there, the only two who have been witness to Catra's skills are herself and Bow. Even still, she notices that Bow is just as eager to see what Catra decides to do.

Meanwhile, Adora spends her time wondering which of the dances she'll decide to do. The one that Catra taught her and spent hours practicing together? Or the one she'll be debuting at a workshop

in the next week? Either one would be great to witness, in all fairness, but she'll admit she might be more partial to the latter given that she's a little sick of the first song after hearing it repeatedly the day before.

By this point, Perfuma, Mermista, Frosta, and Mara were returning from wherever they had run off to.

"What's going on?" Mermista asks.

"Catra's about to show us some dance choreography. She teaches workshops at the dance studio that I go to sometimes," Bow explains.

"Dance! Dance wit' Cashra!" Mara chimes in. Adora scoops her daughter up and holds her up.

"Not right now, baby girl. Cashra's gonna show us some dance moves she's been practicing first, okay?"

"Mmmmmm...but I wanna practice too."

"Later, Mara. I promise." She kisses Mara's temple. "For now, how about we watch Cashra dance like she watched you do a cartwheel?"

They all quiet to a hush when Catra steps away from the table to take her place on the dance floor. If she's affected by the arrival of new audience members, she doesn't say anything. Instead, she begins the process of shaking out her limbs right before motioning to Sea Hawk to start up the music.

After pressing the play button, the music begins to blast from the speakers. As soon as it does, Catra closes in around herself, wrapping her arms around herself and holding her head down. A couple of seconds later, the singer comes in, and Catra explodes into life and movement. Her head whips up and and her arms awaken at the same time before flying out. She bends her knees, dropping her body while her hands move in a slow circular

motion, then springs back up while waving her arms out in front of her.

Well this is certainly...different. And not just because it's choreography that Adora hasn't seen, but from the dances that she'd seen Catra perform yesterday, the mood is just entirely different. The first dance, the one they had done together, was upbeat and exorbitant, bouncing and rocking and having fun with the beat. The next one that Catra had showed her was aggressive, intimidating, and harsh in its movements.

This one, unlike the other two, had a more sensual feel to it. Her movements flow from one to the next with ease, matching the melody rather than the background beats. They're slower, gentler, taking the time to capture her audience's attention with each motion, pulling their eyes from one motion to the next, one moving body part to another, one focal point here and following to the one after.

Her body rolls with the vocals, enticing, enrapturing, grabbing her viewers and yanking them in, trapping them in her flow.

She makes use of the entire dance floor, not moving just from side-to-side or back to front, but in every direction, leaving no part of the floor untouched by her feathery feet. Her hair whips around her face as she jerks her head and spins around, her curls bouncing in the string lights lining the boat. The lyrics reflect her aura, her essence as she commands all attention to be focused on her, demands their unwavering loyalty to be slaves to her circling hips and flights across the dance floor. She's casting a spell, drawing the circle with her body and chanting the ritualistic words with her eyes.

It's over far too soon.

Everyone around Adora is clapping, including Mara who's happily bouncing in her arms. Because she's holding her daughter, she can't clap herself, but when Catra's gaze drifts to her, chest heaving for air, she offers the largest grin that she can physically

manage. Their bond is broken when all of Adora's friends begin to group around her, cheering her on and lavishing her with praises. But even amongst the sudden chaos, she still catches Catra's eyes every now and again, and sees how full and vibrant they are.

Her heart stutters and she wonders when the spell will wear off.

"I'm a little jealous, you know."

Catra rolls her head to look at Adora, swirling the last remaining dregs of her wine cooler at the bottom of the bottle. "Huh?"

Adora's facing her fully on the couch, using the back rest to lay her elbow on so she can prop her head up. "Of you. I'm kind of jealous."

The party has mostly died down by this point. All of Mermista's co-workers have long since gone home. After that left Bow and Perfuma to go back to their shared apartment (Bow had been lamenting about some paper revisions he needed to do for his thesis in time for a meeting with one of his advisors on Monday). A little bit after that, Glimmer and Adam had called it a night and took Frosta with them to drop her back off at her dorm on campus. Soon enough, it was just Sea Hawk, Mermista, Catra, Mara, and herself left. Sea Hawk and Mermista had disappeared somewhere below deck not too long after Glimmer and Adam had vanished, probably doing exactly what Adora would imagine on Mermista's birthday party night. They were staying on the boat for the night, but assured Catra and Adora that they were fine to stay as long as they wanted.

For now, the two women are just conversing on the couch, nursing the remnants of their drinks while Mara sleeps away on the couch right in-between them.

"I mean, of course you should be. But I'd love to hear you elaborate more. Fuel my ego."

Adora chuckles and pulls on her hair, which she had let down not too long ago. "I dunno. I guess...it just feels like you really have your life together."

Catra tilts her head and picks her foot up, resting it on the couch so she can lean against her knee. "And what exactly gave you that idea?"

"Well," she starts ticking off her fingers, "You're a successful freelance artist, which is a profession that most people can't make work for them. You teach hip-hop dance classes as a side hobby, even though you're good enough to open your own studio and charge whatever you want. You have an apartment to yourself and the freedom to do what you want, whenever you want. You have jobs that you love, ones that you actually wanted and worked towards all your college career." She sighs. "I wish I was as lucky, I guess."

Catra was nodding along as she went down her list, but as soon as she's finished she playfully shoves her shoulder. "Hey. Don't sell yourself short. You've got a lot going on for you too. You basically have your own apartment too, sans the kid. You have a pretty swanky job at a high profile tech company. And, craziest of all, you're a single mother to a toddler. And you still manage to have free time to spend with all your friends and keep fit. You're like, Superwoman or something."

Adora snorts and rolls her eyes. "You mean the job where I sit behind a desk all day catering to men who think my only skill set is to bring them coffee? Yeah I'm living the dream."

"Well, you still do some marketing stuff on the side, don't you? It's not sports marketing sure, but you told me how you manage your dad's website. Even Perfuma said she wants your help marketing her yoga studio." She rests her head against her knee. "Something it's the small things that can get you started."

"Yeah, well," she sighs, "The small things don't pay the bills or for daycare or food or anything like that. I need a stable job, but one

where I'm not treated some some kind of magical coat rack that provides coffee and takes phone calls." She frowns shifting uncomfortably in her seat. "And has to listen to the most degrading sexual comments from the men around the office."

Catra lifts her head up and leans forward. "What? Adora, have you told anyone at your job about this?"

She shrugs and attempts to wave off Catra's concerns. "Most of it's minor, so I don't really want to make a big deal out of it. Besides, there's only but so many women in the office. They'd figure out who it is soon enough by process of elimination, and I can't risk something like that affecting my job."

"Those men's grossness is already affecting your job!" Now Catra is sitting up fully and facing her completely. "Do you know what I do when I get disgusting clients who decide they can't resist the urge to make some gross comment towards me?"

Adora blinks, waiting for her answer.

"I walk away! I don't accept the job offer because no amount of money is worth having to put up with that shit."

"I don't have that luxury, Catra. If I lose my job I won't have any way to provide for Mara." Twisting her hair around her finger, she looks down at the little girl in question. "For her, I'd endure anything."

"But you shouldn't *have* to."

"Sometimes things just don't work out that way." She raises her head to look up at Catra, who is looking more and more distraught the more dismissive Adora is. "I appreciate your concern, Catra, and I see your point, but...it's just not an option right now."

"What would you do if it was Mara in your shoes right now?"

"Ex....excuse me?"

Catra crosses her arms and stares her down. "If Mara had a job, like you have right now, and was the victim of endless sexual harassment, what would you say?"

Adora frowns. "Well, that's not fair…"

"So why are you putting up with it?"

It just...isn't that simple.

Of course she would be upset - outraged, even - if Mara had to put up with half the shit she does on a daily basis. And she hopes and prays that will never be the case by the time Mara's grown and out on her own. But the reality of the situation is that she just doesn't have the options to be reckless about this. Finding a new job that still pays around the same so her and Mara can live comfortably is next to impossible given that she doesn't have any actual experience in her field. The most she can hope for is another secretary job which will more than likely have the same shit, just different names and faces. At least here she has better job security, if only somewhat.

And like she had just told Catra, if she tries to do something about the situation at her current job, there's a high chance that they'll figure out that she's the one who filed the reports and will make her life there an even worse living hell.

"It's...complicated, Catra." She bites her lip. "Some things are just out of our control, you know?"

"Is it that it's out of your control? Or are you just too scared to do anything about it?"

She can tell that Catra's trying to get some kind of rise out of her. But of course, she's about to disappoint, because she's already mostly resigned herself to her current situation, learning that it's better to accept it and adapt than to be constantly upset over it.

"Maybe I am," she says with a small smile. "But when you have a kid to take care of and worry about, you're more scared to do a

lot of things."

Only then does Catra finally back down. Possibly because this is the one thing she can't argue with her on, not being able to understand without kids of her own. "I guess." Then she snaps her head back up, narrowing her eyes. "But don't think this conversation is over. We'll be revisiting this at a later date."

"If you're that worked up over it, then sure." She spares another glance down, seeing Mara restlessly obliviously to what's going on around her. "For now though, I think I should get Mara home. It's getting late."

"Yeah." Catra nods and stands up. "Here, I'll walk the both of you to your car."

Adora smiles as she scoops Mara into her arms, resting her head against her shoulder. "Thank you."

They leave the boat, not bothering with checking out with Sea Hawk and Mermista in order to not disturb them. The walk from the docks to the docks is short and silent, and soon enough they're standing next to Adora's car, Catra watching over her as she buckles Mara into her carseat. Once Mara's settled in and the car door is shut, Adora turns to Catra. "Thank you again."

"Of course. Anytime."

Adora smiles and gestures back to the boat. "You know, that whole thing went surprisingly well. Real bold move with the gift card, by the way."

Catra shrugs and shoves her hands into her jean pockets. "Eh. I mean, I already said that I don't really know her that well apart from what you've told me about her. So I didn't exactly have much to work with."

"Well, it worked...somehow. And she seemed pretty cool with you afterwards. Well, by Mermista's standards, at least."

"I'm just glad that she's the only one I had to apologize to. I mean, can you imagine if I had to apologize to *Glitter*?" Adora considers correcting her, but realizes she's doing it on purpose so it would be wasted breath.

Instead she says, "Like I told you, I made her keep it a secret from everyone else. And Mermista is, if nothing else, fiercely loyal. I knew she'd respect my wishes."

Catra hums and hunches her shoulders against the breeze from the water, squinting at something in the distance. "Speaking of...can I ask why? Why you didn't want any of your other friends to know about what happened between us? I mean, wouldn't the extra support and number of people hating my guts have helped?"

Adora frowns and leans against her car. "Catra, I…" She tries to consider her next words, figuring out what she wants to say. "I didn't want my friends to hate you. You hurt me," she notices Catra flinch and tries to keep moving quickly, "but turning my friends against you wouldn't have made me feel any better about it. Especially because whatever it is that caused you to push me away…." She looks down at her feet, wrapping her arms around her upper body to protect herself against most of the chill. "I felt like it was my fault somehow. So I didn't want them to blame just you."

It's silent between them for a moment, with only the sound of the breeze whisking past them and the quiet lap of water against the docks. Then, "Adora." She doesn't respond. "Adora, look at me."

When she doesn't raise her head immediately, she feels two warm hands encompass her face and gently raise it up so that she's looking into mismatched eyes. The hands are holding her firmly in place, keeping their gazes locked, and Adora can feel a tension building in her chest but somehow relaxing all the muscles in her body at the same time.

"None of it was your fault. I told you that I was going through some shit at the time. Shit that was *way* out of your control." She

pauses, allowing that to sink in.

Adora decides to try again, to take responsibility where she can. "Sure, but...I probably wasn't helping you any either. Especially if you felt the need to cut me out instead of coming to talk to me about it." She tries to drop her gaze again, but Catra's hold on her is steady.

"*Adora*." She shivers but chalks it up to the sudden gust that blows through them. "*None* of it was your fault. Okay?" She feels Catra's thumbs gently stroking her cheeks, eyes locked into hers, and she feels her heart stutter again, the spell still refusing to release its vice grip.

"*Are you sure you're ready for this?"*

They'd sat like this then too.

"*Feel free to stop me at any time you get uncomfortable."*

Just like now, she could remember the gentle sounds of the water from the pool lapping against the stone walls, the pool chair they shared digging into her thighs. The night had been hazy with nerves and alcohol.

She had smelled like rum and mangoes, her skin shining in the dim pool lights.

"*And remember: don't fall in love with me after this*," she had joked, unaware, ignorant to the irony of her statement. Dumb to the truth it already held.

She raises a hand to lay over one of Catra's and gives it a light squeeze. "Okay," she whispers, too caught up in the memories, too in danger to speak any louder. These feelings...they were simply residual. They weren't real.

The past was in the past.

And things just aren't as simple anymore.

Maybe they never were.

Chapter End Notes

Man this quarantine has really empowered/enabled me to write. So here's another chapter, my longest yet for this fic, to tide you over since we just got 30 more days inside (Thanks Obama)

I dunno if I'm gonna do these quick turnarounds for the entire duration of the quarantine, but I might be able to churn out a few more chapters, for sure. The only reason this one came out so quickly is because I was really excited about this one, if only because I've been thinking about the moment at the end of the chapter for FOREVER.

As a reminder, I'm still accepting questions for my video. In fact, I'll be accepting them right up until I film it (though I don't know exactly when that'll be). So keep sending your questions through the comments, my twitter, or my tumblr (both listed on my ao3 profile page). I'm hoping to film that sometime within the next few days and have the video up next....week? Idk. Fingers crossed.

Other notes! No art to link because I wrote this chapter so quickly lol, but I do have choreography videos!!!

The dance that Catra teaches Adora

The second dance that Catra does for Adora in the studio

The dance that Catra performs at Mermista's birthday party

I also have a link to buy the shirt Catra was wearing at the beginning of the chapter!! I found it randomly and though it fit her perfectly, but if y'all liked it, you can totally get your own apparently lol

Also, random note. So my bf kept checking on me while I was writing this and was baffled when I had reached a point of 9k words. So he asked how long this fic in total was, I told him 75k words. (Btw, apparently this fic is longer than the average novel? WOW)

Anyways, he told me that once I reach 100k words, he'll give me $10. So you all are now my witnesses. Once I hit that goal, I'm getting $10. And I need y'all to back me up if he tries to back out. 'Cause I'm getting my damn $10

As always, I super appreciate you guys and look forward to your comments. They're honestly what keeps me writing most days <3

Until next time~! Stay safe, stay healthy, be smart and practice social distancing. Love y'all

lookin' pretty by candlelight

Chapter Summary

Kyle plans a kidnapping, Adora bakes now (?), and Catra is a grandma/mom/aunt?

Well at least there's cake.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Something on your mind?"

Catra jumps, relaxing only when she realizes she recognizes the voice and quickly schools her expression into something more neutral. Turning away from the sound system she's been fiddling with for the past fifteen minutes or so, she sees Rogelio with his arms crossed. The smirk on his lips tells her he absolutely noticed that he caught her off guard.

She decides to push it anyway. "Nothin' in particular. Why you ask?"

He rolls his eyes at her. "You've been pretty quiet since you came in. Kyle told me you didn't even insult him when you passed by the desk."

She shrugs and leans against the cart holding the sound system. "With that new buzzcut? Too easy."

"You also didn't even notice me coming from behind." He cracks a smile and nudges her shoulder with his knuckles. "I mean, I know your birthday's in a couple days but don't go all abuela on me now."

His laughter is cut off when she returns his gesture in kind, but harder and straight to the middle of his chest. "Yeah, laugh now

before this *abuela* decides to smack you upside the head with one of her *chanclas*." She smirks through the thinly-veiled (if somewhat serious) threat and he joins in, the air becoming lighter with their banter.

"Better than a wooden spoon, I guess." All jovial quips aside, he looks at her seriously, fixing her with an almost concerned gaze. It makes her squirm and she half-turns back to the sound system, eyes moving in the pretense that she's checking over everything. "Seriously though, everythin' okay? You've been kinda...off? Dunno if that's the right word."

Well...she supposes she can't keep him in the dark forever. In about twenty minutes time he's going to find out anyway. Catra might as well give him a heads up.

Scratching at her temple and turning to him, keeping her eyes averted from his, she tries a blasé approach first. "Hey, uh, remember last week when I mentioned to you that I invited someone to our class today?"

Rogelio's brows raise and he takes a step back, nodding along. "Yeah. I distinctly remember you never mentioning that whatsoever."

Crap. "Ya sure? I must've said it about a thousand times."

"Run it by me again. My memory must not be what it used to be then."

Catra snorts and crosses her arms, cocking her hip to the side and gives him a sly look. "Now who's the old one?"

His expression is less than amused.

Realizing her tactics are failing monumentally, she groans and throws her head back, finally straightening up and facing him head-on. "Okay, okay. Fine! I invited someone to come watch our class today."

"And you're just now mentioning this to me?" His eyes flick over to the digital clock on the wall above the mirrors then back to her. "Not even half an hour before class starts?"

She gives a haphazard shrug. "Must've slipped my mind." When he hums at her in an almost disapproving tone, she caves. "Look, I figured it wouldn't be an issue. You'll barely even notice she's here and-"

"'She'?" His brow furrows and he leans forward to jab at her shoulder again, ignoring the growl that crawls out of her throat. "Catra, for the love of all that is Holy, do *not* tell me you invited one of your damn trysts to my dance studio."

"What?" Her voice is pitched, embarrassingly so, and she clears her throat before speaking again. "No! For fuck's sake, Rogelio, I'm not trying to show off! How big do you think my ego is?" The look he gives her has her cutting him off before he can even think to speak. "Nevermind. But I swear, it's nothing like that. In fact...she's the one who asked if she could come." A blatant lie. But she can't stand the way he's looking at her. As if she's some dumb high school jock doing a keg stand to impress some tipsy floozy across the room in hopes of it getting him laid.

"Well, if it's not some hook-up, then who is it?" The golden question.

She smirks, already anticipating his reaction. "Remember Adora?"

It takes a second longer than she had figured it would, but eventually the pieces click and a dawning mixture of recognition and shock falls over his face. Then again, she can't be awfully surprised either. Rogelio was a part of their little ragtag group back in the days, but he'd been quieter then, to an almost intimidating extent, and he and Adora hadn't really talked much one-on-one. Truthfully, out of all of them, Kyle was the one that seemed to worm his way underneath Rogelio's thick shell, slipping through the cracks and softening him up.

It didn't surprise her in the slightest when she reconnected with them to find out they'd started dating mid-way through college.

"From high school?" asks Rogelio. "No fuckin' way. What's she up to these days?"

Catra hums and swivels on her heel to start messing with the sound system again, actually focusing on her task this time. "Ask her yourself when she gets here."

Their conversation stops there because some of their students are beginning to file into the studio, flocking in chattering groups decked out in a myriad of sweats, leggings, and other choice dancing outfits. Rogelio walks over to greet them while Catra finishes up adjusting the speaker.

With every face that passes through the doorway, Catra glances over eagerly, only to look away again when she fails to place a familiar mop of blonde paired with baby blue eyes. Hooking her phone up to the sound system and flicking to the playlist for today, she presses shuffle to have some music filter through the atmosphere as everyone arrives. Adora still isn't there, though she can't say she's terribly surprised if she is, in fact, bringing Mara with her. The kid was spunky, and a bit hard-headed, not too unlike her mother. Getting her out of the house was sure to be a nightmare.

Joining Rogelio in a conversation with a couple of their students, a pair of high school siblings, she hangs back for the most part, checking in and out of the conversation as she continues to watch the door sparingly. Factoring Mara in aside, if Adora doesn't show up soon, they might not even have a chance to talk before Catra has to go into teacher mode. It wouldn't be the worst thing, but she sort of wants to revel in Rogelio's stunned expression when he finds out…

"Rogelio!" Kyle's voice chimes from the doorway. Both Catra and Rogelio look over to him, Rogelio with his brows raised and Catra rolling her eyes (good-naturedly though) to see him peeking his

head past the door frame. His eyes are shining, a large dopey grin splitting his face in half and he begins frantically gesturing for Rogelio to come to him. "Rogelio, oh my gosh! You'll never guess who's here!"

Catra's heart stutters and she feels a sharp, heavy pang in her stomach, fluttering and exploding, and she knows that this is the moment she had been waiting for. She looks over to Rogelio who's looking back at her and smirks at the smug grin he's giving her, as if he thinks he has some kind of an upper-hand. He really doesn't know what's about to hit him, does he?

They excuse themselves from the two high schoolers before heading out to the hallway, Catra lagging behind Rogelio's lumbering form, the anticipation growing until it's choking her.

"Kyle, it's okay. Catra already-" He stops. Catra nearly runs into him but manages to stop herself just in time, instead using her momentum to swerve around him and off to the side.

Adora's standing next to Kyle, a nervous smile painted on her lips when her and Rogelio's eyes meet. Her gaze falters for a second, to look at Catra, who meets her gaze with a warm smile. It seems to fill her with some confidence, if just a smidge, and she readjusts Mara in her arms, propping her higher up on her hip. Her gaze focuses back on Rogelio, who's still standing stock-still, mouth almost gaping at the sight of them.

The whole thing is a beautiful kind of hilarious.

"Hey, Rogelio. It's been awhile, huh?" Adora finally says, breaking the silence.

Like that, the spell is lifted and a large grin breaks across Rogelio's face. He steps forward and pulls her into a hug, which she can only return with one arm, given the other is occupied. "Adora! Damn-" His eyes flick over to Mara and he coughs, loudly. "Wow girl. Look at you! Barely recognized ya." Then he focuses his

attention on Mara again, smile growing softer. "And who's this pretty little thing?"

Adora bounces Mara on her hip, readjusting her higher again. "Rogelio, this is Mara." She bites her lip. "She's my daughter."

Kyle decides this is the time to jump in. "Isn't she just the cutest, Rogelio?" Without waiting for an answer, he begins fawning over Mara, who giggles at the attention.

Rogelio chuckles, watching his boyfriend play with Mara. "Wouldn't expect anything less with a mama like Adora." He turns to Adora next. "As much as I'd like to catch up some more, our class does start in five minutes, so we gotta start getting everyone ready."

"Right! Of course. I hope you don't think I'm barging in or anything. I figured it'd be alright since Catra offered to let us watch."

Shit.

When Rogelio turns to look at Catra, she makes sure to look away. "Nah, you're good fam. You can sit at the back of the studio 'til we're done." Then he claps a hand on Catra's shoulder, kind of hard actually, and starts leading her back into the studio. As he guides her along, he leans down, muttering into her ear.

"She asked you, was it?"

"Shut it."

The class goes by agonizingly slowly.

Normally, Catra loves heading workshops. It's a quick escape from the stress of life and work, full of difficult clients, bills, complicated booty calls, and...well just about everything really. When she first started attending hip hop workshops, begrudgingly at the suggestion of her therapist at the time, she thought the hour was

absolute torture. Not that she didn't love dancing, but with the heavy reminder sitting on her back as to *why* she was there, her bitterness tainted every second, every moment, every movement. She didn't talk to the other students, barely arrived on time, and left the exact second class let out. Letting go of her anger was difficult, not only because it was a complicated process, but because she didn't *want* to let go of it. At the time, she still felt she was in the right to hold onto it, letting it fuel her and devoting her energy to fueling it in kind.

She thought of the dance classes as some kind of joke. Like when suburban moms suggest yoga as a cure to depression, or Smiling Sallys that thought their cookie cutter instagram posts with stock photos plastered with asinine quotes would be the end of all misery. It was annoying. It was degrading. Almost outright insulting.

She'd laughed at the idea initially, too. Dance her anger and problems away? Like she lived in some subpar fucking musical where the solution at the end was the power of friendship or the strength of formed bonds or some bullshit like that?

She'd been broken. Run down and beaten by a cruel universe. Forgotten and abandoned by her best friend, the one person she had let herself trust fully and unquestionably. Life wanted to throw her curveball after curveball, pelting her with high speed pitches and some lady with a jar of months-old jellybeans and a goddamn rolodex (like she was unaware or uncaring of the fact that this was the fucking 2000s) on her desk figured that the best combative technique to deal with that was...dancing?

"*The exercise is good for you. It helps alleviate anxiety and negative moods and gives a boost to your self-esteem and social withdrawal,"* she had explained.

Yeah right, Karen. Her life wasn't some production of Annie. Happiness wasn't a pop or lock away.

But she went nonetheless, if only to shut her up. Especially because when she didn't go, Shonda (yeah, okay, her name wasn't *actually* Karen but it was still funny calling her that) would go quiet and purse her lips together and start bombarding her with questions why that was. It grated on Catra's nerves, so she went every week, once a week, just to get the woman off her back.

A month or so went by and not much progress had been made. She had been lamenting about how it wasn't working and how the whole psycho-placebo shit was a farce when Shonda surprised her.

"*Then stop going*."

That had only served to piss her off even more. Why suggest something so stupid in the first place only to tell her not to go? What was the point of any of it? She'd walked out early that day, a whole half an hour before her session was actually supposed to end.

A few days later, she'd been sitting in her apartment, draped over the couch and watching some dumb shit on TV when her phone alarm went off, telling her it was time for class. Out of habit, she'd gotten up and dressed to go, before remembering that she no longer had to. She was finally free from the stupidity. No questions, no comments in any future sessions.

She was free to choose for herself.

Which is why it had been so odd when twenty minutes later, she was standing at the back of the dance studio, mirroring the movements of the instructor. Following their movements exactly, letting the music carry her away, away from all the stress of school and friends and family and all the other bullshit that plagued her every other moment.

Because when she was in the studio, she was mad. But not at any of that. She never even thought about any of it. The only thing

she'd actually been angry at was being forced to do something she didn't want to do.

By the end of her college career, she still hadn't made any lasting friendships from the class. But the one thing she did take away was something that could be solely hers, even if just for a short period of time, where she didn't have to think about anything except following the choreography and the burning of her lungs afterwards.

The first thing she looked for once moving after graduation was a nearby dance studio. And that's how she met up again with Kyle and Rogelio. A few classes and she was offered the opportunity to help teach some of the workshops.

She'd been doing it ever since.

And now, here she is, watching the students follow Rogelio's moves with vigilant eyes, slowly going through the motions. A normal thing for her at this point to the point of it being one of the most relaxing parts of her week.

Her eye catches Adora's eye in the back of the room, sees the warmth and pride in them. In her lap is a bouncing Mara, excitedly watching the class procession, occasionally reaching back to mumble something into Adora's neck while pulling on her side braid. And Adora will smooth a hand over her hair, whispering something back a kind and gentle smile on her face.

Suddenly Catra wishes to be anywhere *but* here.

After what feels like far longer than a standard hour, Rogelio dimisses everyone and they all slowly disperse, going to the walls to collect their belongings. A few hang around for a few minutes longer to talk to each other, some even heading over to speak with Rogelio. If any of them try to speak to Catra, she doesn't notice, because she's already crouching in front of Adora, smiling at the two girls.

"So?"

Adora lets out a breath of a laugh. "It's certainly different watching a class than a one-on-one session."

Mara jumps up at that time, hands raised above her head and hopping from one foot to the other. "Dance! Cashra dance!"

Catra smiles and ruffles her hair before resting her elbows on her raised knees. "Yeah, kiddo, I sure did. Whatcha think?"

"I wanna dance too! Show me! Show me!"

Adora steps in to explain. "She was telling me how she wants to take dance classes too."

Catra's brows raise. "Really?"

Adora only shrugs, as if to silently say "you know how kids are".

"Well, we don't really offer classes that young, unfortunately." Both women look up to see that Rogelio has walked over to them to join the conversation. "But we do start beginner classes around seven to eight years old. Maybe she could start there in a few more years."

Adora chuckles and reigns Mara back into her lap, practically impervious to how much she squirmed. "We'll see when the time comes. Who knows what she'll be into by then?"

Rogelio smiles and nods, chuckling lowly himself. "Fair enough. Well, if she is still interested by then, she's more than welcome to come here. Could even offer you a friends-and-family discount."

Adora's eyes widen and she immediately begins to shake her head. "No! I couldn't take that. I wouldn't mind paying full price."

"Nonsense, Adora. We've known each other forever."

"But-"

He points a warning finger in her direction. "Keep it up and she'll be dancing here for free."

That shuts her up. Catra laughs, earning her a glare from Adora and a curious look from Mara.

"Hey, Catra. Help me clean up and lock up real quick?" He looks back to Adora. "You can wait by the front desk with Kyle while we finish up here. We won't be long."

Adora smiles and begins to stand, gathering up Mara who protests rather loudly. "Yeah, no problem. I'll see you both in a minute then." Then she heads over to the door, tight grip on a shouting toddler who complains the whole way like it's nothing.

Once she's gone, Catra hops back onto her feet and heads over to the sound system to collect her phone and shut it off. Instead of going off to do his duty of sweeping the floor, Rogelio follows her.

"So first you lie about who asked who to watch the class *and* you lie about this not being some stunt to show off for another lady crush?"

Catra nearly drops her phone. She swivels so quickly she actually feels something in her neck pop, but ignores it in favor of sending daggers by way of a glare. "Rogelio...*don't*."

He raises his hands as a show of surrender, but presses on anyway. "Doesn't sound like a denial."

She groans and turns back to the sound system, angrily flicking the switches off. "Not you too, dude." Then she sighs and braces her hands on both sides of the cart, leaning on it heavily. "It's not like that, okay? We're just friends. And that's," she pushes herself off the cart to swivel around to face him, expression hard and stern, "how it's gonna *stay*."

Rogelio nods and finally walks off to grab the push broom to start sweeping the floor. "Yeah, probably for the best. Wouldn't want to be a homewrecker to someone with a tot, yeah?"

Admittedly, it takes her a second to realize what he's saying. "She's….it's not like that."

Rogelio pauses and shoots her a curious glance. Catra fidgets under the heat, wondering if it's even her place to say.

"The dad's not in the picture."

Rogelio blinks. Then nods slowly in understanding. "That's rough."

"Yeah."

He smirks at her through the tension laying in the air. "But it also means she's single."

Catra rolls her eyes and stomps over to her bag to drop her phone in there. "And I already said *it's not like that*."

Rogelio loudly scoffs, the sound echoing in the empty studio. He begins pushing the broom across the wood-paneled flooring. "C'mon, Catra. Everyone with eyes and a brain could see that you were stupid crazy for her in high school."

"And that was *high school*." She marches over to the opposite side of the room to pick up the regular broom and dust pan, standing off to the side while he finishes collecting the dust and dirt. "Years have passed. Things have changed."

"Not all things change with time." Having covered the whole floor, he shakes off the broom to release any dirt caught on the cloth. He walks past her to prop it back in its place, turning around just as she's finishing collecting the pile into the dust pan. "I mean, why'd you invite her here then?"

Catra shrugs and dumps the contents of the dust pan into the trash bin, tapping it against the side to shake loose any excess that got caught. "I just figured she might be interested. Friends do stuff like that all the time."

"You never invite Scorpia or Entrapta up here, though."

That...that's different.

She's not sure how though, and doesn't feel like trying to figure it out to explain, so she settles for shooting him another glare and depositing the broom back on the wall. "Hurry up or I'm locking you in here in the dark." It's a weak threat and they both know it.

Luckily, Rogelio knows when to quit. "Yeah, yeah. Just lemme grab my bag."

They both collect their things and leave the room, Catra hanging around as Rogelio shuts off all the lights and locks the door. As they descend the stairs to the reception area they exchange meaningless banter, thankfully avoiding any of the previous topics they'd been discussing. When they reach the front desk they see Adora and Kyle, the latter indulging Mara in conversation that consisted of nonsense mostly. Even still, he seemed fully engaged, listening to her intently as she rambled on about one thing and another, giving her the attention that kids that age craved so much.

As much as she likes to tease him for, well, just about *everything*, Catra has to admit that he's surprisingly good with kids. Then again, it's not that much of a stretch to imagine it, considering he's always been the odd kid out since they were younger. If anything, he probably knew what it felt like to be dismissed and ignored because he wasn't able to keep up with the rest of them most of the time. They were patient with him to an extent, but for the most part he was their punching bag for the worst insults and jabs, sometimes purposefully exploiting his naivety for their personal enjoyment. They never really treated him the best, though some of that could be attributed to the fact that they were teenagers who couldn't really be bothered to care at the time.

When Catra had reconnected with him and Rogelio, she had been a little surprised when he didn't hold any lingering resentment towards her. Granted, Kyle isn't the type of person to hold a grudge (if anything, her and Lonnie would fight for that title), but given all the horrible jokes they made at his expense and cruel

pranks they played on him, she was a little surprised to find that he hadn't minded most of it.

And sure, she still teases him and makes the occasional jabs (because old habits die hard and Catra never claimed to be perfect), but with growth and time they've lost the edge they used to hold. Now it's far more light-hearted, akin to the banter that her and Rogelio share save for the fact that Kyle rarely fires back like his boyfriend does. Even so, Catra would dare to say that it's still a balanced enough dynamic and it works for them.

Rogelio laughs and approaches his boyfriend, grabbing the back of his neck and shakes him lightly. "Careful Adora. Next time you blink Kyle might snatch your kid and run away with her."

Catra has a quip lined up already, her wit sharp and quick as ever, and opens her mouth to throw her own gentle teasing in there.

Adora beats her to it. "You really think this scrawny stick could outrun me?"

Rogelio laughs, a full-bellied one that reverberates in the mostly empty space and pats Kyle on the back. "There she is! You can take a girl out of Grayskull High School, but you can't take Grayskull out the girl." He lifts his foot to rest on the seat of one of the chairs in the main chill space, leaning against his raised knee with his elbows. "So seriously, what *have* you been up to? Besides poppin' a kid out, that is."

Adora grimaces at the word choice, as Catra had assumed she would because it *was* a little cringeworthy. "Well, I went to BMU, got a degree in Sports Marketing, but I'm currently working at Eternia Tech, going onto about four years now."

Rogelio gives a low, drawn-out whistle. "That big, fancy company? What they got you doin' over there?"

Adora gives a wry smile. "Fetching coffee."

He sucks in air between his teeth and Kyle frowns beside him. "Ouch, Mama. Four years you said?"

"Yep," says Adora, adding extra pop to the "p". "But I also do some freelance marketing stuff on the side. Mostly for my dad's construction business and the occasional friend. It's minor and definitely not what I'm specialized in, but work is work, you know?"

Rogelio hums and looks at her thoughtfully. "Interested in taking on another client?"

Adora's brows raise and she leans forward slightly, doing her best to remain somewhat reserved and not appear overeager. "You know someone?"

Then Rogelio cracks a grin and hooks his elbow around Kyle's neck, reeling him into his chest. "You're lookin' at 'em." At Adora's stunned expression, he elaborates. "Between the studio and the bar, me and Kyle do most of our media promotions and stuff. At first it was because we couldn't really afford to hire someone to do it for us, but now that we're in a stable enough place we could certainly use someone with a little more expertise."

Adora smiles and folds her hands in her lap. Catra notices the spark of intrigue in her eyes, but she's still holding herself back, her modesty stronger and more powerful than her excitement at new opportunities. "You guys don't have to do that, seriously! I'm fine."

Rogelio scratches the back of his neck and Kyle smiles nervously. "Yeah, well, we're not. I've hardly been able to bring in many new students and the bar's been kinda quieter than usual. We're still in safe territory right now, but unless we find some way to reach out to the public we could start dropping to the red zone. And between me coming up with choreo and Kyle handling the bar, we could use a lighter workload by having some manage our media and marketing." He shrugs and releases Kyle, dropping his foot to

standing at full height again. "It's no sports marketing job, but 'work is work', right?" he parrots her words.

Adora chews on her bottom lip, still seeming unsure. "I don't know. I'm still not sure if I'm best the best-"

"She'll do it."

They all turn to face Catra who's standing with her arms crossed, looking at Adora specifically. She seems shocked at Catra volunteering her up for the position, perhaps even a little miffed, but frankly she's a little tired of all this back-and-forth. She knows what Adora's capable of, even if she's never actually seen any of Adora's portfolio or work herself. If anyone can pick up a sputtering couple of businesses off the ground and turn them into something grand, it would be her best friend. She hopes the silent look she gives her conveys that, but it's impossible to tell with the impassive expression on Adora's face.

Rogelio decides to step in at that moment. "Well, you don't gotta make the decision now. Just thought we'd let you know we'd be interested in your help. Though, if it helps any, doing this would earn you that discount we talked about earlier."

Adora takes a second to look down at Mara, who during this whole conversation has decided to occupy herself by going through the contents of Adora's purse, singing quietly to herself. Nothing notable that Catra's ever heard, so probably something the girl is making up as she goes.

"I...yeah. Okay. I'll think about it."

"Great!" Rogelio readjusts his duffel on his shoulder. "Well, I hate to leave, but Kyle and I gotta go run some errands before setting up the bar to open tonight. Catra can give you our contact information for when you make up your mind. Speaking of, feel free to drop by the bar at any time. First round on the house."

"I…" Adora looks almost ready to argue again, but thinks better of it and settles for a small smile. "Yeah, I will. Thanks, you two."

Rogelio gives a one-shouldered shrug. "Eh. What're friends for?" He stretches his arms above her head, letting out a large breath. "A'ight, we're off then. Catra, you good to lock up?"

She waves him off. "Yeah, yeah. Right behind ya."

"Right. See ya later, *abuela*."

She glares at him as he laughs. It takes all of her self-control not to flip him off.

Kyle gets up to follow Rogelio, turning around to walk backwards to bid them a last goodbye. "Bye guys! Bye Mara!" He gives her a wave of his fingers, smiling when Mara looks up to shout bye back. He turns around only to immediately pull a 360, cupping one hand around his mouth to shout again. "Oh yeah! Happy early birthday, Catra!"

She considers saying something smart. Instead, she decides to give him a break and shouts back a lame, "Thanks, Kyle."

As they're leaving, Mara looks up at her, interest clearly piqued. Her round eyes are shining. "It's your birt'day?"

Catra chuckles and brings her back around to her front to fish out her ring of keys. "Not yet, kiddo. Few more days."

"My birt'day's in a few more days, too."

Catra raises her eyebrows and pauses in looking for her keys to laugh. "Is it now?" Grabbing her keys from the zipper pocket, she pulls them out and then looks down to fix Mara with narrowed eyes. "Are you trying to steal my birthday?"

"Mmmmm….no!" Mara shakes her head violently, her whole body swiveling with the motion. "We can share!"

Catra hums and watches as Adora gathers up her bag and Mara so they can leave the building. "Well isn't that sweet of you?" Of course, she *knows* that Mara's birthday isn't until the summer

because Adora had told her, but she figures that a four-year-old has a loose grasp on the concept of time. So she's playing along. Adora seems amused by all of it.

But less amused by other things.

"So do you always make people's decisions for them?" she asks as Catra twists the lock on the front entrance and jiggles the handle to check it.

Catra breathes out through her nose. She figured this was coming. "Only when they're too busy being humble to make the decision themselves." Before Adora can say anything back, she turns on her heel to face her. "Adora, we *both* know that you'd be great for the job. If you don't start taking initiative, you'll never get away from that crap job with those assholes." She flinches when she remembers that Mara is in Adora's arms, privy to everything she's saying. Dammit.

Adora shoots her a glare, though she's not sure whether it's due to her choice of language or the scenario in its entirety. "How about you let me handle that?"

"So you're telling me you *enjoy* being those men's little S-E-X object gopher?"

Hopefully Mara doesn't know how to spell yet.

Adora frowns and shifts Mara in her arms, keeping her eyes off Catra in favor of adjusting her daughter's shirt. "That's not what I said."

"It's how you're acting." Okay, shit, *that* was a tad harsh. And not even necessarily true, either. Adora complained about her job plenty, her co-workers moreso. But Catra has a hard time wrapping her head around the fact that the girl she used to know in high school who'd threaten a guy if he so much *looked* at her the wrong way with a well-placed punch to the throat is now a woman who takes the same shit and *worse* every day without hardly batting an eye.

Adora opens her mouth to retort, before closing her eyes and shaking her head, stroking a thumb over the denim of Mara's jeans. "Another time." Then she opens her eyes again, looking at the door they're still standing in front of. "So Rogelio's….different."

Catra already knows what she's referring to. "Yeah. I think that's Kyle's doing for the most part. They got a lot closer in college apparently. Honestly, I never knew the guy could be so funny."

"It's nice." They leave it at that.

Catra walks Adora over to her car, like she had the week before. After buckling Mara into her carseat, she shuts the door and leans against it, gnawing on her bottom lip. She's obviously mulling something over in her head and honestly Catra wishes she'd just get on it with it. She can't read her as well as she used to, even if she's starting to get better at it again. They used to practically be able to read each other's minds, but ever since meeting up again, there's always something in the way, blocking her.

"You doin' anything tomorrow?"

Catra shoves her hands into her jean pockets, toeing her black ankle boot into the parking lot gravel. "I'm working on some preliminary designs for that one client I told you about a couple weeks ago. I've got a meeting with 'em Tuesday and they're still being insanely picky about the whole ordeal." She quirks a single eyebrow, eyeing Adora carefully. "Why? Got something in mind?"

"Well," she pushes off the car and clasps her hands behind her back, biting deeper into her lip. "Scorpia and Entrapta asked if I could have dinner at their place tomorrow night. And obviously they want you to come too."

Huh?

Catra blinks, clearly confused. Scorpia and Entrapta invited Adora to have dinner with them? And they didn't go through her to do it? Wait, no, rewind. Since *when* have Scorpia and Adora been talking on their own?

"Scorpia didn't mention anything to me," she mutters, wondering if she should feel hurt.

"I told her that I'd ask you. But she reached out, saying she wanted another chance to talk to me, since last time there were too many people." Adora tugs on her braid. "So?"

Well, a dinner couldn't hurt. Granted, she's not too sure how she feels about her friends having a setting to bombard Adora with a million questions and (possibly) relaying embarrassing tales from their college days, but she supposes that would even the scales considering that they'd done something similar with Adora's friends. "Yeah. I'll be there. What time?"

Adora smiles. "I'll pick you up at six."

Catra laughs. "I can't drive myself?"

"Just text me your address."

"I-" She stops herself, realizing that even though she knows where Adora lives and that she's even been there a few times now, she never thought to return the favor. "Right. Okay."

Opening her car door, Adora pauses to lean on the frame. "See you tomorrow then?"

"It would seem that way."

When Catra goes to climb into Adora's car, there's something impeding her. "The heck is this?"

Adora lifts the container by the handle at the top so she can sit down. "You'll have to hold it."

"That does not answer my question."

Adora rolls her eyes as Catra shuts the door. "What do you think it is?"

Well, the plastic is somewhat a frosted kind of transparent, so even though she can't see the contents clearly, she can see the outline. "A cake? What do you have that for?"

"I told Scorpia I'd handle dessert." As Catra continues to sit there, she gives her a pointed look. When Catra doesn't pick up on it straightaway, she sighs and tilts her head to the side. "Seatbelt?"

Oh. "Right. Not used to cars." After buckling up, Adora places the container on her lap and shifts the car into drive to pull away from the curb. As they drive, Catra taps her manicured nails - a treat to herself earlier that afternoon - against the plastic container, staring intently down at its contents. Something just isn't adding up.

"There's something you're not telling me."

The GPS chimes in so Adora doesn't have to, directing her to take a turn at the next light. Catra frowns and picks up her phone, looking at the route it's guiding her through. "You know I could just tell you how to get there, right?"

"I already have the GPS set up."

Catra swipes her thumb over the "X" to exit out of the route and app, waving Adora's phone back and forth. "Whooooa! Look how easy that was! Technology's amazing!"

Adora casts her a sharp look for the corner of her eye, gesturing to both of her hands on the steering wheel. "I'm driving, remember?" Her hands are exactly at nine and three, different from the eight-and-four method they'd been taught in high school, though Catra's aware that's the new and updated hand position. Leave it to Adora to keep up with all the innovated safe driving practices.

Instead of commenting on it, Catra looks past the windshield. "Take a left at this next street coming up."

As expected, Adora turns on her blinker and checks all of her mirrors before merging over. There's a million more jabs and jokes she could make about Adora's prim and proper driving, but she opts to forgo it all in favor of trying to dig more information out of her. "So seriously, what's up the cake?"

"Keep asking questions and you won't get any."

"Oh you are *definitely* hiding something."

Adora doesn't confirm or deny her statement which is affirmation enough. Catra contemplates pressing it further, to simply annoy the information out of her. "Take a left up here."

They're close to Scorpia's now. She probably wouldn't have the time to break Adora down.

After they park in one of the guest spots in the garage adjacent to the apartment building, Adora collects the cake off Catra's lap and gets out, walking around to unbuckle Mara from her carseat and pull her from the car. Then they're walking up all the stairs (all fucking twelve flights). When Catra offers to carry something for Adora she's immediately turned down.

"This is nothing," Adora casually comments. Always a show-off.

But Catra can't pretend she isn't impressed. Carrying a cake, a large tote bag, and a damn *child* up six floors is no easy feat. Adora manages without barely breaking a sweat.

When they get to the door, however, Catra's the one who knocks. Immediately they hear Scorpia's distant voice from within shouting "Door's open!" and Catra tries the handle, finding it to be the truth. Her and Adora shuffle into the apartment and walk down the short little hallway where both Scorpia and Entrapta greet them in the kitchen.

"Surprise!" they both shout in unison.

Catra blinks as she takes it all in.

Scorpia and Entrapta are decked out in party gear, donning tiny party hats (Entrapta's idea, no doubt) and an arrayment of other tacky party supplies. Scorpia has a purple feather boa wrapped around her neck and Entrapta has neon purple plastic glasses on her face and a glowstick necklace hanging from her neck.

On the counter is an assortment of snacks, coupled with ceramic dishes filled with actual food for a meal. All around the setting are piles of confetti that look like they're a simple blow away from ending up in the food itself. A banner hangs from the ceiling, drooping in a couple places. It reads "Happy Birthday, Catra!" in cut-out letters, with a crude drawing of her, Scorpia, and Entrapta formulated in a triangle. Off to the right, it seems like another crude drawing of Adora and a smaller Adora was added on at the last minute. All the figures are surrounded by colorful dots and are wearing party hats akin to the ones Scorpia and Entrapta are already wearing. The only exception is Catra, who is wearing a bejeweled crown and sunglasses.

When Catra finally tears her eyes away from the decorations, she fixes Scorpia with an incredulous stare, somewhat torn between feeling honored that so much effort had been put into all this and a little annoyed that they'd gone so overboard with it. She opts for the first option, not wanting to start a scene so soon after arriving.

"You planned all this?"

Scorpia smiles and taps her prosthetics together. "Actually…"

"It was my idea."

Catra looks over to Adora, who at some point had walked past her to set the cake container down on the counter with the rest of the food after brushing aside some of the copious amount of confetti. She turns around and sets Mara on the floor, the little girl immediately reaching up to the counter on her tiptoes to grab a fistful of confetti to toss into the air, laughing as it rained down on her.

"This was you?"

"Well," Adora leans against the counter, sweeping some of the confetti back from the edge so Mara couldn't throw all of it on the floor. Though she does take a pinch of it between her fingers and sprinkles it over Mara's head, watching the little girl giggle and dance as it gets caught in her locks. "I wasn't lying when I told you Scorpia wanted a chance to talk in a more intimate setting without so many people. But I was the one who suggested we do it while celebrating your birthday."

As she sits there processing that, Entrapta hops up, space buns jiggling on top of her head with her vibrant movement. "So we decided to have a mini party here! Scorpia and I were in charge of the food and decorations and Adora got the cake!"

Catra looks at the container then back at Adora, who's slyly smirking at her.

"It's red velvet," she sing-songs. "Buttercream icing," she tacks on with a waggle of her eyebrows.

Catra smirks. Her favorite.

"Good to know you remembered."

"How could I forget?"

Scorpia slides in at that moment, holding a small cardboard box spilling with more party supplies and gear. "Here! Put these on and let's get this party started!" She offers the box to Adora first who procures a pointed party hat, bending over to place it on Mara's head. She takes a pair of red plastic glasses, similar to Entrapta's, and puts them on herself and turns to Catra to make a weird face.

"Come on, Birthday Girl. Suit up."

The night is...fun.

Admittedly, she was a little worried pairing her childhood best friend with her college best friends in a small space together without the distraction of other people, but it goes well all things considered. Thankfully, Scorpia and Entrapta remember her orders from the previous event and stay away from all sensitive topics. Mostly they stick to current situations: jobs, friends, hobbies.

Some of the stories divulge into swapping crazy college stories, most of them centered on Catra this time around given that her, Entrapta, and Scorpia had been roommates for a year before they graduated. Nothing too embarrassing (not that Catra has much shame anyway), but there's the odd tale here and there that has Catra cringing and burying her face into her plate.

Adora's amused by it all, but she figures it's more due to the fact that this is payback somehow. Fair's fair, but *God* would Scorpia learn to ever shut her mouth?

When it comes time to cut the cake, they all gather in the kitchen. Adora sticks the candles in the cake that Scorpia bought - novelty birthday candles that say "26". They place a few more birthday candles in a circle around it and Entrapta turns off the lights while Adora lights them. Scorpia leads them all in an off-pitched rendition of "Happy Birthday", with Mara being the loudest of them all, while Catra stands there awkwardly, not really sure what to do.

Her attention drifts over to Adora and Mara, both of their faces illuminated in the candlelight. They're both smiling at her - Mara with a big dopey grin that Catra thinks is mostly at the prospect of eating cake, whereas Adora's is softer and more reserved, but no less genuine.

It occurs to her that this is the first birthday in awhile that she's been able to celebrate with her.

When it comes time to blow out the candles, she squeezes her eyes shut, wishing for many more.

After turning the lights back on, Catra is tasked with cutting the cake and passing plates around. They all go back to the living room to dig in. Adora's watching them all intently, picking at her own slice demurely.

Taking her first bite, Catra rolls her eyes up into her head and lets out something not too far from a moan, chewing slowly to savor the taste. "Oh my God. I've missed this."

Adora perks up to her left. "It's good?"

Scorpia butts in, waving her plastic fork in the air. "It's amazing! I mean, I love all kinds of cake for sure. But this is absolutely scrumptious!" she declares as she makes a big show of taking another bite.

Entrapta nods. "Yes. Normally I don't rate red velvet cake very high, but I'd have to say that this cake in particular would certainly rank in my top ten."

Adora breathes out a sigh which ends in a grateful smile. "I'm glad. I wasn't sure since I haven't tried this recipe in awhile. Normally Mara is my main taste tester, but she'd eat a bag of sugar if I let her." Said girl was already nearly done with her cake, scraping her finger across the paper plate to gather up excess icing and crumbs.

Still chewing on her cake, Catra frowns. "Wait, this isn't a box cake?"

Puffing out her chest, Adora looks to her. "Nope. One-hundred-percent from scratch."

"Really?" Scorpia exclaims. "No way! Where'd you get this recipe? It's amazing!"

Dropping her eyes down to her cake, she picks at it with her fork. Her smile is still there, but it's...sadder? "I had someone teach me how to bake not too long ago. Really helped with the stress of

school and the pregnancy. Though she preferred baking pies, so I know a little more about those than cakes."

"Hey!" Catra doesn't have time to dissect that statement because Scorpia's shouting again, turning in her seat to face Adora. "Can you bake pumpkin pie?"

"Yeah."

"Apple?"

"Of course!"

"Oh! Oh! What about peach pie?"

"It's been awhile but yeah, that too."

Scorpia throws a quick glance behind her to Entrapta who's a little preoccupied with her thin slice of cake. "Do you think you could join us for Thanksgiving next month? You could bake one of your pies!"

"Oh." Adora casts a look over to Catra, as if she were looking for some kind of permission or something. She only offers a shrug, leaving it up to her. "Um, yeah. That sounds nice actually. If you don't mind, that is."

"Of course not!" Scorpia assures her. "I'd love a chance to taste one of your pies if your cake is this good!"

"I would like to be able to analyze and rank your pies compared to your cake, as well," Entrapta offers with a nod.

Adora smiles. "Sounds like a plan then. Any preferences?"

They only stay a little over an hour after that. They take some time to let Catra open gifts from all of them, including one handmade card from Mara that shows a picture of Catra with cat ears and a tail and scribbles instead of words. The four women

talk for a while after that, though Adora has to cut them all off when she notices that Mara is beginning to crash.

Scorpia shoos them out the door as Adora offers to help clean up, bidding them goodnight and wishing Catra a happy birthday one last time. Catra carries the cake container with a mostly eaten cake and all her gifts to give Adora the space to carry her sleeping daughter as they leave the apartment and begin the trek back to her car.

The car ride is quiet for the most part. It's comfortable - they're both still riding the high of a good night in and full stomachs. Mara is fast asleep in the backseat. The only interruptions to the silence is Catra giving short directions back to her apartment and Adora humming in response.

"Take a right here."

When Adora doesn't offer any response, Catra looks over to make sure she was heard. She finds her best friend staring intently past the dashboard, eyes locked on the road, but barely seeing it. Her teeth are worrying her bottom lip and she almost absentmindedly flicks on her blinker to make the turn.

As Catra mulls over in her head how to breach whatever's on Adora's mind, she speaks.

"October twenty-eighth."

Catra blinks before breaking out into a grin and laughing. "Yeah. That would be my birthday. Wasn't the whole purpose of tonight?"

Adora shakes her head slightly. There's a pause as Adora merges to pass the car in front of her and Catra eyes her curiously the whole time.

"I went to a Halloween party the night before that." She taps the steering wheel as she continues to chew on her lip. At this point, Catra begins to worry she might break skin. "With...with him."

Oh.

It's going to be *that* kind of conversation.

She remains quiet, deciding to allow Adora to take this at her own pace. She knows that talking about this sort of stuff is difficult enough for her, which makes it extra shocking that she's brought it up without prompting this time. Maybe this is progress.

Catra inhales a quick breath. Is she about to find out who he is? What happened between them?

She holds that breath as she waits for Adora to speak again.

"We didn't leave until somewhere around two AM." Her voice is smaller, distant, lost in a memory. "We were both pretty wasted at the time. One of his friends picked us up. We…" She pauses, shakes her head, reevaluating something. "October twenty-eighth. That's when Mara was conceived."

Catra chokes on her own spit. What...where is *this* coming from? Of all things to tell her…

She coughs, regaining her bearings and breath. Decides to dip a toe in. "How...Are you sure?"

Adora nods and turns to give her a quick look before focusing back on the road. "We'd been arguing off-and-on for awhile. I'm sure."

Catra picks at her jeans, not sure how to feel about this new information. "Why are you telling me this?"

"I…" Adora frowns, like she's not sure herself. Catra can see her chewing on the inside of her cheek, brow furrowed deep in contemplation. The car pulls over to the curb and Catra realizes they're back at her apartment.

She doesn't get out.

"I think he hated you," Adora says finally.

Catra frowns and scoffs. "He never even met me."

"He hated how much I talked about you." That hits something deep. So deep she's not sure how to respond. "I don't know for sure but...sometimes I wonder if that night was him somehow making a swing at you. Or something." She sighs and leans her head back on the headrest. A moment passes and her eyes drift up to the rearview mirror and Catra looks too, knowing where her gaze is directed at.

Mara is limp in her carseat, sleeping like the dead. Hair still littered with confetti, it glints off the low light entering through the car windows, making her light hair shimmer with color.

"Little does he know, his little stunt is what would inevitably drive me back to you." Catra looks away from Mara to see Adora looking back at her, a soft and ironic smile pulling at the corners of her lips. "Funny how it all works out in the end, huh?"

In the back of her head, Catra tries to remember what she had been doing that night. She can't.

But she certainly hadn't been imagining that in just five years time, she'd be sitting in the car of her best friend - that more-or-less had been dead to her at the time - having a conversation about fate and irony in front of her apartment with said best friend's kid in the back of the car.

No way in Heaven or Hell could she have ever dreamed of such a scenario.

Catra chuckles. "So he fucks you on *my* birthday as some kind of 'fuck you', knocks you up, and then turns tail and runs? She might as well be mine, in that case."

What?

What?

What?!

What the hell kind of comment was *that*, Jauregui? Joke or not, the implications of it were just...oh *fuck* her sideways how the hell does she recover from something like that?

The answer is she can't. She can't and she absolutely, one-hundred-percent, without a single fucking doubt screwed all this up and there's no backpedaling out of it. Out of all the *weird*, cryptic comments to make, *that's* what comes out?

Just then, Adora laughs, breaking through Catra's internal panic. "You as a mom? I'll believe it when I see it."

Did...did she actually just avert disaster? By some grace of a god or the universe that has almost *never* been on her side, was she actually just granted some kind of mercy?

Nope. She won't question it. Best to just take the gift and go. Maybe this is their birthday gift to her. She can survive to see their friendship flourish another day.

"Yeah, s'pose you're right," she concedes. "I'm way better suited for the crazy fun aunt role."

"A menace to parents everywhere," Adora adds.

Deciding this is the perfect time to exit before she can stick her other foot in her mouth, Catra unbuckles and opens the door to get out. She starts to set the cake container on the unoccupied passenger seat, but Adora reaches over and nudges it towards her.

"Keep it. It's your cake, after all." When Catra hesitates, she adds on, "I'm not worried about the container. I'll get it later."

"Um...thanks." She plucks the container back up, holding it in front of her. "Goodnight, Adora."

"'Night, Catra." She smiles, warmly and Catra has an unexplainable urge to get back into the car. "Happy birthday, *grandma*."

With a smirk and roll of her eyes, Catra shuts the car door and watches as Adora pulls off the curb, trailing her as she rides down the street until she turns the corner. Still standing on the sidewalk, she looks down at the cake in her hands, finally alone with only her thoughts.

"Me as a mom, huh?"

Yeah. Fat chance in hell.

Chapter End Notes

What up what up. It's been a month already?

Sorry for kinda disappearing. A lot of has happened recently regarding school and personal life stuff and I've been stressed as fuck. This quarantine isn't helping matters.

Also sorry for Rogelio's character. It was difficult trying to write for him considering we see so little of him in the show, and even when he talks we have NO idea what he's saying. So I kind of had to invent his personality here.

And regarding Catra's last name...YES, I stole it from ceruleanstorm's UWS story. But I genuinely tried to come up with my own and nothing seemed to fit as well because that surname feels so perfect for her.

Anyways, I wanted to get some input from you guys real quick. Personally, as a reader, I love long chapter updates. But as a writer, I'm a little worried that you guys might not enjoy them. I know my chapters have started averaging around 8-9k words, and was wondering if you guys actually like that or if you'd prefer shorter chapters. Let me know. Depending on what people say, I might alter how I write from here on out for this fic (though, as a disclaimer: the length of

the chapter does NOT affect my updating speed. I tend to finish chapters within 1-2 days regardless of how long they are. This is more of a question on how you guys want them to be broken up really for readability reasons).

Moving onto other topics, ART!!! I received some wonderful art from mellorine91 once again with Catra's outfit from last chapter. I also got some art from shuckel depicting my FAVORITE moment from last chapter!!! You guys never cease to amaze. Keep being awesome.

And a reminder to follow my tumblr or my twitter to stay updated on fic progress and even catch snippets of WIPs.

Until next time~! Stay safe out there guys!

i (don't) want to feel like this, so that makes it all your fault

Chapter Summary

Monsters, vampires, ghouls, and goblins? Pfffft. Not scary at all.

Catching feelings? Uh oh.

It's time to get spoopy.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Halloween.

Catra's never really been sure how to feel about the holiday.

Now, granted, it's not that she hates the holiday or anything. Ultimately, it was one she thoroughly enjoyed as a kid. Any excuse to eat an abundance of candy and have pointless celebrations in grade school that meant free treats and skipping grammar lessons. Even well into her college years she's held a certain kind of appreciation for the time of year that gave high schoolers and college kids an opportunity to destress and drink themselves dead at parties. *Especially* because it was the one time of year that girls could dress as slutty as they wanted without anyone really saying much about it (and by *God* did Catra appreciate the view).

Horror movie marathons screwed on most cable channels, another thing she could get into (because to the disgruntlement of pretty much all her friends, she *loves* horror movies), but honestly with streaming services making their big wave a few years back, the marathons have lost some of their appeal. Still, the crisp fall air puts her in some kind of mood, so she'll find herself curled up on her pleather couch wrapped in a blanket with a couple bottles of hard cider and ice cream, rolling her eyes at dumb (but

ridiculously hot) blondes shrill screaming as they twist their ankles trying to run from masked killers.

Though she prefers the heat of summer, there's also something to the relief that comes with a crisp, cool breeze dividing the month of October in half, signalling the *true* beginning of autumn. And even though the sun does give a slight reprieve, there's the faint scent of the smoky incense of wood burning in fireplaces and backyard pits that still manage to send a cozy warmth through her bloodstream.

There was also always the factor of her birthday being so close to Halloween (just three days apart) that added her excitement for the holiday when she was a kid. Back then it was almost like having a second birthday. Now, in her adult years, most of the novelty has worn off, and to be fair, it's almost a little annoying seeing everyone so worked up about Halloween when she's trying to forget about how she's mostly outgrown it. Her favorite bars string up tacky decorations as some sort of half-acknowledgement for the capitalist-centered holiday, knowing that for them it mostly means hosting costumed events to bring in more revenue. If her birthday doesn't fall on a weekend, it's most likely that Halloween falls closer, so she can't even really celebrate it properly with a night out without having Jack Sparrow and Batman sandwich her with their gross, grinding pelvises.

But she doesn't exactly hate Halloween either. There's still some things she enjoys, if only due to nostalgia. She doesn't love it either. At this point, she's mostly indifferent.

So when Adora invites her to take Mara trick-or-treating, it's a change of pace. Whether it will be a pleasant one remains to be seen.

Admittedly, she hadn't been sure about the idea of helping Adora babysit her own daughter as she frolicked through strangers yards with a bucket full of candy, but Adora - the evil manipulator that she is - had Mara put up to the phone.

"Please Cashra? Please come with us?"

Because how do you say 'no' to a four-year-old kid? Without accumulating some kind of bad karma?

When Adora had taken back the phone, she had added on, "She's been asking me all week if you'd come with us. We won't be out too long since it's a school night but, of course, you don't have to come."

Of course she had to go. Catra prides herself for being "that bitch", but goddammit she's not a *monster*.

So yeah. That's how she ends up in Adora's car on Halloween night - dressed in ripped black jeans with lace leggings underneath, a gray sweater, and light leather jacket to fend off the chill of the night - to drive an hour away.

Because that's the *other* part of this whole thing.

It's not just Mara going trick-or-treating around Adora's apartment building (like Catra assumes is what most of the kids who live there do without any other means). They're going back to their hometown because, as Adora puts it, she wants Mara to have the "genuine experience of Halloween by trick-or-treating through a suburban neighborhood (you know, like when we were kids, Catra?)".

And not just any neighborhood either. No, of course Adora wouldn't take Mara to some random patch of suburbia (something, something, people are untrustworthy).

They're going home. Back to the place they grew up. Or, mainly, where *Adora* grew up.

Adora's childhood home looms above them from where they sit in her parents' driveway, looking every bit the same as it did when they were younger. All the times they ran around the front yard, circling the house as they chase each other with water guns on blistering summer days; the nights they sat in the backyard,

roasting marshmallows over the fire pit under the guidance of the spackle of autumn constellations, laughing and dodging Adam when he dipped his too far and it caught fire; mashing clumps of snow into each other's hair on days that school shut down, their noses and cheeks flaming with a pair of mugs with their names on them inside when the frost grew too much to bear and needed to be thawed by Mama Hartvigsen's hot cocoa, brewed and mixed with creamer on the stove and spiced with whole sticks of cinnamon (two in Adora's and three in hers).

The porch where the door of them sat, both eighteen, the brick stones of the steps digging into Catra's bared thighs as her thoughts nagged her, *begged* her, to say something before she lost Adora to college life. The place where they had said their goodbyes, bright-eyed and still so naive, unaware of what the future had already woven of their fates, the heartache and hardships that would plague them when the world had a full grasp on them, no longer under the safety blanket of childhood and the peeling yellow paint of wooden paneled-strips of a house that had offered them so many memories and so much solace.

Catra hasn't seen it in years.

It feels like home and a twisted knife in her heart all at once.

Adora turns the car off, notices her staring at the house, and reaches over to gently cover Catra's idle hand with hers. "They're going to be so happy to see you. Don't worry so much."

Yeah. And then there's Adora's parents.

Adora had already assured her countless times that Mermista was the only one who knows the truth about what happened between the two of them. But there's still a gnarling dread eating away her insides at the thought of seeing Adora's parents again, after so many years of silence and static. After all, even if they don't know, they're surely have questions right? About where Catra was, where she went, why her and Adora had dropped out of each other's lives. After all, Catra had spent nearly every day of her

childhood tied to this house. After school, weekends...her parents worked a lot. They had long hours and were away from home most of the day. Adora's mom worked from home, mostly, so when Catra had nowhere else to go, she always ended up here. It worked out.

So how do you explain to a woman that had basically been your second mother since you were old enough to talk that you almost hated her daughter that you used to be inseparable from? What do you tell them to make up for it all?

Catra has about forty-five seconds to figure it out.

Adora's already exiting the car and opening the backdoor to unbuckle Mara from her car seat, a task made more difficult because the little girl's bouncing so much in excitement that she's practically vibrating. Catra herself is tasked with carrying the tote bag holding all their trick-or-treating supplies - costumes, party store makeup, flashlights, and candy bucket along with a change of pajamas for Mara for the ride home - while Adora focuses her attention on corralling her daughter to the front door.

Catra follows numbly behind, her legs lead and heart pounding as she gazes upwards at the imposing structure that extended to the heavens when she was little, but now just hovers over her, examining her and how much she's changed. With a shiver she shrugs it off, reverting her focus in front of her, as her boots scrape against the faded brick of the steps leading up to the porch. It extends out the width of the house, underlining the bottom floor windows, and each side is filled with wicker outdoor furniture, accented with cushions dyed autumn colors. String lights twist around the white guards, plastic skulls unblinking, and fake, cotton spider webs act as an extra (but flimsy) barricade from the railing to the top of the overhang.

Off to her side, Adora is sifting through her ring of keys to enter the house. Mara runs off, no longer tethered down, to jump onto the loveseat, bouncing on the cushions a few times before flopping over to kick her legs in the air.

"Mara Noelle! Stop that and get back over here or you won't get to eat *any* of your candy tonight!"

Despite everything, Catra can't help but reveal a small smile as Mara bolts upright, panic in her eyes as she watches her mother stare her down, assessing the seriousness of her threat. After deciding that, yes she absolutely means it, she slides off the couch and scurries back over to stand back at Adora's side, still fidgeting but less so.

Adora's always been good at that.

With Mara returned to her side and the key finally placed, Adora unlocks the door and pushes in. Mara scrambles in with little fanfare, her little feet pattering across the rug of the entrance deeper into the house towards where Catra remembers the kitchen to be. There's a pause of sound in the kitchen interrupted by the shrill, ear-piercing cry of "Grandma!"

Grandma. Just when she thinks she's used to the idea of Adora having a kid, now Catra has to confront the fact that her mom is a *grandma* now.

Too little too late, Adora sighs as she steps in. "Hey, Mom! We're here!"

A laugh comes from the kitchen and Catra freezes in the entranceway. "I guessed as much!"

Adora then turns around to a still frozen Catra, sly smile playing on her lips as she drops her voice to a whisper. "I didn't tell her you were coming too. Hang back so we can surprise her, yeah?" Punctuated with a wink.

As if that simple statement didn't send Catra into another panic spiral. Not only does she risk being bombarded with questions she doesn't know how to answer and facing disappointment from her secondary mother figure, but now it turns out that her presence wasn't even forewarned? Which means that whatever her reaction

is going to be is going to be how she *really* feels about all of this. And Catra has to face it head on.

Maybe coming *was* a bad idea, after all.

Adora doesn't hang back long enough to notice Catra's growing uneasiness though because she's already toeing off her shoes and heading towards the kitchen, going on about traffic or something. Unsure of whether to flee, stay rooted in her spot, or inch forward, Catra glances around the familiar space, somehow finding all the niches and grooves that had been ingrained into her brain so long ago, tracing over them with her eyes like she was here only yesterday.

For the most part, nothing's changed. The walls are still the same color, if maybe a bit faded and washed with time. The table to her left by the door is the same, etched with a few new scratches and stains, but sturdy despite its age. Shoes litter underneath it, keys and such haphazardly tossed on its surface. Further in, she notices the picture frames nailed to the walls. Most of them she remembers, snapshotting Adora and Adam's childhoods, family vacations and the like. But some of the frames are newer, fresher. All Mara.

Curious, Catra wades through the nostalgic atmosphere, studying each one individually: Lena holding a newborn in a hospital room at Adora's bedside with Randy on the opposite side, watching the two women fawn over the baby; a slightly larger child with wisps of hair so blonde it was practically white, seated on a table next to a cake with a candle shaped like a '1' stuck into it; Mara again, a little older than last photo, standing up, arms raised above her head and pudgy hands wrapped around Adora's thumbs, the woman standing behind her and doubled over, hair tucked behind her ear and smiling proudly down at her daughter; and so on and so forth. A collage of memories, moments from Mara's short span of life already lived, splayed out in front of her, an archive to the years that saw to her growth.

An archive that further spells out Catra's absence during all of it.

She turns away to the opposite wall, to escape the unpleasant thoughts creeping in again, and immediately comes face-to-face with Adora.

She's smiling, triumphant as she holds up a deep purple-colored folder, the other hand throwing up a dorky thumbs-up. The graduation gown she's wearing matches the color of the folder in her hand, if maybe a little lighter. It's open, revealing the brilliant contrast of her white dress underneath, loose and flowing, stopping at her knees.

Her stomach is prominent and eye-catching, so round and full in the photo that even the bulky build of her dress barely manages to hide it.

"*She was born just after I graduated*."

Catra frowns and exhales slowly, eyes lingering on Adora's smiling face.

"Oh, Adora."

At that moment, the chatter from the kitchen registers and she's brought back to the hallway leading from the entranceway to the kitchen. She hears Adora's voice rattling on some more - detailing their plans for the night - before Mara cuts in about her own extravagant plans. They earn a chuckle from Lena, who then goes on to inform Adora that dinner's just about ready and that the table needs to be set.

A pause.

"Actually, Mom, we're gonna need another plate."

Every muscle in Catra's body tenses and her head whips to the doorway, watching it intently with bated breath. There's a brief pause before she hears Lena state in confusion, "No, I definitely put out four plates."

"I mean," Adora drags out while taking a step forward into Catra's view. "We're going to need a fifth plate."

Another pause and Catra feels like her lungs are about to burst open inside her chest.

Then, "A fifth? Is someone else joining us?" She sounds almost wary and still a little confused.

Adora glances her way, a grin of excitement twitching on her lips, and Catra guesses that's her cue to enter.

Her feet don't move.

A million worst-case scenarios speed through her thoughts in the span of seconds, overheating and frying her brain to a crisp that cognitive functions are impossible. She stands there, like a deer in headlights, waiting for the inevitable impact.

Through the ringing in her ears she hears the distant sound of Lena scoffing. "Oh, Adora! Would you just quit it with all the secrecy," Catra hears footsteps approaching and her limbs lock up so tight she thinks the tendons will all split, "and just show me who this mystery guest-"

And then she's standing in the doorway, brown eyes locked onto Catra and mouth hanging open mid-sentence.

She's older, but not so much so that she really deserves the title "grandma". Her hair is still a dark brown, shining and lustrous, though upon closer examination Catra does notice thin threads of gray interspersed throughout. It's twisted up behind her head, secured with a hair clip and her bangs swoop across her forehead, curled. Her complexion is also mostly the same as Catra remembers, with no more wrinkles than before though mainly slightly deeper and more prominent. She has a dish towel thrown over her shoulder and is wearing khaki capris, topped off with a powder blue long-sleeve shirt.

Seeing her brings a lump to her throat and Catra's at a loss for words.

"Catra? Catra, sweetie, is that really you?" Her voice comes out in a near whisper, like she's afraid of frightening her away, or that if she speaks too loud Catra might dissipate into thin air.

Slowly, Catra turns to fully face her, also afraid that if she moves too quickly she might vanish and end up in some kind of weird limbo. The static in her ears and the fuzziness of her head make her feel like she's already halfway there.

A moment passes. Then half of another before Lena is rushing towards her, arms outstretched. Catra is gathered into her embrace, pressed against her warm body and she's stunned for just a brief second before she feels a rush of feeling melt into her limbs, allowing her to lift them and return the hug in kind.

She still smells like the same Macy's brand perfume Catra remembers, pungent and so mom-like, like diluted flowers mixed with pure chemicals. She remembers the time when her and Adora were kids and coated themselves in about a quarter of the bottle each, during one of their games of pretend, and how it took *weeks* to wash the smell off their skin and longer still from the deep recesses of their nostrils. Underneath it is the distinct smell of odorless flour and laundry softener, the lavender kind.

It smells like home.

When they pull away, Catra manages to crack a smile. "Hi, Mama Hart."

Lena tuts gently and cups her face, thumbs brushing the lines of her cheekbones. "Oh! Look at you! You've grown so much! And your *hair*! What on *Earth* possessed you to cut off all those pretty curls?"

Catra gives a wry smile. "Twins."

An immediate understanding flashes in her eyes. "Ah. Right, of course." Then she pauses, lips twisting and chin tucking to her chest. "Yours?"

Catra's eyes widen and she shakes her head violently, bring her hands in-between them with her palms facing out. "No! My brother's!"

Lena's shoulders relax. "Good. Keep it that way. Raising twins is no walk in the park, even on a good day."

"I resent that!" Adora huffs from the kitchen.

Lena ignores her. "But that's so great! You're an auntie! Oh! You *absolutely* need to show me pictures. And tell me what you've been up to these days while you're at it." Then her eyes light up. "Oh wait! I need to tell Randy you're here! Oh he'll be so delighted to see you again! He's out in the shed, doing some reorganizing. Let me go fetch him real quick." She releases Catra and turns to walk back to the kitchen. "Adora, hun, can you and Mara set the table for me? And get an extra set down for Catra!" Then she's heading towards the sliding glass door that leads out to the back patio, an extra skip in her step.

Catra shuffles into the kitchen and is greeted by Adora's grinning mug.

"Told you, didn't I?"

"Shut up and get me a plate."

By the time that Adora and Mara have finished setting the table with Adora doing most of the heavy lifting while Mara folds the napkins, Lena re-enters the kitchen with Randy in tow. He makes a beeline for Catra, wrapping her up in a second hug and giving her a gentle squeeze. "Catra! Good to see you!" He brushes her fingers at the ends of her curls. "Accident with scissors?"

Lena cuts in before she can answer. "Randy, Catra's an aunt now! Can you believe it? Her brother has *twins*."

Randy blows out through pursed lips and raises his eyebrows at Catra. "That's rough."

Adora, standing over by the kitchen table, huffs again and crosses her arms. "You know I *am* standing right here."

Turning to address his daughter, Randy pulls Adora into a hug as well, muffling her grumbles with his chest. "Hey, baby girl, how've you been? Busy?"

A sigh. "As always."

"Papa! Papa!" In seconds Mara wraps herself around Randy's leg, causing him to releasing Adora and redirect his attention to his granddaughter. Mara giggles when she's tossed into the air and caught seamlessly before Randy plants a fat kiss on her cheek. "Papa, it's Halloween!"

His eyes bug out of his head. "Oh! Is it? I almost forgot!"

Mara pouts and places her hands on his cheeks, shaking his head from left to right with a whine. "Papa!"

Lena interjects at this time. "Well, the food's ready if we want to eat. The kids are going to start coming around in about an hour or so and I know that Mara still has to get all costumed up." She disappears into the kitchen while Randy takes a seat at the table, setting Mara down in her own chair while she rambles on and on about her costume and how much candy she's planning on getting.

Catra follows Lena, like it's second nature, to help her bring in the food.

She receives a gentle and appreciative smile for her efforts. "You're still polite as always. Now, seriously, you need to tell me what you've been up to!"

Catra grins back. "Well where do I start?"

"You could always start by telling me more about those twins."

Dinner is a pretty short affair. Mara, impatient, really only eats half of her plate despite Adora's urgings that she needs to eat dinner to balance out the candy intake later that night. They compromise (or rather, Adora concedes) to Mara eating at least half of her broccoli and porkchop, which the little girl does begrudgingly. The rest is shoveled onto Adora's plate and she practically has to inhale it as Mara pesters her to hurry so they can start getting ready. Once she's finished, Mara starts tugging on her sleeve to go upstairs so she can change while Adora tries to placate her.

"Mara, sweetie, we'll get ready as soon as Mommy helps Grandma with the dishes, okay?"

According to the way that Mara's face darkens and the prominent pout on her lips, it's not.

Catra swoops in to save Adora from having to deal with a temper tantrum. "I can help your mom with the dishes. You two go get yourselves dolled up."

With an appreciative glance and a mouthed "thank you", Adora sweeps Mara upstairs, snagging the tote bag as they ascend. As soon as they're gone, Randy helps Catra and Lena gather up all the dirty dishes, making quick work of packing up all the food to put in the fridge before kissing Lena on the cheek.

"I'm going to go back to the shed and finish reorganizing before it gets dark. Maybe even get the stuff to set up the firepit tonight." He looks to Catra with a smile. "After you girls are done trick-or-treating, we could sit around the fire and catch up some more, yeah?"

Her heart feels light and her face betrays it. "Sounds great, actually." And then he's gone through the sliding door, leaving her and Lena alone.

Lena begins washing the dishes, leaving Catra the job of rinsing and drying them. They work quietly for the first minute or so before Lena decides to strike up a conversation.

"Were you shocked when you found out?"

She doesn't have to ask what she's referring to. "Honestly? A little bit, yeah. But I guess that's sort of on me for not really keeping contact." She bites her lip, hoping that their conversation won't sour by going too far down that road.

Lena, the merciful woman she is, doesn't press it. "I'm sure. I mean, imagine how I felt when she called to tell me."

She hadn't considered that before, actually. Thinking about it now though...she is sort of curious on how all of that went over. Currently, it looks like both Adora's parents are okay and love Mara, but when they found out…

She doesn't want to press.

She also doesn't need to.

"You know, it really is one of a mother's worst fears to answer the phone to their crying daughter telling them that she found out she's pregnant and the guy who did it left her for dead." Lena frowns, scrubbing at a particularly rough spot on the pan she's washing. "But I can't say I didn't see it coming either. You know," she drops the pan into the second basin and Catra picks it up immediately, running it under the stream of water to get rid of all the suds, "I never did like that boy. Always whisking her off on vacations where we wouldn't hear from her until she got back. Buying her all those fancy things and such, like he was trying to buy her too." She sighs and rolls her shoulders, placing another dish in the sink. "But I know if I said anything she wouldn't have listened. She's always been stubborn that way."

Catra is well aware.

"After everything though, I almost wish I had. Might've saved her some heartache."

Catra stands there silently, unsure what to say. She already has such limited information on Mara's father and what happened between him and Adora. Everything she's learned so far has been straight from Adora herself, but only when she gets in a mood. She's not sure if she should be hearing any of this. But she can't bring herself to stop Lena from telling her more either.

"I think her friends did try. She made so many excuses for him, though." Lena pauses and looks out the window above the sink into the backyard, a pensive look on her face. "I feel like if there's anyone she would have listened to, it might've been you. She's always valued your opinion above everything else."

Catra digs her teeth into her bottom lip. If not for her, Adora may not have even gotten into the situation at all. She's not sure how she knows, but something tells her it's the truth. She doesn't voice that thought either, not willing to divulge her own regrets and insecurities at the present time. Maybe ever.

Lena looks over to her with a smile. "But some things can't be helped, I guess. Regardless of everything, she did give me a beautiful and lovely granddaughter, so I guess everything happens for a reason."

They go back to silence, Catra toweling off some of the dishes and flitting about the kitchen to put them away in their respective places (everything is where she remembers it to be which almost lets her forget how much has really changed). As she's drying off one of the plates, she admits quietly, "She hasn't actually told me much about it. Just a few things here and there."

Lena hums and drops a few more dishes into the dishwater before setting to work on another plate. "Well, I can't say I blame her. That fucker really did a number on her, leaving the way he did."

Catra blinks in shock, unused to hearing Lena swear like that. As a kid she remembers her being so well-spoken. She's not sure whether to attribute it to her maturity or Lena's strong feelings towards the man. Maybe a bit of both.

"You know, I was there when Mara was born. In the delivery room, that is," Lena continues, oblivious to Catra's shock. "Adora was so scared. I mean, she'd been nervous the whole pregnancy, but I think it really hit full-force when she actually went into labor. Like she'd just realized what she really signed up for. Raising a kid all alone. The tighter she squeezed my hand, crying and screaming, the more I wished it was his balls."

Catra chokes on her spit and goes into a coughing fit, eyes watering as she tries to regain her breath. Beside her Lena looks over in slight worry but chuckling gently. She dries her hand off on her pants before rubbing circles into Catra's back as she recovers.

"Trust me, if you met him you'd think the same thing."

Catra lets out a breathless laugh as she straightens up, patting her chest. "I'll take your word for it." Sure, from what she's heard of the guy already she surely agrees with most of what Lena is saying (as surprisingly blunt it is), and she's sure she'd love to bruise him up a little bit. But it's unlikely that she'll ever get the chance. Between what Adora's told her and everything Lena's saying, the dude is long gone. The most satisfaction she'll get is imagining him falling into a ditch somewhere or both of his legs being snapped by twigs.

Even still, what she wouldn't give for a chance to meet the bastard face-to-face one day and show him what happens when someone hurts the people she loves.

Er...like a friend. Best friend, of course.

Just then, she hears Adora calling her name from upstairs, halting her and Lena's conversation as they both turn towards the front of the house. Lena chuckles and pats a hand on Catra's arm. "Seems

you're needed elsewhere. I can handle the rest of the dishes. Thank you for your help."

"You sure?"

Then they hear Mara's shriller voice shout down the stairs and Lena nods. "Now that's one person you definitely don't want to keep waiting. Go on now. We'll talk more later."

Catra nods, folding the towel in her hands and placing it on the counter before heading out of the kitchen towards the entranceway to go upstairs. She finds Adora and Mara in the hall bathroom - Mara is sitting on the toilet, kicking her feet idly and tugging on the fairy wings on her back, watching them spring back into place when she releases. She's also wearing a lilac dress, the skirt large and covered in glitter, with a pair of hot pink leggings underneath. Her hair has been twisted up into a bun with a plastic crown tucked on top, bejeweled with fake rhinestones and lined with pink fuzz. Her cheekbones are caked in glitter, lips painted with cheap pink lip gloss, and Catra notices that she even has a bit of purple eyeshadow. On the floor lies a plastic sword.

Adora's standing at the sink in front of the mirror, dusting some glitter onto her own cheeks, her lips the same shade as Mara's, but that's about it. She's wearing her own set of fairy wings to match Mara's on top of her deep red off-the-shoulder sweater and she's pulled her hair into a side ponytail that falls past her shoulders in front of her chest. Upon hearing Catra's footsteps, she looks up, topping off the glitter and smiling.

"Nice contour."

Adora rolls her eyes. "Hush."

Now noticing Catra, Mara hops off the toilet and runs over to her, doing a twirl that puts air underneath her skirt and fans it out. "Look, Cashra, look!"

Catra nods and puts her hands on her hips. "I can see! And what are you supposed to be?"

Mara gives her a deadpan look, mirroring Catra's stance and leaning her torso forward until she's almost doubled over. "I'mma fairy worry-er princess. Duh!"

Screwing her lips up, Catra tries to decipher. "A fairy...warrior princess?" That would explain the sword.

Mara throws her hands up as if to say "obviously".

Catra looks up at Adora again, giving her outfit a once over. "So that makes you…?"

"A fairy queen. Mom to the mighty fairy warrior princess."

"Of course. What else?"

Mara begins jumping up and down and reaches forward to take Catra's hand to pull her into the bathroom. "C'mon! You gotta put on yer costume now!"

"My costume?" She looks up to Adora in confusion and her smirk drops when she sees the silent confirmation. "You didn't say I had to wear a costume."

Adora shrugs, caught somewhere being sheepish and indifferent. "Mara picked it out for you. She wants you to dress up with us."

The thought of Catra donning her own set of fairy wings and glittered cheeks makes her cringe. "That's not assuring."

"Relax. There's only room for one fairy queen in this kingdom," Adora laughs. At this point Mara has let go of Catra's hand to rifle through the tote bag. After a couple seconds she pulls out a headband topped off with a pair of ears.

Cat ears.

Oh you have *got* to be kidding her.

"For you!" Mara holds them out, her face so bright and proud of herself for her choice that Catra has no choice but to pluck them from her grasp and weigh them gently in her hands. She glances up at Adora again, an exasperated pull to her face as she silently begs for some way out.

Adora only shrugs again. "I talked her out of getting the tail."

Great.

With a sigh and small shake of her head, she slides the headband on, adjusting it so it sits properly. She looks down to see Mara practically brimming with joy and holds her hands up. "Alright kiddo. How do I look?"

"Awesome!" Then she seems to think better of it because she frowns. "Yer missing your whiskers, though."

Adora points a finger in the air and picks up an eyeliner pencil from the bathroom sink. "She's got a point. Come here."

With a groan, Catra complies, deciding it's fruitless to argue against a fate that's already been written into stone. She lets Adora pull her face closer, wrinkling her nose as she feels the pencil drag across her cheeks. Then Adora moves on to her nose, penciling in what she can only assume is a cat's nose.

She tries to ignore the light touch of her fingertips across her jawline, the soft breaths as she works, the way those blue-gray eyes are so intently focused on her. Catra ignores it all, just like she ignores the fact of how close they are like this, how quickly she could bridge the gap…

"Done!"

She yanks her face away, blinking away the strange haze that had consumed her in favor of shouldering past Adora to look at herself in the mirror.

Staring back at her is her transformed self, painted on whiskers and cloth cat ears and all.

"You know," Adora chimes in, looking at her reflection too. "I think your eyes really tie the whole look together."

"I feel ridiculous."

Adora snickers and starts packing all the makeup back into the tote bag. "Come on, Catra. Where's your Halloween spirit?"

"It died somewhere between the ears and the whiskers."

Mara, ignorant to their conversation, picks her sword off the floor and runs out of the bathroom. "I'm going to go show grandma my costume!" And then she's running down the stairs, the quick pattering of her footsteps echoing throughout the house.

Catra leans against the sink with her arms crossed, watching as Adora finishes cleaning up. "And to think, I gave up a *Scream* movie marathon for this."

Adora hums and throws the tote bag over her shoulder. "I'm sure Neve Campbell and Courtney Cox will understand." She pats Catra on the shoulder, laughing at the sour look shot her way, before her expression softens. "She's really happy you're here, you know. She likes you, Catra."

That takes away some of her bitterness and she looks down at her feet. "Yeah? What makes you so sure?"

"As soon as she saw those cat ears while we were shopping, she wanted to get them for you. She hadn't even picked out her own costume yet." Adora's smile fades. "I know this is all still probably weird for you but…Mara loves having you around." Catra feels a squeeze on her shoulder and looks up to meet Adora's eyes. "I do too."

Catra's thoughts go back to all those pictures in the hallway downstairs. All the moments she was absent for, all the memories

she missed out on. She remembers Lena's words from earlier, reminding her that Catra wasn't there, even if that's not what she was trying to accuse her of. Because it's true. She wasn't around. She should've been.

But she's here now. Standing in the bathroom of the house that was basically her second home growing up. Staring into the eyes of her best friend, the light bouncing off the glitter on her cheeks and glimmering and shifting as her cheeks lifted in a smile. A smile that's doing weird things to Catra's chest and stomach, weird things she hasn't felt since…

"Yeah, yeah. You're such a sap, you know that?"

Adora shrugs and laughs, the sound punching Catra straight in the heart. "Only for you."

Catra gnaws on her lip and pulls away, heading down the stairs and - hopefully - leaving those old thoughts and feelings behind her.

A group of kids run past them, laughing and shouting at each other as they swerve a hard left to run up to the next house. Another group of kids, coming from the opposite direction, follow closely behind as they all race up the stairs to the doorway. The one kid in front presses the doorbell and, in seconds, an elderly woman appears, holding a plastic bowl still filled to the brim with candy.

It's still early, but there's already plenty of kids - some escorted by parents or older siblings - meandering down the sidewalks and crossing the road. It's not quite late enough to be dark yet, but the sun has gone down enough that the street lamps are already on and buzzing with electricity, lighting the street and pathways. The atmosphere sounds with laughter and delighted squeals as children of various ages chase each other through people's yards, an echoing chorus of "trick or treat" heard periodically from every household.

Catra, Adora, and Mara are walking a slower pace. Insistent that Mara holds her hand, Adora has them set at a steady stroll, even though from the way that Mara pulls her along it's obvious she wishes otherwise. Catra walks a little bit ahead, hands shoved deep in her jacket pockets, not being weighed down by a lumbering toddler to allow her a faster pace. Still she tries to not get too far ahead, only a couple skips ahead at most.

They've only hit a few houses so far, starting at the one next to Adora's parents', and Mara's bucket is barely filled. She swings it back and forth as she traipses beside her mother who's holding Mara's sword in her other hand.

There isn't much room for steady conversation because every so often they have to stop so Adora can walk Mara up to the door of the next house. Catra hangs back on the sidewalk, watching as Adora leads Mara (or more like Mara drags Adora) towards the door. Once settled in front of the house, Adora relinquishes her hold on Mara's hand to give her the sword, just in time for the homeowner to appear and pass out a handful of candy straight into Mara's bucket. She listens as Mara gently prompts Mara each time to thank them, to which Mara does obediently with a brilliant grin and sweet voice. Then, once the homeowner wishes them both a happy Halloween, the two girls retrace their steps back down the walkway, Mara proudly holding her bucket up for Catra to see.

They've gone down the block, turning to hit the next when Mara pauses on the sidewalk in front of the house, hesitating to go further.

"Mara, sweetie, what's wrong?"

Mara looks up at her mother with a frown, then turns to Catra thoughtfully. Catra stares back, confused, before Mara turns back to Adora, stating firmly, "I want Cashra to go wit' me this time."

Adora gives her a brief look. "Well, maybe you should ask Catra if she'll go with you."

Catra knows her answer before Mara even turns back to her.

Seconds later, she's standing on the steps of the house, watching a young woman come through the door, holding a bucket of candy. "Well, hello there! Aren't you a pretty princess?"

"I'mma fairy worry-er princess!" Mara corrects, brandishing her sword.

"Ohhhh." The woman nods in understanding. "Would you like some candy for your journey Ms. Fairy Warrior Princess?"

Mara nods and holds out her bucket. "Yes, please!"

The woman drops the candy into her bucket with a smile and Mara tells her "thank you" without Catra having to remind her. Then she swivels on her heel, almost falling over herself before righting herself again, holding her bucket out to Catra. Catra smiles and takes her hand again, sending one more thanks over her shoulder before leading Mara back down the pathway, dodging a gaggle of kids running past them.

It goes on like that for a while. They visit more houses, with Adora and Catra alternating who takes Mara up to the door to receive her next candy conquest. Their chatter is mostly idle and brief, always interrupted when they reach the next house over. For the most part, it's Mara who carries the conversation, relaying to them all the different types of candy she's gotten so far, even telling them which ones were her favorites and which ones she didn't like.

After going at it for about two hours, it becomes clear to both older women that Mara's growing tired. Her gait is more lethargic and the enthusiasm she had at the beginning is quickly waning. Luckily enough, they've circled a couple blocks and her candy bucket is about three-quarters full, so Adora tells Mara they'll hit a few more houses before heading back. When the little girl doesn't put up a fight, they both know that it's the right decision to make.

Once they've gone to their last house, they begin the trek back to Adora's parents', Mara walking in-between the two of them. She's rustling through her winnings, which slows them down a little bit, but the two women take the opportunity to talk and don't bother to rush her.

Eventually Mara interrupts them, looking up at Catra. "Cashra, wha's your favorite candy?"

Before she can answer, Adora cuts in with a shit-eating grin. "Blue airheads."

Catra rolls her eyes, immediately recalling that conversation from the bar a few weeks back. "Ha ha."

But Mara's already digging into her bucket again, which gives Catra the perfect chance to flip Adora off without risking Mara seeing it. It only sends Adora into a fit of giggles.

Eventually, Mara pulls out a small piece of candy and holds it up to Catra. Sure enough, it's a blue airhead.

"I like dese too, but you can have this one."

She thinks about declining the offer, but Mara is smiling so sweetly up at her that she finds herself taking it anyway. "Thanks, kid. But you can keep the rest for yourself. You worked hard for it."

Mara nods and turns back to going through the contents of her bucket. "Oh, I know. You only get the one."

Adora laughs again, the sound echoing louder than all the kids still running around.

The five of them - Catra, Adora, Mara, Lena, and Randy - sit gathered around the firepit in the backyard. Mara has dumped her bucket of candy on the ground, sorting them into piles of what she likes, what she doesn't like, and which ones are her favorites.

Every so often she unwraps a piece, chewing on it as she continues sorting.

Lena and Randy are sitting next to each other on the loveseat they have set up out there. Adora is sitting in a chair next to them, nursing a mug of tea, while Catra sits across from her on the opposite side of the firepit with her own bottle of beer.

"So you're doing freelance, you said?" Randy asks before taking a sip of his soda.

Catra nods and moves her foot up to sit on it. "Yeah. Mostly design stuff for businesses and all that, commissions here and there. I've drawn stuff for tattoos, prints, you name it."

"You make good money?"

Catra shrugs. "It pays the bills."

"I hear that."

"You know," Lena starts. "Adora thought about freelancing for a while after she graduated. Taking on clients to help them market their products and services and all that. But she ended up getting a job from a friend of one of her friend's parent's at the tech company." She shakes her head and takes a swig of her own beer. "I think it's a waste of time if you ask me."

Adora groans. "Mom, *please* don't start this again."

Adding fuel to the fire, "I think so too, Mama Hart. There's always a market for freelancers. Took me a while to get settled into it, but it's easy once you do."

She ignores the daggers Adora sends her way, refusing to back down. Maybe if she says it enough something will finally click. But she decides to not bring up the topic of the sexual harassment, knowing that if she did that Lena would quite literally *force* her daughter to quit.

But the threat is there and Adora knows it by the way her eyes are dangerously narrowed.

"That's what I told her, too! And her father and I offered to help her out if money ever became an issue but...well you know Adora." They share a laugh over that at Adora's expense, who sits in her seat grumbling into her mug.

Randy, trying to diffuse the situation, changes topics. "So do you do anything else? In your free time that is."

"Well, I do help out a friend who does hip hop dancing workshops. It's more a side gig than anything else, and I don't get paid for it, but it's not something I do for money so I don't mind."

Randy nods. "Hey, not everything has to be about money. Of course, it's something important to think about, but if you're doing well there's no problem in doing stuff to just enjoy it."

Lena chimes in again with her own question. "Are you seeing anyone right now, dear?"

She pauses, beer raised halfway to her lips. Her eyes drift over to Adora who looks back at her, expression unreadable. The strange feelings flicker again, but she's quick to snuff them out, tearing her eyes away so she doesn't have to think about them.

"No. I'm not."

"Nothing wrong with that. It's good to focus on yourself too. You've also still got your youth."

"Yeah." She takes a sip of her beer, swirling around the last dregs idly. "I'm not too worried about it anyway. Probably too busy for a relationship anyway." At least, that's mostly why she figures she hasn't been actively going on dates for the past few months. New clients meant more time spent devoted to her work, something that would take time away from developing anything meaningful. Besides, she's still trying to mend her friendship with Adora, which

is emotionally taxing enough. She wouldn't even have the energy for one.

And she's sticking to that.

She avoids looking at Adora entirely.

They talk for a little longer after that, sharing what's been going on in each of their respective lives and telling stories. When Catra finishes off her beer, she's offered another but declines, knowing she probably won't even get through half of it. The night is wearing on all of them as time goes on, and soon enough, Randy stands to kiss his wife on the forehead, telling her he's going to take his meds and head to bed.

Adora shifts in her seat as she prepares to get up. "Honestly, we should be heading out too. It's a school night and I have work in the morning, and we still have to drive back."

Lena stands too, picking up her empty beer bottle. "Would you girls like to take some food home with you? Randy and I probably won't be able to get through all those leftovers on our own."

"Sure, Mom."

They all head inside after Adora instructs a crashing Mara to put all her candy back into her bucket, and leave the already dying fire to wither to ash. Lena packs them some plastic containers filled with the dinner they just had and even packs a couple extra for Catra to take home. When Catra tries to protest, Lena silences her with a stern look and she doesn't try again.

With Randy having already gone off to bed, Lena sees them to the door alone. "Drive safe, dear, okay?"

"Of course, Mom. I'll text you when we get home."

"Thank you." Then she turns to Catra. "I'm so happy I got to see you again, Catra. Don't be afraid to come around more often,

yeah? Maybe next time you come I'll make some of my homemade baklava for you."

Her mouth waters at the thought of it. "That'd be great, Mama Hart. Thank you."

Soon enough, they're loaded up in the car, Mara already falling asleep in her carseat. She's dressed in her pajamas now, the makeup from earlier already scrubbed off so that all Adora has to do is lay her down in bed when they get back. With a last few goodbyes, they're pulling out of the driveway and headed off.

Fifteen minutes into the drive, Catra curls up in her seat with the pretense of going to sleep. Truthfully, she just wants it to seem that way, to give her time with her own thoughts.

Thoughts of fingertips brushing her jaw, a face too close to hers, and just what the hell is going on that she can't seem to forget the sensations.

She has her suspicions, of course. She doesn't want to have them. The implications alone are terrifying enough without giving any substance to them. Because as soon as she does…

She'll spiral all over again. Worse than before. And the most terrifying thing is not that she won't be able to stop it, but that she won't even want to.

It's the scariest Halloween she's had yet.

Chapter End Notes

> Y'all wanted more of Adora's parents? You get more of Adora's parents. Y'all wanted more Catra-Mara interactions? GUESS WHAT.
>
> Don't think I have a lot to say for this chapter tbh. But whoa! 600 kudos?? Unbelievable, truly. I can't believe you guys. Truly the best readers I could ask for.

Also? I stan Adora's mom. I hope y'all feel the same.

Btw, this fic has officially reached 100k+ words. My boyfriend owes me $10. Fuck yeah

Well, it's 3 am here. I'm gonna go pass out but don't hesitate to let me know what you guys think. I'll try to start the next chapter....soonish.

Until next time~

wish that i had never let you love me

Chapter Summary

NAME DROP NAME DROP NAME DROP

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora's lips smack when she releases the straw of her drink, back straighter when Adam drops the tray between them before taking his seat across from her. Setting her cup aside, she reaches immediately for her sub, unwrapping the paper so hastily it tears. She inhales deeply, sighing with a hint of a moan at the aroma it releases, before she digs in fervently.

Adam quirks a singular brow as he takes his time unwrapping his own sub. "Hungry?"

Gulping down her mouthful of food, Adora licks her lips and pulls back more of the wrapping to free the half of the sub entirely. "Was in such a rush to get Mara out of the house this morning I didn't even eat breakfast."

Well, not entirely true. She'd made breakfast for Mara (which really means that she went back and forth with the toddler about what she wanted to eat until eventually Adora poured her a bowl of cereal and called it a day). But then Perfuma had come over for their yoga session which ran later than it usually would. Between Adora's lack of focus - partially due to the hunger pains - and her already present incoordination, they'd ended the session early, but Perfuma lingered a little longer so the two women could chat.

Most of it had been basic catching up on each other's lives considering they rarely had the chance to talk outside of their allotted yoga time weekly. On Adora's end, it was centered around how Mara was doing because, truthfully, she doesn't have much of a life outside of her daughter, as pathetic as that sounds. Making

up for Adora's own lack of excitement, Perfuma detailed her own endeavors - running her studio, her collaboration with a local performance artist to call attention to the environmental issues that plagued the world and the government's lack of resources dedicated to rectifying them, and - of course - the trysts she pursued here and there.

"It's a natural and human desire, Adora," Perfuma had said, a flash of annoyance painting her tone. "Don't make that face."

Except it isn't that she disagrees (hello? She's the only one of their friend group that had a *kid*). And, despite the wriggling discomfort that crawls under her skin when Perfuma goes into *too much* detail about her "sexscapades" as Sea Hawk once lovingly deemed them, it's not that she ever feels judgemental towards her free-loving friend. Most of it is typically due to the fact that there are just some things you keep to yourself and refrain from sharing with friends.

The other...well, okay. Fine. She's….*jealous*, okay?

To be able to live so freely - go where she wants, do what she wants - without the constant weight of responsibility for a whole human life weighing on her shoulders each step of the way? Yeah, Adora sort of wishes she still had that luxury. Not that she resents her daughter in any color, shape, or form, but...well, she can't deny her regrets. Can't help but think late at night, laying in her bed far too large for one, what life would be like if she hadn't been so reckless. If she'd been smarter, if she'd listened to her friends when they first expressed their concerns…

If she hadn't ever met him.

Hadn't ever let herself *love him*.

But...the past can't be rewritten. Mistakes can't be erased once they're locked in, etched into non-shattering stone. She made her choices. She's living with the consequences. It's a waste of time pondering the "what if's" that will never come to fruition no

matter how lonely the days could be or how heavy the weight of everything crushes her - a stone added each day, until it became a matter of *when*, not *if*, she would crack under the pressure.

Her life no longer belonged to just her. She has a daughter who relies on her, who needs her if she's going to grow into a beautiful young woman that, if Adora has *anything* to say about it, will not be subjected to the same mistakes and cruel web of fate that Adora found herself spun into.

Her life is not her own.

On the darkest of nights, she wonders if it ever was.

A snap pulls her from her thoughts and Adora focuses on Adam's hand centimeters from her face. She blinks, reeling back and lifting her eyes to narrow in on his face which is interrupted by a small smirk.

"Houston to Space Cadet Adora. Do you read?" His voice takes on a comical fifties-radio-host lilt which prompts Adora to roll her eyes before swatting his hand away.

"At least I *can* read," she fires back lamely. Another bite of her sub as she hunches her shoulders at Adam's laughter. Then she sighs, her annoyance slipping with nothing to actually hold on to. "Sorry. Guess I was just lost in my own thoughts for a second."

Adam simply hums and takes a bite of his own sub. His eyes lift up, looking past her out the window of the sandwich shop. "It's cool," he says.

Adora narrows her eyes, taking in his faraway gaze and quiet demeanor with high scrutiny. Okay. *Something* is up.

"You sick or something?"

He takes a few seconds to tear his eyes away to redirect them towards her. Her eyes narrow further and she drops her arms to the table, no longer interested in her sub.

"I'm fine," he brushes her off.

Adora shakes her head and leans forward. "Bullshit. I practically handed that one over on a silver platter. Seriously, what's up with you? You've been like this the whole time."

He squirms in his seat, avoiding her gaze, but attempts to keep up his charade to deter her. "I'm above easy pickings like that."

"Bull!" Adora wads up a napkin and throws it at him where it bounces harmlessly off his chest and back to the table. "*Shit*! Now out with it!" When he doesn't budge, she decides to pull out the big guns. "Do *not* make me call Glimmer to find out what's going on."

It works. Maybe a little too well.

Adam's eyes grow to the size of large saucers, pupils shrinking to little pinpricks as panic overrides his body causing him to go completely rigid. A little niggling of concern settles into her stomach, wondering why her threat evoked such a visceral response in him and what the implications of that might be. But then Adam is dropping his sub, holding his hands up in surrender.

"No! No, okay, I'll tell you."

A beat passes.

Adora tilts her head. "Well?"

With a long, drawn out sigh, Adam drops his hands to his lap, arms moving back and forth with the motion as he wipes his palms on his pants. His eyes are locked on the tray between them, lips twisted as he agonizes over his thoughts. Adora watches him carefully, curious but at the same time worried beyond words because...well…

Adam *never* gets like this.

Her brother has never been the type of person to torture himself with his own thoughts, to suffer quietly. That's always been *her* gig. Adam has always been the exact opposite of her - carefree, unhindered by anxiety and worry, speaking before he thinks (which has often been his shovel to dig his own grave). Seeing him like this…it's almost disorienting. Scary.

Is this *really* what she looks like to other people?

"You…" His voice is hushed and Adora has to lean in further to hear him properly. "You know I love Glimmer, right?"

The seed of concern begins to bud into something darker. Adora sets her own sub down on the tray, sucking on her cheek as she approaches with caution. "Yes. I would sure as hell *hope* you do."

Because Glimmer is her best friend. One of the closest she has that she would do *anything* for. And, brother be *damned*, if Adam ever hurt her…

She would *happily* become an only child.

Across from her and unaware of her own spiraling thought process mixed with vague murderous intentions (you know, *just in case*), Adam exhales with a nod. "Yeah, yeah I do. A lot. *More* than that."

Adora sits silently, gripping the table as she patiently waits for him to get to the point.

"I…" He pauses, takes another breath, and Adora fidgets in her seat. "I want to ask Glimmer to marry me."

It takes a moment for her to process. Two. Two and a half.

Then she balls up another napkin and throws it at him, this one bouncing off his face. "It's about!" She throws a packet of plasticware at him. "Damn!" Another packet. "Time!"

He catches the third projectile after getting over his own shock and is shooting her the largest grin that she's ever seen him wear. "You think so?"

Adora rolls her eyes and leans forward onto her arms, food forgotten and hunger miraculously vanished. "Duh! You two have been dating for - what - *five* years now? I almost thought you were too chickenshit to do it." She dodges the plasticware still in his hands when he chucks it at her, giggling at his only slightly disgruntled expression. But that same grin is too wide, too prominent to ebb away for too long, and it's back full force before she can even blink.

"Seriously though," she says once most of her laughter has died down. "I'm happy for you." Then she juts out her lower lip in mock thought. "Well, actually, maybe a little sorry for Glimmer. Having to be stuck with you forever and all." She's already leaning back to avoid the swipe hurtling her way with another laugh.

Adam squints at her. "Yeah, laugh it up. I know you're just covering up the hurt for not getting to her first."

Adora shrugs and picks up her sub again, picking off some lettuce that's sticking to the outside of the bread.
"Ehh...*technically* I *did* get to her first." When he doesn't offer any sort of rebuttal, she takes a triumphant bite of her sub, grinning gleefully at him through a mouthful of food as he stews in his annoyance. "But if it makes you feel any better, you can count this as a win for you in the books."

Picking up his own sandwich with a huff, he nods definitively. "I will!"

They eat in silence for the next few moments, the tension before dissipating into thin air now that Adam has come clean. Adora watches him as she finishes off the first half of her sub, reaching for her bag of chips and tearing them open. Still reeling in the fact that her brother, of all idiots in the world, is finally taking the next step and getting hitched.

A Kodak moment if there ever was one.

"So when are you planning on asking her?"

At that moment, Adam is shoveling the remainder of his sub into his mouth, pausing with his cheeks puffed like a chipmunk prepping for winter and eyes wide like a doe. When she looks at him expectantly, he begins the slow process of chewing it up, dusting off his hands and reaching for his drink in an effort to wash it all down quicker.

"Well," he exhales, (barely) swallowing the last of it, "I figured I'd throw her this real nice party next month. Ya know, for her birthday. Was plannin' on asking her then, with all our family and friends."

"Awwww," Adora coos. She cups her chin with her hands and leans forward. "How romantic."

The only thing she earns for her teasing tone is the finger.

"You got a ring yet?" she asks, moving on.

"Actually," he gives her a look that makes her sit up straighter and squint, "that was the other reason I invited you out today."

When they reach the jewelry store, Bow is already waiting out front for them. One hand tucked in his jacket pocket, the other is scrolling through his phone. Adam calls out to him first and he looks up, pocketing his phone with a smile and jogging halfway to meet them. The two of them lock hands and reel themselves into a one-armed hug before Bow shifts over to wrap Adora up in his arms with a gentle squeeze.

"Hey, dude. Hope you weren't waiting too long."

Bow shrugs. "Not really. Was skimming some psychology articles to pass the time."

Adora smirks and crosses her arms. "The grad student never sleeps, does he?"

"Only when Perfuma slips herbs into my tea."

"Yeah, yeah. Tea, grad school, Freud…" He claps his hand on Bow's shoulder and pats his back twice with the other. "Time to go find my girl a ring that'll rocket her to the moon!" And then he's off, already heading towards the store entrance.

The two of them watch him go with a hint of amusement, even chuckling at the way he rips the door open (after pushing, not pulling first). Bow turns to her with a small grin.

"At least he's enthusiastic?"

"Glimmer has no idea what she's getting herself into."

The shop itself is rather small, but average as far as jewelry stores go, Adora supposes. She hasn't been in many to pass total judgement, but she's passed plenty in malls and shopping strips and they all look relatively the same.

The lights are bright above them, a warm hue cast over the shop and the glass cases that float like islands scattered in the ocean of the shop floor. In each case is a row of different types of jewelry - necklaces, rings, bracelets, earrings, cufflinks - lit up with shining white light strips along the bottom of the casing. Gems and diamonds of all cuts glittered and dazzled the eye from near and far, prompting those whose gaze fell upon them to take that closer look and fall in love.

A lilting tune plays over the overhead speakers, strings spinning the atmosphere into something classy. It heightens the overall vibe of the place, that whoever occupies the space is worthy and deserving to rest their eyes on the treasures that inhabit it, their minds free to roam with images of them wearing a piece that calls to them and only them. For the cynical, it's a tactic to push people to drop their money then and there, to feel the urgency and

innate need to reach that brief indulgent euphoria. For the romantic, well…

"Wow." It leaves Bow's mouth in an awed whisper, and Adora finds herself feeling somewhat the same.

Further to the back of the store, Adam is already perusing one of the longest cases that runs adjacent to the wall, hands clasped behind his back and torso hovering over the glass as he slowly runs over his options. It's the most dedicated Adora's ever seen him.

It's a relieving thought that he's taking this whole thing seriously.

"Well," Bow begins, "Guess we should try and find something that Glimmer will like."

They decide to split up, figuring it might be best to cover more ground that way, despite the shop's small size. Where Bow goes left, she goes right, stopping first at the case to the furthest right and ducking down to rake over the different rings on display.

Most of them are...gaudy to put it nicely. Diamonds cut too big, bands encrusted with far too many, things that look downright impractical to wear on the daily. Adora finds herself scrunching her nose at most of the designs, but realizes that she needs to put her own personal preferences aside because this isn't for her. It's for Glimmer. And, as many years of friendship has proven, the two women have *vastly* different tastes in style.

So she tries running through the options again, slower this time, picturing each option on Glimmer's finger, the way her face would light up when presented with it. The thought of Glimmer's excitement brings a quiet grin to her lips, knowing just how over the moon her friend will be when Aiden gets down on one knee, in front of all their friends and family, as he asks her…

Adora stiffens. Wait….did she just…?

Her gut twists and wrenches. Body breaking out into a cold sweat, she feels herself pulled back, hurtling at an alarming speed as her eyes gloss over. The sounds around her warp into a jumbled cacophony, lights dimming to black, mind whirling like a spinning top as she realizes her mistake much too late.

Had she really just thought about….?

"*Aiden!"*

Her giggles trill from her lips as she stumbles forward blindly, hands reaching up for the steadying comfort of the wrists attached to the hands covering her eyes. Fingers brush against warm skin, warm as the presence at her back that slowly guides her forwards. Her feet shuffle against the pavement of the sidewalk, testing the waters and feeling out her path to ensure she doesn't trip or fall.

But she knows he would never let her.

Adora giggles again and playfully tugs at his arms which don't budge an inch.

"*Seriously, Aiden. Where are you taking me?"*

His voice dips low to her ear and she shivers, biting her lip to reign in the grin threatening to split her face in half. "If I told you, it wouldn't be much of a surprise, would it?"

She groans but obediently stops pestering him, even though she hates *surprises. Part of it is due to unbridled curiosity, but the other part is because she likes to know what to expect at all times. She doesn't like being caught off-guard, but she supposes she'll indulge her boyfriend's more spontaneous and romantic side every once in a while.*

They take a few more steps before he reigns her to a halt, hands loosening around her eyes. "Okay. I gotta open the door. No peeking."

She only hums, a neutral sound of non-commitment. Clearly, it's not a good enough answer because he doesn't relent his hold on her. In fact, he leans in close to her neck, mumbling against it.

"*I mean it." Then his teeth scrape against the skin there, drawing out a gasp and another fit of giggles.*

"*Okay!" she laughs out, trying to squirm away from his attacks. "Okay, fine! I'll be good." Then she raises her hands, poised to replace his when he moves away.*

"*That's my girl." And then he's gone, warmth vanished and footsteps walking away and leaving her standing there, anxiously switching from foot-to-foot. She's tempted to part her fingers and gain just* one *small glimpse, but knows that she's not the best actress and it wouldn't fool him for even a fraction of a second. So she stands there and waits until she feels a hand at her elbow, pulling her and guiding her forwards and through the door that he's holding open for her.*

The air conditioning raises the hair on her arms, painting her skin in goose pimples. Warm, soft thumbs smooth over it, sending shivers throughout her being as she's led further into the building they entered, eyes still covered by her own hands.

When they reach a stopping point again, she goes to drop her hands, only for Aiden to cover them with his own, holding them in place.

"*Not until I say, okay?"*

And she can only nod, obediently following his wishes.

Another voice somewhere in front of them greets them, even calling Aiden by name. His official *title. The one he'll adopt after taking charge of his family's business.*

"*You have it ready for me, yes?"*

"*Of course, sir. I'll get it for you right away."*

There's the telltale sound of footsteps falling away, presumably leaving them alone once more.

Adora grins wrly, twisting to face behind her even though she can't see where Aiden's standing or see his face. "What is all of this about anyway?"

A pair of arms slides around her waist, looping around her and pulling her backwards until she collides with the hard plane of his chest. Immediately, he hunches over and lips latch on to her neck, skimming along the skin hot and wet, and she flushes deeply at the thought of the person from before coming back to find them in this position. She squirms in his hold in an attempt to pull away only for his grip to tighten, jerking her back roughly and pressing her hips closer to his own body.

"*A-Aiden!"*

"*Patience," he commands, voice low and husky. Her body stiffens, heartbeat quickening, but regardless, she obeys and stills and ceases fighting against him. "You'll see soon enough." And when his thumbs hook into the waistband of her jeans as he plants an open-mouthed kiss on the side of her neck, she swallows her discomfort and anxiety, knowing that bringing it up won't get him to relent.*

It's fine, really.

He always tells her not to worry so much.

So she relaxes into his touch, allows him to hungrily devour her neck as they stand there in wait.

When they hear footsteps again, Adora squirms in his grasp once more and this time he lets up. As the footsteps get closer, Adora does her best to quickly readjust herself, straightening up just in time for the person to reappear in front of them.

"*Here it is. I hope it's to your liking."*

And then Aiden's hands are covering her own again, fingers prying them from her eyes. "Well, why don't we ask the lady?"

When Adora is finally able to open her eyes, she has to blink and squint past the sudden brightness. Everything is blurry for a couple of seconds as she readjusts to her sight being returned to her. A moment passes and she's finally able to focus on her surroundings where she briefly registers that they seem to be in some kind of jewelry shop.

Her gaze hones in on the sales clerk before them, her hair wrapped in tight curls that cascade to her shoulders, ears accented with dangling pearls that match the string of them around her neck, rested against her navy blue ruffled blouse. In her hands she balances a thin, flat box, hinged open with a metal chain on full display inside. Adora leans in to get a better view, gasping through her nose sharply as she takes it in.

The chain is silver, shining under the fluorescents brilliantly in a way that is almost overly flashy. Dangling at the center of it is a small pendant in the shape of a heart. The heart-shaped diamond is inlaid into a metal backing that hooks around to hold the stone in place. The refractions of light bouncing off the cuts sparkles and glints in the overhead lighting, casting the necklace and surrounding velvet of the box in shimmering pricks of light that dazzle and steal the breath of anyone who has the privilege of gazing upon it.

*Most of all, it looks...*ridiculously *expensive. More than it ought to.*

She turns to give Aiden an unsure look, but he's already reaching around her, lifting the necklace from the box and holding it up so that it dangles in front of her face. "What do you think?"

It's too expensive. It's too flashy. It's too much.

"*It's perfect," she murmurs, knowing that's what he wants to hear.*

And when he smiles, teeth glinting and dazzling like the diamond, she knows she said the right thing. It makes her feel giddy. Like

she did good.

"*Let me put it on you."*

She turns obediently, brushing her loose hair over her shoulder to allow him to drape it around her neck. He clasps it, fingers brushing against her skin, and she shivers at the contact, pointedly looking away from the clerk who's been watching them this entire time. When he's finished, she turns back to him, flashing him a smile, fingers rising to delicately pinch the pendant and turn it carefully.

She feels ridiculous.

His eyes burn into her, raking over her face and chest, eyes lingering at the necklace that has now made its home around her neck. They're filled with pride, longing, possessiveness*.*

She feels beautiful.

And then he's drawing her in for a kiss, deeper and more intimate than they had any right to be doing in public, in front of a total stranger. But she can taste his want, she can feel his passion and love and she decides to not care. Not if he keeps kissing her like this or looking at her like she's the only thing that matters.

When they pull away, he looks over to the clerk, shoulders squared - his business stance. "Send the bill to my father. He'll handle everything." The clerk nods and thanks him for his business and then Adora is being led from the jewelry store by the hand, following in a red haze.

He pushes her against his car, pinning her to the door as his lips capture hers again, hands gripping her hips greedily. The sun beats down on them, but Adora knows that the heat she's feeling isn't from that.

Of course, her brain decides to ruin things. "Are you going to tell me how much this cost?"

He chuckles, because with him, cost is never a factor. Most girls would swoon over being spoiled as much as Aiden spoils her, but Adora worries too much and so she always asks questions, only to be told...

"*Don't worry about it."*

It's difficult, but she doesn't want to press and upset him. So she drops it. Like every other time.

"*Okay." The tail end of her response is muffled by his lips again, hot and heavy, engulfing her in fiery passion and desire and she can't help but melt. She always will under his touch. His molten gaze that sears every inch of her skin, tunnel visioned and piercing.*

The next time he pulls away, one of his hands moves from her hip to her mouth, thumb pulling on her bottom lip, and that gaze follows the motion. They darken with something more, something hidden, a black hole that sucks her in and leaves her shaking and drained. His other hand, scalding her hip, paws at the clothes there, and Adora's breath hitches.

"*Though, if you're that worked up over it, I know a way you can thank me."*

The message is clear.

She hesitates anyway.

"*I…" Adora bites her lip and tries to look away, tries not to be hooked so easily. "I have homework."*

He frowns. "Finals are over."

"*I'm taking that Maymester course." She frowns, bottom lip pulling against his hold as she pouts up at him. "I told you about it. Multiple times."*

"*Always the overachiever. Aren't you, Adorable?" He looks annoyed, the nickname sounding sour on his tongue where it should be sweet. He begins to pull away, taking his heat with him, and Adora lunges forward, not wanting him to be angry with her. Not when he had just been looking at her like she had strung up the moon and stars herself.*

She takes a deep breath. He waits patiently. Expectantly.

"*Drive me home first?"*

He smiles and her heart flutters, even though she notices it's not the same as before.

Aiden parks outside her apartment building. He doesn't like going inside. Not when Bow and Glimmer are home.

His fingers comb through her hair as she wipes off her mouth with the back of her hand. Large eyes look up at him from the car floor expectantly, waiting to hear some kind of praise. Hoping *to hear it.*

He gives it to her, readily and freely, with such a charming smile she wants to weep from happiness. "You're so gorgeous like this, you know that?" His hand slides down to cup her cheek and she leans into the touch, nuzzling her face into his warm palm.

She grins up at him, eyes half-lidded with content. "Was that enough of a 'thank you'?"

His laughter echoes in the backseat and she mirrors it with her own softer chuckles, the contagion spreading and infecting her. "It almost makes me want to take you back and buy you everything in that store."

Then his gaze turns thoughtful. She watches him curiously as his eyes drift over her face, looking for some answer to some war raging within him. She wants to reach out, offer her assistance, but knows that there's really nothing she can do besides wait for him to reach a conclusion on his own.

"*No," he decides, finally. "No, next time I take you to a jewelry store, you'll be there to pick out your engagement ring."*

Adora's eyes widen as her chest implodes. The sentiment came from nowhere; they'd never once discussed the topic of their future together, let alone marriage*. She hadn't even been aware it was something that's been on his mind. They'd both been busy with school and the prospects that awaited them on the other side, as well as the novelty of each other, to really consider something to that magnitude. Besides, isn't it a bit….soon? Their relationship is still fairly new and fresh. Adora wasn't even sure they were* ready *for that sort of discussion.*

None of that stops the fast-paced fluttering of her heart, the warmth that pumps through her veins and the swell of love and adoration and happiness that threatens to burst inside her.

"*Really?" It comes out in a hush. Like if she speaks too loud he'll take it back.*

But when he smiles down at her, thumb brushing along her cheekbone, she's assured that he really and truly *means it. Without a doubt in his mind, he* wants *her.*

Forever.

"*One day," he promises. "After we both get out of school and I start the process of taking over for my dad, I'll take you somewhere* much *nicer than that rundown place and buy you any engagement ring you choose. No limits. No restrictions." His hand moves back to card through her hair again and she sighs into the sensation. "Whatever you want, baby. Just say the word.*

"*Until then," he removes his hand from her hair where it falls to her chest, fingers pinching the pendant that hangs in front of it. "This will show everyone out there that you belong to me, got it?" She nods eagerly, mind still hazy with euphoria over his promises to love her always.*

His finger hooks onto the chain pulling it and she follows, obediently. "So don't ever take this off, hear me?"

"*I won't."*

"Adora? Hey, you okay?"

A voice - warbled and familiar - cuts into her thoughts abruptly and she's warped back to the present, eyes staring intently through a glass jewelry case. She blinks rapidly, trying to reorient her mind, before looking up to see dark eyes glazed over with concern staring back at her. Her hand paws at her clavicle, nails scratching in the absence of a weight that's long been lifted. She whips her hand back to her side.

Bow. Right.

Glimmer. Engagement ring. Helping Adam.

Adora nods, numbly, trying to shake the remnants of the sudden memory from her head, rooting herself back in her current surroundings while trying not to lose herself from the flurry of sudden emotions that came with her...recollections.

"Yeah." Her voice is raspy, but she pushes past it. "Yeah, I'm good." She smiles, but it's strained, and Bow sees through it right away.

Fortunately, he doesn't comment on it. Not straight-away, at least. "Adam thinks he's found 'the one'. He wants your opinion."

She nods again and turns to see Adam on the opposite end of the shop with one of the store clerks, holding a small piece of jewelry up to the light, scrutinizing it from every angle. Steeling herself, she walks over and stands next to him, looking up at the ring.

He grins when she appears, but she doesn't miss how it falters when he takes in her current state. "Yo, Adobo. You sick or something? That sub not agreein' with ya?" It's light-hearted and

obnoxious on the surface, but behind all his taunts are soft eyes that ask the real question, "*Are you okay?*"

Pressing her lips together, she squints up at the ring. "I don't know how you expect me to see it when you're holding it up so high."

Without any other comments, Adam drops his hand to hand her the ring so that she can look over it properly. She takes it gingerly, turning it over in her hand.

It's a bit much for her personal tastes, but once again, Adora reminds herself that she can't base her decision based on her own biases. This is all for Glimmer. *Glimmer*.

The band is gold with a pink diamond centered on top, wrapped in the interlocking threads of the metal. On either side is a silver plated rose with two overlapping leaves off to one side, a smaller, plain diamond embedded in the center of the rose bloom. It's simple though not overly so, and when Adora thinks about it, she can picture it proudly sitting on Glimmer's ring finger for all the world to gawk at.

"I think this one is good. She'll love it."

Adam practically snatches the ring back from her grasp and holds it out to the store clerk with an almost manic grin. "This one! I'll take this one!"

The store clerk beams at the both of them, a cookie-cutter retail smile. "Excellent! What's her ring size?"

Adam deflates, despair overtaking him as he finally realizes the single flaw in his plan.

Behind them, Bow swoops in for the rescue. "Nine."

Adam shoots him a grateful grin before looping the crook of his elbow around Bow's neck and pinching his cheek, much to Bow's chagrin. "I *knew* there was a reason I invited you along!"

As Adam sorts out the payment information and setting a date for pickup after the ring adjustment, Bow and Adora decide to wait outside of the store. Or, rather Adora sprinted towards the door and Bow followed leaving behind a trail of worry. She doesn't acknowledge any of the looks he sends her way. She doesn't even acknowledge her own clawing thoughts, preying on her moment of vulnerability and prodding her with questions she didn't want to think about.

Soon enough, Adam joins them outside, shoulders pulled back and chin held high. She tries to put on a happy face for him, knowing that this is the start of one of the happiest times of his life, but she can't help but feel a cold bitterness tainting her every movement.

"Thanks guys. Don't know if I could've done this without you. You two are Glimmer's best friends, so I knew if there was anyone who'd know what she'd like, it would be you." Bow waves off his praise and Adora says nothing at all. He cocks his head to the side, eyeing her for a short moment. She doesn't miss the look that he exchanges with Bow next and she wants nothing more than to go home and escape all this.

He doesn't say anything to her though. "Welp! Think I'm gonna go home and start plotting some hiding spots. It'll be tough finding a place she won't get into, so I gotta start scouting now." He gives them a two-fingered salute and with one last thank you and a goodbye, he's gone.

Adora turns to Bow, about to announce her own departure when Bow cuts her off. "When do you have to pick up Mara from Cynthia and Viv's?"

She checks her phone and frowns. "Not for another two hours," she answers honestly, but she knows where this is heading and she's decidedly not in the mood. But before she can come up with another excuse as a reason to leave, he drops a hand on her upper arm, giving her that signature Bow Smile™. Predictably, it

forces her guard down, which she knows is exactly what he wants.

"I'm really craving some ice cream right now. What about you?"

When she hesitates for a beat, he leans in closer, turning up the charm.

"I'll pay~"

Grumbling, she knows that she lost this battle before she even walked out of the store. Might as well get it over with. "It's your wallet's funeral," she grits out.

Bow manages to find them a little secluded spot at one of the outdoor patio tables. The day is nice enough - warmer than any of the others in the past week. A few other people are outside, taking advantage of one of the last warmer days with the harsh frost of the winter months slowly encroaching. But ultimately, they're not a problem and really aren't even paying them any mind.

Adora knows what he's doing but she pretends otherwise. As if refusing to acknowledge it will help her avoid the inevitable.

Their topic of conversation stays delicately away from any mention of the jewelry store. With some prompting, Adora gets Bow talking more about his thesis despite knowing she won't be able to keep up, if only to get him rambling. It works. For a little while anyway.

Bow twists his spoon in his ice cream, lecture fading when he noticed the glazed over look in her eyes that told him that his words were sliding in one ear and out the other, nothing sticking. He tilts his head at her, which she pointedly looks away from, before sighing.

"Do you want to talk about earlier?"

She doesn't try to play dumb. He's too attentive for that. Plus, no point in trying to pull one over on a psych major of all people. Instead, she stabs at her half-finished ice cream with her own spoon, scooping up a large mouthful and shovels it into her mouth.

"No," she says curtly, voice garbled. Then, with resignation pushing down on her shoulders, she drops her spoon into her cup and leans back in her chair, gulping down the quickly melting ice cream. "But I know you do. So where do you want me to start?"

"Wherever you want."

She nods and crosses her legs, then her arms. Shooting him a look, eyes narrowed, she says, "Okay. But if we're going to do this? You need to turn off 'Psychologist Bow' and just be 'Friend Bow', got it?"

He makes a show of drawing an "X" over his heart before clasping his hands together like he's about to pray.

Slightly amused by his display, knowing that it came from a place of purest intentions, she relaxes marginally. If there's anyone she can vent to, especially about all of this, it's Bow. Probably the least judgemental out of the entire circle of friends and certainly the kindest and most willing to provide whatever she needs - a listening ear, shoulder to perch on and cry, even the occasional advice or gentle encouragement.

Still...after years of leaving most of this behind her, it's not easy to bring herself to dredge it up again. She hardly wants to deal with it herself. After all that she'd been through, she'd thought it'd been long buried.

But lately, it's been cropping up again, little by little, like budding weeds, stretching and straining to break the surface and flourish in the exposure of light. She doesn't know why.

She has some ideas though.

"Do you…" She tries to start but trails off, unsure how she wants to phrase this, how much she's up for revealing. "Do you ever feel like everyone else is happy and moving on with their lives, Bow?"

When she leaves a large enough pause, Bow steps up, treading carefully. "Well...maybe. But that's a good thing, isn't it? Seeing our friends happy?"

Quickly, she jerks up in her chair and slams her elbows into the table by accident in her haste. "No, no no, like...Of *course* I want them to be happy!" she clarifies. "I'm glad, you know. I'm glad that they're happy but…" She trails off again, trying to collect her dissolving thought process.

"It makes you realize that you're missing that own happiness and fulfillment in your life? And seeing them so happy instills something bitter in you that's fueled further by the fact that it seems like everyone is purposefully shoving it in your face?"

She turns on him, glaring. "Hey! I said '*Friend Bow*'!"

Bow holds his hands up defensively. "They overlap sometimes!"

With only a finger pointed at his face in warning, she continues. "Well, anyways...yeah. That." She sighs and drops her hand back to the table, watching her melting ice cream with a sour taste in her mouth. She nudges it away with two fingers so she can slump further down. "Does that make me a bad person?"

"Of course not. Why do you think it does?"

Adora narrows her eyes, wondering if this is another therapy-psychoanalysis tactic, but she sees only genuine concern. "I...don't know. Because I *say* I'm happy for them, but really I'm just bitter and jealous because I don't have what they have?"

"Well," Bow swirls around his milky ice cream, pooling some of it onto his spoon to slurp into his mouth. "Do you want them to not be happy?"

"What?" Her eyes widen and she shoots up, looking at him as if he'd pulled a knife and threatened to stab a puppy. "No! Never!"

"Then you're not a bad person." He shrugs, as if it's that simple.

She wants to let herself believe it is. But things are so much more complicated than her just being lonely.

"You know," she starts, voice lowered to a near-whisper. "Aiden...he said he wanted to marry me one day."

Bow sputters, spoon falling from his mouth and clattering to the woven metal of the table. He looks at her incredulously, leaning forward as if he'd somehow misheard. "Whoa, wait...wait he *what*?"

Adora winces, suddenly reminded why she never brought it up before. But after today, after being reminded of his broken promise - his *lie* - she figures it's finally time to come clean. "Yeah. Said he planned to actually propose and all that after we graduated." She chews on her thumbnail, recalling all of their conversations where they planned their future together. Well, *he* planned their future. Adora just went along with every word he said, riding the high of someone promising her forever, promising to never leave.

But everyone *always* leaves.

She chases them away.

"Oh." She can see the dots starting to connect in his head, a sad and uncomfortable realization dawning ever-so-slowly in his dark eyes. "*Ohhhh*."

"Yeah. I didn't mean to ruin Adam's day but I guess it dredged up some memories. Reminded me of what I almost had." She bites her lips to stave off the onslaught of tears. "What I'm never *going* to have."

"Hey, wait." Bow reaches out, laying a comforting hand on her shoulder. "Don't say that."

"Well it's *true*!" she snaps. When he looks ready to protest, she scoffs and keeps going. "Seriously, Bow. What person wants to be with someone who already has a kid?"

"Plenty of people," he answers plainly, as if it's the most obvious thing in the world. "Those people do exist and they are out there, Adora."

"Yeah, well," she falters, looking back down at the table, attention briefly caught by her completely melted ice cream. "I don't exactly have time to hunt them down."

"Maybe they'll find you."

Adora wants to laugh. Yeah, sure. She knows that Bow is just trying to help and any other time she'd appreciate his sincerity. But right now, it's grating on her nerves and she realizes she doesn't want to talk about this anymore. She's tired.

"Yeah, well...maybe someone should give them a GPS or something. Speed up the process a little." She chuckles, even if it isn't as full or hearty as it normally would be. She just wants to diffuse the tension and change topics already.

Bow, sensing this, waggles his eyebrows with a sly grin. "You could always give Tinder a shot."

Adora groans, throwing her head back. "No. Nope. My Tinder days are *done*." She remembers being practically glued to the dumb app, matching with anyone and everyone as desperate as her, shortly after…

After Catra left her.

The weight in her chest sinks heavier and she grimaces. Seems she's just *meant* to drown in miserable memories of abandonment today. Serves her right for thinking she's allowed

to *want* anything. Every time she tries, the universe spits in her face and rips it all away as punishment for indulging in selfishness.

She really just needs to learn how to let these things go. Save herself the disappointment and heartache.

"It's fine, really." She stuffs her napkin into her abandoned ice cream cup. "I'm busy with Mara anyway. Picking her up, dropping her off, getting her to do her homework...I'm booked really." She sighs, resigning herself to the fact she already knew. "I wouldn't even have time for a relationship. It's better this way."

Bow looks like he wants to say something, but thinks better of it. Instead he picks up his own ice cream cup and stands up. "Well, make sure that if someone ever *does* come around you don't push them back out for the wrong reasons."

And there it is. "Psychologist Bow". Back for one last appearance.

Instead of berating him for it, she brushes him off with a wave of her hand. "Yeah, yeah. But I mean it. Mara's my whole life right now." Her tone softens. "She's my whole world. I can't risk wrecking that too just because I'm feeling a little sad." She checks her phone and flies out of her chair. "Oh crap! Speaking of, I need to go pick her up. Can't keep Cynthia and Viv waiting."

She sees Bow pull out his phone too and rushes in gathering her things before he can call her out on her lie. "Anyways, thanks for the ice cream! See you later!"

With a short wave she's walking away from the table at a brisk pace, keeping up the appearance that she's in a rush to get Mara. Truthfully, she still has another forty-five minutes. But she knows that the longer she sits and talks to Bow about all of this, the more the truth will sink in:

She's afraid.

Afraid to love again. Afraid to let someone back in only to have them trample all over her heart. Afraid of history repeating itself, over and over and over again because she just *can't* seem to learn her lesson.

But most of all, she's afraid that Catra coming back into her life is just her setting herself up to be hurt all over again.

And she's terrified that she's not sure she minds. As long as she stays for just a little while.

Above all else, she just wants *one* chance, *one* time where she's allowed to be selfish. And that the universe won't punish her for it.

Because she wants Catra. She just isn't sure in what way anymore.

Chapter End Notes

> Heyo~ I haven't forgotten about this fic. I just was struggling for awhile and ended up having to rewrite the entire beginning because I just could not progress.
>
> HOW ABOUT THAT FINALE GUYS???? *SCREAMS* And I feel validation in this Chili's tonight.
>
> But legit, another reason this took so long is because I've been busy writing post-s5 fics. I actually have two up if you haven't checked those out yet (please validate me).
>
> Another reason I took so long with this is because I was trying to finish up the semester and finals were a bitch (as usual). BUT! The good news?
>
> I GRADUATED BITCHES!!!!!! :DDDDDDDDD Class of 2020 babey!!!! Take THAT corona!! (Now comes the job hunting...ick)

Moving on, some songs that really helped me write this chapter: Had by TeZATalks & Guest Room by Echos. Check them out because it really illustrates Adora's feelings towards Mara's father. Or...well, I guess I can FINALLY start saying his name now! Thank god too because I cannot tell y'all how many times I almost slipped up lmao

Now....art!!! I have a few pieces here by the lovely @TheDorkizoid on twitter! Here's some character sketches he did and then a scene from Chapter 10! Thank you so much I genuinely teared up getting these c:

Remember if you ever draw art for this, do not hesitate to tag me on my tumblr or twitter. I LOVE to see it. It makes my day.

Also, if anyone's curious: Glimmer's engagement ring & Adora's necklace

What else....oh! Yeah so I'm still in the process of actually naming all my chapters (still trying to find titles for a few). They're all song lyrics, so bonus points to anyone who can guess the songs I'm using (no google because that's CHEATING!)

Anyways, I'll shut up now because I know this author's note is about to be as long as the chapter itself lol

Until next time~!

take an angel by the wings; beg her now for anything....

Chapter Summary

TIME FOR PIE! TIME FOR PIE! TIME FOR PIE!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She can feel their stares.

She's never really paid much mind to her classmates before. Granted, the semester had just started a couple weeks prior, so it's not like she had the time to get to know many of them anyway. But with everything she's been through the past few weeks - finding out she's pregnant, toiling over the anxiety of what that means for her future and the fact that she doesn't feel nearly ready to be a mother, and then everything with Aiden….

It hasn't been a priority of hers.

Class doesn't start for another fifteen minutes. The professor hasn't even arrived, which means that the class has free reign to be a little more rambunctious without the pressure of being monitored. Conversations echo in the small space; most of them are mundane retellings of weekend adventures or complaints about heavy workloads so earlier on in the semester. But every so often, she hears the hushed tones that prick her skin, hears the scandal and judgement that ooze off their indecipherable words. And when she risks a glance, she finds eyes quickly darting away and maliciously humored grins straining against pressed lips.

Adora takes out her notebook, ignoring the burning at the back of her neck, and tries to put it all out of her mind. She shouldn't care. She doesn't *care.*

The pang in her chest betrays her and she thinks back to Aiden again, like she has been for the past four weeks. The pure disgust that marred his face before he walked away, the unbridled anger that tightened his grip around her arm that brought panicked tears to her eyes as they fought in the parking lot…

It makes sense that word spread so quickly. Aiden's never been shy with his words, probably never knew the meaning of prudency. It's something that always put her off while they were dating, but she attributed it to his powerful aura - as Perfuma would call it - that commanded people's attention that he easily gave in to like a ruler speaking to his subjects. She always brushed it off, even when his tales were too transparent and personal, because she knew it would just spark an argument if she tried to combat it. At the time, all it cost her was a shredded veil of privacy and mild discomfort.

Now...now she's the target of the ire of most of the business majors, exchanging gossip and jests at her expense as they laugh at her from just a few feet away. Finding humor in her circumstances, berating her idiocy and carelessness.

A part of her wants to turn on them, level a glare and let them know that she's aware of their immaturity and hushed taunts. She wants to show them that she isn't one to take their ridicule sitting down and just shut them up for good*.*

But ultimately, she knows it won't make a difference. It won't bring him back. It won't change their opinions of her. It won't undo what's already been done because once the clock hands move forward, they can't turn back. She's made her choices and now she has to live with the consequences.

Besides, she's still broken and raw from the emotional whiplash of the past month and as much as she believes she would be unwavering in her challenge, she knows that all it would take is a couple of choice words to bring her crashing back down.

It'd be easy to blame the hormones. But the truth is….she's a coward that doesn't know how to stand up for herself anymore. Maybe she never did. Otherwise she'd never be here in the first place.

So she opts to sit there quietly, head ducked down as she doodles across the margins of her notebook, and waits for class to begin. But she can still feel their stares, can practically hear their thoughts, and it wittles her down more and more until - just two minutes before class is supposed to begin - she feels like storming out and going back home to hide underneath her covers.

It feels like some twisted version of high school all over again.

Before she can divulge in her desire to flee and not look back, leaving the trails of venomous whispers in her wake, the professor calls everyone's attention to the front of the classroom as he rattles off announcements of upcoming assignments due. Adora takes a deep breath to steel herself and shifts in her seat to root herself in place to tough out the next hour and fifteen minutes.

Just before he can dive into the day's material, the classroom door swings with a clank *and everyone's attention turns to see an older woman with hunched shoulders stumbling in. She stands there for a moment and most people lose interest fairly quickly and turn back to the front. Squinting through round, coke-bottle glasses, she grips her wooden walking stick that stretches past her height and scans the room, before her eyes linger exactly where Adora sits.*

A flash of panic zings her nervous system, her anxieties of being perceived and talked about from earlier putting her on edge. But after a moment, she realizes it's because the only empty seats sit on either side of her which is probably what the woman was looking for. It allows her to relax, marginally, but there's a brief stab of annoyance when she remembers why *the only empty seats are by her.*

They wouldn't admit to it if she accused them, but she knows that since everyone apparently knows about her predicament, most of them have made it a point to sit as far removed from her as possible, quarantining her to her own little space.

It's not contagious, *for fuck's sake.*

Moving past the slight interruption, the professor begins the introduction of the class lesson for the day, and Adora turns to face the front again, but tries to stay on alert for when the woman inevitably comes her way. She takes a few notes from the slide presentation he has plastered on the pull-down screens when she hears a shuffling to her left. Sure enough, there's the woman, gray hair tinted...pink? and pulled back into a braid that falls down to her waist. Her hair is erratic and looks fried, in all honesty, but Adora supposes that at that age, appearances mean less and less. Not that she certainly doesn't have a way of expressing herself.

She's seen the woman before. She was a late addition to the class (she remembers overhearing her conversation with the professor about a schedule mix-up) but regardless, she's still been here for a majority of the semester. Obviously, being so far beyond the median age group of everyone else there, she isn't particularly talkative with many of the other students, but it never seems to bother her. It's not an odd occurrence for people her age to partake in college classes; Adora has seen her fair share of older adults taking classes to finish up degrees never finished, or simply because their jobs have offered them money to take a class in lieu of training. Even still, it's rare enough that it's noticeable, and this woman seemed to take that and sprint *with it.*

The best way to describe the woman - as harsh as it sounds - is that she's….well, kind of kooky. The kind that one expects to find on intersection corners where they have to kindly avert their eyes in order to be passed by and ignored. But she also seems kind enough, from the way she carries herself and smiles at everyone around her, even when it's never returned.

Her clothes are...eccentric? It's hard to place a solid or singular description on them. If Adora had to attribute a particular vibe to them, she imagines it's something close to what Perfuma might wear once she starts getting on in age with a dash of cottagecore grandma. Dresses of purples and pinks and reds, patterned and not, hang over her frame with a variety of accessories adorning them. Shawls of knitted wool (and even one made entirely of what might have very well been real bird feathers) with beads or flowers or those little colorful cotton balls stitched on. Her ears drooped with heavy earrings, weighed down with colorful glass beads, chains of metals, trinkets and charms and tassels and gems and crystals and feathers - if it could be attached, it was. Her movements were always obvious to everyone in the room, wooden and glass and plastic beads from her sleeves of bracelets bouncing and skimming across the surface of her desk as she took notes. Around her neck was typically the same, though sometimes she had floral and tribal and paisley scarves tucked into her neckline as well.

All-in-all, she's about as kooky, eccentric grandma as one could get.

This is probably the closest Adora has ever gotten to her. The older woman always had a habit of coming into class at the last possible second, if not late by a couple minutes, and as a result, would often be relegated to sitting in whatever empty seats were available. Before now, they were often nowhere near her. But then Aiden happened, and rumors spread quickly, and now she's facing the reality and being treated like some animal or odd creation in a cage to be looked at from afar, heralded solely for the bemusement of others.

Now, with a closer look, Adora notices the detail and care that go into her outfits. Sure, it's still a conglomeration of mix-matched clothing and accessories, something that can be defined as an eyesore, but it's not as patched together or haphazard as it seems from a distance. Everything is neatly arranged, pressed and aligned in a way that draws attention to every aspect of her outfit - purposefully chaotic.

Another quirk to being this close to her is catching the pungent and powerful scent of her perfume. She smells of mothballs, flour, incense, and vanilla - a cacophony of smells that on paper should have been overwhelming and distasteful. And though it's very present and hits Adora with a wave each time that the woman shifts, she finds that they interweave with each other in just the right ways that give it a sense of nostalgia and familiarity. Like safety and home and quiet sunny afternoons in the kitchen as something boils on the stove. And in the living room, the drawl of a retrograde television that's more static than image buzzing in the corner, background noise to whatever mundane activities occupy them.

At some point, Adora realizes she's staring and quickly turns away with a rush of shame, doubling down on her note-taking. It goes smoothly for a minute, but then she feels a gentle tap on her upper arm and looks up to the woman's kind, wrinkled smile.

"*Excuse me, dearie. Would you happen to have a pencil I could borrow? I seem to have misplaced all of mine."*

Immediately, Adora's eyes are drawn to the braid trailing down the woman's back, noticing about three pencils and two pens jutting out of it. "Um…"

A moment passes before the woman seems to catch on to where Adora's gaze has centered on and she lifts her hands behind her head, patting down her braid and giving a raspy chuckle when one of the knocks into the array of writing utensils sticking from her braid like a porcupine. "Oh! Silly me! Must have forgotten about these." She unsheathes one of the pencils and waves it in Adora's face like a wand, crow's feet dancing at the corners of her eyes. "Makes ya wonder what else I've lost in there! So many years of lost treasures that wandered off and got lost in the depths of the forest, no stars to guide them back home!"

"*Um…" Adora leans back, trying to avoid losing an eye to the sharpened point of the pencil. "Yeah. I guess." She's not really sure what an appropriate response to that is.*

Somewhere behind her, she hears a muffled snort and burns hot, knowing that on top of everything else, now she's got "talks to crazy old women" added to her rap sheet. She ducks her head down again, turning away from the woman. When she lifts her head to look at the clock, she notices that class has only been going for five minutes and groans internally.

Luckily, the rest of the class goes by without many other interruptions or incidents. The professor drawls on about the economics of Eastern Europe, something she's already vaguely aware of, so her focus lapses every now and again. Looking out across the sea of blank faces, she knows she's not the only one. The only one who still seems attentive is the woman sitting next to her, who's paused in her note-taking entirely and instead has her chin propped on her bridged fingers, leaning forward as she listens.

"*So what I want you all to do for the next five minutes is to turn to the person next to you and discuss some of the potential causes that led to the Great Recession in Greece, the impact those had on the economy, and maybe even what could've been done to prevent such a large economic collapse. Try to be thoughtful with your answers and when discussing the impact, try to think beyond the fact that the economy suffered and more what that* meant *for the society and country as a whole. We'll spend some time with that and then come together and share some of the things you talked about individually."*

Partner next to them? Adora glances towards the woman who has yet to look her way. Right. Of course. Great.

She turns her eyes back down before the woman can look her way, wondering if maybe she can just brainstorm some ideas of her own. She knows enough about the Great Recession personally actually, having family over in Greece who talked about it (and still do sometimes). It'd be easy enough to do this on her own. Of course, she risks being rude, but she wonders if the woman would even notice as she seemingly seems to be off in her own world at

any given time. Besides, it's not like she isn't used to it - no one really talks to her, so she's probably used to being ignored.

A pit weighs heavy in her stomach. That doesn't mean that she should treat her the same way. And considering that she now knows what it's like to be avoided in a class of her peers…

Before she can come to a decision of her own, however, the woman is speaking to her, ripping her attention away from her own inner struggles.

"*I'm afraid my mind may have wandered during some of that last bit. I don't know a terrible amount about Greek economics."*

Adora blinks and straightens up. She shifts her notebook, taking a breath in as she readjusts her position. Okay. Yeah. She's doing this.

"*It's okay. I actually know a lot about this. I have family over there that were there when it happened."*

The woman's eyes light up. "Oh! How fun! Have you been there yourself?"

"*Yeah, actually. A few times. Not too recently though." Adora shifts again, bringing her notebook closer to try and bring them back on track. "Um, so-"*

"*Does your family know?"*

Adora frowns in confusion, only slightly irritated by another derailment. "Do they know what?"

The woman chuckles and her gaze drops for a short second, eyes crinkling with her gentle smile. "The baby, dearie! Do they know about the baby?"

Adora freezes in her seat, veins turning to ice as the cold grips her heart. Immediately, she tugs at the bottom of her hoodie, pulling it out in an effort to cover up her stomach. She'd been wearing

her baggiest shirts and hoodies lately, trying to divert attention from the small bump already growing, to alleviate some of the stares and attention that's already piling on her day-by-day. Did she slip up? Does she need something bigger? Or is it all just fruitless?

She swallows, noticing the difficulty in the simple action, and looks away, feeling the back of her neck burn and hearing the whispers echo in her head. "I…"

Before she can spiral any further, she feels a gentle hand over her own shaking fist. A bony thumb strokes the smooth skin of the back of her hand and Adora chances a glance up, cursing how blurry her vision has gotten.

"*It's nothing to be ashamed of, dearie. The ability to create life is one of the most magical gifts that we've been graced with. There is a raw power in it that nothing can compare to." She leans forward, a humored grin on her lips that belies some secret joke that Adora isn't privy to. "Though, I suppose as someone who is a mother, I can understand the difficulties and struggles that come with it as well. But...I believe that is part of what makes the whole ordeal so magnificent, no? The perseverance, the* strength *and will that must go into the process," her eyes sweep the room and Adora follows her gaze reluctantly. Everyone around them is busy talking to their partners, most of them not even about the assignment. "Some people simply cannot understand the trials that one must endure to achieve such a feat. Worrying about what people who don't understand may think of someone who does, well, it's a waste of time if you ask me," she ends with a resolute nod, leaning back with a final pat to Adora's hand.*

Adora sits there, stunned. In all honesty, she had expected the same level of judgement - if not one of a higher caliber - from the older woman. To be pregnant out of wedlock? Isn't that something that most older people are vehemently against?

Then again, she also can't say that the woman's words were entirely out of left field. Given the way she acts and dresses, she

seems to be more lenient and understanding than most people her age. Kinder too.

She supposes most of her shock comes from how observant the old woman is, considering that she normally seemed so lost in her own world and thoughts. Adora didn't know that she isn't as oblivious as she lets on.

And most of all, her words were comforting. Though her anxieties couldn't be wiped away so easily with a few encouragements, it's a nice breath of relief compared to everything else she's been subjected to lately from her own peers. Even her professors weren't as kind to her when she finally relayed the information as a warning, all of them mostly concerned with how it might affect her performance in their classes as they believed she would use it as a crutch to slack off.

Aside from her friends and her mother, this woman is perhaps the first person to offer her what no one else thought to: acceptance.

"*Alright class, let's settle down and discuss some of…"*

The remainder of class is dedicated to sharing and discussing what they'd all talked about individually. But Adora finds that she can't maintain her focus on the conversation, instead replaying the woman's words over and over in her head, letting them permeate her and sink in. She thinks about the weight behind the woman's words and how she may not even be aware of how much they carried. She thinks about all that she's been through, with Aiden, with the uncertainty and fear, the indecision and the pain, and how she's barreled through it all in spite of the hand she's been dealt. She's come out on the other side of it all and is still standing and breathing, moving forward from one day to the next.

And everyone around her who judged her...they wouldn't know what she's feeling. They wouldn't care. In fact, she suspects most of them expect her to fail, to sink so low that she can never climb back to the surface.

Aiden most of all.

She screws her mouth into a grimace, brows furrowed in determination as she begins packing her bag after the professor dismisses them. She wouldn't give them the satisfaction. She's strong. She's already come so far. She had the will to carry her forwards and she would show everyone that she couldn't be reduced to the simple jabs they speared her with.

As she zips up her bag, the woman taps her again, and Adora pauses long enough to look over at her. Looking into those kind eyes magnified by her glasses, she considers thanking the woman for her kind words earlier. Instead, the woman speaks first.

"*Do you have any classes after this?"*

Adora frowns in confusion. "Um...no. I don't actually. I was just about to head home."

The woman in turn smiles, turning sheepish. "Would you mind helping an old woman understand these Greek economics then? You said you know quite a lot about them and I've just been so lost with all these people talking." When Adora hesitates, she presses on. "We could go to my house and I could make you some tea and something to eat." Her eyes flicker downwards and there's a warmth and nostalgic joy in them. "I'm sure you both must be very hungry."

Adora bites her lip, considering carefully before giving a slow nod. "Yeah, okay. That sounds fine." It's the least she can do, right? Then, something occurs to her. "I'm Adora, by the way."

The woman smiles wider and something glints in her eyes - a flash of recognition, lost to time, distant and present all at once. "You may call me Madame Razz."

"Coming!"

Adora wipes her hands down the front of the apron tied around her waist, dusting off the excess flour and sugar. She pushes the mixing bowl she'd been working on further back on the counter before half-skipping out of the kitchen to the front entrance. After unlocking the door, she swings it open to find Catra in the apartment hall, her chin-length hair tucked underneath a maroon beanie. In her hands is a rectangular glass container with aluminum foil covering the top.

"You're just in time! We just started making the pies."

"And here I was hoping I could avoid doing any work." She smirks and steps into the apartment when Adora steps aside. "Hey, could I put this in the fridge?"

"Yeah, of course."

Together, they head to the kitchen with Catra making an immediate beeline for the fridge, placing her dish on the bottom shelf before turning to be greeted with Adora holding out an extra apron. She takes it, looking over the quoted text on the front. An amused smirk breaks out on her face and she turns it around, eyes flashing.

"'I bake because punching people is frowned upon'?"

Adora rolls her eyes. "Adam got it for me. Said something about my 'anger issues' or whatever."

Catra chuckles and throws the top loop around her neck, reaching to knot the strings behind her back. "Did you punch him?"

"Of course I punched him."

Mara, who is standing on one of the kitchen chairs pulled up to the counter, looks up from her task of plucking the leaves off of a bowl of strawberries and fixes her mother with a squinty glare. Her nose scrunches up adorably, drowning whatever intimidation effect she was possibly hoping to convey.

"Hey! You say-ed that punching isn't very *nice*!"

Ignoring how Catra is sputtering with barely constrained laughter, Adora turns to her daughter, placing a gentle hand on her head and brushing back stray wisps of hair. "You are so right, baby girl. But this was a very long time ago and Mommy already said sorry to Uncle Adam." Well, that's a lie but it's not like Mara could call her out on it.

Mara scrutinizes her for a moment more, before her face softens marginally and she nods in a stiff, approving manner. "Okay. Good. You hafta play nice with others." She turns back to the strawberries, pudgy fingers plucking off more leaves. "Or you gotta sit in time-out." Mara looks back up quickly with a smile, hand patting Adora's arm. "But it's okay. I'll give you a warming this time."

Adora smirks and quirks a single eyebrow. "You're giving me a *warning*?"

"Uh-huh." She carries on, not even noticing that she was corrected. "But you only get *one*!"

Behind her, Catra has her hip cocked against the counter, arms crossed over her chest. "Yeah, Adora. You only get *one* warning before you go into time-out."

If someone had told her months ago that having her best friend back in her life would mean that she would team up against her with her daughter well… actually, Adora wouldn't have been very surprised at all. It's exactly on brand for Catra.

Even still, she turns back and sticks her tongue out at Catra, displaying her own grand level of maturity. It earns her one of Catra's signature cackles, shrill and so full of delight that something deep - distant and timeless and nostalgic - pangs in Adora's chest as she watches her. A few seconds pass where she just openly stares, watching the way that Catra's shoulders shake and her lips pull to reveal pointed canines, and an image flashes:

Catra with her hair well past her shoulders wearing a dark red tank top and black choker, Adora's letterman around her shoulders so she wouldn't get dress-coded for the fifth time in three weeks.

Adora blinks dumbly and the image vanishes, leaving only a curious short-haired Catra staring at her.

Snapping out of it, she reaches over to the counter and slides a piece of paper Catra's way. "Well, since you have time to joke and laugh, you might as well start mixing the second batch for the pie crust. I already have the ingredients out-" she gestures to them with a sweep of her hand "-so all you have to do is follow the instructions."

Catra plucks the paper off the counter and drums her nails against the countertop with her free hand. "Wait, so you don't buy your crust? You make it from scratch?"

Adora chuckles and nudges an empty mixing bowl closer. Pre-bought, frozen pie crust? She can hear Razz now…

"*Shortcuts are for the ignorant and the unskilled."*

"Get to work, Jauregui."

They take the bus to Razz's house. Glimmer had dropped Adora off on campus earlier that morning so she didn't have her car, and apparently Razz had her license suspended nearly two decades prior and never bothered to get it reinstated.

"*My eyes aren't what they used to be antywho," she explains on the bus ride over. Adora raises her brows at the unique word choice, but doesn't comment on it, opting to clutch her bag tighter to her chest. "Not that I did much driving before then anyway. This bus gets me anywhere my old legs can't carry me."*

Once they get off, they still have to trek down the street of a quiet cul-de-sac. The biting wind of February nestles its way through the slips and cracks of Adora's winter jacket and she shivers

against the wind violently the whole way. When she looks over to Razz, she expects her to look much the same, if not worse because of her age, but she seems rather unbothered by it all. As if she doesn't notice it, or is on another plane of existence entirely where Jack Frost can't traverse.

As they reach the end where the road opens up into a circle, Razz finally glances back at her and sees the way her arms are wrapped around herself, nose and cheeks a rosy red. She gasps and reaches back, looping her hand in the crook of Adora's elbow.

"*Oh Mara dearie, why didn't you say you were cold?" She tuts and pulls Adora along faster, somehow spry and energetic for someone surely well into their eighties. "Let's get you inside and I'll put on some nice, hot tea, yes?"*

Adora sighs at the thought, eager to get out of the cold. But then it occurs to her….Mara? Who is that?

She thinks of asking, but thinks better of it and shakes her head to clear the thought. Perhaps she misheard. Or, alternatively, maybe Razz had misheard her earlier when she introduced herself. And if that is the case, it would be easy to correct if she brought it up again.

Razz begins to lead them down a dirt and gravel path through a stretch of trees on either side - a mini forest that, during warmer months, must be so dense with life and greenery that it bordered on magical. But for now the trees are barren, skeletal branches chafing against each other with each gust as leftover broken leaves from autumn whisper as they skirt across the ground. The trees are skinny and don't offer much buffer from the wind. So when the walkway tapers off into a larger, more open little courtyard that stretches before a squat, cottage-style house, Adora practically weeps in relief.

It's a one-story house, with a worn cobbled pathway leading from the courtyard to the front door. Forest-green shuttered circle windows sit on either side, like ancient, kind eyes overlooking the

little alcove they've found themselves in. The stretch of trees that guided their hike to the house roll onwards, circling the area around to the back of the house, stretching further than Adora's eyes can see, even with the lack of foliage. Gnarled vines, brown and dry from the harsh weather, drape over the roof of the house like a straw wig, trailing down the outer walls and spiraling the brick chimney - laced armor, a protective knitted shawl of dormant life.

With the house so close in reach, it seems that Razz is even more eager to rush Adora along, pulling her with haste to the front door. They only pause at the door for Razz to rummage through her large sling bag that is more patches than the original material, muttering incoherently to herself. Adora holds herself and watches, shifting quickly from foot-to-foot in some weak effort to stave off the cold.

Eventually, Razz procures her ring of keys with a triumphant shout. But they stand there even longer as Razz sifts through the ungodly amount of keys she has - which has Adora wondering if she even needs *all of them - as she tries a few only for them to not work. Just when Adora is sure that she can no longer feel her nose because it fell off, one of the keys turns with a satisfying* click *and then Razz is ushering her inside.*

As soon as they pass the threshold, Adora can feel the burning warmth target her frozen bits; nose, ears, and cheeks stinging with the change of temperature. Her body violently shivers as the cold from outside slowly melts away. A sigh escapes her lips, and she's happy to see that it isn't condensed.

She has maybe only been standing there for a few seconds before Razz is pushing her further in, chattering away as she pulls at Adora's coat and scarf. Adora slips out of them easily, taking note that Razz tosses them absentmindedly on the couch that lines the walkway on her left. Spread out before the couch seems to be a sort of living room/sitting area, that is probably as large as her original dorm room from freshman year. Maybe a bit smaller.

It passes by in a blur as Razz guides her to sit in a chair at the long wooden table in the kitchen with promises to start on the tea immediately. Once she walks off into the kitchen, Adora allows herself to get settled in and comfortable, body slumping as her veins start pumping blood normally again, her limbs not as stiff as before. Now without the prominent threat of freezing half-to-death hanging over her head, she's able to better take in her surroundings.

The table she's seated at is covered in stacks of newspapers and open books - cookbooks, novels, old tomes with yellowed pages and faceless covers. They're scattered haphazardly with no real structure or sense of order. It sort of reminds Adora of her desk back in her room. Just with significantly less crushed plastic water bottles and more dirty mugs and tea plates. In the center amongst all the chaos is a mosaic patterned vase, chipped with pieces missing, that contains what look to be wilting wild daisies.

Across from her is the living room they passed by on the way in. The couch where her coat lies hanging over the back is certainly old but in pretty stable condition all things considered. It's a pearly off-white, the back and seat cushions lined with a shining plastic covering to prevent stains and the like. Opposite that, just diagonal to the table she sits at, is an armchair that doesn't match; it's a pea-green and far more loved, clearly, if evidenced by the wear and tear on the upholstery. There's no plastic on this one, possibly used more for comfort than presentation. A woven afghan drapes over the back, vivid colors of thread against a dark background that bleeds to the edges in a rainbow of fringe.

A low-rise coffee table sits between the two seats, more newspapers splayed across it along with a just barely started crochet project and wooden bowl full of potpourri. In the corner, an old box television set with knobs and rabbit ears, sitting low on the ground. Atop it, a line of potted plants, vines of leaves cascading down like green waterfalls, framing the screen like green theater curtains.

Off to Adora's left is the kitchen area. A counter attached to the wall separates the space she's in from the stove and cooking area. That's where Razz is currently, boiling water in a kettle and erratically tossing open cabinets in search of clean mugs probably. Just when she manages to find two, a shrill whistle comes from the kettle, steam pouring from the mouth.

In just a short moment, Razz approaches the table again with both mugs, placing one down in front of Adora. With a grateful smile, she picks it up with both hands, humming at how it warms her still frozen fingers. The tea bag still sits in it, as it hasn't quite finished steeping, along with a thin lemon slice.

"*For your immune system," Razz explains. "Can't be gettin' sick with a little one swimming around in ya." She chuckles to herself then halts, looking at Adora with an alarmed expression. "Oh! Dearie me, you're* still *shaking!" She sets down her mug and shuffles off to the living room, tugging the afghan off the armchair. Before Adora can voice her protests, Razz is draping it around her shoulders, tucking it around her frame delicately.*

"*Learn to speak up, Mara! I've* told *you about suffering there quietly!"*

Adora frowns, fingers tightening around her mug. No. No she definitely heard right this time.

"*Um….Madame Razz? My name's* Adora*," she corrects, adding slow emphasis on each syllable of her name.*

Razz blinks dumbly at her, before waving a flippant hand as she falls into her seat. "Yes, yes! Adora! That's what I said."

It isn't, but Adora doesn't feel like combatting her. Especially not when she's being so hospitable. So instead she blows gently on her tea, watching it ripple before taking a tentative sip.

They sit there quietly for a moment while Adora slowly sips on her tea, allowing both that and the blanket to thaw her the rest of the way. Razz, having almost completely forgotten about her own

mug, is fidgeting with one of the newspapers on the table, mouth screwed to the side as her eyes skim the text.

Once Adora regains total feeling throughout her body, she clears her throat and sets her mug down. Bringing them back around to why she's here, she asks, "Would you like to go ahead and go over the material? I can try and answer any questions you might have or explain what you didn't understand."

Startled, Razz whirls around, eyes bugged out to an almost inhuman degree, heightened by the magnifying effect of her thick lenses. Her brows furrow, probably having forgotten already the purpose of Adora's visit, before snapping her fingers and grinning toothily at her. "Ah yes! The German economics!"

"*Greek economics."*

"*Yes! Your family, they're Greek?"*

Adora nods. "My mom's side is. Dad's side is Swedish." She looks down at the table at the array of newspapers and other clutter. "Should we clear some space to go over the texts and notes?"

Razz's eyes follow, widening as if noticing the mess for the first time. "Ah, yes! Go on and move it wherever there's room."

After clearing off a small space for them to work, Adora brings out her notebook and the class textbook, opening each to the relevant topics. Then she begins explaining all the terminology and concepts of the current material to a very rapt Razz. There's the occasional interruption where Razz asks about her family specifically or goes off into some tangent after being reminded of something from her own experiences, derailing them for a few additional minutes until Adora steers them back on track.

Under different circumstances, it would've been more annoying. Maybe it's the tea, or the afghan wrapped around her that smells of lemongrass, or just the simple fact that this is the most relaxed she's felt in a while. But Adora genuinely can't find it in her to be frustrated with the older woman.

If anything it's….nice. To have this distraction. To have a space where her anxieties can thaw and melt away just like the chill from her bones.

Even when Razz begins asking questions about her pregnancy, she doesn't feel the same edge she does when her friends question her, or her parents, or the doctors.

"*How far along are you now, dearie?"*

Their notes lie abandoned in front of them, pushed off to the side in favor of plates topped off with deli sandwiches that Razz prepared for them and slices of oranges.

Adora swallows thickly, gulping down some juice before answering. "Fourteen weeks."

Razz smiles then and Adora can't help but smile back. "You wear it well. So why hide behind such baggy clothes?"

Picking at the crust of her sandwich, Adora gnaws on her bottom lip. "I...Well, you know how it is." She hopes she won't have to explain it, but when Razz stares at her, clearly not *understanding, she puts her sandwich back down with a sigh. "People will stare. And they're all already talking about me like I'm some kind of…" She hesitates and casts a wary eye Razz's way, biting down her lip to halt the word that almost escaped. "Like I'm someone who sleeps around a lot. I guess….I figured if I tried to cover it up, it wouldn't be as bad."*

"*You're ashamed," Razz says, oversimplifying the whole thing and nailing it right on the head simultaneously.*

Adora spins her glass, chin tucked to her chest. "Wouldn't you be?"

Razz hums and plucks up one of her own orange slices, waving it in the air in Adora's direction. "Are you ashamed of your child?"

Adora stiffens, eyes blown wide. She….she hasn't really heard the baby referred to that way yet. It was always "the baby" or "them" and sometimes even "it". But hearing Razz's words, putting it that *way….it makes it that much more real somehow. More personal.*

Reflexively, her hand twitches towards her stomach, fingertips brushing the fabric of her hoodie but not quite resting on her stomach. "I…." Is she? Does the shame she feels stem from the judgement of her peers, the lamenting over her own thoughtlessness, or the baby itself?

Her hand settles there, cradling the small bump through the thickness of her hoodie. Comforting. Apologetic.

"*No. I'm not."*

Razz smiles, the lines of her wrinkles deepening with the warmth and sincerity of it. It makes Adora feel more confident in her answer and more sure of her situation. And for the first time since she held that pregnancy test in her hands, the cold linoleum of the bathroom floor underneath her as she drowned herself in her tears, she feels like she can actually do *this.*

They chat for a little longer after that, mostly about Adora's family and her friends, until Adora's phone gets a ping.

"*Oh! That's Glimmer. She's here to pick me up." She stands and folds the afghan neatly before setting it down in the kitchen chair. She goes to clean up her dishes as well, but Razz's hands are shooing hers away until she's forced to back off.*

"*Go, go dearie. It's late and you need to get home. I'll take care of everything else."*

Normally, Adora would argue that it wouldn't be a hassle, but Razz is already working on collecting the dishes herself. So instead of arguing, she gathers up her books and replaces them in her bag before heading over the couch to slide her coat on and wrap her

scarf around her neck. By the time she's zipped up and ready to brave the night chill, Razz is behind her to escort her out.

She pauses at the doorway, hand hovering on the doorknob. "Um...I'll see you in class Thursday?"

Razz smiles and she smiles back before shouldering the door open and wincing at the first gust of wind that hits her face.

"*Goodnight, Razz!"*

Razz waves her off as she hurries down the cobblestone walkway to Glimmer's car idling in the courtyard, calling out after her over the wind.

"*Goodnight-"*

"Mara!"

Said girl jumps, looking over with wide blue eyes and a fist clenched around a crushed strawberry, juice dripping through the cracks of her fingers and down to her wrist.

Adora sighs and sets down her mixing bowl, wiping her hands on her apron and picking up the wet washcloth. She walks over to her daughter and opens her hand, scooping the ruined strawberry from her palm and tosses it into the trash can. Then she sets to work cleaning up the juices with the washcloth, sighing again when she realizes that it had also sprayed all over Mara's shirt sleeve and apron. Well...she has to take a bath anyway. So no real harm.

Mara watches her mother clean her off with a deep-set pout, chin tucked to her chest. "Sorry, Mommy."

Adora places a hand behind Mara's head and pulls her in to kiss her temple. "It's alright, Mara. You just have to be more careful, okay?"

When Mara doesn't look convinced, Adora pulls over the bowl of plucked strawberries and gasps dramatically, making sure to put every ounce of excitement she can convey into it. "Look! You've done *such* a good job with these! I don't see any leaves!" She sifts through the strawberries to showcase her point.

Shyly, Mara looks up at her, the beginnings of a grin on her lips. "Yeah?"

"Mmmhmmm!" Adora picks out one of the strawberries and holds it up to the light. She turns it over and over, lips pursed and eyes squinting in a big show of examining it. Then she brings it closer, connecting her thumb and pointer finger in a circle and bringing it to her eye, like a weird monocle-magnifying glass. "Yep! Definitely no leaves! You're a real pro at this!"

Mara brings her fists to her mouth, stifling her giggles at her mother's theatrics.

Then Adora brings a finger to the air, straightening up substantially. "But noooow, it's time for the taste test!" She holds the strawberry out, stopping just in front of Mara's mouth.

Mara leans forward and takes a bite from the tip of the strawberry.

"So, my little leaf-picking-professional, does it pass?"

Mara smiles before giving her two thumbs up. A shriek followed by a string of hysterical giggles escapes her when Adora immediately scoops her into her arms, peppering her face with kisses and laughing in-between. After a few seconds - too many apparently for Mara's tastes - she begins to squirms in Adora's grip until Adora finally sets her back down onto the chair. Even still, she doesn't move from Mara's space, bending her knees to be eye-level with her daughter and knocking their foreheads together before placing another kiss on her cheek, this one wet and sloppy.

"*Mommy*!" Mara squeals, hands pushing against Adora's face as the older woman laughs.

"What? I'm just rewarding my best big-girl helper!"

Mara wipes furiously at her cheek, tongue poking out between her teeth. "Dat one was *gross* though!"

Adora mock-gasps as she reels back, hand delicately pressed against her chest. "You think Mommy's love is 'gross'?"

Mara pouts and reaches out her hands and, naturally, Adora leans forward to let Mara grab onto her face, pulling her forward to kiss her forehead. "Nooooo! Just your kisses!"

"But my kisses *are* my love!"

"*Some* of yer kisses are gross," Mara rectifies.

Humming, Adora leans forward and gives a light peck to Mara's cheek, eyebrows lifted as she pulls away. "Better?"

"*Much* better."

Straightening up, Adora pats Mara's shoulder. "Alright then. How about you go get ready for a bath now that you're all done? Mommy will be there to help you in a minute."

"Okay!" She tugs her apron off, leaving it on the kitchen chair after hopping down. Then she's running out of the kitchen and down the hall to her room, the pattering of her feet cut off by the sound of a door shutting.

Adora chuckles to herself as she watches her daughter go. Tossing the unfinished strawberry into her mouth, she finally turns back around to complete her own task...

...And finds Catra staring at her, eyes wide and glazed over, lips parted in something akin to…awe? Confusion? Fondness?

Catra whips back around to her own mixing bowl, head ducked down before she can decipher it.

She almost has half a mind to question her on it, but knows that even if she does that Catra will just get defensive and she wouldn't give a straight answer anyway. So, saving herself the effort and Catra the face, she pretends that she didn't notice anything and goes back to prepping a wooden board with flour.

She's just begun to knead the dough when Catra grunts in frustration. She turns to find Catra clutching the bowl to her chest, fist wrapped around the fork as she leans over the recipe paper, squinty-eyed and tongue adorably poking from the corner of her mouth.

Adora smirks. "Everything alright over there?"

"Huh?" She looks up. "Yeah. Yeah, I just..." Her eyes flick back downwards, squinting at the paper again. "I'm not sure if I'm doing this right. It's still...crumbly but shouldn't it be - I dunno," she holds up the bowl, eyeing it carefully. "Smoother? Like dough is supposed to look?"

Abandoning her own dough, Adora slides over and gently nudges the bowl from Catra's grasp to place it back down on the counter. "It'll start to clump together if you press like," she grabs a handful of the dough and makes a fist before revealing the now lumpy ball of dough, "so."

"Oh."

Adora smiles. "It's pie crust dough, so it's not going to behave the same way dough would for bread. Yours is actually ready to knead now if you want to get started on that."

"Right." Catra looks down at her bowl, lips pursed. "Right."

Adora stands back and watches her pick up the set of instructions, eyes squinting at the paper. A smirk pulls at her lips when Catra sets the paper down, only to pick it back up while chewing on her

lip. Then she nods resolutely and sets it down again and picks up the bowl, tilting to dump it out, her eyes shifting to the side before she commits.

"Um, I need one of those things." She's looking pointedly at the wooden board that Adora has rested her dough on top of.

Adora laughs and bends down to open one of the cupboards beneath the counter. "And here I was, perfectly content to watch you dump it all on my counter."

"Hey! At least I caught myself!" She grumbles as Adora sets down the board and sprinkles a bit of flour over it. "Cut me a break. Those instructions are *really* vague."

"Or maybe you just don't have reading comprehension skills?" Adora teases, flinching back when Catra makes a sharp motion like she intends to dump the crumbled dough on her head. "Hey! We need that!"

Catra shrugs, but pours the bowl's contents onto the wooden board nonetheless. Her hands set to work squishing and pinching the crumbled dough together to begin forming a large, lumpy ball. "We wouldn't have to waste it. Just put you in the oven and let *you* bake."

Adora snorts and rolls her eyes. "Now why does that sound familiar?" She props her hip against the counter and crosses her arms, content to watch Catra work for a moment. Also, she partially wants to be ready for when or if Catra asks for her help, or begins to falter in uncertainty. "Wouldn't have anything to do with a certain movie you made us watch over and over and over again, would it?"

"Okay, *one*: You made us watch *Princess Bride* all the time, so you could handle a little *Sweeney Todd*." Catra pulls away from the dough and shoots up two fingers. "And *two*: I'd let Helena Bonham Carter bake me into a pie any day of the week and I will take that to my grave."

"Oh I bet you would."

"What's *that* supposed to mean?"

"Nothing." She smiles when Catra narrows her eyes at her high-pitched voice and opts to ignore it entirely in favor of turning back to her own dough. "Just that you have a real odd taste in women and some *very* concerning kinks."

"Adora, are you *honestly* insulting Helena Bonham Carter and kinkshaming me all in one breath?"

Adora sticks her tongue out between her teeth and giggles. "My kitchen, my rules! I can do whatever I want."

"Tyrant!" Catra faux-gasps. "The people will not stand here and accept your unjust rule!" And then her hand begins to inch towards the open bag of flour.

Adora's eyes widen and she takes a half-step back. "Catra, you *wouldn't*."

Her hand keeps creeping forward and Adora debates between backing away a safe distance or tackling Catra. When Catra's fingers brush the paper of the bag, she lunges forward but - as Catra has teased her about for practically their whole lives - she's just too slow.

Her shriek of surprise echoes in the kitchen and spills into the apartment as she reels back, blinking against the flour now spattered across her face. She sputters and wipes it away furiously, the sound of Catra's shrill laughter piercing her from every direction. By the time she's able to fully open her eyes, she finds Catra completely doubled over, eyes leaking mirthful tears.

"Oh! Oh man!" She takes a deep breath and dissolves into another fit of giggles. "You should see your face right now!"

Adora pouts for a moment, but it's short-lived as a lightbulb goes off above her head, replaced by an evil smirk instead. "Actually, I

have a better idea." And before Catra can collect herself enough to realize what she's doing, Adora is shoving her hand into the bag of flour.

"Wait….wait no, Adora, not the-"

Poof!

"...hair."

Adora laughs, full-bellied and chest-swelling, as Catra bats at her own face and now flour-drenched curls. "Oh. I see it now!" She wipes away the tears from her eyes, noticing how gritty they feel with the remaining flour still clinging to her cheeks. "Yeah, yeah you're right. That *is* funny!"

"Laugh while you still can, Hartvigsen. Because the next handful is going down your *throat*!" And then she's lunging for the bag of flour again. She almost gets there too, but Adora wraps her arms around Catra's waist and yanks her back roughly, causing Catra to stumble and flail wildly as her balance teeters.

Catra reaches back and pushes down on Adora's head, trying to force her off, but where Catra has always been the quicker of the two of them, Adora's been the stronger. Her grip never wavers or slips and, after setting her feet, she pushes off with her legs and lifts Catra off the floor entirely.

"Gack!" Catra claws at her arm with her nails and kicks her feet as she tries to regain solid ground. "Adora! Adora, put me down!"

"Only if you agree to a truce," Adora says, voice muffled by Catra's shoulder.

"What? Afraid you can't beat me?"

Adora doesn't respond. Instead, she squeezes her arms tighter around Catra's middle, arms straining with the hold.

"Okay!" Catra wheezes. "Okay, fine! Truce! *Truce*!"

Adora releases her grip, and Catra drops neatly to the floor with a deep gulp of air, rubbing her side tenderly. She shoots Adora a pout, which is promptly ignored as Adora walks back over to the counter, picking up the bag of flour and putting it on the very far end. Catra follows, and they both resume working on the dough they'd abandoned; Adora gently kneading hers while Catra continues putting hers together.

"Are you still working out? Cause….holy *hell,* Adora. I think you might have dislocated some of my organs there."

"I…" Adora turns, giving Catra a quick once over. "Yeah. You okay? I didn't mean to squeeze you that hard but I guess I just didn't realize…"

Catra waves her off abruptly, halting her anxieties in one smooth motion. "Relax, *Mom*. You know I exaggerate." She eyes the flour at the end. "Can you pass me that?" And when Adora gives her a wary look, she groans and rolls her eyes, gesturing to the wooden board in front of her. "For the *dough*, moron. I learned my lesson, Diana Prince. No more going up against Amazonian warriors for me."

She….thinks that's supposed to be a compliment. Then again, with Catra it's always difficult to parse through her playful jabs and her heavily-veiled praises. Adora decides not to dwell on it as she reaches over for the bag of flour, but she can't help but notice the way her heart thuds when their fingers brush as Catra takes it from her.

Adora rips her hand away and goes back to focusing on her own disk of dough, pressing and turning it with her head ducked down, eliminating each intrusive thought in her mind with each spin of the dough.

(Ignores how the worst ones sound like *him*.)

She shakes her head. No, none of that. Not today. Today isn't about any of that.

Adora steps back from her dough, realizing she's kneaded it enough (and maybe just a little more than that due to getting lost in her thoughts, but she hopes that it won't be that much of an issue). She turns to get the plastic wrap to wrap up her disks, but notices that Catra is struggling with one of hers. She smiles softly, watching for a couple more seconds as Catra growls and sprinkles more flour onto the dough.

Realizing that if she stands back much longer she'll drown the thing, Adora steps up. "Need some help?"

Catra jumps. "What? No!" Then she follows Adora's eyes to her sorry lump of dough and grumbles to herself. "Maybe."

"Well, firstly, you have more than enough flour at this point." Adora sets the bag aside. "Next, you don't need to be so rough with it. This is pie crust; it's supposed to be nice and flaky. If you knead it too much you'll activate too much yeast."

One look at Catra's face says that she's already lost her. "Okay, fine, whatever. How am I *supposed* to do it then?"

"Well," Adora takes Catra's hands and places them back onto the disk at the edges. Her hands lift for a moment, as if she means to remove them, before buckling down and keeping them in place. She squeezes gently (ignoring, *ignoring* how Catra tenses against her because today isn't the day), indicating that Catra should do the same. "You'll want to press down softly," and then she's moving their hands together. "And then-"

"*...you turn it just like so, dearie!"*

Adora watches with rapt attention, bottom lip jutted out as she watches Madame Razz handle the dough disk with such fluidity and ease that her own hands would not allow her. Her fingers twitch at her sides, mimicking the way that Razz's own move.

When Razz steps aside to let her try again, Adora works on it for maybe a few seconds before Razz is pushing her aside again.

Adora lets loose a loud groan that trails off into pathetic whimpers.

"*I don't get it! It's just dough! Why does this have to be so difficult?"*

Razz levels her with a look akin to offense, before shaking her head with a sigh. "You cannot be so rough with everything you do, Adora! That attitude is what's blocking you! Until you get past it, you will find that there are many things you cannot achieve."

Adora grumbles. Leave it to Razz to make a simple task like kneading dough (or...not simple. Seriously, why is *this so hard?) into some kind of philosophical or deep life lesson. She blames it partly on the being a grandma thing, but then again, maybe it's just a Razz thing.*

Fed up, Adora takes a step back and lets Razz attempt to show her the proper technique again, muttering some "helpful" phrases and reminders that sound like general nonsense that probably only connects in Razz's mind. Her hand inches towards the ceramic bowl filled to the brim with raspberries and she tosses her head back dropping a couple in.

Then her hand is throbbing*.*

"*Ow!" Adora yelps, pulling her hand to her chest protectively. She looks down at Razz who -* somehow *- has procured a wooden spoon while Adora wasn't looking. "That hurt!"*

"*Those are for the* pie*!" Razz chides her as she pushes the bowl far away from Adora's itching hands.*

"*I only took a couple!"*

"*The* pie*, dearie.* The pie*," Razz insists. Her expression softens as her gaze drops and a smile cracks her face. Before Adora can say anything, she's already placed a gentle hand against the swell of Adora's stomach, thumb gently brushing against the fabric of her shirt.*

"*Is the little one hungry?"*

Adora chews on the inside of her cheek, a tad indignant. "Well, I mean, they're not the only *one who's hungry."*

Razz hums and turns away, acting as if she hadn't heard the slight annoyance to Adora's tone. Maybe she hadn't. "Once the dough is chilling, I can get started on something for dinner. I might have some things for a beef stew, uh….yes. Yes! I should have some things lying around here somewhere." Then she looks back to Adora, head tilted to the side.

"*Will you be staying for dinner today, Mara?"*

Adora sighs. "I'm not Mara," she corrects, the words rolling off her tongue in a familiar tumble. It's practically fruitless at this point; every time she corrects Razz, the woman never really grasps onto it and ends up slipping again. At this point, it's more a force of habit.

Then she leans against the counter, wincing at the sudden pain that shoots up her legs. She's been standing for far too long. "And that sounds great, actually." Razz's cooking is amazing*, and her stomach twists and her mouth waters at just the thought of it. Living in a college apartment with your two roommates - where no one out of the three of you knows how to cook beyond a simple grilled cheese or bowl of ramen - really makes you miss hot, home cooked meals with...well,* actual *flavor.*

The best part is how, after every time she visits Razz, the older woman sends her home with a stack of tupperware containers ("Take, dearie! Take as much as you like! I'm an old woman. I couldn't possibly eat all this food by myself!") and Bow and Glimmer practically herald her as some hero or white knight. Though, with the pressure to put on weight to accommodate the baby and the sheer amount of energy she spends just existing *as a pregnant woman, she typically helps herself to a more generously healthy helping than the two of them combined.*

Adora stutters, old anxieties creeping up before she can stop them. "Of course, if you don't mind that is!"

"*Bah!" Razz waves her off, already abandoning their task of making a pie to rifle through her pantry. "If it were up to me, I'd lock you up here and spoonfeed you. You're too skinny! You could use a little more plump."*

Adora looks down at her stomach, a brow quirked. "Um….I'm kind of carrying a baby here. I feel like that's the opposite of skinny."

Razz scoffs and yanks a bag of potatoes from the far corner of her pantry, tossing them back haphazardly and narrowly catching Adora's ankles. "That's exactly my point! Too skinny even with *the baby! When I was pregnant, I was about three times your size!" She hobbles out of the pantry, clutching a can of broth to her chest as she carefully steps over the litter of food items on the floor.*

When Razz reaches her finally, she pats Adora's cheek twice before pinching it between her fingers, yanking roughly much to Adora's chagrin. "A little more meat on you will do the baby good. Skinny people pop out skinny babies."

Adora rubs her cheek with a pout, taking a step back to put space between them. "I...I just have a high metabolism. That's all." And a very minimal food budget. Not like she'd mention that *to Madame Razz. Otherwise she really might never let her leave.*

"*That's why you need to* eat*, dearie." Razz rolls her eyes and pulls over the bowl of raspberries, holding it out to Adora.*

Hesitant, Adora plucks one from the bowl and eyes Razz warily. "I thought you said these are for the pie?"

Razz stares at her blankly for a few seconds and then the wooden spoon is batting at Adora's hand again. "They are! If you're so hungry just say so*, Adora!"*

Adora opens her mouth to say something - about how they've been talking about how hungry Adora is, how Razz isn't making any sense, or maybe even something about the ethics of battering a pregnant girl - but ultimately decides against it. Sometimes, it just isn't worth the trouble trying to talk to Razz when they're clearly on different wavelengths.

That's not to say that Adora doesn't appreciate Razz's company or hospitality. In fact, over just the past month, visiting Razz has become one of her favorite pastimes. Tuesdays and Thursdays don't fill her with as much dread as they did at the beginning of the semester, because those are the two days out of the entire week where she can sit in class and easily ignore the stares and whispers directed her way.

When her and Razz bonded after that one day, the older woman made it a point to sit next to Adora each class (not that there was anywhere else to sit, but somehow Adora knew that that wasn't the reason). Her presence was comforting, made her feel almost impenetrable to the criticism and judgement she knew her peers still haven't grown tired of.

The visits also quickly became a regular occurrence, with Razz coming to her for her help in understanding the class material. Adora readily gave her help and Razz rewarded her with hot meals and a break from everything going on in her tumultuous life.

Of course, the past month also enlightened her to some of Razz's more frustrating qualities. For instance, the way she would detract from the conversation consistently, derailing their study session no matter how hard Adora jerked the wheel to steer them back on track. Or how she would talk herself and Adora in circles, to the point that Adora just started letting it happen while nodding along, knowing that Razz would (probably) sort herself right on her own given enough time.

And, the biggest problem of all, is that Razz consistently *gets her name wrong.*

Adora had given thought behind the reasoning of Razz's almost senile-way of mixing up her identity. At first, it had started with a name, but it progressed slowly to Razz asking her questions that she didn't know the answers to or just didn't apply to her.

She remembers one day, when she'd asked Adora a question that had completely caught her off guard.

"*And how is Lena doing, dearie? Well, I hope?*"

Adora blinked rapidly, running over the past couple of weeks to try and parse out when she'd ever told Razz her mother's name. Nothing.

"*How do you know my mom's name?*"

And Razz had given her that owlish look, squinting and blinking, like she was trying to make out something that wasn't quite focusing. Eventually, she gave up and turned back to watering one of her plants - already dead, but Adora wasn't about to dissuade her from what she chose to do in her own home.

"*Mom? That's not your mother's name, Mara. I should know. I'm the one who picked it out. Though...yes, yes I suppose they sound similar enough.*"

Adora had shaken her head, deciding this time to press further. "Madame Razz, it's me, Adora. Not Mara. Lena is my mother's name. Did I tell you that?"

"*Adora…." And then her shoulders had hunched forwards, hand stilling and the water can she was pouring into the potted plant kept going, until soaked soil bubbled and spilled over onto the plate underneath. Adora had lunged forward, gently prying the can from Razz's grasp as the woman continued to gaze into the browning leaves of the plant. Her lips were moving rapidly with no sound, eyes glazed over completely.*

Just as Adora had reached her hand out to try and bring her back, Razz had suddenly snapped upright, grinning brightly at Adora.

"*Adora, dearie! How's the baby? What did the doctor say?"*

At the time, Adora had thought of pressing further, thought of prodding Razz for answers to finally understand what some of her babbled nonsense was all about. Especially if it meant that Adora could finally see why she was called "Mara" just as much as she was her own name.

But she stopped when she saw unshed tears in Razz's eyes and promptly dropped it, bookmarking that topic for another day.

Ever since then, she hasn't quite known how to bring it up. She thinks of casually dropping the question every time she has to correct Razz, but then she remembers the deep sorrow behind those thick-framed glasses, and a pit of dread settles in her stomach, rendering her mute.

She doesn't know who Mara is or even if they're a real person, but she does know that it brings Razz pain and sorrow, and she doesn't know if it's her place to rip open that wound.

"*Adora, dearie, I need you to finish kneading the dough so I can get started on this stew." Razz takes out a large pot and sets it on the stove before flitting about the kitchen, gathering all the ingredients she needs that she's set down in different spots.*

Adora stiffens and looks at the pile of dough, grimacing like it's planning to bite her. "Um, Madame Razz? I...I still don't get how I'm supposed to do this or know when I need to stop."

"*It's very simple, Mara! I've already taught you how!"*

Adora whimpers. "But...what if I start the stew and you knead the dough?" She's not a great cook either, but surely *cutting up some vegetables and getting a broth started has to be easier than punching dough until it waves a white flag, right?*

Or….something like that.

Razz whirls around and fixes her with a stern glare that has Adora shrinking back. She very suddenly feels like a child in for a scolding and her eyes immediately dart to Razz's hands, checking for the wooden spoon again.

"*How do you expect to learn how to bake a pie if you don't try?"*

"*I* did *try," Adora argues. She slumps against the counter now, pain flaring in her hips. "But I'm tired and sore and it's just not working out. I mean, you already taught me how to make the filling. I could just buy some crust at the store if I ever want to b-Ahh!" Adora jumps when a wooden spoon - one that Madame Razz* definitely *had not been holding just seconds before, smacks down onto the counter next to her with a loud* crack.

"*Store-bought crust? Ha!" Razz laughs, but there's a cruel edge to it. "You might as well buy the whole pie if you're going to be that lazy. No...no, if you're going to bake a pie, you have to put in the work." Leaving no room for further arguing, she grabs Adora's hands and places them back on the dough disk.*

"*You have to press and twist. Gently." Adora tries and Razz shakes her head. "*Gentler*."*

"*I...isn't this gentle?"*

Razz gives an exasperated sigh and Adora wonders if she's finally on the verge of giving up on her. She wouldn't be the first.

"*I want you to imagine your baby."*

Adora blinks, hands twitching but she fights the reflex to touch her stomach. "I...what? Why?"

Razz gestures to her belly. "Think of how small the baby is. How fragile. How would you hold them?"

Adora stares.

"*Now...treat the dough like you would your child."*

When Adora presses and twists the disk this time, Razz says nothing. When she does it again and again and again….nothing.

"*There you are, dearie. Just like that. A few more turns and the dough should be ready to chill."*

After about a minute passes of Adora kneading and turning the dough, she calls Razz back over to check if it's ready. Razz prods it gently, feeling it's density and firmness, before she turns back to Adora with a proud grin. Adora feels something swell in her chest and it explodes when Razz places a kind hand against her cheek.

"*Perfect, Adora. Now, I'll teach you how to make beef stew while these chill."*

After an odd nineties-movie-esque kneading lesson that ends with Adora just completely taking over and doing the last two disks of dough herself while Catra resigns herself to sulking by the stove, they have some free time while the pie crust dough chills. Normally, Adora would make the most use out of that time to start prepping the filling for each of the pies, but Mara loves to help with that part of the process, so it'll have to wait until after she's taken her bath.

Speaking of…

"Think you can handle wrapping these and putting them in the fridge to chill while I get Mara in the bath? Or do you need someone to hold your hand for that too?"

Catra rolls her eyes at Adora's tease. "Oh, come off it. Go clean your kid. I think I can handle a little saran wrap."

Adora unties the strings of her apron before hanging it over the back of one of the kitchen chairs. "I dunno. Saran wrap can be pretty tricky. Sure you're up to the task?"

"You have five seconds to leave this kitchen before we both find out how tricky it'll be to suffocate someone with it."

Surrendering with her hands up, Adora side-steps out of the kitchen, shooting Catra one last shit-eating grin before disappearing into the hallway.

Wrangling Mara into the bath turns out to be hassle enough that she almost sort of wishes that Catra had followed through on her threat. It's not that Mara hates taking baths per se. In fact, once she's in the water it's practically impossible to fish her out. To the point that Adora has to drain the tub to force her daughter to clamber out of it - dripping wet, shivering, and beelining towards the bath towel that Adora has prepped and ready for her to wrap up in.

No, it's more the fact that chasing down a naked toddler - who already barely listens on a good day - to get her to cooperate and do something is a skill that isn't nearly as easy to master as, say, kneading pie crust dough or talking your way out of a speeding ticket. Four (nearly five) years of practice and it's something that Adora still struggles to achieve without any casualties.

As Mara joyfully splashes the water of her bath and scoops up bubbles with her hands, Adora blows the flyaway wisps of her ponytail from her forehead and tugs on her now wet t-shirt.

Well, at least her *pants* managed to stay dry this time.

After telling Mara she has ten minutes to play until it's time to wash up, Adora exits the bathroom - leaving the door wide open so she can listen out for her - and heads back to the kitchen. If nothing else, she can at least use this short time window wisely by cutting up the strawberries to have them ready for the actual cooking portion once Mara is washed up and dressed.

And, of course, Catra is still there waiting for her, scrolling idly through her phone as she sits on the counter.

"You know, there are chairs that are, like, barely even two feet away from you." Adora taps Catra on the thigh pointedly, putting on her best "stern mother" expression that she finds she's using

for more than just Mara lately. The funniest part is that it actually works a good chunk of the time. All of her friends hate it.

Catra rolls her eyes but she pauses in sliding off the counter after taking notice of Adora's shirt splotched with dark spots. "Decided to go for a little swim?"

Ignoring the obvious bait, Adora shakes her head and strides over to the stove where she keeps her assortment of kitchen knives and pulls out a medium-sized one to slice the strawberries with.

"Whoa, Adora! Jeez, take a joke would ya?" Catra hops down off the counter and backs away towards the kitchen table, arms held out defensively.

"Hush, you big baby. This is for the strawberries."

"Is that what the kids are calling 'ridiculously hot latina best friends' nowadays? I swear, the lingo just isn't the same from when we were kids."

"Yeah." Adora digs out a clean cutting board from one of the bottom cupboards. "I much preferred the simple days when we still referred to you as 'assholes'."

"Ouch." Catra places a hand over her chest with a mock-pout. "Is that the sort of language you're teaching your kid, Mama Hart Jr.?"

"No, I figured you and Adam could tag team that responsibility." Then she looks up with a plastered on sweet smile. "Though, of course, the day you do will be the last day either of you wake up."

Catra raises her eyebrows and hops up onto the kitchen table, putting her feet in one of the kitchen chairs and grinning maniacally at Adora's disapproving glare. "Feisty. Did that come with the pregnancy or mothering a toddler?"

"Somewhere in-between." Adora grabs a large bowl from one of the cabinets. "Must've been something I picked up from all those

parenting books."

Catra nods as though she knows *exactly* what Adora's talking about, despite the fact that in high school she barely bothered to crack open their textbooks. Granted, she was always simultaneously smug and nonchalant about the fact that she simply didn't need to study, and her perfect grades were truly just the cherry on top of it all. That's also why it wasn't surprising that even though they *both* got scholarships to their respective universities, Catra's was an academic one. *And* hers was a full-ride, which is something she never seemed too humble about.

"Mommy bloggers gone rogue. Sounds kinda hot actually. Like *Desperate Housewives* but with sippie cups instead of champagne flutes and minivans instead of Corvettes." She takes a moment to swipe an apple from the fruit bowl resting in the center of the table and juggles it from hand to hand. "I'd watch that."

Adora shakes her head and ignores the faint smile resting on her lips. "You have the *weirdest* fantasies, you know that?"

"So you're telling me that people go to PTA meetings for - what - the actual concern and desire for the betterment of their child's education? Come on, Adora. We all know it's about the *drama*." Catra takes a bite of her apple, the wet crunch punctuating her statement.

"Well," Adora dumps some of the strawberries onto the cutting board, grouping them into a pile before plucking out one and beginning the process of making thick slices, "Thankfully you're not a parent then. Who knows what sort of chaos you'd reign on those poor suburban mothers and their Mini Coopers?"

Catra nods again, taking another bite of her apple and wiping some of the excess juice away with her pinkie. "It's for their safety, truly."

Even with that established - along with hazy memories of their youth and Catra's abhorrence to anything at all relating to motherhood - it's still an entertaining enough thought to imagine Catra rolling up to a PTA meeting, ripped jeans and leather jacket, snide remarks and devilish grin as the rest of the parents stare in nothing short of abject horror. Mara is still in preschool and wouldn't be in public schooling until next year, but Adora is a little curious and tempted to invite Catra to one of the future meetings she'll inevitably have to attend.

Because she has a point. PTA meetings are *totally* about the drama.

Though with Catra, she might bring it to a whole new level. Might even get them *both* banned.

So maybe not. Still...a fun thought to have nonetheless.

In a few minutes time, Adora's finished with cutting up the batch of strawberries and is washing her hands to go check on Mara and get her cleaned up so they can start on the rest of the filling process. Catra has finished her apple and Adora's a little surprised that as she heads towards the bathroom, Catra is right behind her. When she raises an eyebrow in silent question, Catra only shrugs, before tacking on with a conniving grin,

"I want front row seats when you get your ass kicked by a toddler *again*."

Instead of rising to meet her taunting, Adora brushes it off with a sigh. "Alright. Just stay by the door to stay out of the splash zone then."

When Adora enters the bathroom, she's greeted by Mara's pudgy, smiling face, a cone of bubbles piled onto her head. "Mommy! I'm a pirate captain! Arrrrrr!" To accentuate the look, she raises one hand with a crooked finger and covers one of her eyes with her hand - the hook and eye patch presumably.

"Are you now?" She kneels down next to the tub and gathers everything she needs - shampoo, conditioner, and body wash. "And where's your ship?"

Mara frowns at this and puffs out her cheeks. A sore spot, apparently. "The other pirates kicked me off 'nd stole it!"

"Well that wasn't very nice." She grabs the plastic cup they keep on the tub ledge. "Alright, baby, lean back for me so I can wet your hair."

"It's already wet." Then she crosses her arms. "And I told you! I'm a pirate captain, not a *baby*! I hafta get my ship back!"

Adora hears snickers behind her but elects to ignore them. "Well I'm sorry *pirate captain*. But I have to get the bubbles out of your hair so I can wash it. And then you can go on an adventure to get your ship back." She fills the plastic cup with some of the bath water. "Though while you're doing that I'm gonna have to get someone else to help me make the pie filling."

Mara considers that for a short moment. Then, "It's okay. I have a shark army now, so I'll make dem do it for me."

"Tell your shark army I appreciate it. Now lean back for me please."

As Adora begins the process of washing Mara's hair, the young girl takes the opportunity to detail her daring pirate adventures, spinning tails of ship battles, sword fights, and sea shanties (perhaps she'd been spending too much time with Sea Hawk). Adora works quickly, careful to keep the shampoo from Mara's eyes as she offers half-distracted affirmations that she's listening, interjecting a well-placed question here and there that really doesn't go any more in-depth than "what happened next?" and "is that so?".

Soon enough, Mara's standing in the tub as Adora scrubs her down with a shower scrunchie as she continues to ramble on and on, though now on the topic of how her pirate friends got mad

and stole her ship and left her stranded on an island. After she's rinsed off and sitting back in the water, Adora stands up - grimacing at the new wet splotches on her shirt - and tells Mara she has five more minutes to wrap up her play time before it's time to get out.

"Ten more minutes!" Mara argues.

"If you stay in there longer you won't be able to help finish the pies. And I know you were so excited to tell Auntie Pia that you helped."

Disgruntled but knowing full well that she's been had, Mara grumbles out a dejected "fine" before making waves in the bath water, emulating what must be a fantastical battle to regain control of her pirate ship.

Satisfied, Adora turns on her heel to exit the bathroom to find Catra propped against the doorframe, arms crossed over her chest and watching the exchange with a soft, fond look that vanishes the almost exact instant Adora faces her. She pushes herself off with a cough and moves aside to let Adora pass.

"There wasn't nearly as much carnage as I'd been hoping for."

"Don't sound so dejected." Adora turns around with a grin. "Give it five minutes."

"*Adora if you chew off anymore of your nails they're going to be bloody stubs."*

Ripping her thumb from her teeth, Adora tears her gaze away from the clock mounted on the waiting room wall to face her best friend. In an attempt to resist further temptation, she presses her closed fists into her lap, but that only gives way to the option of chewing on her bottom lip instead.

"*I know, I know, Glimmer. But she said she'd be here by now. I guess I'm just worried is all."*

Glimmer lets the baby magazine that she'd been idly flipping through - out of boredom mostly - fall to her lap in order to rest a reassuring hand on Adora's knee. "It's not too late for me to go and pick her up if you want."

Adora waves her off, remembering how adamant that Madame Razz was about getting there on her own. "No, it's fine. I just wish I had some way to call her and make sure she's on her way."

"*She doesn't have a cell phone?"*

Adora shakes her head. "If you knew Madame Razz, you'd understand why."

"*Well," Glimmer chews on her next words, eyes drifting to the receptionist desk which seated a heart-faced intern with chopped brown bangs and blonde-highlighted hair pulled back into a high ponytail. "They've haven't called you back yet. She still has time to get here." Then she squeezes Adora's knee and leans forward with a soft smile. "And I'll still be back there, so you won't be alone or anything."*

And Adora knows that and it's not that she isn't grateful for Glimmer's support or doesn't want it. Truthfully, ever since Adora found out and told Glimmer that same night, she's been there every step of the way - her very first doctor's appointment and each one that followed, when Adora told Aiden and subsequently got dumped, the whole ordeal of telling all of their friends and that very tearful phone call with her mother. Without Glimmer, Adora isn't sure she would've gotten through nearly half of that without breaking down completely or locking herself in her room and dropping out of classes on her final semester.

But...it's different this time. Razz has been such a huge help too, even if she had her own odd ways of going about it. There's something about the older woman that makes Adora feel more sure of herself, of everything*, than Glimmer or any of her friends could provide. Not that they didn't try their damnedest to be helpful but - in all honesty - this is something larger than any of*

them and they can only do so much to help. Plus, with all of them being college seniors that are dealing with graduation preparation on top of their normal classes, Adora feels it's a little unfair to dump all of her problems on them.

They didn't sign up for a pregnancy. And….well, she hadn't either, but she's the one who made the choice to keep the baby and go through with it, and that certainly *wasn't on any of them.*

Even still, they always set aside time for her, including her in group gatherings when she was able - AKA not struggling to keep up with her studies on top of doctor's visits, planning for the baby's arrival, and just being a general miserable pregnant mess of a human being. It was a nice sentiment and she's glad that they still stuck their necks out to keep her in the loop, but underneath it all was the gnawing razor-sharp teeth of guilt that she really only took them up on about half of their invites.

Besides, once they'd all graduated and moved onto their careers, the chances of them staying in contact with her while she traversed the new territory of raising a baby were low, so she figured that the sooner she started distancing herself, the less it would sting when they all moved on without her.

And even though Adora can't be sure that her relationship with Razz would last any longer, there was something different about that whole situation that felt vastly different. She can't exactly place her finger on it, but if she spends the time to give it more than a passing thought, she figures it has something more to do with the fact that Razz has already long passed her prime. Being older, she's already experienced a great deal of her life and isn't moving on to anything bigger or better after school is done and over with. In fact, they'd already had a conversation about why Razz is even finishing up her degree in the first place.

"*Oh, I don't plan on doing anything with my degree. My bones are too old to try anything new and I wouldn't even know what to do with it. I just figured it was long overdue."*

It had been a short conversation, and Adora had the distinct feeling there's something more than Razz was willing to divulge, but the point still stood - Razz wasn't doing anything grand after college. Which also means that she isn't planning on going anywhere, much like Adora herself.

Not for lack of trying, of course. While all her friends were applying for and even accepting internships for their careers, Adora was stuck at home mostly, watching all her hard work crumble right before her eyes. Sure, she'd done odd campus internships here and there during her sophomore and junior years, but the internships that would have really *given her a leg up in her chosen field essentially didn't want her.*

Legally, she couldn't be discriminated against because of her pregnancy. But they always found other reasons to turn her down or not respond back after interviews and she really didn't have a case to stand on without that solid evidence. So she had to sit back and simmer with frustration as her chances for landing a good sports marketing job slipped through her fingers like sand, letting it fester as each of her friends bragged about all the callbacks they were receiving and their personal achievements.

Being with Razz was a break from all of that.

"*Adora Hartvigsen?*"

Both her and Glimmer look up simultaneously to see one of the clinic nurses lingering in the doorway towards the back of the clinic. She's holding a clipboard, eyes roaming the half-full waiting room before finally settling on the only two that have acknowledged her. She offers a smile and pushes her glasses up the bridge of her nose. "The doctor will see you now."

Adora spares one last glance towards the clinic entrance, noticeably deflating when Razz doesn't step through them. A hand rests on her arm and she turns back to see Glimmer watching her sympathetically.

"*Do you want me to wait out here for when she comes?"*

Adora twists her mouth up, considering it. "No," she decides. "No, it's alright. She probably forgot if I'm being honest with myself. She does that a lot." Still, would this *be something she'd forget so easily?*

It's difficult to say.

Glimmer is in the process of helping Adora out of her seat while the nurse waits patiently on the other side of the room when the front door bell chimes. Hopeful, Adora whips to look, and a relieved smile splits her face when she sees thick-lensed glasses tucked away on a wrinkled face framed by hair split into a dozen braids.

Razz squints into the waiting room, mouth moving minutely until she spots where Adora and Glimmer are now standing, and her face lights up in recognition. "Ah! Dearie, there you are! Madame Razz was worried she might have missed it."

"*Nope, you're just in time actually. We're heading back now." Adora outstretches a hand to place it on Razz's elbow, guiding the woman back there with them. The nurse moves aside to let the three women pass, before again jumping to the front to lead them down the hall into one of the rooms.*

"*Good, good. You know, I think they must have changed the bus schedules. Everything's all topsy-turvy!" She chuckles and Adora doesn't have it in her to tell her that she probably had read the maps wrong….again.*

They all settle into the room where the nurse begins taking Adora's vitals, making small talk with her while both Glimmer and Madame Razz sit quietly next to each other. This isn't the first time they've met, but Glimmer has confessed in the past that she's not sure how to feel around Razz, so she typically doesn't breach any topics of conversation on her own. But Adora assured her that she wasn't offended and said that Razz probably hadn't even noticed.

Once the nurse finished up and informed them that the doctor would be there in a few short moments, she's gone and the three of them are alone again.

Playing with her fingers, Glimmer speaks up finally, attention completely directed towards Adora. "So...you excited?"

"*I…." Adora gives a breath of a laugh and rests one of her hands on her stomach. "I honestly can't say. I mean, on one hand I guess but….the longer this goes on the more real it feels." She bites the inside of her cheek and looks around the room at all the medical charts - all of them different infographics or anatomy models relating to pregnancy and childbirth. "I feel like I'm nowhere close to ready for the next part and everything just seems to be moving so quickly."*

Glimmer nods, but Adora knows that she doesn't actually understand. Another reason that even though she appreciates her constant support and presence, it's not entirely reassuring having just her around.

Her eyes drift over to Madame Razz who's looking around the room, squinting at the variety of posters and mumbling to herself.

"*Madame Razz, were you nervous to find out the sex of your baby?"*

"*Huh?" She turns to face Adora, eyes wide like she'd forgotten she was there. Knowing Madame Razz, that might not be far from the truth. "Baby? What baby?"*

Glimmer gives Adora an odd look, but Adora brushes it aside to focus on Razz once more. "Your baby. When you were pregnant, were you nervous about finding out the sex?"

"*Nervous? Haaa….no, I don't think I was. But I'd known from the start that my baby would be a girl. I'd had a dream about it."*

"*O-oh." Well, there isn't quite a proper response to that, now is there?*

"*Oh! That's right! I almost forgot to tell you." Madame Razz stands from her seat and shuffles over to where Adora is sitting on the table, taking her hands in her own. "I had a dream about your baby too!"*

"*What, like your dream when you were pregnant?" Glimmer interjects, smiling incredulously, like this is all some kind of practical joke.*

Razz raises a finger in the air and shoots Glimmer a smile. "Yes! Yes, exactly!"

Glimmer's own smile wanes and, once again, she looks up to Adora with concern. Adora gives a minute shrug, not knowing how to further explain Razz's….kookiness. You either get it or you don't.

Turning back to Adora, Razz strokes the back of her hand with her thumb, a brilliant grin lighting up her features. "Yes, yes dearie. You're having a-"

"*Good afternoon, ladies! How's everyone doing today?"*

The three women look up in unison and watch as the doctor enters the room, one hand holding a clipboard and the other buried deep in her coat pocket.

Adora shakes off the shock first and offers up a smile. "Hi, Dr. Owens. I'm doin' okay. How about you?"

"*I'm doing fantastic, thanks for asking! Everything been alright with the pregnancy so far? Any concerns about anything?"*

"*Nothing that I can think of." She slowly removes her hands from Madame Razz's grasp. "I mean, strange things are happening all the time, but all the reading I've been doing has told me that most of it is normal."*

"*Well," Dr. Owens sets the clipboard down and washes her hands in the sink. "Your body's changing pretty rapidly. You'll definitely*

continue to experience a lot of weird things as the baby keeps growing. Speaking of," She dries off her hands and steps over to Adora with a smile. "Time to check on that growth. Lay back for me and lift your shirt up?"

Adora does as she said while Razz shuffles back to her own seat. In the meantime, Dr. Owens preps the ultrasound machine, asking for little tidbits of information here and there - mostly medical, though some of it does venture into Adora's schooling.

Soon enough, she's rubbing the ultrasound gel on Adora's stomach - which, no matter how many times she's been through this process, sends shivers down her spine from how cold it is - and unwraps the ultrasound stick from the machine. Pulling up a chair, she gets settled in for the process while Adora holds her breath.

A moment later, a black-and-white image of Adora's womb crackles onto the screen, a mesh of motion and pictures that somewhat resemble those funny little pictures she's seen in some of Bow's psychology textbooks. Rorbeck? Roshack? Something *like that.*

"*Well, there's the head." Dr. Owens points to a point on the screen and Adora cranes her neck, tilting her head before deciding to just take her word for it. "And here are the legs." Her finger moves and Adora's eyes follow, but she still can't make much sense of any of it.*

Glimmer, as always, is the most impatient of them all. "What is it? Boy or girl?"

Dr. Owens chuckles good-naturedly and leans closer to the screen, studying it carefully. "Well, if you look closely here," she points and Adora and Glimmer zero in on the spot she's indicating, "you'll see there's no extra appendage."

"*So that means…"*

Dr. Owens turns to her with a smile. "Congratulations, Miss Hartvigsen. You're having a baby girl."

A girl. She's having a girl*.*

As her throat begins to close up, she cranes her neck again to view the image. "Can I see again?"

"*Would you like me to print some photos out for you to take home?"*

She nods. "Please."

Dr. Owens gets her cleaned up and helps her sit back upright before she leaves the room to retrieve the photos and file away information from the visit. As soon as she's closed the door behind her, Glimmer pounces.

"*A girl! You're having a girl! Oh gosh, Bow is gonna* flip*! Oh, oh! We have to start looking at baby clothes now! We can go shopping, all three of us!"*

"*Whoa, slow down, Glimmer. All I wanna do after this is go home and take a nap."*

"*Well, okay not* today*. But we can take a shopping trip this weekend! And maybe even set up a registry for you. Oh! Are you gonna have a baby shower? Can I help plan it?" If Adora isn't reaching, from the way that Glimmer is practically jumping for the ceiling - despite her short height - and talking a mile a minute, she'd say that Glimmer is more excited about this than she is.*

"*I….isn't it a bit soon for all that? I still need to tell my parents."*

"*Right." Glimmer points at her with both fingers. "Right. Maybe I can ask your mom and we can plan one together!" As always, missing the entire point. But she supposes she doesn't want to rain on Glimmer's sudden baby fever parade, so she opts to nod along as Glimmer rambles on and on about parties and shopping and names.*

God help Adam if they ever decide to have a kid together.

The nurse returns with Adora's ultrasound photos and escorts them back to the front where Adora checks out and schedules her next appointment. In the meantime, Glimmer decides to get the car and bring it around to the front so Adora doesn't have to walk to the back of the parking lot where they're parked. She tries to argue - both her and Glimmer knowing full well how much she hates this sudden coddling that her and Bow have started doing as of late - but she ultimately loses when Glimmer skips out the front door anyway while Adora is still talking to the receptionist.

Once she's done, her and Razz walk out the front door and wait for Glimmer to pull the car around, which Adora uses as time to try and convince Razz to let them give her a lift home.

"*Are you sure?" she asks when Razz turns it down with a wave. "It's hardly out of our way. And it's a much shorter trip than taking the bus, I'm sure. Seriously, it's no hassle at all."*

"*No, I'm fine with the bus, dearie. Gives me time to rest my old bones and watch the city go by. I don't go out very much, you know. But thank you again."*

"*If you say so."*

Just then, Glimmer pulls up and Adora begins bidding Razz farewell, promising to see her in class the next week. But just before she climbs into the car, she pauses and gives Razz a pondering look.

"*Hey, Razz? Is that what you saw? In your dream?"*

Razz gives her a smile and Adora notices the tell-tale glaze of her eyes that suggests that she's not with her anymore. "I saw you*, Mara dearie. I always see you in my dreams."*

Chapter End Notes

Hey I'm NOT dead!

Sorry this one took one took so long. I actually started it over a month ago but between packing up to move, looking for jobs, grad pics, and more I just....lost a lot of energy to come back to it. Add that to the fact that this has ended up being the longest chapter I've written for this fic so far and I've really just started to psyche myself out.

'Cause that's the other thing....this is just part ONE. This started getting so long that I had to break this chapter up into two separate chapters. So next chapter is going to be the conclusion for this particular segment. Should be up sometime later this week if I can lock myself down and finish it. But I figured I'd go ahead and upload this one now because it's already been so long since my last update and to give y'all a buffer before I drop the next one.

Also, I got a beta! Because I am trash with grammar and finally admitted that I need help lol. So thanks so much to @OMeganTownshend on Twitter for all your amazing effort and your time :) As well as helping me make the decision to split this goliath of a chapter and advising me where to make the split. You're amazing~

Anyways, not much to say at the moment since this part isn't finished yet, so I'll see you all in about a week.

Here is Adora's apron though if anyone's wondering

Until next time~!

NOT AN CHAPTER!!! BUT PLEASE READ

Chapter Summary

FAIR WARNING THIS IS NOT A NEW CHAPTER

BUT I WILL BE EXPLAINING MY ABSENCE A BIT SO PLEASE READ

Hey y'all!

I really tried my best to avoid doing this (because I know how disappointing it is to get the update email and it's just an author's note), but I really felt like I should explain my extended absence to this story in particular.

For those who don't follow my twitter (though you should because I provide semi-consistent updates and sneak peeks and such), I've made a few tweets here and there recently apologizing and giving vague explanations on why this chapter is taking so long, especially since I promised to have it out within a week of the last chapter.

When I updated the last chapter, it was just a week before I had to move out of my college apartment and I got caught up with packing that I didn't really have time to finish the rest of the next chapter. And unfortunately, I didn't have much time to finish when I moved back home because I immediately hit the ground running trying to look for a job since I have student loans to start paying off pretty soon.

I somehow ended up with three jobs (two volunteer and one paid) which pretty much ate up all of my time. Since then, I've put a hold on my volunteer jobs (my "employers" thankfully being very understanding) because my paying job took priority and I'm also still currently job searching for something in my field. Blah, blah, blah...life as a college grad is tough and COVID hasn't been helping any.

However, as of late, the paying job I have has been draining me so badly and giving me so much stress, anxiety, and heightening my depression that I pretty much don't do anything in my free time anymore. All my days off are spent regaining the energy I'm spending at work for my next set of shifts. I'm working my ass off trying to have enough money to start paying off my student loans, get an apartment, as well as start putting money towards my wedding/honeymoon.

(Did I mention? I got engaged!!!!!!)

But my work environment is pretty toxic and has been putting me down so much that I've been getting physically sick from the stress and exhaustion. (If it's not my co-workers dragging me into unwarranted drama, it's my manager who is possibly one of the worst people to be leading a team of people in customer service. But I digress.)

Couple that with the fact that I've been having physical health issues, seasonal depression, depression from COVID, and my regular depression and you have a pretty strung out and exhausted Ash.

Regarding the physical health issues, I've had problems spanning the last few months which I only just went to the doctor about and they're currently running some tests. It's nothing too serious, but it might be another big part of why I've been so exhausted and depressed lately (it's a condition that runs in the family that we were hoping would skip over me, so fingers crossed the test comes out negative).

As for the depression, I've technically always had that, but I only just recently went through testing last month and got an official diagnosis. So the good news is that I just had a prescription filled out for antidepressants. The somewhat less good news is that it's going to take roughly a month to see any results, if any (and then we'll either have to up the dosage or try a different medication). Which means that I can't make any solid promises to make much progress until the meds start to take hold, especially considering

that the meds apparently tend to have a somewhat opposite effect when you first start taking them. But here's hoping!

Lastly, I'm working on trying to leave my toxic job at the moment. I recently applied to a somewhat temporary job (and actually have an interview tomorrow) so if I end up getting it, my schedule will be doing a complete 180. That means it'll take me some time to readjust to it, ON TOP OF getting used to being on a new medication. Basically, this upcoming month or so is about to be very tiresome. That means I don't know for sure how much progress I'll be making on any of my fics or even IF I'll be able to make progress. I want so badly to have the next chapter out by the end of the year (because y'all have been patiently waiting for so long) so I will absolutely do my best, but I also don't want to make any promises I can't keep.

Anyways, the gist of this whole message is that I'm working on updating (I have not abandoned you!!), but so much is going on in my life currently that's getting in the way of that. I'll try my best to have something soon (because I've already made some progress), but at this point, I'll just get it out whenever it's ready.

On an end note, I want to thank all of you who have been supporting me throughout this fic and have been patiently waiting for my return. Your support and kind words mean so much to me and I think about this fic and all of you just about every day <3 This project is my baby and one I'm eager to return to once things have calmed down and straightened out on my end.

If you want to stay in the loop on my writing progress, please go follow my twitter @technoskittles! I'll try to be more active there in the next bit just because I know I've been pretty radio silent for so long.

Until next time~!

End Notes

Want to know more about this story? Check out my tumblr @ technoskittles.tumblr.com/tagged/pure-feeling

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!